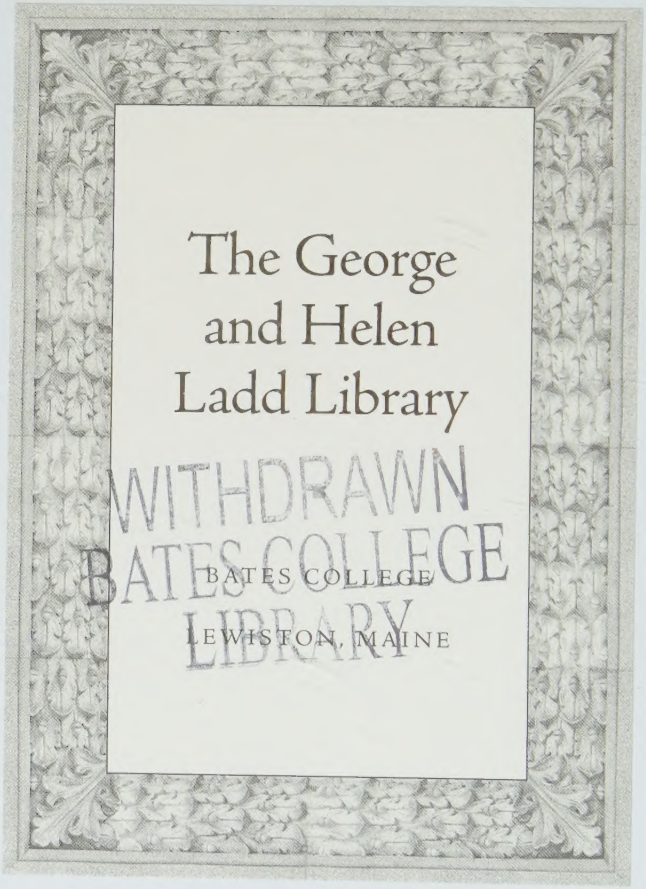
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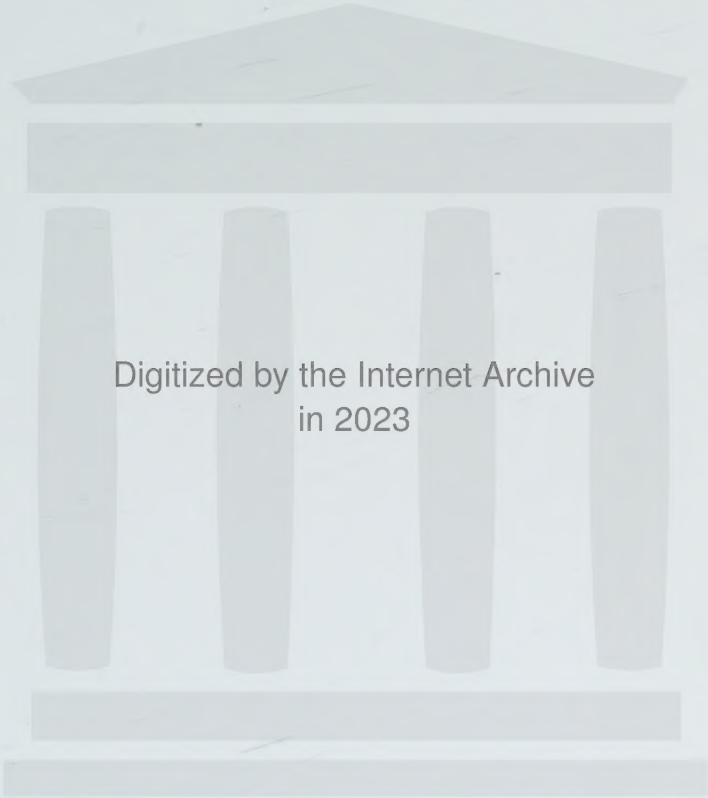
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Ammianus Marcellinus

The Allusive Historian

Ammianus Marcellinus is usually regarded as our most important source for the history of the second half of the fourth century AD, while his literary qualities are neglected. This book demonstrates what a subtle and manipulative writer Ammianus is; attention is paid particularly to his rich and variegated intertextuality with earlier classical literature and history. Questioning the prevailing interest in the historian's life as the key to his work, Dr Kelly re-evaluates the historiographical function of the vivid and thrilling autobiographical passages. The range of Ammianus' allusions is surveyed, including his use of classical examples, his relationship with historical source-texts and the workings of internal echoes within the history. His interactions with other texts are seen as carefully controlled and meaningful; and both his allusive techniques and writing in general, it is argued, are better viewed as reflecting a classical, rather than a late-antique, aesthetic.

GAVIN KELLY is Lecturer in Classics at the University of Edinburgh. A specialist in the literature and political history of the Roman Empire, he has published articles in leading journals on the historical work of Ammianus Marcellinus.

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AMMIANUS MARCELLINUS

The Allusive Historian

GAVIN KELLY

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The Master and Fellows of Peterhouse, Cambridge, elected me to a Research Fellowship in 2000 and gave me a comfortable, friendly, amusing and sometimes inspiring home for the next four years. I had the good fortune, there as in subsequent appointments at Manchester and (since 2005) Edinburgh, to work alongside generous colleagues and stimulating students.

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ABBREVIATIONS

Abbreviations of journal titles in the bibliography are as in *L'Année Philologique*, with the customary minor alterations for English usage. For full titles of ancient works see Index locorum.

CIL	*Corpus Inscriptionum Latinarum* (Berlin, 1862–)
CSEL	*Corpus Scriptorum Ecclesiasticorum Latinorum* (Vienna, 1866–)
ILS	H. Dessau (ed.), *Inscriptiones Latinae Selectae*, 3 vols. (Berlin, 1892–1916)
OLD	*Oxford Latin Dictionary* (Oxford, 1968–82)
PG	*Patrologia Graeca* (*Patrologiae cursus completus, series Graeca*, ed. J.-P. Migne) (Paris, 1857–66)
PL	*Patrologia Latina* (*Patrologiae cursus completus, series Latina*, ed. J.-P. Migne) (Paris, 1844–55)
PLRE I	A. H. M. Jones, J. R. Martindale and J. Morris (eds.), *Prosopography of the Later Roman Empire* I *(AD 260–395)* (Cambridge, 1970)

INTRODUCTION

The historian of the Roman Empire's decline and fall called Ammianus Marcellinus 'an accurate and faithful guide', who had 'composed the history of his own times, without indulging the prejudices and passions, which usually affect the mind of a contemporary'.[1] Ammianus' *Res Gestae* was originally not a wholly contemporary work. It began with the emperor Nerva's accession in AD 96, the end-point of Tacitus' *Histories*. But like the closing books of Tacitus' work, Ammianus' opening books no longer survive. If we go by the book-numbers found in the manuscript tradition, the first thirteen books have been lost, covering over 250 years.[2] The remaining eighteen books (14–31) cover only twenty-five years, from 353 to the battle of Adrianople in 378: the latter part of the reign of Constantius II, the rise and usurpation of his more talented deputy, the Caesar Julian, Julian's sole rule, culminating in the tragic failure of the Persian campaign, and his inferior successors, Jovian and the brothers Valentinian and Valens. Over that short span, the breadth of Ammianus' learning, his geographical range across the whole empire, and his huge and characterful cast-list set his *Res Gestae* apart from everything else from the period. His uniqueness lies not only in the massive quantity of information but in the ability to capture individuals and scenes with an arresting image: a Prefect of Rome standing against a riotous mob who hissed like snakes, a low-born imperial favourite so exultant

[1] Gibbon (1776–88) [ed. D. Womersley, 1995], I.1073.

[2] See Reynolds (1983), 6–8, on the manuscript tradition. The only fully authoritative manuscript is *V*, the *Fuldensis*, itself a copy of *M*, the lost *Hersfeldensis* (Robinson (1936)). A few pages of this were discovered in the nineteenth century, and some fragments have been found since (see Broszinski and Teitler (1990)). Readings from *M* were also haphazardly incorporated into the 1533 edition of Sigismund Gelenius (*G*): unfortunately it is rarely possible to tell for sure that *G*'s readings come from collation against *M*, rather than an earlier edition or independent conjecture. For the possibility that a third independent manuscript survived to the Renaissance see Cappelletto (1983) and Cameron (1989).

in treason trials that he seemed to walk in the air like a Brahmin, a battlefield long afterwards white with bones.[3] Gibbon was certainly right to lament when the last surviving secular Latin history could no longer serve him as a source, and by contrast to bemoan the inadequate collation of partial narratives which was forced on him for the years after Adrianople.

Since Gibbon's regretful leave-taking, Ammianus has appealed to many historians of late antiquity as a faithful guide for that quarter-century up to 378, and the most important historian by far of the fourth century as a whole. His eye for memorable detail and his ear for anecdote, and his appearance of 'sincerity and moderation',[4] have ensured that Ammianus' version of his age has become canonical. Most historical scholars have identified with, and forcefully maintained, his self-image as an honest and independent historian. For those whose concern has been more specifically with Ammianus, the central issue has been and remains the support, refutation, defence, or revision of his reputation for accurately and faithfully representing the Roman Empire which he knew.

Such a concern certainly dominates the two most important studies of Ammianus in recent years, John Matthews' *The Roman Empire of Ammianus* (1989) and Timothy Barnes' *Ammianus Marcellinus and the Representation of Historical Reality* (1998). Together they saved me from much toil and error, and have made writing this book a far more agreeable and less solitary labour than it could otherwise have been. Matthews' book, which appeared when I was first gripped by ancient historical writing and by the allure of the later empire, 'conveys its main message in its very title'.[5] Fully appreciative of Ammianus' range, Matthews fills out a prodigiously broad canvas around him, demonstrating his author's virtues and uniqueness without panegyric. His Ammianus is tolerant, inquisitive, gentlemanly, and ultimately optimistic. (It was also in an unassuming way an iconoclastic book, painlessly putting to sleep several long-lived canards.)[6] Matthews' Ammianus

[3] 15.7.3–5, with Auerbach (1953), 50–60, Matthews (1987), Barnes (1998), 11–16; 28.1.13; 31.7.16 and Ch. 1 below.

[4] Gibbon (1776–88), 1.1074. [5] Barnes (1998), 7.

[6] For example, the work's publication in instalments, the significance of Tacitus as an influence, and the curial status of the historian.

was extremely well-received, and his approach remains dominant: arguably most of the papers in the volume edited by Drijvers and Hunt in 1999 belong to the school of Matthews.

Barnes' very different book appeared in 1998, the first year of my doctoral studies: it was immensely stimulating for me to read (in one sitting) a self-consciously revisionist reinterpretation. Typical of this is the consideration of whether Ammianus wrote thirty-one books, as the transmitted book-numbers suggest, or thirty-six. Barnes argues convincingly that the existing books are divided into three groups of six books ('hexads'); furthermore, he argues that the contents of the lost books were so expansive that they must also have included three hexads, making thirty-six books in total, and that the transmitted book-numbers are out by five – a theory which to my mind is neither impossible nor proven.[7] More importantly, evidently provoked by Matthews, Barnes is concerned as to whether Ammianus' picture of his world is really an unmediated and authentic representation of his age. He sees Ammianus as belonging to the company of the truly great historians not because he was 'an accurate and faithful guide' but because 'his *Res Gestae* exhibit the creative and imaginative powers of a novelist'.[8] In countless places he convicts the historian of misrepresentation and bias, or as Gibbon put it 'prejudices and passions'. In particular, he focuses mercilessly on a blind spot in Matthews' study: religion.[9]

For nothing has the pagan Ammianus been more praised than for his tolerant attitude to Christianity, in an age of intolerance and fanaticism. Tolerance comes more naturally to those on the losing side, but even then is a rare commodity in the late fourth century. Contrast him to the likes of Libanius, Eunapius, or even Symmachus, and Ammianus appears exceptional, with his willingness to criticise the religious fervour of the only pagan emperor of the period, Julian, and his praise for Christian meekness. Richard

[7] Barnes (1998), 20–31. [8] Barnes (1998), 198.

[9] Matthews has many perceptive remarks on Ammianus and religion, but I cannot agree with his overall conclusions (see esp. (1989), 442–51). It is understandable but regrettable that he did not devote more time to the arguments of Roy Rike's book of 1987 (Matthews (1989), 545 n. 10). See Ch. 3, Section v below. For other important recent discussions of religion in Ammianus see Neri (1985) and (1992), Hunt (1985) and Davies (2004), who has the virtue of exploring Ammianus' attitude to religion in continuity from Livy and Tacitus.

Porson, in an early reaction to Gibbon, wrote that he showed 'so strong a dislike to Christianity, as visibly disqualifies him for that society, of which he has created Ammianus Marcellinus president'.[10] Gibbon, it appears, has not been so faithful to his faithful guide. But in fact, as many have suspected, and as Barnes has proved, Ammianus was a militant pagan. He denigrated Christianity and Christians not through open criticism but through ironic juxtapositions and polemical silence. He praises provincial bishops, certainly, but for their humility and in order to attack the opulent bishops of Rome; he praises the glorious deaths of martyrs, but at a point when he has just described the lynching of a couple of villains.[11] His strategy has been remarkably successful in ensuring that his versions both of his own fairness and of the later fourth century have dominated subsequent historiography.

Ammianus' religious persuasions are an occasional refrain in my work, after the manner of the elder Cato,[12] rather than its subject (Barnes' book precluded that, for which I am grateful). And yet the still controversial re-evaluation of his religious position has spurred me on and has encouraged my general approach. This is founded on a belief that Ammianus is a subtler and more manipulative author than has sometimes been assumed, and that elements of his text that do not appeal to modern tastes, his digressions, allusions and historical *exempla*, are more meaningful than has been allowed. This is partly, no doubt, because I have been strongly influenced by recent scholarship on earlier Latin historiography and on intertextual relationships in Latin literature more generally. The approaches of (for example) Tony Woodman to Tacitus, or Richard Thomas to Vergil, were part of my education, and it always seemed plain to me that Ammianus, striking both for his high-minded attitude to his historical calling and for the degree of his allusive engagement with earlier Latin and Greek texts, could benefit from similar scholarship. And accordingly this book is focused in part on viewing him as belonging to a great bilingual tradition of classical historiography (especially in

[10] Porson (1790), xxviii, quoted in Cameron and Cameron (1964), 316 n. 2.
[11] 27.3.15, 22.11.10.
[12] For this refrain see the closing remarks of Kelly (2003), (2004), (2007).

Chapter 2); and to a rather greater extent it is focused on Ammianus' intertextual relationships.[13]

Ammianus is an extraordinarily allusive author, and a considerable amount of scholarship since the seventeenth century has been devoted to the questions of what he read and disgorged in his *Res Gestae*. Rather less attention has been paid to how he read what he did and what impact his allusions to other texts might have upon the interpretation of the *Res Gestae*, and when it was, his allusiveness tended not to be held in high esteem. It was a sign of derivativeness and pretentiousness, or it showed an extraordinary and eccentric aesthetic.[14] Allusion is not of course invariably meaningful, but I argue that Ammianus deploys it with a consistent and controlled aesthetic, and that it very often imports meaning from the source-texts (Chapter 4 below). Also under the heading of allusion I consider how Ammianus used his sources: here focusing less on the grand-scale use of previous historians, as divined by scholars a century ago,[15] and more on the often short-term and always independent use of a diverse range of contemporaries. This aspect of Ammianus' work, highlighted in Guy Sabbah's outstanding study *La méthode d'Ammien Marcellin* (1978), has still not fully been appreciated.[16] The juxtaposition of these source relationships with those of traditional allusions turns out to be justified (Chapter 5). I then turn to look at two other forms of intertextuality: Ammianus' use of classical *exempla* in Chapter 6 (extremely close to textual allusions both in their aesthetic and their capacity to create meaning), and internal allusions in Chapter 7.

Alongside my belief in the importance of allusions, I am also deeply sceptical about the potential value of a biographical approach to the author. These four chapters on allusion are preceded by three chapters which confront the dominance of biographical interpretations. In Chapter 1, I introduce the tension

[13] Ammianus' historiographical roots have been examined by many. See in particular the abundant discussion of his links to Tacitus (Ch. 4, Section 1 below) and the focus on the influence of the Greek tradition in Matthews (1989), 452–72. The most valuable publication on this subject in recent years has been John Marincola's book on ancient historiography (1997), in which Ammianus plays the full role that many earlier studies of that sort had denied him.

[14] Hertz (1874a), discussed below in Ch. 4, Section II. [15] Seeck (1906a).

[16] I also follow a lead which I can trace to a short passage in Kraus and Woodman (1997), 97–102, on interpreting source relationships in Tacitus as intertextuality.

which subsists between these two methods of interpretation; in Chapter 2, I argue that the remarkable autobiographical passages are frequently complicated by allusion, and that, rather than being incomparably revealing, they are calculated to show openly or imply metaphorically the qualities which made Ammianus the definitive historian of his age. The third chapter follows up the implications of the previous two, and argues that the types of biographical reading which are common (and which, among many others and for all their differences, Matthews and Barnes share) are simply too speculative to be relied on. I am happy to believe that he wrote with anger and partiality, less happy that we can identify the causes of his every opinion in personal resentments. It is time, I suggest, that scholarship on Ammianus moved away from the figure of the author. A passage encapsulating what is different about my argument is the brief prologue which opens the second extant book of Ammianus (15.1.1):

> Vtcumque potui ueritatem scrutari, / ea, quae uidere licuit per aetatem / uel perplexe interrogando uersatos in medio scire, / narrauimus ordine casuum exposito diuersorum; / residua, quae secuturus aperiet textus, / pro uirium captu limatius absoluemus, / nihil obtrectatores longi, ut putant, operis formidantes.
>
> As far as I have been able to search out the truth, I have narrated those events which it was possible to see through the course of my lifetime or to know by rigorous questioning of those in the thick of things, setting out the diverse events in order. The remainder, which the following text will reveal, we shall complete with greater polish, fearing nothing from the detractors of a work which, in their view, is long.

Much could be and has been written on this important passage. Many of its themes and much of its vocabulary, including above all the prominent claim to *ueritas*, truthfulness, are echoed by other programmatic statements later in the work. Ammianus has substantial comments on the nature of history at a number of points between the preface to Book 26 and the epilogue that closes Book 31, but this is the only such passage in the first two extant hexads. This prologue also stands out for the description, not found elsewhere, of the matter narrated in the *Res Gestae* as 'those events which it was possible to see in the course of my lifetime or to know by rigorous questioning of those in the thick of things'. And this

self-proclaimed dependence on what he himself had seen (autopsy) and on interviews with important eyewitnesses has struck a chord with many of Ammianus' readers. For Edward Thompson, writing *The Historical Work of Ammianus Marcellinus* in the 1940s, this passage in particular offered an escape from Otto Seeck's characterisation of the historian as closely and unintelligently combining written sources, a distasteful and eminently attackable portrayal. It promised an authentically first-hand view of fourth-century history, an unequivocally *primary* source. In the vast range of characters found in the *Res Gestae* it was not hard to identify those who might have served as Ammianus' informants, even if none are specifically claimed as such, and I have already mentioned the frank and exciting passages of autopsy, found in small-scale interventions throughout the work, but in particular in a series of episodes from his military career between the years 355, when Ammianus was in his early to mid-twenties, and 363.

The preface to Book 15 was not, of course, the first time that a classical historian had proclaimed the centrality to his work of his own experience and of rigorous interviews with those involved. For Thompson, Ammianus' echo of Thucydides (not to mention countless other ancient historians) merely served as further proof of his quality. But for a generation which no longer considers Thucydides the father of modern scientific history, the comparison may be less reassuring. Autopsy, beyond being a description of specific places or events allegedly seen by the historian, is an established way of arguing for the expertise and authority of the historian, not only in describing particular times and places, but also for writing history at all. I shall argue below that it may be dangerous to rejoice in the authenticity, rather than the artistry, of Ammianus' autobiography. The value of allusion, by contrast, is that though its interpretation may be open, its existence is often relatively secure and objective. For example, to me it seems more obvious and more significant that Ammianus read Libanius than that he knew him.

The argument and structure of this work is, in common parlance, more 'literary' than 'historical' (I dislike the antithesis), but it is firmly grounded on historical foundations and some of its conclusions are significant in historical terms: for example, the dubiety of biographical reconstructions (Chapter 3) and the manner in

which the historian used written sources (Chapter 5, in particular). Throughout, it is consistently maintained that the work engaged not only with the times which it covered but with the times in which it was written, the 380s AD. I follow the emerging consensus that the work was published as a whole at some point between late 389 and mid-391.[17] The overwhelmingly dominant figure in the imperial college, following the overthrow of the western usurper Magnus Maximus, was Theodosius I, and Ammianus' attitude is one of equivocation, both related to the emperor's intolerant instincts in religious policy, and, for all the assertions of victory, to his appeasement of the Goths.[18] It used to be held that Ammianus published his last six books towards or after the end of Theodosius' reign. No real justification for this exists. The dating indications of the earlier surviving part of the work bunch around the late 380s, and there are a cluster of references to that period in the later books and none which point any later. Typically these are the names of later office-holders.[19] Ammianus published after the name of the junior consul of 390, Neoterius, was known (26.5.14), presumably late in the previous year, and after Sextus Petronius Probus was dead (27.11.2), perhaps in 389. He published before Valentinian II had killed himself in 392. That is the best explanation for the forceful defence, against most logic, of the legitimacy of the four-year-old's acclamation in 375 (30.10.5–6).[20] And though this aspect of the question tends not to be considered, I would also argue that many intra-textual features, from cross-references to the use of common themes, suggest that the work was conceived, written, and very probably published, as a unity.[21]

[17] See Cameron (1971), 261–2, Naudé (1984), Matthews (1989), 22–7, and Rike (1987), 110–11 n. 113, 137, Barnes (1998), Lizzi (2000). For a recent and thorough assertion of the alternative viewpoint (publication of the last six books in the mid-390s) see Sabbah (1997).

[18] Ch. 1, Section II below. See also Kelly (2007), Section III.

[19] There are also some 'missed opportunities' to name office-holders of the early 390s.

[20] Ammianus missed an opportunity to attack Probus, one of those responsible for the elevation of the younger Valentinian (see Barnes (1998), 119). For a different interpretation see Paschoud (2005a).

[21] I give just one example, which appears to have been overlooked: that at 17.3.3 Ammianus notes his intention to describe the later misgovernment of the Praetorian Prefecture of Illyricum (*ut docebitur postea*, 'as shall be told later'). Most commentators refer to 19.11.2, but that is a reference to the good government of Anatolius in the later 350s. The reference can only be an oblique one to the prefecture of Probus in the 360s and

The text of Ammianus which I have generally followed is Seyfarth's fine Teubner. Though Seyfarth is reluctant to fill lacunae and occasionally prone to defend indefensible or unlikely readings in *V* (in which case I have printed an emended text),[22] this is a fundamentally sensible edition, more accurate and better presented than any which has preceded it. A particular virtue is its punctuation, the clausula being marked either by a double space or, at the end of the line, a hasta (/). The clausulae in Ammianus are almost entirely regular (simply put, there are two or four unstressed syllables between the last two stressed syllables of each colon); because they function within as well as at the end of sentences, they provide a guide to understanding quite as helpful as modern punctuation.[23] I have marked clausulae in virtually every quotation from Ammianus, as well as inserting normal punctuation more generously than Seyfarth. Unless otherwise stated, I am responsible for the translation of all Latin and Greek quotations, though I consulted the various published versions. My renderings are generally quite literal, in the case of Ammianus closer to the style adopted in J. C. Rolfe's Loeb than to that of the more accurate but sometimes bloodless Penguin Classics translation of Walter Hamilton. I have also translated all quotations in modern European languages.

370s, as described in most detail at 30.5.10. If one wished to argue that the *Res Gestae* was composed in sequence, one could assume that the earlier references at 17.3.3 and 19.11.2 showed Ammianus waiting for Probus to die before being more explicit. But at any rate, Ammianus plainly intended to continue beyond the death of Jovian.

[22] The text is notably more conservative than his earlier version with parallel German translation, where Seyfarth was constrained by the need to print something he was able to translate.

[23] See Harmon (1910), and the edition of Clark (1910–15); Oberhelman (1987); Barnes (1998), 225–30, with Paschoud's review (1999a).

PART I

THE ELUSIVE HISTORIAN

CHAPTER I

THE BONES ON THE BATTLEFIELD

humatis denique pro locorum et temporis ratione / honoratis quibusdam inter defunctos, / reliqua peremptorum corpora dirae uolucres consumpserunt, / assuetae illo tempore cadaueribus pasci, / ut indicant nunc usque albentes ossibus campi.

Finally some of the more highly ranked among the deceased were buried, as far as time and place permitted; the rest of the bodies of the dead were consumed by ominous fowl, who at that time became used to feeding on corpses, as is shown by the plains which even now are white with bones.

(Ammianus Marcellinus 31.7.16,
describing the aftermath of the battle of Ad Salices, AD 377)

Ammianus Marcellinus closed his history with the battle of Adrianople in AD 378. Two thirds of the Roman army in the field were killed by the Goths.[1] The emperor Valens was among the dead, his body never found. It was, Ammianus considered, the worst Roman defeat in almost 600 years since Cannae (31.13.19). The battle, only a dozen years before the *Res Gestae* was offered to the Roman public, weighed heavily on the historian and his history.[2] The traditions of Roman historiography compelled Ammianus to end his work with Adrianople, on the threshold of the reign of the ruling emperor, Theodosius.[3] But the battle's significance did not diminish, and its effects were still to be seen and its lessons to be learnt. The Goths' presence in the Balkans had

[1] The proportion comes from 31.13.18; the actual number of casualties is debated. See e.g. Heather (1991), 146–7.

[2] On dating see Introduction, p. 8 above.

[3] A tradition acknowledged in the closing words of the *Res Gestae*, which carry the suggestion that what follows must be panegyric: *scribant reliqua potiores aetate, doctrinis florentes. quos id, si libuerit, aggressuros procudere linguas ad maiores moneo stilos* ('Let the rest be written by men with youth on their side, in the bloom of learning. To those who would embark on this, if it please them, I give the advice to forge their tongues to grander styles', 31.16.9). Cf. e.g. Eutropius 10.18.3, *HA Quadr. Tyr.* 15.10, and for further discussion Paschoud (2004) and Kelly (2007).

been established and formalised by an uneasy peace from 382, but Ammianus was one of those to whom it seemed an enduring and unresolved problem. His thirty-first and last book eschews his characteristic variation of scene and subject matter in favour of a ceaseless crescendo towards Adrianople. In the East Valens was forced to make peace with Persia, but Ammianus gives this a single sentence (31.7.1); he suppresses altogether a major uprising in Isauria and a Saracen revolt.[4] Of western events he narrates only the emperor Gratian's military successes against the Lentienses (31.10.1–20), which turn out to be a contributory factor to the disaster at Adrianople: Valens might have learnt from his nephew's victory, but was in fact led to be fatally jealous and precipitous (31.12.7). Ammianus' account stands out for its thoughtful analysis and its reconsideration of the more complacent or calamitous assessments of his contemporaries.[5] Alongside this, from the start of Book 31, omens of the coming disaster, which have been plentiful throughout the last hexad of the work (Books 26–31), become omnipresent.[6]

The text which is the epigraph and subject of this chapter describes an event a year before Adrianople. In the late summer of 377, the Romans and Goths fought bloodily and inconclusively at Ad Salices, near the delta of the Danube.[7] The Romans could ill afford their losses (31.7.16); the Goths retreated afterwards into their circle of wagons and were not seen outside it for seven days (31.8.1). The poignant account of how the great majority of the bones were left unburied concludes Ammianus' lingering description of the horrors of the battlefield. The immediacy of the words has often struck scholarly readers. It was Edward Gibbon's adaptation of this passage into Chapter 26 of *The Decline and Fall* that

[4] The reality of the Isaurian uprising is admirably confirmed through references in the Cappadocian fathers by Lenski (1999), esp. 314; see also (2002b), 199–200. The forward reference at 26.8.9–10 to Aliso's death in Isauria may well refer to an event during this revolt.

[5] For analysis see Rosen (1992); for contemporary views see Lenski (1997). Blockley (1994), 60, describes Book 31 as being almost a discrete historical monograph and argues that the historian's use of *exempla* differs from his normal practice.

[6] As Sabbah remarks in the introduction to his Budé (1999, xviii), even the ugliness of the Huns (who are ***prodigiose*** *deformes*, 'prodigiously misshapen', 31.2.2) is an omen. See Kelly (2004), 163, on omens of Adrianople in the earlier books.

[7] On the location see Heather (1991), 144.

first displayed what would become a commonplace interpretation – that Ammianus had himself visited the battlefield and beheld the bones:

> Such funeral rites, as the circumstances of time and place would admit, were piously discharged to some officers of distinguished rank; but the indiscriminate vulgar was left unburied on the plain. Their flesh was greedily devoured by the birds of prey, who, in that age, enjoyed very frequent and delicious feasts; and several years afterwards the white and naked bones, which covered the wide extent of the fields, presented to the eyes of Ammianus, a dreadful monument of the battle of Salices.[8]

In a footnote Gibbon quotes the crucial words from which he infers Ammianus' autopsy: *ut indicant nunc usque albentes ossibus campi*, 'as is shown by the plains which even now are white with bones'. 'The historian might have viewed these plains, either as a soldier, or as a traveller'. Whether or not he was still in the army in the period after 378, Ammianus was undoubtedly well-travelled. He famously describes his digression on Thrace and the Black Sea as combining 'things seen and things read' (*uisa uel lecta*, 22.8.1), and he had certainly visited Thrace, which was on the land route between the East and the West of the empire, in his travels of the 350s.[9] One possible rendering of the verb *indicant* is 'witness' (though it does not necessarily imply the author as eyewitness) and the words *nunc usque* plausibly represent the historian's autopsy at another place in the *Res Gestae*.[10] Subsequent studies of Ammianus – including those of Seeck, Enßlin, Thompson, Rowell, Syme, Blockley, Crump and Barnes – follow Gibbon in supposing, with varying degrees of certainty, that Ammianus had travelled to see the battlefield of Ad Salices. John Marincola's influential work on ancient historiography exhibits no doubt that Ammianus is here deploying 'implied autopsy'. John Matthews

[8] Gibbon (1776–88 [ed. D. Womersley, 1995]), 1.1057 with n. 82.

[9] Ursicinus, Ammianus' commanding officer, and his entourage appear to have travelled post, rather than by sea (see 14.11.5). He would therefore have passed through Thrace three times in the 350s; he certainly did in 359 (18.6.5).

[10] At 26.3.5, an unnamed senator, acquitted on a capital charge thanks to bribery, is said still (*nunc usque*) to parade himself ostentatiously in Rome – which is of course where Ammianus composed his history. Other instances of *nunc usque* at 14.2.13, 17.4.2, 22.8.14 and 27.7.5 are not so helpful.

hypothesises that such a visit might have coincided with Ammianus' move from Antioch to Rome in the early 380s.[11]

Still, Matthews for one admits that such a hypothesis is overshadowed with doubt, and that autopsy is 'not a necessary inference'.[12] The main reason for this is a second, and contrasting, way in which this passage can be read: through its intertextuality. The 'plains white with bones' constitute an allusion; there is a close verbal similarity to passages of Vergil and Tacitus.[13] In the last book of the *Aeneid*, Latinus laments the recent fighting (12.35–6):

> recalent nostro Tiberina fluenta
> sanguine adhuc **campique ingentes ossibus albent**.
>
> The Tiber's streams are still warm with our blood and **the vast plains are white with bones**.

And in the first book of the *Annals*, Germanicus brings his army to the battlefield of the Teutoburger Wald, six years on from Varus' defeat in AD 9. Tacitus clearly alludes to Vergil, in the whitening bones and in other details (*Ann.* 1.61.2–3):[14]

> **medio campi albentia ossa**, ut fugerant, ut restiterant, disiecta uel aggerata. (3) adiacebant fragmina telorum equorumque artus, simul truncis arborum antefixa ora.
>
> **In the middle of the plain whitening bones** were scattered, where they had fled, or heaped up, where they had resisted. (3) Nearby lay shards of spears and horses' limbs, while faces were attached to trunks of trees.

[11] Autopsy is assumed unequivocally by Seeck (1894), 1846, Enßlin (1923), 6, Thompson (1947), 14, Rowell (1964), 26, Syme (1968), 5, Crump (1975), 80, Barnes (1998), 1, and Marincola (1997), 81 with n. 90. Blockley (1975), 10 n. 17, is less certain. Matthews (1989), 16, makes what he admits to be a conjectural reconstruction of Ammianus' journey to Rome, and adduces a detail which might hint at his presence at Constantinople in the period leading up to the peace in 382 (see Ch. 3, n. 171 below).

[12] Matthews (1989), 16.

[13] These two allusions were first observed by Lindenbrog ad loc. in 1609, and would thus have been known to Gibbon, whose adaptation of Ammianus seems to incorporate Vergil's *campi . . . ingentes* 'the wide extent of the fields' – a 'window allusion'? (See Ch. 4, Section IV.6 below).

[14] For a list and discussion of Vergilian allusions in the wider context of this passage see Baxter (1972), 254–6. Particularly striking is the allusion to Cacus' lair in *Aen.* 8.196–7 *foribusque adfixa superbis ora uirum* ('attached to the proud doors were men's faces'). It is also worth observing that in *medio campi albentia ossa* Tacitus alludes to *Aen.* 9.230 *castrorum et campi medio* ('in the middle of the camp and the plain') as well as to 12.36 (see Woodman (1988), 171), and that Tacitus' *fragmina telorum* ('shards of spears) echoes the sound of *Aen.* 10.306 *fragmina remorum* ('shards of oars').

It is from Ammianus' allusions to these passages of Vergil and Tacitus that some scholars have concluded that his autopsy at Ad Salices need not be 'a necessary inference', or indeed that the bones may be 'only' a literary reminiscence – and others altogether rule it out.[15]

Autopsy or allusion? It is obviously false to suggest, as some have, that there is any intrinsic opposition between the two. A definite allusion to Vergil does not rule out a possible autobiographical reference – and it will be seen that Ammianus elsewhere complicates openly autobiographical passages with blatant allusion to earlier historiography and poetry.[16] The question as to whether Ammianus visited the battlefield should depend on other arguments. My own inclination is to doubt it. Ad Salices is a long way from the main roads, on the way to nowhere, and not much of a destination in itself; it must have been difficult of access even after the supposed outbreak of peace in 382.[17] It is not even clear whether the phrase *ut indicant nunc usque albentes ossibus campi* ('as is shown by the plains which even now are white with bones') explains that birds of prey defiled the battlefield of Ad Salices, or whether it refers to all, or other, battlefields of the Gothic War. The generalizing description of the birds as *assuetae illo tempore cadaueribus pasci*, 'accustomed in that period to feed on corpses', suggests that the reference could be to the bones of many battlefields. And yet, on the other hand, tenuous evidence could suggest that Ammianus had been in Constantinople in the early 380s, which could tally with a visit to a Thracian battlefield.[18]

This not-quite-opposition between allusion and autopsy can be characterised in miniature by varying interpretations of the striking phrase *nunc usque*, 'even now'. The words are reminiscent of the usage in Greek historians of expressions like ἔτι νῦν to confirm the endurance of monuments and practices from the past up to the

[15] 'Unless the statement which he make<s> there is simply to introduce a Virgilian echo.' Blockley (1975), 10 n. 17. For stronger statements, rejecting autopsy because of allusion, see Richter (1974), 166–7, Rosen (1982), 22.

[16] Ch. 2 below, esp. Section II.3.

[17] There is also doubt about whether Ammianus' *oppidum Salices* is to be identified as Ad Salices. Ammianus places the battlefield 'near Marcianople' (31.8.1), and Ad Salices is a hundred miles away. See Heather (1991), 144.

[18] See Ch. 3, n. 171 below.

time of writing. Ammianus has an exceptionally strong awareness of historiographical tradition, and a desire to confirm his qualifications to write the definitive history of his times.[19] It could be argued that it was Ammianus' design to let readers infer the possibility of autopsy, a potent form of authority, whether he had visited the field or not. Equally, one could point to a different function of *nunc usque*: the words act as an intertextual 'signpost' integrated within the text, acknowledging the pre-existence of other literary 'plains white with bones', and, so to speak, putting them inside quotation marks (which is in fact how Guy Sabbah renders the phrase in his Budé translation of Ammianus).[20] 'Even now' draws attention to the allusion and contrasts the present instance with Vergil's ancient Latium and Tacitus' Teutoburger Wald.

I have begun my investigation with this passage not because the minor biographical problem at issue seems important (or even soluble), but because the wider implications certainly are. Those who imagine that Ammianus had visited the battlefield make of him a fellow scientific historian, exploring the terrain in order to aid his analysis. More generally, most scholars, whether or not they have assumed autopsy at this point, have consistently believed that useful biographical information can and should be extracted from and ploughed back into the *Res Gestae*. In contrast to the biographical extrapolations, Ammianus' intertextuality has been plentifully identified, as evidence of his reading habits, but not really interpreted in any detail, perhaps because of a preconception that the former soldier and Greek is an unsophisticated Latinist for whom allusion is ostentation, or even a crutch. Even when the response is not negative, there is often a loss of interest once a feature of Ammianus' work is found to be 'mere literature'. In the rest of this chapter I shall examine both the technique and the interpretability of allusion in the passage. Two main conclusions will emerge. First, the allusions are plentiful, varied, and formally complex, but their multiplicity does not mean that they retreat into the marsh-ground of parallels. Second, the passage has a political

[19] Ch. 2, Section III below.

[20] '. . . comme l'indiquent, encore aujourd'hui, "les plaines blanchies d'ossements".' For examination of this process whereby allusions are given (meta-)textual signals see e.g. Hinds (1998), Ch. 1, and below pp. 184–5, 210.

animus, which is reinforced by its intertextuality: the unburied bones subtly condemn the ruling emperor Theodosius' policy of détente with the Goths.

I The breadth of allusion

The dense allusiveness of the passage can be illustrated by the fact that, as well as the verbal resemblances to the classics Vergil and Tacitus, Ammianus has visibly developed an idea from contemporary literature – by no means a rare phenomenon in his work. Not long after Valens' death, Libanius, the sophist of Antioch, had addressed an oration *On Avenging Julian* to his successor Theodosius. He defends the Roman generals and soldiers from the charges of incompetence and cowardice, calling to mind their many battles, their acceptance of death and how they had stained Thrace, Macedonia and Illyricum with their blood. He continues (*Or.* 24.4):

ἀλλὰ τοῦτο μὲν ἀνεῖλον ὄμβροι καὶ χρόνος, σώζονται δὲ οἱ τῶν ὀστῶν κολωνοί. ἐν δὲ τοῖς ὀστοῖς τούτοις ἐνεῖναί φασι καὶ τὰ ταξιαρχῶν καὶ λοχαγῶν καὶ τῶν ἐν τοῖς ἄλλοις σχήμασιν. ἐν μέσοις δὲ αὐτοῖς ὁ βασιλεὺς μαχόμενος ἔπεσε . . .

Rain and time have carried off the blood, but the piles of bones remain, and among them, they say, are the bones of both generals and captains, and those in other ranks. In the midst of them the emperor fell fighting . . .

Notwithstanding the allusions to Latin authors, purposeful imitation again seems certain here.[21] Ammianus and Libanius share the idea of bones remaining unburied on a battlefield; they also blur the distinction between the battlefields of the whole war and one particular battlefield. But whereas Libanius stresses the equality of the varying ranks (even the emperor) in death, Ammianus describes social discrimination in the burial of the higher ranks only. The character of the interaction with Libanius is striking. It would be tempting to see Ammianus using him as a factual 'source' – but they are describing the aftermath of different battles: Libanius, Adrianople and Ammianus, Ad Salices. The nature of Ammianus' inspiration from his contemporaries differs markedly from

[21] Observed by Sabbah (1978), 282.

modern expectations of how historians use sources, an issue that I shall explore later in this book.[22]

In this dense intertextual thicket, some scholars have responded to the apparent reminiscences of Vergil and Tacitus by cutting Ammianus' learning down to size, and suggesting that he alludes only to one of them.[23] This is probably unwarranted. In the first place, Ammianus alludes elsewhere to the immediate vicinity of both *Aen.* 12.36 and *Ann.* 1.61.[24] Moreover, when the three texts are placed side by side, the allusion to Vergil at any rate appears unmistakable and surprisingly detailed:

. . . sanguine adhuc campique ingentes ossibus albent. (Vergil *Aen.* 12.36)

medio campi albentia ossa. (Tacitus *Ann.* 1.61.2)

ut indicant nunc usque albentes ossibus campi. (Amm. 31.7.16)

Ammianus' *albentes ossibus campi* is a single letter away from the clausula of a Vergilian hexameter.[25] He preserves *campi* and *ossibus* in the same cases and has *albentes* in the position where Vergil placed the rhyming *ingentes*, in each case preceded by enclitic *-que*. As well as advertising the allusion, *nunc usque* also corresponds in meaning ('still') to Vergil's *adhuc*. Yet a case can be also be made for allusion to Tacitus, whose abbreviation of the Vergilian original has picked out exactly the same three words as Ammianus (. . . *campi albentia ossa*), and shares the present participle form with him. Ammianus' near-hexameter ending could be inspired by Tacitus, whose *albentia ossa* need only minor adjustment – in this case, an enclitic *-que* – to make the last two and a half feet of a hexameter.[26] Moreover, the echo of Tacitus is more obviously

[22] Ch. 5. Cf. also Kraus and Woodman (1997), 97–102. Ch. 7 below, and Kelly (2003), 603–6, and (2004), 148–55.

[23] Thus Richter (1974), 366–7, and Barnes (1998), 193 n. 43, dismiss the allusion to Tacitus. Sabbah (1978), 282, on the other hand, excludes the Vergilian allusion by giving privilege to Tacitus as a historian. For good summaries – and diverging views – of the tired topic of Ammianus' allusions to Tacitus see Matthews (1989), 32 and n. 45 (on 482–3), and Fornara (1992b). See also Ch. 4, Section 1.

[24] Cf. 17.4.14 to Vergil *Aen.* 12.35, and 18.2.10 to Tacitus *Ann.* 1.65.

[25] Indeed, in the prosody of earlier Latin poetry, the final 's' of *ossibus* could elide to make *ā/bēntēs/ ōssĭbŭ'/ cāmpī* an unobjectionable fragment of hexameter verse.

[26] The metrical point on Tacitus is taken up in Foucher's work on poetic allusions in Latin historiography (Foucher (2000), 326), from Soubiran (1964), 58. Unfortunately, in his comparison of Ammianus' and Tacitus' allusions to this same passage of Vergil (which

interpretable than the Vergilian one. It implies a comparison of the two great Roman disasters, those of Varus and of Valens, at barbarian hands. In both cases, bones are left unburied and unhallowed many years on, whereas Vergil's Latinus speaks in the immediate aftermath of the battle; and there is a contrast of Germanicus' pious burial of the bones with the failure to do so in the modern case. What we see is perhaps a 'window allusion', a recognition of Tacitus' allusion to Vergil and a linguistic correction to bring him closer to his model.[27]

Further comparison of Ammianus and Tacitus shows aesthetic similarities, worthy of note whether or not they are the product of conscious imitation. Tacitus' magnificent flashback breaches the temporal limits of the work, by referring to an event from before the formal start of the *Annals* in AD 14, rather as Ammianus uses the present tense and *nunc usque* to refer to the state of affairs beyond his formal terminus.[28] In a more developed form than Ammianus, Tacitus deploys a device which might be called archaeological reconstruction, in which the battle or its aftermath is seen through its remains. It is a type of twisted ecphrasis, as is suggested by the untranslatable words which bring Germanicus' army to the scene: *incedunt maestos locos uisuque ac memoria deformes*, 'they enter sad places hateful to look at and remember' (or 'hateful to look at and relate', or even 'twisted by viewing and describing'). The words prepare for the device of having survivors describe the battle by pointing out and reminiscing over the remains (the ambiguity of *memoria* is prolonged by the way that these soldiers both remember *and* relate it).[29] They are also apt signals for the many deformed Vergilian memories which fill Tacitus' text.[30] Ammianus, as I argued above, shares this device of signalling allusion within the text.

predictably comes down hard on the late-antique author), Foucher misses both the fact that Ammianus combines his obedience to the *cursus* with attention to metre and that this is by no means an isolated Vergilian allusion within the passage (n. 31 below).

[27] On 'window allusion' see Thomas (1986), 188–9 (= (1999), 130–2), Wills (1998), 284 and n. 13, and Ch. 4, Section IV.6 below.

[28] See Pagán (2002) for a comparison of the Tacitus passage to Vergil's account of Actium in *Aen.* 8.

[29] For cases of similar ambiguity in the meaning of *memoria* cf. Ch. 2, n. 128 below.

[30] See n. 14 above and n. 31 below.

In this passage Ammianus also shares Tacitus' density of Vergilian allusion. In the preceding sentences, a corpse on the battlefield is found with its head cloven in two and hanging over each shoulder, an allusion to *Aeneid* 9, and day yields to evening with a formula from *Aeneid* 10.[31] The preceding clause (*reliqua peremptorum corpora dirae uolucres consumpserunt*) also has a significant Vergilian allusion. The ominous birds which consume the bodies of the dead are an epic, and originally Vergilian, pairing.[32] Their first appearance is a description of Harpies in *Aen.* 3.262 (*siue deae seu sunt dirae obscenaeque uolucres*, 'whether they be goddesses or ominous and loathsome birds'), and the second comes in the Cacus episode at *Aen.* 8.235, where the Aventine hill is described as *dirarum nidis domus opportuna uolucrum*, 'a fit home for the nestlings of ominous birds'. On the basis of these two usages it appears that *dirus*, as well as its normative meaning of 'ominous', may have a particular meaning when attached to birds, that of 'flesh-eating'. And indeed, in a note on the latter passage Vergil's commentator Servius points out the specialised meaning of *dirus* applied to birds, justifying his view with a cross-reference

[31] Compare 31.7.14 *quorundam* ***capita per medium frontis*** *et uerticis mucrone* ***distincta / in utrumque umerum*** *magno cum horrore* ***pendebant*** ('**the heads** of some, **split** by the sword **through the middle of the forehead** and crown, **were dangling over each shoulder** in horrifying fashion') to Vergil *Aen.* 9.749–56: *sic ait et sublatum alte consurgit in ensem / et* ***mediam*** *ferro gemina inter tempora* ***frontem / diuidit*** *inpubesque immani uolnere malas. / fit sonus, ingenti concussa est pondere tellus: / conlapsos artus atque arma cruenta cerebro / sternit humi moriens, atque illi partibus aequis / huc* ***caput*** *atque illuc* ***umero ex utroque pependit*** ('Thus he speaks, and he rears himself on high towards his lifted sword, and with his steel he **divides the middle of the forehead** between the twin temples, and the youthful cheeks with a massive wound. A sound comes forth, the earth is shaken by the vast weight, his collapsed limbs and weapons gory with brains he spills on to the ground in his death throes, and in equal portions this way and that **his head dangled from each shoulder**'); cf. also 31.7.15 *cedens uespero dies* ('day giving way to evening') to *Aen.* 10.215 *dies caelo concesserat* ('day had given way in the heavens').

[32] It is tempting to identify internal acknowledgement of this allusion, and the plurality of the manifestations of this particular *iunctura*, in the word *assuetae* (cf. p. 17 above). The pairing *dirae uolucres* is first found in the singular in Cicero *Tusc.* 2.24 applied to the eagle which consumed the liver of Prometheus. But Vergil is the primary influence on its appearance in silver epic (Lucan 1.558, Valerius Flaccus 3.508, Statius *Theb.* 2.522, 3.510, 7.404, Silius 13.597). One might also think of the winged *dira* who is sent to destroy Turnus at the very end of the *Aeneid*. *Dirus* is absent from Sallust, very rare in Livy, occasional in Tacitus and frequent in Ammianus. *Volucres* occur once each in Sallust and Livy. The closest Tacitean parallel is *foedae uolucres* in a list of omens at *Hist.* 3.56.1 (to this compare Lucan, loc. cit. above, also in a list of omens).

to the decaying remains left by the monstrous Cacus on which the birds are presumed to have fed:

dirarum modo non mali ominis dicit, ut sunt bubones, sed quae humanis cadaueribus uescebantur. dixit enim <8.196–7> foribusque adfixa superbis ora uirum tristi pendebant pallida tabo.

By *dirarum* he refers not to birds of ill omen, such as owls, but those which fed on human carcasses. For <at 8.196–7> he has written: 'attached to the proud doorposts faces of men hung pallid in ghastly decay'.

This specialised interpretation of *dirus* is supported by the later poets who use this Vergilian pairing, in particular Silius Italicus, who describes a tree in the underworld as if writing a commentary on the introductory words *hic dirae uolucres*. He has the Harpies from *Aeneid* 3, and the nests from *Aeneid* 8, and he appears to allude to an ancestor of Servius' note on *Aen.* 8.235: he has both 'birds of ill-omen, such as owls', and 'those which feed on carcasses' (Silius, *Punica* 13.597-600):[33]

> hic dirae uolucres pastusque cadauere uultur
> et multus bubo ac sparsis strix sanguine pennis
> Harpyiaeque fouent nidos atque omnibus haerent
> condensae foliis; saeuit stridoribus arbor.

Here birds of ill omen dwell – vultures who feed on corpses, troops of owls, and screech owls with blood-spotted plumage, and Harpies have their nests here and cling in clusters to every leaf; the tree is savage with their din.

Like Silius, Ammianus himself appears to allude, with the words *assuetae illo tempore cadaueribus pasci*, to the tradition contained in Servius that has *dirae uolucres* being carnivorous, *quae humanis cadaueribus uescebantur*. (Whether his source was a commentary, or a poem such as Silius' – to which he certainly alludes elsewhere – is not clear.)[34] Ammianus' allusions comment, scholia-like, on their texts. And just as Servius uses the rotten heads outside Cacus'

[33] The passage also alludes to Statius *Theb.* 3.508–12. Surprisingly Spaltenstein's commentary on Silius Italicus (1990) ad 13.597 does not note any aspect of his author's allusion either to Vergil or the commentary tradition; instead he mentions Seneca *Hercules furens* 687–8 *hic uultur, illic luctifer bubo gemit / omenque triste resonat infaustae strigis* ('on this side the vulture, on that the grief-bearing owl groans, and the sad omen of the unlucky screech-owl resounds'.)

[34] Ammianus' allusions to Silius Italicus: Hagendahl (1921), 15 n. 1; Fletcher (1937), 388–9; Owens (1958), 58.

lair to explain *dirae* as carnivorous, so Ammianus combines two Vergilian phrases, 'ominous birds' and 'fields white with bones', with the scholiastic *ut indicant* explaining the causal link between them.

This is an interpretation far removed from, though not absolutely in opposition to, the tendency to think that these words in particular and the passage in general suggest autopsy. But the passage can be pressed further, and a political message inferred.

II Theodosius and the peace

It may be the case that the *dirae uolucres* are flesh-eating birds, but the normative meaning also applies. The birds are omens: they belong to an incessant series of portents throughout the book, as it builds up to Adrianople. Unlike many other ominous phenomena, but like much else in the disastrous Gothic War, they could have been prevented. That much is clear from the intertextuality of the passage. If the allusion to Tacitus *Ann.* 1.61.2 is accepted, there is a significant contrast between the very limited burials carried out at Ad Salices and Germanicus' pious concern with burying all the bodies in the Teutoburger Wald. And more certainly, there is a striking internal allusion to the aftermath of Julian's glorious victory over the Alamanni at Strasbourg (17.1.1).

. . . Martius iuuenis, / Rheno post Argentoratensem pugnam otiose fluente, securus / sollicitusque idem **ne dirae uolucres consumerent corpora peremptorum**, / sine discretione cunctos **humari** mandauit.

His mind at ease now that the Rhine flowed peacefully after the battle at Strasbourg, the warlike youth was at the same time anxious **to keep dreadful birds from devouring the bodies of the slain**, and gave orders that all should **be buried** without distinction.[35]

[35] A correspondence noted by Sabbah (1978), 13 n. 12: 'The verbal echo is such as allows us to believe that Ammianus wishes to make the reader feel the decline in the condition of Roman arms over twenty years, from Julian to Valens' ('l'écho verbal est tel qu'il permet de croire à une volonté de faire sentir la dégradation de la situation des armes romaines en une vingtaine d'années, de Julien à Valens'). It is also possible that the unburied bones at Adrianople could remind a reader through the Vergilian context (*Aen.* 12.35–6) of the battle of Strasbourg, when the Rhine had flowed red with barbarian blood (16.12.57).

Julian's pious and correct behaviour after Strasbourg contrasts with that of the Roman commanders after Ad Salices, whose failure to act produces yet another omen of the greater disaster to come and must be seen as impiety.[36]

With the same words which to some readers seem to imply autopsy – *nunc usque*, 'even now', 'to this very day' – Ammianus extends this implicit criticism of Roman leadership before Adrianople to Roman leadership since Adrianople. A dozen years on, the bones of this battlefield (and, it may be inferred, the whole Gothic War) are still unburied.

After Adrianople, the Goths had penetrated large parts of the Roman Balkans from Thrace to the Julian Alps; they isolated the towns and destroyed villas.[37] The orthodox view is that the treaty of 382 brought peace until 395, though at the expense of establishing something close to a Gothic nation within the frontiers of the empire.[38] But a less positive case can easily be made, and indeed *was* made by contemporaries. There were tensions in the peace: the Greuthungi, a group of Goths outside the empire, were defeated trying to force their way over the Danube in 386, and a Gothic band came close to killing Theodosius in an ambush in 391.[39] In 396, admittedly after Alaric had shattered the peace, Jerome 'shudder[ed] to recall the ruins of our age: for twenty years and more, Roman blood has been spilt every day between Constantinople and the Julian Alps', and, after a comprehensive list of the affected provinces, concluded: 'the Roman world is collapsing and yet we do not bend our haughty necks' (*Ep.* 60.16).[40]

[36] Whether or not he believed in them, Ammianus certainly appears to be using omens as a literary device here, as elsewhere, for example 19.12.20. There is an irresolvable difficulty in proving that references to deities, or the apparent accuracy of omens, or the efficacy of sacrifice, are signs of religious belief rather than literary artifice. On this problem see Davies (2004).

[37] 31.16.7.

[38] Scholarship has been very much concerned with identifying the precise terms of the treaty, though the best of it recognises the disjunction between constitutional theory and reality. See e.g. Heather (1991), 157–92, Cesa (1994), 30–45.

[39] This incident is described by Zosimus 4.48–9. On the period more generally see particularly Heather (1991), 181–92, Burns (1994) and Potter (2004); I also discuss these themes in Kelly (2007), Section III.

[40] *horret animus temporum nostrorum ruinas prosequi – uiginti et eo amplius anni sunt, quod inter Constantinopolim et Alpes Iulias cotidie Romanus sanguis effunditur . . . Romanus orbis ruit et tamen ceruix nostra erecta non flectitur.*

Similarly sensational and critical views of the peace can be found in Ambrose or Synesius, or are implied by the defensive rhetoric of Themistius' or Pacatus' panegyrics.[41]

Such dissatisfaction with the reality of the peace is by implication critical of the regime. Ammianus could not have allotted responsibility at the time when he was writing, during the reign of Theodosius.[42] One need only cite the implication of his closing words that the present age was destined to be the material for panegyrics, in contrast to his history, which was undefiled by lie or silence (31.16.9).[43] Ammianus' occasional references to that emperor lacked the clarity of the panegyrists. His ambiguity is characterised by the quasi-encomiastic description of the campaigns of the emperor's father, Count Theodosius, which one observant reader has found rendered subtly critical of the hero by allusion.[44] Optimistic passages mingle with implied criticism. The end of Book 29 juxtaposes the future emperor's successes with the construction of a portico named after the temple of Good Outcome (29.6.16, 19). But the praise of Valentinian's tolerance damns the religious policies of his successors (30.9.5). Ammianus' adherence to his formal chronological limits becomes notably tighter in the last book. The lack of coverage of western events enables him to pass silently over the execution of Count Theodosius in the winter of 375–6;[45] and whereas Ammianus is willing, especially in Books 26–30, to refer to events beyond the time frame of his

[41] For example, Ambrose, in a work dated to later than 386 (*Expositio Evangelii secundum Lucam* 10.10, *CSEL* 32): *nos quoque in Illyrico exules patriae Gothorum exilia fecerunt et nondum est finis* ('For we too have been made exiles from our fatherland in Illyricum by the exiling of the Goths and no end is yet come'). Examples of the defensiveness of Themistius and Pacatus are e.g. Themistius *Or.* 16.211a, Pacatus *PL* 2.3.3–5. For more examples see Lenski (1997).

[42] One does not have to agree with the more extreme parts of Thompson's arguments (1947, Ch. 7), that Ammianus' last six books showed authorial censorship (that had not been exercised in the earlier books) of pro-pagan feelings which he was no longer at liberty to express. This conception of the repression of the written word, appealing in the Second World War when Thompson wrote, now seems rather unnuanced. But it seems unquestionable that Ammianus could not directly have accused Theodosius of negligence.

[43] See Kelly (2007), and below Ch. 2, Section VI and the Epilogue. [44] Seager (1997b).

[45] Chifflet and Valesius were led to postulate a missing book between 30 and 31 covering western events in 375–8 (most easily found in the introduction to the edition of Wagner and Erfurdt (1808), cxi–cxiii).

history, notably the subsequent careers of his characters, reference to the future is all but absent in Book 31.[46] The book shows one such breach of the work's chronological limits, when we learn, unshatteringly, that Munderichus was later *dux limitis Arabiae* (31.3.5); a second temporal breach has a rather different nature: the meaningful but inexact description of the Thracian plains, 'even now white with bones'.

The closure of the whole work reinforces the subtle criticism of Theodosius. I have already drawn attention to the implication of the closing words, but the last events narrated are also worthy of attention. The Goths give up on attacking Constantinople but wander at will between Thrace and the Julian Alps (31.16.7); Julius, a Roman *magister militum* in the East, organises the elimination of Gothic recruits in the Roman army (31.16.8).[47] The historian makes no suggestion that the Gothic presence would be dealt with in the future and explicitly approves the massacre.

Ammianus' use of *exempla* at an earlier point in that book (31.5.11–17) reinforces this interpretation. The historian complains that certain people ignorant of history had said that the state had never faced such evils before as it faced after Adrianople. They were wrong. The Teutones and Cimbri had been driven out by Marius and other generals.[48] In the time of Marcus, the barbarians were again defeated. Finally, the crisis of the third century had been resolved by Claudius Gothicus and Aurelian. When Ammianus explains the eventual Roman recovery under Marcus, he presents the reader with a sober and conservative morality (31.5.14):

uerum mox post calamitosa dispendia / res in integrum sunt restitutae, hac gratia, / quod nondum solutioris uitae mollitie sobria uetustas infecta / nec ambitiosis

[46] There are six references to events beyond the end of the work in books 14–25 (14.6.19, 19.11.3, 20.4.18, 21.4.2, 21.10.6, 25.10.9), none of which come from the sole reign of Julian. There are thirteen in books 26–30 (26.3.5, 26.5.14, 26.7.2, 26.8.9–10, 27.5.10, 27.6.1, 28.1.57, 28.2.5, 28.6.25, 29.2.16, 29.6.15, 30.3.6–7, 30.10.6).

[47] See Matthews (1989), 16, for Julius' location. See also Elbern (1987), Zuckerman (1991), Sivan (1993), Speidel (1998), Kelly (2007), Section III, as well as the Budé note of Angliviel de la Beaumelle ad loc.

[48] Marius is not named. Eutropius (5.2) is similarly unwilling to attribute the Roman successes to Marius alone, a choice that can be seen as ostentatiously 'senatorial'.

mensis nec flagitiosis quaestibus inhiabat, / sed unanimanti ardore / summi et infimi inter se congruentes / ad speciosam pro re publica mortem / tamquam ad portum aliquem tranquillum properabant et placidum.

But soon, after disastrous losses, the state was restored to health, for this reason: that sober antiquity was not yet tainted with the softness of a more dissolute way of life, and did not gape at lavish feasts or shameful profits, but with single-minded determination, the highest and lowest came together and rushed to a distinguished death for the sake of the republic as though to some quiet and peaceful harbour.[49]

In all the *exempla* which Ammianus offered, the Romans had eventually fought back and conquered, thanks to old-fashioned virtue, unity, selfless leadership – and extirpation of their enemies. There had been little such fight back or genocide after Adrianople, except the massacre of the Goths in Asia Minor (31.16.8). In general, Ammianus did not so much find that the scale of the threat was greater than in the past as that the scale and efficacy of the response was inadequate – as linguistic detail suggests. The allusion to modern-day softness (*mollities*) may well be a discreet anti-Christian jibe.[50] And when he refers to the unanimous determination of the highest and lowest on behalf of the state (***summi et infimi** inter se **congr**uentes*), he introduces a verbal echo recalling the behaviour of Julian's soldiers at Strasbourg (16.12.18): *cunctis igitur **summis infimisque** approbantibus tunc opportune **congr**ediendum* ('so with everyone, both highest and lowest, agreeing that the time was ripe for battle . . .').[51] The implicit comparison to Julian condemns his successors, Theodosius not least among them.

In this context, the 'even now' which Ammianus uses to discuss the bones has a particular significance. Read together with other passages in the final book, this passage appears with a complex mixture of internal and external allusion to express something of

[49] Barnes' interpretation of this passage (1998, 175–6) is illuminating.

[50] For comparison, note the persuasive argument of Woods (1998a) that the *molliores cantilenae* sung by the troops when Julian took over (22.4.6) are snidely described Christian hymns.

[51] Admittedly *congruentes* echoes the sound rather than the precise sense of *congrediendum*.

his interpretation of the causes and the aftermath of the great battle of the age.

III Conclusion

The examination of the bones on the battlefield of Ad Salices and their literary antecedents has shown a remarkable variety of possible approaches. For example, the words *nunc usque* have been interpreted, not necessarily contradictorily, as implied autopsy, as part of a Vergilian allusion, as embedded intertextual marker, and as politically motivated breach of the work's chronological limits. How these various features interact is debateable: for example, one might argue either that the allusions reinforce, or that they obscure, the political criticisms. The passage aptly illustrates what I believe is a general misdirection in previous studies of Ammianus, and introduces some of the chief arguments of this book. Biographical reconstructions are heavily privileged interpretative tools, and have been used to make Ammianus a hyper-anxious bourgeois, sadistic bully, or apostate Christian. Such conclusions might or might not be true, but are utterly speculative. The fragility of biographical interpretations, particularly when the presence of allusion, a far more verifiable phenomenon, is taken into account, will be a theme of Chapters 2–3. My second argument is more pervasive. The detailed interpretation of allusions, the principal interpretative strategy for earlier Latin literature, is little applied to Ammianus: allusions have certainly been plentifully identified, but not in general taken beyond the initial 'cf.' This example helps to demonstrate what sadly appears to need demonstration: that Ammianus' knowledge of Latin literature has depth, and his allusions are not just a disordered cento. Looked at in purely formal terms, they work on the same learned and self-conscious principles as in earlier Latin literature: the similarities between how Ammianus deals with Vergil, and how Silius or Tacitus deal with the same passages, are striking. The formal characteristics of Ammianus' allusions, and their relationship to allusion in earlier classical literature, will be discussed throughout this book, particularly in

Chapter 4. But the following chapters will develop this theme to argue that his allusion frequently has political implications beyond its aesthetic significance. Closely examined, passages such as the bones on the battlefield, or the recollection of Roman successes of old in 31.5.11–17, reveal him deploying allusions and *exempla* to underline or challenge the superficial argument of the text. By failing to read intertextually, political historians risk missing the politics.

CHAPTER 2

THE ADVENTURES OF AMMIANUS

In the spring of 359 Ammianus had been accompanying Ursicinus, his much revered commanding officer, back from the East to Sirmium. Ursicinus had received the position of Master of the Infantry at court (*magister peditum praesentalis*), an ostensible promotion, but, having got as far as Thrace, he received a message from the emperor ordering him and his entourage back to the eastern front (18.6.5). He was to assist his successor as Master of the Cavalry in the East (*magister equitum per orientem*), Sabinianus, but had only very few men under his personal command. Ammianus tells vividly how they played mouse to the Persian army's cat, and how he himself ended up trapped in the besieged city of Amida, eventually escaping during its capture. The narrative is thrilling and fast moving: 'there are few passages in ancient literature as evocative'.[1] The landscape is massive and looming, and the individuals small against it. The most prolonged passage of first-person narration in Ammianus' oeuvre, it is also the most personal.

At a moment of profound peril, when the Romans had been ambushed on the road from Amida, and Ursicinus had fled the battle, Ammianus found himself alone (18.8.11):

> mihi dum auius ab itinere comitum, / quid agerem, circumspicio, / Verinianus domesticus protector occurrit, / femur sagitta confixus; / quam dum auellere obtestante collega conarer, / cinctus undique antecedentibus Persis, / ciuitatem petebam / anhelo cursu rependo.
>
> As for me, I had taken a direction apart from my companions and was looking around what to do, when Verinianus, a *protector domesticus*, came up to me, stuck in the thigh with an arrow; and while at my colleague's bidding I was trying to pull it out, being surrounded on all sides by the foremost Persians, I made for the city [Amida], crawling in a breathless race.

[1] Potter (1999), 29. Similar praise of autobiographical passages in Thompson (1947), 9, Rosen (1968), 33, Matthews (1989), 46, Marincola (1997), 201.

Verinianus was the historian's contemporary in the elite regiment of the *protectores domestici*: he had shared with him in the dangerous mission against the usurper Silvanus in Cologne four years before, and like him had been too young for promotion when Ursicinus was sent back from the West two years before (15.5.22, 16.10.21). He is the only army comrade of the historian whose name is known to the reader. Whether Verinianus said anything as the Persians caught up with them, whether he begged his friend to finish removing the arrow, or urged him to make his escape when he could, we are not told; nor whether Ammianus saw what happened to him. But he was presumably held back by his injury, and is never mentioned again.

For some readers this moment encapsulates something distasteful in Ammianus' character. The case is most concisely made by Roger Blockley: 'as he passes through various adventures, he is totally alone – no friendship, no real relationship at all, no feelings'.[2] Timothy Barnes, in a quietly melodramatic mode, goes further. He adds as evidence the summary execution by Ursicinus' men of a deserter who was spying for the Persians, brusquely and unemotionally described (18.6.16), and the immediate sequel to his leaving Verinianus, when he spent a night on the narrow path up to Amida, pressed against a corpse (18.8.12):

> . . . ita conferti, / ut caesorum cadauera multitudine fulta / reperire ruendi spatium nusquam possent, / utque miles ante me quidam, / discriminato capite, quod in aequas partes ictus gladii fiderat ualidissimus, / in stipitis modum undique coartatus haereret.
>
> We were packed together to such a degree that the bodies of the slain were propped up by the multitude and could find no space to fall, and so that a soldier in front of me, with his head split open, riven into two halves by a powerful sword stroke, stood still like a tree stump, hemmed in on every side.

Barnes concludes that 'the fourth century was a brutal age, and the historian was capable of brutality', and goes on to infer (riskily, as he admits), from a description of the resistance of Egyptian peasants to torture (22.16.23), that 'Ammianus may have enjoyed

[2] Blockley (1975), 156.

inflicting pain on others. For much in his narrative has a palpably sadistic quality.'[3]

Blockley is right to draw attention to the silence on Verinianus' fate: it is a brutal piece of writing. But I am uneasy about subjecting autobiographical sections of the text to psychological readings: Ammianus was writing a literary history, a self-conscious act. This was how he chose to portray himself. The sentence describing the encounter with Verinianus jumps from idea to idea and person to person, matching the breathless sequence of events which befell Ammianus. Ancient historians knew as well as their modern counterparts that an individual witness does not provide a complete or ideal account, particularly in battle, and Ammianus is describing his experiences rather than the skirmish as a whole.[4] He probably never saw his colleague's fate and had no time to think about it. The narrative, it may be argued, is purposely mimetic of the historian's experience.

The aim of this chapter is to explore the function of passages of personal memoir in the *Res Gestae*. They are a notable and distinct feature of the work, unusual in classical historiography both in their length and (much of the time) their vividness.[5] Just as Ammianus' last sight of Verinianus has encouraged psychological extrapolation, so more generally the presence of involved personal narrative has led to the perception of the historian as exhibiting, in Arnaldo Momigliano's words, 'an almost indecent readiness to talk about himself'.[6] John Matthews, who rejects the allegation that Ammianus is evasive, evokes the sections of open autobiography and calls him 'in many respects the most self-revealing of ancient historians'.[7] One may or may not agree with this assessment, but such passages have undoubtedly been a major factor in encouraging the interpretation of other parts of the work as covert autobiography. (My own view, already expressed in Chapter 1, is that this practice

[3] Barnes (1998), 100–2.

[4] See Woodman (1988), 15–23, on Thucydides 1.22. On the problems of writing literary accounts of battles see Keegan (1988), 17–66.

[5] The obvious exceptions are works on the fringes of historiography, Xenophon's *Anabasis* and the commentaries of Caesar.

[6] Momigliano (1974), 1394. He continues: 'yet there were limits to what even an unconventional historian could say about himself in the course of his work'.

[7] Matthews (1989), 5.

is methodologically flawed: it will be subjected to fuller critique in Chapter 3.) These passages have caused bemusement to those critics who think that a failed attempt to pull an arrow from a thigh, for example, is inconsonant with Ammianus' belief that history should avoid *minutiae* – to say nothing of their own preconceptions about history.[8] And beyond the question of these passages' relevance, scholars throughout the twentieth century cast major doubts on the reliability of large parts of the first-person narrative: they were found too implausible to be true – or else too plausible.[9] It is hardly surprising that autobiography should be scrutinised for partisanship, and Ammianus' undeniably defensive and partial attitude towards Ursicinus may affect large portions of his first-person narrative.[10] More striking is the suggestion that his desire to write a learned and allusive history has taken precedence over strict truth.[11] A classic example, which will be examined in greater detail in Section IV, is his apparent claim to have seen the Persian army, led by Sapor himself, from a high point fifty miles distant.[12] But the phenomenon may be more widespread. The description of the dead soldier on the path to Amida has been doubted: a soldier with his head split in two reappears on the battlefield of Ad Salices in Book 31, and both cases allude to a Vergilian original. Could this be a sensational and learned fiction?[13] Even the arrow in Verinianus' thigh is redolent of a number of precedents from epic.[14]

A survey will confirm that the passages of memoir are far from artless. Ammianus is both highly selective and studiously evasive in personal interventions in his narrative (Section I). Nevertheless, he constantly possesses, and at times boldly exhibits, a sophisticated awareness of the tensions between the roles of eyewitness-narrator and literary historian. The presence of autopsy, as one would expect

[8] Avoidance of *minutiae*: 26.1.1, cf. 23.1.1, 28.2.12. See Austin (1983) for an assessment of autobiography in Ammianus against historiographical criteria which are unashamedly, and unexaminedly, modern.

[9] See in particular Büdinger (1895), Rosen (1968), Paschoud (1989), (1999b).

[10] See Thompson (1947), 42–55, and n. 37 below.

[11] Rosen (1968), 10–68, Paschoud (1989), 41–53, and (1999b). [12] Section IV below.

[13] Matthews (1989), 486 n. 22, exhibits doubts at this point, though his robust positivism eventually, and characteristically, triumphs. See 31.7.14, Vergil *Aen.* 9.749–56 (quoted in Ch. 1, n. 31) and 6.540.

[14] Rosen (1968), 37 n. 1, cites Homer *Il.* 4.210–19, 5.109–13, Vergil *Aen.* 12.387–90.

in a classical historian, is related to Ammianus' claim to special authority in describing the events of his own period: in particular he likes to portray himself alone and in danger, a sole imperilled witness. The allusiveness of passages of autopsy to earlier historiography and other literature functions as an additional form of authority, which can sit uneasily, though not necessarily in conflict, with the authority derived from autopsy (Sections III–V). Accordingly, in what follows, I shall reach no sweeping conclusions on Ammianus' veracity (though in Section II I shall defend him, or not, in individual cases), but concentrate instead on exploring how autopsy and allusion interact in creating Ammianus' authoritative persona.

This is, it hardly needs saying, a very partial interpretation: I would not wish to obscure the strange, picaresque, and vividly real qualities of the narrative, and I would not wish to discourage interpretations of these passages as valuable historical evidence for war and espionage on the Persian front. I can imagine a reader retorting to me that it is common for memoirists to recall the events of their twenties with particular vividness: the memoirs are there because they are exciting, and they reflect the need of a man in his sixties to record the simultaneously traumatic and wondrous events of his early manhood, when his strength was undiminished and, caught between responsibility and irresponsibility, he took risks unimaginable later. To such a reader I would reply that, although this is a valuable insight for understanding Ammianus' memoirs, it is neither a profound nor an adequate explanation of how the passages of memoir work within his history. Nor does their vividness confirm their truthfulness.

I The autobiographical passages

Let us begin by surveying the historian's own appearances in his narrative. I have taken into consideration all interventions using the first-person pronoun or verb, whether 'I' or 'we'. There are of course other places where historian's autopsy may be suspected;[15]

[15] See Smith's discussion of the 'implied narrator', (1999), 97–100.

and some of these first-person interventions I shall pass over relatively swiftly. One such category is the author's presence in historiographical organisation (prefaces, cross-references, or glosses of non-Latin words). It should be emphasised, however, that there is not a clear-cut distinction between the historian as participant and the historian as writer. The claim to depend on autopsy and witnesses in the preface to Book 15 is a historiographical statement with undeniable relevance for autobiography, and I shall argue below (Section III) that apparently personal interventions of the historian very often support his capacity to write history. Most of the autobiographical interventions cluster in Books 14–25, while more consideration of the nature and perils of history can be found in Books 26–31: this distribution could suggest that they are more similar in function than they may seem.[16] It should also be noted that there may well have been autobiographical interventions in the lost books. When Ammianus mentions his dependence on autopsy and interviews at the start of Book 15, he is clearly describing what has already been his practice, and is only changing to the extent of writing with greater polish and detail.[17]

The use of the first person in digressions also deserves mention, if only in *praeteritio*. Ammianus famously introduced his geographical digression on the Black Sea as containing 'things seen and things read' (22.8.1).[18] And though scholarship has concurred about the dominance of 'things read', claims of autopsy, or language interpretable as such, are nevertheless found in almost all the geographical digressions. He leaves a powerful impression of his wide-ranging travels, though intruding himself only briefly in each case. He had beheld the Saracens' ignorance of corn and wine; he had read inscriptions on Gallic monuments proclaiming the deeds

[16] As is argued by Jan den Boeft in a recent article (2007), 293–4: he improves on my phrasing in Kelly (2004), 142.

[17] See Fornara (1990). The prefaces of Books 15 and, especially, 26 have often been seen as breaks in composition. But both are concerned with style: the condemnation of excessive brevity and undertaking to write with greater polish (*limatius*) in 15, and the particular dangers of contemporary history and the rejection of excessive prolixity in 26. The aspiration to greater polish is surely because Books 15–25 embrace the imperial career of Julian. See Matthews (1989), 457 and 550 n. 12, 481 n. 36, for an argument that *limatius* should not be interpreted as a comparative.

[18] Similarly, the account of Egypt later in the book was 'for the most part' a description of what he himself had seen (*uisa pleraque narrantes*, 22.15.1).

of Hercules in that country; he had seen the many obelisks, erect and grounded, of Egyptian Thebes; he had crossed the Greater and Lesser Zab, on the Persian side of the Tigris.[19] His comic digression on the depredations of lawyers in the East, though as dense an allusive patchwork as any of the geographical digressions, claims a basis in what he himself had experienced when he lived there (30.4.4). In other places autopsy is a possible inference: a whole band of foreigners (*peregrinorum globus*) will be unable to fight a Gaul if he calls in his wife (15.12.1),

> stronger than he by far and flashing-eyed . . . , least of all when she swells her neck and gnashes her teeth, and, poising her huge white arms, proceeds to rain punches mingled with kicks, like shots discharged by the twisted cords of a catapult.

Whether an unfortunate encounter with an innkeeper's wife or a literary topos or both combined underlie this arresting picture, hardly admits of a clear answer.[20] A more promising case of possible autopsy has been identified in the digression on Persia. The modesty of Persian males means that it is not easy to see them urinate in a standing position (*haud facile uisitur*, 23.6.79). This we knew from Herodotus (1.133), but when Ammianus describes the Persian aversion to drunkenness and pederasty, he diverges from the ethnographical tradition (Hdt. 133–5): it has been persuasively argued that he collates and corrects the tradition against his own experience.[21] That Persian nobles went into battle on special 'Nesaean' horses, he could confirm both from reading the ancients and also from his own testimony (23.6.30). To describe Thrace would be easy, if writers of old were in agreement: as their lack of clarity and contradictoriness were useless for 'a work which claimed truthfulness', it would be sufficient to set out what he himself remembered having seen (27.4.2).[22] (A 'work which

[19] 14.4.6, 15.9.6, 17.4.6, 23.6.21. The identity of the rivers Diabas and Adiabas as the Zabs is not certain: elsewhere he calls the Greater Zab Anzaba. See den Boeft *et al.* ad 23.6.21.

[20] *nec enim eorum quemquam adhibita uxore rixantem, / multo fortiore et glauca, / peregrinorum ferre poterit globus, / tum maxime cum illa inflata ceruice suffrendens / ponderansque niueas ulnas et uastas / admixtis calcibus emittere coeperit pugnos / ut catapultas tortilibus neruis excussas.* The question of the personal applicability of the passage prompts a disagreement between Matthews (1989), 39, and Barnes (1998), 100.

[21] Teitler (1999).

[22] *erat Thraciarum descriptio facilis, / si ueteres concinerent stili, / quorum obscura uaritetas quoniam opus ueritatem professum non iuuat, / sufficiet ea, quae uidisse memnimus, expedire.*

claims truthfulness', *opus ueritatem professum*, is the historian's proud boast of his achievement in the epilogue to the *Res Gestae* (31.16.9); the verbal coincidence gives added importance to this exaltation of personal testimony over literary sources.) Ammianus, then, makes explicit autopsy supplement and sometimes replace the traditional authority of earlier literature in these digressions, and I shall suggest later that autopsy throughout the work is in a wider sense concerned with asserting authority.

These, however, are the autobiographical passages from the main narrative of the history:

(1) 14.9.1: When Ursicinus, the *magister equitum per orientem*, is summoned from Nisibis by Gallus to hear treason trials in Antioch in early 354, Ammianus states that he had been assigned to Ursicinus' staff by imperial command (*cui nos obsecuturos iunxerat imperiale praeceptum*).
(2) 14.11.5: Ammianus hurries with Ursicinus from Antioch to the court at Milan (354).
(3) 15.5.22–31: Ursicinus is ordered from Milan to Cologne in order to deal with Silvanus' usurpation; he is allowed an entourage of ten tribunes and *protectores domestici*, who include Ammianus and Verinianus. On reaching Cologne they pretend to defect and then successfully bribe some of Silvanus' men to kill him. Ammianus vividly describes the party's fearful and rapid outward journey and their search for a plan, but consistently shows himself as part of a group (August–September 355).
(4) 16.10.21: Ursicinus is sent back to the East; Ammianus' older comrades are given commands of their own, while he and the younger *protectores domestici* remain attached to Ursicinus (early summer of 357).
(5) 18.4.7–19.8.12: The Persian War of 359 contains the longest and most intimate sequences of first-person narrative in the *Res Gestae*.
    (a) 18.4.7: Ammianus and Ursicinus (still *magister equitum per orientem*) are at Samosata, when they learn that a well-known merchant and *protector*, Antoninus, has defected to Persia, a major intelligence coup for the enemy.
    (b) 18.6.5–7.2: Meanwhile, thanks to the scheming eunuchs at court, Ursicinus has been recalled to be *magister peditum praesentalis* in Sirmium. His party, including Ammianus, travels as far as Thrace, where orders sending them back to Mesopotamia reach them (6.5). Having met Ursicinus' successor as *magister equitum*, Sabinianus, at Edessa (6.7), they travel on to Nisibis to shore up the defences (6.8). On their way back, Ammianus is pursued

by Persians, and Ursicinus' party flees to Amida (6.11–17). There they receive a coded message from Procopius (Julian's cousin, later a usurper, but then an ambassador to Persia), warning about the Persian army's invasion route (6.17–19); this intelligence is confirmed when Ammianus is sent over the mountains of the Tur 'Abdin to the pro-Roman satrap of Corduene, Jovinianus, who has him taken to a high peak above the confluence of the Tigris and the Greater Zab where he can see the Persian advance. He returns to Jovinianus and thence to Amida with his information (6.20–7.2).

(c) 18.8.1–13: As Ursicinus and his entourage leave Amida, they are ambushed by a large Persian force (1–3). The defector Antoninus has a dramatic battlefield exchange with Ursicinus (5–6); soon more Persians attack their rear, and the Romans are scattered, Ursicinus escaping on horseback (7–10). Ammianus is approached by Verinianus, who begs him to pull an arrow from his thigh; but finding himself surrounded by the enemy Ammianus flees up the hill to Amida (11). He is caught on the narrow paths overnight, so tightly packed with men that a dead body next to him had nowhere to fall (12).[23] In the morning he enters the town by a postern gate (13).

(d) 19.1–8.4: The siege of Amida. Though the siege is described with a wealth of detail, including much implied autopsy, Ammianus lets his involvement be seen only as part of a group.

(e) 19.8.5–12: Having hidden during the capture of the city, Ammianus slips out of Amida at nightfall by a postern gate with two companions (*euado*, 5). After ten miles of flight, Ammianus, who being a gentleman is unaccustomed to going on foot, has his exhaustion relieved by a fortuitous horse, which appears dragging a dead rider behind it: he had fallen off and been unable to untie himself from the reins (6–7). Ammianus and his companions drink water from a well, using tied-up clothing as a rope and a cloth hat to soak up the water (8); coming to the Euphrates they see a Roman column attacked by Persians appearing suddenly over the horizon (9–11). Over rough country Ammianus reaches Melitena, a town of lower Armenia, and thence 'beyond hope, we saw Antioch once more' (*Antiochiam reuisimus insperati*, 12).

(6) 23.5.7–25.10.1: Julian's Persian expedition of 363. Ammianus first mentions his presence when Julian advances from Cercusium to Zaitha. Here as throughout the Persian campaign he only uses the first person plural. Large portions of the narrative are narrated in

[23] One problem with this story is the timing: the ambush seems to take place soon after daybreak (18.8.4), but Ammianus is trapped on the pathways overnight. To this I can offer no solution except that the narrative is contracted.

the third person, and such personal interventions as there are tend to represent the army's experience as much as the historian's (typically *uenimus* and *uidimus*). First-person narration ceases when Jovian's army reaches Antioch.

(7) 26.10.19: Ammianus concludes an account of the great tsunami of 365 by saying that at Methone in the Peloponnese, when he later passed by, he had seen a ship which the wave had tossed nearly two miles inland: it was 'yawning apart from long decay' (*nos transeundo conspeximus, diuturna carie fatiscentem*).

(8) 29.1.24: Ammianus confirms his eyewitness testimony of the treason trials of Valens, presumably in Antioch, in 371/2: 'we saw many sentenced after torturous punishments' (*addici post cruciabiles poenas uidimus multos*).

(9) 29.2.4: Ammianus describes the atmosphere of terror caused by Valens' treason trials: 'at that time we were all crawling about as if in Cimmerian darkness, fearing terrors equal to those of Sicilian Dionysius' party-guests' (*omnes ea tempestate uelut in Cimmeriis tenebris reptabamus, paria conuiuis Siculi Dionysii pauitantes*).[24]

At first sight, it is not surprising that Ammianus is seen as a self-revealing historian. Not only does he let us know the technique which he used to drink water from a well when he and his companions lacked bucket or rope, but he also reinforces the impression given by his encounter with Verinianus outside Amida, that he is willing to tell us candidly of his unheroic side, including various other escapes from battle, and involvement in an assassination plot in which others did the dirty work. And yet, for all the occasional self-revelation and intimacy of detail, it is the lack of intimacy that should stand out from this list: indeed Ammianus' occasional candour could be interpreted precisely as a careful and calculated attempt at creating the impression of guileless honesty. If, as I have here, one takes the adventures of Books 18 and 19 as a single appearance, only three out of nine appearances last longer than a single sentence (15.5.22–31, 18.4.7–19.8.12, 23.5.7–25.10.1). When Ammianus first appears in 14.9.1, Ursicinus has been summoned to Antioch by Gallus to preside over treason trials: one may assume the historian was present at those trials, but it is only an assumption. It is something of a surprise to learn that Ursicinus

[24] Slightly later in the chapter comes a piece of implied autopsy (29.2.15), to be discussed below.

and Ammianus were in the West from the suppression of Silvanus in September 355 until the early summer of 357, in the very period when the young Julian was developing his wholly unexpected military and administrative talents.[25] In 356 Ursicinus was at Rheims when Julian passed through (16.2.8). Nothing in the narrative displays Ammianus' presence or proximity, although he had opined that Julian's reign as Caesar in Gaul was the greatest of his achievements (16.1.5).[26] This pattern continues. There is no indication of the historian's activities between his return to Antioch in 359 and his sudden appearance at Cercusium in 363, and no knowledge of whether he continued in the army afterwards (the weakly supported speculations on these subjects will be discussed in Chapter 3, Section II). Ammianus, it is clear, has only included highlights.

The image of Ammianus Marcellinus as a compulsive memoirist is undermined not only by the gaps between the appearances, but also by the varying depth of his involvement: this is clear from his first major eyewitness appearance. When Ursicinus was entrusted by Constantius II with suppressing the usurpation of Silvanus, he asked for ten tribunes and *protectores domestici*, of whom Ammianus was one, with his colleague Verinianus (*inter quos ego quoque eram cum Veriniano collega*, 15.5.22).[27] The first person singular is used in the chapter only this once, to introduce the historian's participation. On arrival, they found themselves in too deep (*inuenimus cuncta nostris conatibus altiora*, 15.5.24), and the decision was made for Ursicinus to pretend to go over to Silvanus. Passive decision-making is the pattern of this unsavoury narrative. Fear afflicts Ammianus and his colleagues (26, 29). The decisions, once made, are expressed by such impersonal phrases as

[25] Ursicinus' presence in Gaul is alluded to unobtrusively at 15.13.3, in a complaint about his stand-in's corruption in the East.

[26] See Frézouls (1962) on this phase of Ammianus' and Ursicinus' careers. He suggests (683) that Ammianus' reticence may in part be due to Ursicinus' failure to prevent the barbarian attacks of the winter of 355–6 – not least the capture of Cologne by the Franks only a few months after he had suppressed Silvanus there. It was impossible for both Ursicinus and Julian to come out well of the crisis and its resolution (see Sabbah (1978), 464–6).

[27] A lacuna obscures the identity of the rest. Seyfarth's Teubner fills it with Pighi's supplement: *residui<s> omni<bus ab imperatore delectis>*, 'with all the rest chosen by the emperor'. This is certainly an improvement on the Vulgate's *residui omn[i]<es propinqui et familiares>*, 'all the rest friends and relations'.

uidebatur, 'it seemed good' (25), and *sederat*, 'it had been settled' (30). He is willing to acknowledge that 'we searched around' for a plan (*scrutabamus*, 30), but otherwise there seems to be a constant effort to avoid being the subject of the sentence, or responsible for the eventual decision to bribe some of Silvanus' men to kill him. There is no use of the first person singular after the *ego* with which Ammianus announces his involvement on the mission. Indeed, narrative appearances of the first person singular are otherwise only found in four solo exploits during the war of 359.[28] Here too there is light and shade in the extent to which the eyewitness-narrator participates. The flight from battle from which I quoted at the start of the chapter ends with the historian arriving in Amida. As soon as he enters the city, he finds a mass of people (18.8.13) crowded in there because of a fair. Merging into the crowd, he takes the opportunity for the narrative to abandon the first person singular for ten chapters until his emergence from the city at the end of the siege (*euado*, 19.8.5). Though the narrative of Amida is visual and personal in a number of ways, even the first person plural is used sparingly.[29] At times it seems to associate Ammianus with those officers in charge of the defence, the tribunes and *protectores* under Count Aelianus: 'we' indicates those who had to deal, for example, with the problem of aggressive and ill-disciplined Gaulish legions who were unsuited for siege warfare.[30] At other times 'we' refers more generally to the Romans within the city, as when he writes of how 'we strove for glorious ends to our lives, wished for by us all' – a pious emotion in nice contrast to Ammianus' inglorious flight when the siege ends.[31] In one case only does 'we' refer to the historian himself, who states that he has seen secret staircases down

[28] Blockley (1988), 245: 18.6.10–11, 18.6.21–7.2, 18.8.11–13, 19.8.5–12 (5b, 5c and 5e above). In each case the narrative opens with the first person singular before retreating into the plural.

[29] Ammianus describes the view from the walls at a number of places using the passive voice: 'as far as could be seen' (19.1.2, 19.1.5, 19.2.2, 19.2.12).

[30] *inopes nos consilii et quid opponi deberet saeuientibus ambigentes, / id potissimum aegre eisdem assentientibus / tandem elegimus . . .*, 'We, bereft of a plan and uncertain what could be put in the path of their savagery, at last chose this [a sortie] as the best course, with their reluctant agreement' (19.6.5). For one scholar, this is evidence that the Gallic sortie 'was to a large extent the work of Ammianus himself', a startling extrapolation (Austin (1979), 15). 'We' also seems to refer to those in command at 19.5.6 and 19.7.6.

[31] *gloriosos uitae exitus deinde curabamus, iamque omnibus nobis optatos* (19.2.4).

to the river in other cities of the region (19.5.4): the preservation of the first person plural at this point accords with the practice for geographical descriptions elsewhere.[32]

If the sudden impersonality of personal narrative in Amida were insufficient proof of the profoundly calculated nature of the inclusion of first-person narrative, the Persian expedition shows even more studious evasion. Here the first person plural appears always to refer to the army as whole. It is used only intermittently, and in most cases simply to say 'we saw' or 'we came', though as the expedition nears its tragic climax the first-person verbs become somewhat more frequent and more involved. Interestingly, the first-person voice is never used to observe the actions of Julian himself.[33] But the 'we' of these passages never allows more than an inconclusive guess as to what his actual rôle in the expedition was – which has not stopped a great deal of speculation.[34] Altogether, Ammianus' distance from the narrative is such that a great deal of source criticism has been able misguidedly to play down his personal presence.[35]

An even greater challenge to reading the first-person passages as uncomplicated memoir, however, lies in the problems with their truth value. Severe challenges to their veracity have been put forward by scholars throughout the twentieth century. It is not, of course, only in autobiographical sections that Ammianus has been seen as betraying the historian's commitment to truth because of personal biases or the desire to write a literary history, but it is startling to what extent these passages have been the target of criticism. Indeed François Paschoud has forcefully argued that, rather than possessing an extraordinary credibility, claims of autopsy should be viewed as being *more* suspect and *more* subject to the influence of tradition.[36] I shall examine the challenges to Ammianus' veracity under three headings (for ease of organisation rather than because they are always objectively distinct): first accusations

[32] E.g. 14.4.6, 17.4.6, 23.6.30.

[33] Smith (1999), 98. This combines interestingly with the absence of autopsy in the narrative of events in Gaul between the death of Silvanus and the historian's departure for the East nearly two years later.

[34] I shall touch on this in greater detail in Ch. 3, Section II.

[35] For a discussion and demolition see Dillemann (1961), 115–35; see also Fornara (1991).

[36] Paschoud (1989), 39.

of partisanship, then the effect on the text of narrative features such as ring composition and anticipation, and finally the suggestion that the contents of the personal passages are shaped by literary precedents. Inevitably, the events of 359 – by far the longest and most intimate passages of autobiography – will predominate.

II Problems of veracity

1 Ursicinus and partisanship

The most persistent allegation against Ammianus' personal narrations, unsurprising given the preponderance in the literature of source-based historical critics, is partisanship. In particular, persistent personal bias in favour of Ursicinus is alleged. Ever since E. A. Thompson's revisionist book of 1947, Ursicinus' failings as a general, and Ammianus' blindness to them, have been taken for granted. The two main autobiographical sections in the first hexad are potentially affected, the Silvanus episode and the war of 359.[37]

It has been argued with good reason that the defence of Ursicinus is a major factor in how Ammianus narrated the elimination of Silvanus, a Frankish *magister peditum* who in 355 was forced by conspiracies at court into a half-hearted usurpation from the fringes of the empire (15.5).[38] Silvanus was, it should be admitted, markedly able and well-connected.[39] Nevertheless, the rebellion was the direct result of failures of communication; the revolting troops did not leave Cologne; no large army went against them; the usurper was dead within twenty-eight days (his reign probably ran from 11 August to 7 September).[40] All this means that more was known of manoeuvrings at court in Milan than of events at Cologne,

[37] Thompson (1947), 42–55, supported by e.g. Momigliano (1974), 1400 ('an intriguer and a bad general'), and Blockley (1988).

[38] See den Boer (1960), Nutt (1973), Blockley (1980a), 1–22, Fernández Gonzalo (1989), Drinkwater (1994), Brennecke (1998b) and Hunt (1999).

[39] Bleckmann (2000) argues persuasively for Silvanus' connections in the court and in Italy, though it is unnecessary to accept the authenticity, which he tentatively defends, of the two Campanian inscriptions dedicated to Silvanus as emperor (*CIL* x.6945 = *ILS* 748, *CIL* x.6946).

[40] See Seeck (1906a), 501, and (1919), 201. A reign as short as a lunar month provoked the contempt of Constantius II's propagandists, as exemplified by Julian *Or.* 2.99a, and reflected in sources dependent on the *Kaisergeschichte* (see n. 43 below).

as can be seen from the wide range of sources which refer to the episode, fleetingly for the most part.[41] Julian's panegyrics of Constantius, the first of which probably belongs as early as 356, mock Silvanus' hastily manufactured purple garb as effeminate and portray the tyrant's suppression as resulting from the righteous anger of the troops, a lynching comparable to the bacchants tearing King Pentheus to pieces (*Or.* 1.48c, *Or.* 2.98d–99a).[42] But other contemporary panegyrists and breviarists know or tell little.[43] Other than Ammianus, the most detailed source to describe what happened at Cologne is the twelfth-century monk Zonaras, who reflects a more positive tradition about Silvanus which is also found in the *Epitome de Caesaribus* (42.10) and which was quite probably known to Ammianus.[44] Zonaras also makes the only reference to Ursicinus in any historical source other than his former protégé's *Res Gestae* (13.9.24): 'for Ursicinus was sent there and having corrupted some of Silvanus' soldiers with money, used them to dispose of him'.[45]

As one of only ten officers on Ursicinus' mission (15.5.22), Ammianus was in a position to contribute a great deal to the otherwise hazy state of knowledge. And yet although there are many informed details – Ursicinus adoring the usurper's purple, the Bracchiati and Cornuti bribed, Silvanus ambushed on the way to

[41] Comprehensively listed in Nutt (1973). Zosimus, ineptly derived from the near contemporary Eunapius, has a number of details of the plot against Silvanus transferred to Gallus Caesar (2.55.2–3).

[42] On dating Julian *Or.* 1 see Bidez (1932), 3. See also *Ep. ad Ath.* 273d, 274c.

[43] To Julian's panegyrist Mamertinus (*PL* 3.13) Silvanus seems little more than a name; Libanius uses a generalising plural (*Or.* 18.31). To Victor (42.14–16) and Eutropius (10.13) he is the merest detail in their overall coverage of Constantius. Although they were both contemporaries, their brief accounts, and that of Jerome (*Chron.* s.a. 354), may well be influenced by the anonymous *Kaisergeschichte*: Richard Burgess has argued plausibly that this work had a particular interest in usurpers (1993) and that it, or a version of it, was published soon after 357 (Burgess (1995), esp. 127: Burgess (2005) offers a somewhat different approach).

[44] See Bleckmann (2000), 480. On the repeated and intriguing links between Ammianus and Zonaras, many of which were first identified by Valesius, see Bleckmann (1992), 327–95. DiMaio (1980), (1981) supports the alternative theory, originally Patzig's, which sees Ammianus, mediated through John of Antioch, as Zonaras' source.

[45] σταλεὶς γὰρ Οὐρσικῖνος ἐκεῖ καὶ χρήμασι τῶν ἐκείνου στρατιωτῶν τινας ὑποφθείρας, δι' ἐκείνων ἀνεῖλε τὸν Σιλβανόν. The absence of Ursicinus from the historical record outside Ammianus and Zonaras is observed by Valesius ad 15.5.31 and *PLRE* 1, s.v. Vrsicinus 2. Both missed references in the Palestinian Talmud to his role in the suppression of the Jewish revolt of 351–2, on which see Geiger (1979), Delmaire (1982) and Barnes (1998), 47–8 n. 15, 130 and n. 5. *PLRE* 1 speculates that he may be mentioned on some brick stamps from Pannonia Superior.

church – the recurring motif of the narrative is the fear and indecision of Ammianus and his colleagues. Moreover, some aspects of the account have been found implausible, or at any rate hard to explain. The case has been made most forcibly by John Drinkwater.[46] He points out that the distance between Silvanus in Cologne and the imperial court in Milan was probably little less than a week's journey even at the fastest speed. Ammianus may be reticent rather than deceitful; but how could Ursicinus have reached Cologne without it being assumed that he had heard of the usurpation on the way, and consequently falling under suspicion?[47] Surely pretended defection must have been the plan from the outset? Adducing the fact that no authentic coins of Silvanus are extant, Drinkwater speculates that Ursicinus may have been sent before the usurpation was known, or even that the assassination was part of a private feud between the two men, and that the usurpation was invented.[48] But this absence of coins can be explained by the fact (which Drinkwater himself notes) that the troops had been paid in Constantius' name four days before the usurpation (15.6.3), diminishing the urgency of minting coinage.[49] David Hunt suggests that the absence of coins 'may be a product of [the usurpation's] peculiarly local character, and a failure to gain control of the nearest mint at Trier (if in any case that was still in operation in August 355)'.[50] The problem may ultimately be irresolvable because of the lack of information, but Drinkwater's case seems overstated. The feeling remains that Ammianus' focus on how (entirely reasonably in the circumstances) fear and indecision afflicted him and his colleagues, and his use of passive or impersonal verbs to describe their actions until mention of their involvement ceases abruptly before Silvanus' death, indicate a desire to defend Ursicinus. The story would make far more sense as an efficient and carefully planned assassination mission than as an agonised improvisation.

Silvanus is portrayed sympathetically, and given a favourable obituary as 'a leader of no slender merits' (*dux haud exilium meritorum*, 15.5.32). Various explanations can be advanced for

[46] Drinkwater (1994). [47] Drinkwater (1994), 570–2.
[48] Drinkwater (1994), 574–6. [49] Drinkwater (1994), 575.
[50] Hunt (1999), 52, who cites Gilles (1989) on the decline of the Trier mint. See also Bleckmann (2000), 479 n. 12.

Ammianus' choice of a positive portrayal: he was reflecting an opinion which Ursicinus expressed to his subordinates, he was influenced by the positive assessments of the historiographical tradition.[51] Like Ursicinus, who condoles with him at length (15.5.28), Silvanus is a victim of Constantius' suspicions: the fact that he is also Ursicinus' victim can be minimised. Ammianus is accomplished at such complex balancing tricks.[52] Gallus Caesar might have been a monster, for example, but Constantius can still be blamed for his death.[53] And Ammianus' partisanship in this case may not only benefit Ursicinus. A demonstration of how Constantius' suspicions compelled his subordinate to rebel anticipates and deflects possible charges of usurpation against Julian, who five years afterwards would be 'forced' by his army to accept the title of Augustus.[54]

The narrative of the war of 359 is yet more starkly defensive of Ursicinus, just as it is notably more personal. Another account of that year's events, which laid stress, as Ammianus had, on the previous winter's exchange of letters between Sapor and Constantius, summarised the course of events rather more swiftly than Ammianus' one and a half books (Zonaras 13.9.29–31):

> [Sapor] once more set to besiege Nisibis. When he achieved nothing against that city, he left and made attempts on other cities. But when he was repelled from these, he arrived at Amida and captured it.

Zonaras wrote many hundreds of years later and his narrative has been filtered through intermediate sources; it should be pointed out that Sapor in fact passed by Nisibis, which he had so often besieged in previous years, as if it were an unimportant staging post (18.7.8).[55] And yet to many informed contemporaries this would

[51] Matthews (1989), 38; Bleckmann (2000), 481.

[52] For a close examination of the conflicting viewpoints from which Ammianus tells the story see Hunt (1999).

[53] Sabbah (1978), 456–63.

[54] As is well argued by Guzmán-Armario (2003b) (I thank the author for sending me a copy of this article); see also Brennecke (1998b). For another example of a passage defending Julian against the charge of usurpation despite not mentioning him by name see Kelly (2005) on 21.16.11–12.

[55] Ammianus left Nisibis at high speed, for fear of being caught in a siege (18.6.11). He was immediately chased by a Persian advance party, and there must have been a considerable time-lapse before Sapor's army passed the city by, so Nisibis may well have been cut off

have seemed a fair summary of the events of 359. They might also have known that, following a later investigation at which he used intemperate language, Ursicinus was retired (20.2.4–5). The whole of Ammianus' expansive account protests against the injustice of this result.

In what may be called the prelude to the fighting, enemies at court are seen undermining Ursicinus' position as *magister equitum*, while the Persian preparations for war escalate: Ursicinus is first recalled to Sirmium, then sent back to Mesopotamia to assist his successor, with insufficient men and authority (18.4.1–18.6.7).[56] In the course of the action proper, Ursicinus is shown as well informed about enemy plans, but frustrated by events and by the ineptitude of others on the Roman side. He learnt from Procopius' coded message that the Persians, urged on by Antoninus, intended to cross the Greater Zab and the Tigris and launch an attack on Roman Syria (18.6.18–18.7.2). The strategy would have been risky, but is credible.[57] Ammianus' espionage in Corduene appeared to confirm the route, and Ursicinus' later actions, such as setting out to break down the bridges over the Euphrates (18.8.1), were based on this intelligence. But the Persians in the event chose not to advance into Syria, and pursued the more normal course of siege warfare within Mesopotamia by attacking Amida (and this may of course have been the plan from the very beginning).[58] The decision to turn in the direction of Amida, we are told, was provoked by the information of a scout that the swollen Euphrates could not be crossed without turning further north, and the advice of Antoninus (18.7.9–10);[59] the army only stopped to besiege Amida, against Antoninus' advice (19.1.3), because the death of King Grumbates' son from a catapult-bolt demanded vengeance from the city (19.2.1). One

for some time. But there were three famous sieges of Nisibis, and this was not among them (see e.g. Burgess (1999), 171–3; Festus, *Breuiarium* 27.2).

[56] My metaphor of a prelude is indebted to Rosen's analysis of the war of 359 in three acts (1968), 10–68.

[57] Persian armies sacked Antioch twice in the 250s and later in 540; Julian tried an equally penetrative attack from the Roman side only four years later.

[58] Blockley (1988), 255–6, argues that Sapor never intended to attack Syria. Only the message of Procopius actually gave evidence of this plan, and Procopius may have been the victim of 'disinformation'. See also Sabbah (1978), 196, on the apologetic function of the secret message.

[59] Rosen (1968), 45–7, shows reasonable grounds for suspecting this story.

could legitimately wonder in either case how Ammianus knew of the enemy's plans, and it will be seen later that some of the facts which justify his interpretation of Persian actions have been doubted for other reasons. During the actual fighting Ursicinus is portrayed as having been badly let down by others on the Roman side, just as he had earlier been undermined by the courtiers. When he was ambushed outside Amida, it was the fault of 700 cavalry recently sent from Illyricum, who retreated at nightfall to a distance from the road and were overcome by wine and sleep, enabling the 20,000 Persians to pass (18.8.2–3). Later Ammianus breaks off from his narrative of the siege of Amida to show how Ursicinus' plans for guerrilla attacks on the Persians were prevented by his inadequate successor Sabinianus (19.3).

I noted above that in the war of 359 the narrative became both more blatantly partisan and more personal. Are these two features connected? To my mind the partial view of the eyewitness does indeed act as both a support and a cover for the partisanship of the historian. In the narrative of the 'prelude', in which Ursicinus is summoned to court and then sent back (18.4.1–6.7), a close and persuasive analysis has shown Ammianus as carefully manipulative.[60] The court is portrayed as utterly unconcerned about the crisis in the East (18.6.1). In fact, when the emperor and his consistory decided to call Ursicinus to Sirmium to take up an office of higher rank, their distance from the eastern frontier would have prevented their knowing, as Ursicinus and Ammianus did, to what extent the situation there had deteriorated. When the problem became known in Sirmium, Ursicinus and his entourage were sent back to Mesopotamia. The rest of the prelude is structured around the communication of news, and at other points – the usurpations of Silvanus and Procopius, and the political crisis of 361 – Ammianus was keenly aware of the effects caused by the time taken for information to travel. He suppresses, rather than misunderstands, the rationale for the decision made at court.

Events at court are seen from the viewpoint of Ursicinus' staff. In the main action, too, long sections of the narrative are 'focalised' (in the useful jargon of narratologists) through Ammianus himself,

[60] Lenssen (1999). See also Thompson (1947), 48–50, and Matthews (1989), 41.

first as part of Ursicinus' entourage and then alone. He could emphasise his undoubted superiority of expertise by describing what he himself had seen, most notably, when from his mountainous vantage point in Corduene, or from the walls of Amida, he beheld the massive extent of the Persian army; he could display a particular understanding of the danger to the Roman Empire which was not shared by the schemers at court or by the 'yawning midget' Sabinianus, as he skulked among the martyr-churches of Edessa (18.6.8, 18.7.7).[61] Ammianus' status as focaliser exempts him from interrupting the eyewitness narrative to treat events taking place elsewhere, whether at court or on the eastern frontier, except when it is advantageous to do so. One such interruption occurs when Ursicinus walks into the ambush outside Amida. Ammianus saves his blushes by informing us of what he could only have learnt later, that recent reinforcements from Illyricum had failed to guard the road. Their behaviour was 'a terrible disgrace which deserves to be buried in utter silence' (*atrox et silentio omni dedecus obruendum*, 18.8.2). Yet this passage necessarily lets slip information that Ammianus might otherwise himself have been tempted to bury in utter silence, the fact that the court had responded to the crisis by sending troops to the East.[62]

The unusually close focalisation of the narrative on the Roman side through Ursicinus and Ammianus (even those portions of the narrative which take place at the court) has a counterpart on the Persian side. Until the siege of Amida, Ammianus focalises his narrative of Persian plans and actions through the Roman defector Antoninus. The text expands on the story of his escape to Persia (18.5.1–3); he is exalted with *exempla* comparing him to Zopyrus, the double agent in Herodotus who helped the Persians capture Babylon, to Maharbal addressing Hannibal, and to Ulysses among the Phaeacians (18.5.3, 6, 7). In general the picture of the old-fashioned Persian court, where serious matters are discussed at banquets 'after the fashion of the Greeks of old', is brilliantly intercut with scenes at the decadent Roman court, where, in a

[61] The criticism of Sabinianus for hiding amongst the tombs of Edessa is certainly an attack on misplaced Christian devotion. See Barnes (1998), 85–6, tacitly correcting Matthews (1989), 485 n. 20; see also below Ch. 4, p. 179.

[62] Rosen (1968), 29–30.

subversion of traditional expectations, eunuchs – notoriously an oriental invention – are dominant (18.4.2–5, 18.5.4). Antoninus takes up a role of great significance in the Persian court, and his role as a counsellor, reminiscent of Medising Greeks in Herodotus, is constantly made to underlie Persian decisions.[63]

The defection of Antoninus was obviously a blow to the Romans, but did not need to be given so central a place in the narrative. The decision to focus so much attention on him – and the portrayal shows admiration for his abilities and sympathy for his predicament – serves other purposes. Antoninus was evidently known to both Ursicinus and Ammianus; he also has much in common with them. The treatment meted out to him by powerful men on the Roman side, which led him to defect, recalls that of Ursicinus, described shortly beforehand. Antoninus found his losses ever expanding through the greed of powerful men (18.5.1), while Ursicinus was resented and conspired against by the eunuch chamberlain Eusebius because he had not made over to him his house at Antioch (18.4.3).[64] The respect offered to Antoninus among the Persians contrasts with how the Romans treated them both. Antoninus himself makes the comparison when, in a chance encounter on the battlefield, he responds to Ursicinus' angry reproaches by removing his tiara, leaping from his horse and bowing almost to the ground. As he explains to Ursicinus before walking backwards from his presence: 'it was the exactions of unjust men, as you know (*ut nosti*), that drove me to escape' (18.8.5–6). His respect for Ursicinus is not new: he has already been shown praising him, and damning Sabinianus, before the Persian court (18.6.3). To what extent the extraordinary battlefield encounter is a useful fiction is impossible to say: certainly it makes sense to interpret it as a delaying tactic to complete the ambush, but on the other hand Antoninus' adoption of formal Persian manners seems of a piece with the earlier representations of the idealised, and one presumes fictional, Persian court.[65] Antoninus' resemblance to Ammianus is

[63] 18.6.3, 18.6.19, 18.7.10 (reprised at 18.10.1), 19.1.3, 19.9.7, 20.6.1. Antoninus' advice is also consistently portrayed as right (see Blockley (1988), 248).

[64] Rosen (1968), 15.

[65] Matthews (1989), 68, admitting the theatrical element, attractively cites Antoninus 'as an example of that adaptability which characterised social relations and conduct in the

yet more striking. Both serve as *protectores* and are bilingual in Latin and Greek; both are adaptable figures, able to survive amid the dangers and uncertain allegiances of border territory. I shall discuss further details and literary implications of this similarity below.[66] Here it will suffice to say that insights into Antoninus' opinions and intentions are used to offer an authoritative explanation of the Persians' actions, though these were not in fact clear to the historian, and to defend both Ursicinus' and Ammianus' record.

Ammianus' continual and forceful partisanship in recounting the war of 359 is clear and unsurprising. It is possible because the vivid but narrow perspective of the eyewitness makes for different rules of narrative. Earlier on, if the story of Silvanus distorts the truth for partisan reasons, at the centre of the narrative technique is the focalisation of the story through the experience of Ammianus and his colleagues. Their highly emotional response to danger, rather than their cool and bloody calculation, is dominant. One could make a similar case for the narrative of the Persian expedition of 363, though the sheer complexity of Books 23–25, with their relatively restrained use of first-person interventions, dissuades me from treating them in detail. A thoughtful article by Rowland Smith traces two contrasting story-lines in these books, one of a glorious adventure, and the other of an expedition doomed by the gods from the start: his analysis persuasively captures the paradox of the Persian campaign. Smith is inclined to give a significant role to autopsy in the first narrative: how the dazzling and exotic progress of Julian through Persia was witnessed by Ammianus and the whole army.[67] Ammianus has sometimes been criticised for failure to understand Julian's responsibility for the disastrous treaty made by his successor, because he set too much store in the victories he had seen and participated in. But we should argue not that Ammianus failed to understand the potency of this argument, but that autopsy was a central technique for defending Julian from blame.

frontier zone, between two empires and two cultures'. On the fictionalised aspects of the Persian court see Rosen (1968), 19–20.

[66] Section III. [67] Smith (1999), 96–100.

2 *Narrative and* inuentio

Having shown how the focalisation of narrative through the historian enables and justifies personal bias, sometimes to the extent of casting doubt on his veracity, I turn to other features of narrative. It cannot be denied that the stories of the war of 359 are told *as stories*. The account as a whole has been analysed as novelistic, constructed around Ammianus' three escapes from Persian pursuit, from near Nisibis to Meiacarire (18.6.11–15), from outside Amida into the city (18.8.9–13), and from the final sack of Amida by the Persians back to Antioch (19.8.5–12).[68] I have already touched on how Ammianus' entry into Amida through a postern gate provides the opportunity to change from a first-person singular to a first-person plural narration: only at the end of the siege does he emerge, once more through a postern gate, to begin another exciting tale of escape in the first person singular. The motif is anticipated at the start of the first escape story. Two miles out of Nisibis, Ursicinus' party see an eight-year-old boy of genteel appearance (he is adorned with a fine torque), crying on the roadside because his mother has left him behind in her panicked flight from the enemy. Ordered by Ursicinus to take the boy back to Nisibis, Ammianus places him within a half-shut postern gate, 'because the difficulties of a siege alarmed me' (18.6.10–11). The episode is partly included, no doubt, as characterisation of Ursicinus. But it also enables Ammianus to become separated from his colleagues and break into the first person singular for the first of the three escape stories, and it anticipates the siege which Ammianus is doomed to endure in any case, and the way in which he entered and escaped Amida by a postern gate. None of these factors renders the story fictional.[69] Nor does ring composition say anything about the truth,

[68] Rosen (1968), 31–41.

[69] Paschoud (1989) adopts a sceptical approach to the autobiographical passages, based on a belief in their allusiveness (see below). He would like to claim the episode of the lost boy on the roadside as fictional, though he cannot (42). 'There is nothing implausible in the incident *per se*: in a TV series it would make pleasant viewing for soft-hearted families . . . I would not want to swear that we are not in the presence of some literary *motif*.' ('En soi, l'incident n'a rien d'invraisemblable, dans une série télévisée, il plairait aux familles attendries . . . je ne voudrais pas jurer qu'on n'est pas en présence de quelque motif littéraire.')

as opposed to the selection and construction, of the narrative as a whole.

Ring composition can also be identified within the narrative of the first escape. While Ammianus is rejoining Ursicinus after depositing the little boy at Nisibis, he sees the tribune Abdigildus fleeing with his groom from a band of enemy cavalry. The servant is captured and, at the moment when Ammianus is galloping past, they ask him which Roman commander has just ridden out. He gives the name of Ursicinus, and is killed: the Persians then set off in pursuit of Ammianus (18.6.12). When at the end of the chase Ursicinus' men have reached safety at Meiacarire they find a former Roman soldier who has become a Persian spy, interrogate and kill him (18.6.16). In this case, ring composition does raise issues of veracity. Ammianus was allegedly galloping past, struggling to avoid capture himself, when the groom was interrogated and killed. It is hard to imagine him lingering for long enough to hear the interrogation or witness the murder.[70] That the questioning was about Ursicinus looks like a sensible guess on Ammianus' part, but it also coincides with his own desire to emphasise his patron's importance and the danger of the ensuing chase. It is conceivable that he might have seen the slave's death, but the killing could be a (virtually certain) guess.[71]

Ammianus' employment of sensible guesswork in cases such as this has caused alarm. This is unwarranted. Plausible supplementation of certain facts by those founded on inference from the general norm is a standard feature of ancient rhetoric and history. *Inuentio* should be seen as integral to Ammianus' method, rather than a threat to the overall veracity of his account. The same view should apply to the use of information learned after the dramatic date of the narrative. During the siege of Amida, Ammianus describes seeing captives being led off from the Roman fortress of Ziata (19.6.1). Even if the captives were led past those besieged in Amida, to lower morale inside, one might wonder how he knew they were

[70] This objection is in Dillemann (1961), 102. Sabbah and de Jonge ad loc. suggest that the tribune may have been Ammianus' source, and the words *cum ego rapido ictu transirem* ('when I was passing by at a great lick') refer to a coincidence. Nonetheless the tribune was not in a position to hear this interrogation either, and the Persians immediately started chasing Ammianus.

[71] See de Jonge ad loc.

specifically from Ziata. This is not, however, a serious problem: he learnt the fact later but included it at this point for narrative economy.[72] (Indeed, we will see below (Section IV) that Ammianus can be quite explicit about this technique.)[73] Rather, this case should serve as a reminder of how the forceful focalisation through Ammianus himself keeps the readers' thoughts away from events elsewhere in the war-zone.

3 Allusions and marvels

What modern scholars have found most threatening to the veracity of the autobiographical passages, however, is their allusiveness to the literature of the past. Such allusiveness is of course not only a feature of the autobiographical passages. Ancient historiography is an allusive genre on all levels: traditional, often archaising vocabulary, the arrangement of events according to inherited but flexible structures, the analytical use of speeches, the tendency to continue the work of favoured predecessors and to polemicise against those who cover the same period. And whole scenes can allude closely to predecessors. Anecdotes and speeches are prone to this, as are those staples of the narrative of warfare, battles, sieges and pestilence, which overlap with the subject matter of the autobiographical passages in Books 18 and 19.[74]

Worries about allusive type-scenes in historiography are not new. In his essay *On Writing History*, Lucian mocks Creperius Calpurnianus, whose account of Rome's wars with Parthia in the second century AD opened with words all but identical to those which Thucydides had used, and who included whole incidents and speeches imported from Thucydides, including a plague (*DHC* 15).[75] This work did not survive, so we cannot judge to what extent Lucian's criticism was justified. The reprisal of familiar episodes may have been a purposed allusive technique, which added grandeur and offered an analytical key to the work without detracting from its historical authority or its ability to convey the

[72] Matthews (1989), 61.

[73] Ancient historians do occasionally scruple to record explicitly the fact that events only became clear later: see e.g. Caesar *BC* 3.86.1.

[74] See Marincola (1997), 15. [75] Marincola (1997), 12.

specifics of a situation.[76] Ammianus' allusiveness, his engagement with, and dependence on, predecessors in both type-scenes and passages of autopsy, tempts some moderns to put him on the same level as Creperius Calpurnianus. For François Paschoud, author of two fine studies of Ammianus' autobiographical passages, he is to be counted among the 'tragic' historians, a Herodotus not a Thucydides, a Timaeus rather than a Polybius.[77]

Ammianus' allusiveness in passages of autopsy does not consist of simple adoption of historiographical type-scenes. Apart from anything else, it appears to operate across various genres, including epic. It also ranges in depth from simple quotation or allusion, to episodes which appear to recreate commonplaces, to the wholesale construction of the siege of Amida as a re-enactment of the Trojan War.

At its simplest level, the characteristically literary tinge to the autobiographical passages can be exemplified by the way Ursicinus' men comforted themselves on their dangerous mission against Silvanus with an inapposite *sententia* from Cicero, 'issued from the very inner parts of truth herself' (15.5.23):

'And although it is most desirable that fortune always remains blooming, yet that evenness of existence has no sensation as great as when from wretchedness and destruction a man's fortune is recalled to a better state.'[78]

Similarly, the historian shows himself and everybody else in the East under Valens at the time of the treason trials of 371/2 crawling about as if in Cimmerian darkness, fearing terrors equal to those which confronted the party-guests of Dionysius of Syracuse (they looked up to see swords dangling from the ceiling above them, attached only by horse hairs, 29.2.4). The learned cliché of the

[76] After all, had Lucian been able to read the historical works of Procopius of Caesarea, almost four centuries later, would he not have responded with the same polemic against close linguistic and thematic adherence to Herodotus and Thucydides? See Kaldellis (2004), esp. Ch. 1.

[77] Paschoud (1989), 53–4, and (1999b), 83.

[78] *'Et quamquam optatissimum est perpetuo fortunam quam florentissimam permanere, illa tamen aequalitas uitae non tantum habet sensum, quantum cum ex miseris et perditis rebus ad meliorem statum fortuna reuocatur.'* Thought by some to be an inaccurate version of *Post Reditum ad Quirites* 2, the Ciceronian prose rhythms make it likelier that this comes more or less verbatim from a lost work. Blockley (1975), App. G, 195, follows Michael (1874), 7, in suggesting *De Re Publica*. It would have been more suitable after the mission than in its early stages.

Cimmerii living in the darkness of the extreme north is combined with one of the familiar anecdotes about the archetypal tyrant, in this instance apparently inspired by Cicero, *Tusculan Disputations* 5.62.

More significantly, challenges to the veracity of various incidents from the war of 359 have been made on the basis that they allude to and may be inspired by earlier literature. One object of criticism, most effectively in Paschoud's splendid article of 1989, is the story of how, on a night of full moon, with their escape over the treeless plain uncertain (18.6.15),

> the idea was conceived that, having placed a burning lamp on a single pack animal and tied it firmly to stop it falling, the beast carrying it should be set free without a rider and be allowed to go off to the left, while we made for the mountainous outcrops on our right: the plan was that the Persians would believe that a sallow-torch was lighting his path for the general as he made his leisurely way, and would continue in the same direction. If it hadn't been for this forethought, we would have been surrounded and captured and fallen into the power of the enemy.[79]

Paschoud thinks the story incontestably an 'affabulation', and one which shows that readers of Ammianus have not known about horses, and equestrians have not read Ammianus.[80] Otherwise they would have noticed that their fear of fire would have made the procedure of attaching a torch to a horse nigh on impossible, to say nothing of the difficulty of making a riderless horse go off in a different direction to its comrades'. He then notes that attaching fire to animals at night was a trick recorded in books of strategy such as Frontinus', which originated in a ploy of Hannibal's. Burning straw was attached to the horns of cattle in a pass, which were then driven towards the Romans: when the fire had burnt down to their skulls the cattle rampaged. Beyond Frontinus, Paschoud notes parallels in Polybius, Nepos, Livy, Silius, Plutarch and Appian, and that the Graecism *lampas* which Ammianus used to describe the light may well be taken from the Greek sources for Hannibal's ploy.[81] Of

[79] *excogitatum est ergo / ut ardente superposita lampade / et circumligata, ne rueret, / iumentum solum, quod eam uehebat, / solutum sine rectore laeuorsus ire permitteretur, / cum nos ad montanos excessus dextra positos tenderemus / ut praelucere sebalem facem duci lenius gradienti / Persae credentes / eum tenerent potissimum cursum; / quod nisi fuisset praeuisum, / circumuenti et capti / sub dicionem uenissemus hostilem.*

[80] Paschoud (1989), 43. [81] Paschoud (1989), 45 n. 32 for references.

course, Ammianus may well have had Hannibal's famous exploit in mind when writing the passage. But in his defence, a stratagem identical with those recorded in works such as that of Frontinus does not have to have been invented, and might equally be used as evidence that such works had a practical application, and in any case this stratagem is *not* identical to Hannibal's.[82] Moreover, the word *lampas* means lantern as well as torch. A lantern would be a less frightening burden for the animal, less likely to be extinguished and easier to fix.[83] The animal's willingness to leave its companions might be explained by special training (as Paschoud himself allows to be possible), or alternatively unusual fear.[84]

Even within the same chapter, another stratagem which can be parallelled in Frontinus (*Strat.* 3.13.5) has been identified: that of concealing a message in a scabbard (18.6.17). Typically of these autobiographical passages, Procopius' hidden and coded message is interesting and illustrative. (It is also, as I argued above, essential for Ammianus' apologetic purpose to explain that Ursicinus was not expecting Sapor to wait at Amida, but rather that he was intending to thrust further into Roman Syria.) Ammianus describes how the message was found in a scabbard, translates it from cipher and perhaps from Greek, and then gives a paraphrase (18.6.18–19).[85]

'Amendatis procul Graiorum legatis, / forsitan et necandis, / rex ille longaeuus / non contentus Hellesponto, / iunctis Granici et Rhyndaci pontibus / Asiam cum numerosis populis peruasurus adueniet, / suopte ingenio inritabilis et asperrimus, / auctore et incensore Hadriani quondam Romani principis successore; / actum et conclamatum est / ni cauerit Graecia.' (19) qui textus significabat Persarum regem transitis fluminibus Anzaba et Tigride, / Antonino hortante dominium orientis adfectare totius.

'With the ambassadors of the Greeks removed to a distance, and perhaps to be killed, the long-lived king, not satisfied with Hellespont, will lay down bridges over Granicus and Rhyndacus and will come to overrun Asia with countless peoples. Of his own nature quick to anger and harsh, he is spurred on and fired up by the successor of Hadrian, sometime Roman emperor; if Greece doesn't watch out, she's dead and buried.' (19) This text meant that the Persian King, when he

[82] See Campbell (1987) on military handbooks in use. [83] De Jonge ad loc.

[84] Paschoud (1989), 44. Dr Elisabeth Watson suggests to me that a horse could conceivably be terrified into separating from its group.

[85] It might well originally have been in Latin, the language of the army, as the *exemplum* is likely based on Sallust's *Histories* (see Ch. 3, Section II below).

had crossed the rivers Greater Zab and Tigris, would bid at Antoninus' instigation for dominance over the whole of Oriens.

Precise comprehension of the coded language has only been achieved quite recently, in an article of 1986 by Roger Blockley. The 'long-lived king' doers not refer primarily to Sapor but leads the reader to the reign of that Mithridates who famously died old. 'Procopius begins to write as though he were reporting from Pontus the intentions of Mithridates VI Eupator on the eve of the Third Mithridatic War (74/3–64 B.C.).' Hellespontus and Asia, the names of Roman provinces, represent Mesopotamia and Syria (and in his paraphrase Ammianus means the diocese Oriens rather than the prefecture of the same name, Syria and Palestine rather than the whole eastern empire).[86] Despite his confident interpretation of the crux, Blockley concludes with the thought that the message is so dramatically – and, one might add, militarily – convenient that it may well be a fiction: 'another illustration of Ammianus' desire to link the events that he records with those of the famous past and to entertain his hearers with historical *exempla*'.[87] Allusiveness may then cast doubt on the message itself as well as its means of delivery.

The most prolonged and striking case where events witnessed by the historian have been moulded into a re-enactment of, or prolonged allusion to, a literary model is the siege of Amida, in which a series of *exempla* recall the Trojan War. When Sapor arrived, he had intended merely to pass the town by. But on the second morning, as Sapor's ally King Grumbates approached the city, his youthful son was shot by a ballista (19.1.7). A day-long battle over his body is said to have ensued, and at nightfall he was brought back by the Persians from among the heaps of dead, 'as once at Troy his allies fought in savage war over the body of the Thessalian leader's lifeless comrade' (19.1.9).[88] The comparison to Patroclus may surprise, but a quick glimpse just at the start of the book will exemplify how thoroughly pervasive the epic atmosphere is. The

[86] Blockley (1986), 63–4.

[87] Blockley (1986), 65. For my part I see no reason to doubt the possibility of such learned exchanges between Roman officers (see below Ch. 3, p. 123).

[88] *ut apud Troiam quondam super comite Thessali ducis exanimi / socii Marte acerrimo conflixerunt.*

vista from the walls (*teichoscopia*) which opens Book 19 can be viewed as, at the least, epic background noise: 'and when dawn first gleamed, everywhere that could be seen glittered with twinkling arms' (19.1.2).[89] At the death of Grumbates' son, when the bolt 'pierced the breastplate and penetrated the chest' (19.1.7), we have a poignant echo of young warriors in Vergil.[90] The words with which the youth is described at his funeral, 'the hope of his people cut down in the first flower of his age' (19.1.11), offer another combination of Vergilian *floscula*.[91] Likewise the property of epic is the seven-day truce for the funeral, with the description of the rites of the Chionitae (19.1.10), as is the idea that this individual death is the motivation for the continuation of the siege (19.2.1).

The comparison of Grumbates' son to Patroclus is the first direct reference to the *Iliad* during the siege; three more open citations follow (19.4.3, 19.4.6, 19.6.11). When sickness strikes the besieged inside the city, Ammianus again explains what he had himself experienced with an appeal to *exempla*, both Thucydides' plague narrative (19.4.4) and the plague which opens the *Iliad* (19.4.3). Homer's example is brought closer to the state of affairs at Amida by scholarly rationalisation: 'when Greece sweated in a ten year war, . . . and devastation of this sort was on the march, many perished by the arrows of Apollo (who is reckoned to be the sun)'.[92] The Iliadic plague is shortly afterwards cited as the first example to show what has since been demonstrated by many subsequent experiences, that in plagues animals die before men.[93] (A further similarity to the Homeric model for the plague narrative can perhaps be

[89] *cumque primum aurora fulgeret, / uniuersa quae uideri poterant armis stellantibus coruscabant*. Other teichoscopies: 19.1.5, 19.2.2, 19.2.12.

[90] *thorace cum pectore perforato perfodit*, close to *Aen.* 10.337, *thoraca simul cum pectore rumpit*, 'it broke the breastplate along with the chest'.

[91] *in primaeuo flore succisam spem gentis*, cf. *Aen.* 7.162–3 *ante urbem pueri et primaeuo flore iuuentus / exercentur equis* ('before the city, lads and the youth in the first flower of age train on horses'), the comparison of the dying Euryalus to a 'flower cut down by the plough' (*ueluti . . . flos succisus aratro*, 9.435), and the use of *spes* in the *Aeneid* to describe Ascanius (1.556, 4.276, 6.364, 10.524, 12.168) and Pallas (8.514–15). Note how well the rationalisation of the Adonis myth that follows in 19.1.11 fits with this image.

[92] *cum decennali bello Graecia desudaret /, . . . huius modi grassante pernicie, / telis Apollinis periere complures / (qui sol aestimatur)*. Apollo's arrows which cause plague are interpreted as the sun's rays. The rationalisation can be paralleled in Homeric scholarship (see Lindenbrog ad loc.).

[93] Cf. *Il.* 1.50.

found in the fact that the rain that ended the plague in Amida fell 'on the night which followed the tenth day' (19.4.7).[94] It was on the tenth day that Achilles called the assembly of the Achaeans which led to the soothing of Apollo's anger and the ending of the plague.) The last proclaimed reference to the Trojan War comes with the sortie of the Gallic soldiers by night.[95] The secret plan (19.6.7) was that they might even mount a surprise attack on the royal quarters, but this was not to be. Ammianus praises them: it was not Rhesus and the Thracians asleep before the walls of Ilium, but the king of the Persians girt about with 100,000 armed men, whom they must surely have slaughtered in his very tents, had not a more powerful fate intervened (19.6.11).[96] The comparison of the sortie to the *Doloneia* of *Iliad* 10 seems inapposite in a number of ways: there are far more attackers, the victims are the besiegers rather than allies of the besieged, and the enemy leader did not come close to being killed. Finally, although the *Iliad* ended before Troy's capture and there are no more obvious Iliadic references in Book 19, Ammianus' escape from the captured city through an unguarded postern gate with two companions will remind the reader of the story told to Dido by the founder of the Roman race, and Ammianus' last evasive action (19.8.5) may possibly close the episode of Amida with a verbal echo of Book 2 of the *Aeneid*.[97]

[94] *nocte quae diem consecuta est decimum.*

[95] In this section too are Vergilian allusions: e.g. 19.6.10 *portae panduntur* ('the gates are spread open') is taken from *Aen.* 2.27; 6.574. The historian's use of the present tense accommodates the quotation more comfortably.

[96] *qui non Rhesum nec cubitantes pro muris Iliacis Thracas, / sed Persarum regem armatorum centum milibus circumsaeptum, / ni obstitisset uiolentior casus, / in ipsis tentoriis obtruncarant.*

[97] *in abstrusa quadam parte oppidi cum duobus aliis latens / obscurae praesidio noctis, / postica, per quam nihil seruabatur, euado* ('lurking in some hidden part of the town with two others, protected by a dark night I get out through a postern gate over which no guard was kept', 19.8.5) ~ Vergil *Aen.* 2.453–8 *limen erat caecaeque fores et peruius usus / tectorum inter se Priami, **postesque** relicti / a tergo, infelix qua se, dum regna manebant, / saepius Andromache ferre incomitata solebat / ad soceros et auo puerum Astyanacta trahebat. / **euado** ad summi fastigia culminis . . .* ('There was an entrance with secret gates and a passage which interconnected Priam's mansions, a **postern gate** set apart, through which while our kingdom stood Andromache was often wont to pass unattended to her in-laws and lead the lad Astyanax to his grandfather. **I get out** to the highest point of the roof . . '). Vergil's *postes* matches Ammianus' *postica* (indeed Servius glosses *postes* as *postica*). Vergil and Ammianus both change tense for the verb *euado*, used only here in Vergil. Compare also some adjacent passages of *Aeneid* 2: *has [fores] **seruant** agmine denso* ('on these gates they **keep a guard** in thick column', 2.450), and ***obscura nocte*** ('in the dark night', 2.420).

Much of Ammianus' story may be doubted. One might, with Paschoud, draw particular attention to the fight over the body of the youth (no sortie is described and the Romans had no use for the corpse), and the details of the funeral (which Ammianus would have been hard-pressed to observe).[98] The aim of the sortie as an assassination attempt on Sapor seems so improbable that it is hardly surprising to hear that that aspect was only planned secretly.

Modern readers are likely to be puzzled by the allusiveness of the autobiographical passages and inclined towards disbelief, and this tendency will be reinforced above all by the fact that some events and sights described by Ammianus are not only picturesque and unexpected, but in fact marvellous. Take his story of travelling to a high point above the valleys of the Tigris and the Greater Zab, and seeing the Persian army on the horizon at a distance of fifty miles. Thus far the claim, though unusual, is credible enough, but Ammianus also claims to have seen what he could not possibly have seen at that distance, Sapor in a red garment, with a client-king on either side of him (18.6.22). In a complex *exemplum* he compares the Persian army to that of Xerxes and his autopsy to the legendary exaggeration of Herodotus, apostrophising 'Storied Greece' (*Graecia fabulosa*). I shall treat this difficult piece of writing in greater detail below (Section IV), and at this point simply draw attention to the fact that this is not the only place where Ammianus explores the relationship of autopsy and the fantastic (represented by *fabula* and its cognates). When he was fleeing Amida, he marvelled at the sight of a distant military rout (19.8.10–11):

> We beheld far off a disordered column of Romans with cavalry standards, and chasing them a host of Persians; it was unclear from where they had attacked them with so sudden a charge. (11) From this example I believe that the so-called 'earth-born' did not rise from the recesses of the earth but were endowed from birth with extraordinary speed, and because they appeared suddenly in diverse places, they were called 'sown men' and believed to have sprung forth from the

[98] Paschoud (1999b), 81–2. Paschoud maintains that, like much in the account (the presence of elephants, 19.2.3, 19.7.6), the battle over the body is inconsonant with the nature of siege warfare (82–3). He also argues that the episode involving the Persian capture of a tower (19.5.4–5) is inappropriate to the geography of Amida (85).

earth, **since antiquity exaggerated the facts in legendary fashion** (*uetustate rem fabulosius extollente*).[99]

Autopsy is used to explain or to confirm what might otherwise seem fantasy. Similarly the description of the tsunami of 365, which opens with the observation that neither legends nor truthful ancient histories (*nec fabulae nec ueridicae . . . antiquitates*, 26.10.15) had shown the like, and which ends in autopsy (to be discussed further in Section v).

Now the use of autopsy to justify the extraordinary, the otherwise incredible, is of course a practice which is associated with classical historiography from its beginnings with Herodotus, and which is brilliantly satirised by Lucian in his *True History*. Ammianus shows himself fully conscious of this when he uses legendary or incredible *exempla* and justifies, condemns, or rationalises them by comparison to his own extraordinary experiences (and he notably adduces Herodotus without naming him when describing his view of the Persian army in Corduene). Whatever one's attitude to Ammianus' veracity, these allusions should make one question his aesthetic purposes. Might it not be his aim, both in these particular passages and possibly in first-person narration more broadly, to make his readers balk at the improbability and unexpectedness of what is nevertheless confirmed by autopsy?

To summarise: criticisms of Ammianus' truthfulness in autobiographical passages cover a wide range, and extend to allegations of persistent bias, or even large-scale fabrication of exemplary fictions. A range of reactions is due. Some cases are minor and insignificant: when he errs on the orientation of Amida, putting the Tigris to the south rather than the east (18.9.2), his failure of memory thirty years on is of little account, and hardly reflects badly on him.[100] Features of narrative-like ring composition, small-scale *inuentio*, or prolepsis should not cause alarm. It seems unanswerable that the narrative, and especially the focalisation, of the

[99] *ecce autem Romanum agmen cum equestribus signis disiectum eminus cernimus, / quod persequebatur multitudo Persarum / incertum unde impetu tam repentino / terga uiantum aggressa.* (11) *quo exemplo terrigenas illos non sinibus terrae emersos, / sed exuberanti pernicitate credimus natos, / qui, quoniam inopini per uaria uisebantur, /* σπαρτοὶ *uocitati / humo exsiluisse / uetustate rem fabulosius extollente / sunt aestimati.*

[100] Observed by Dillemann (1961), 106.

Silvanus episode and the war of 359 helps to justify Ursicinus, but it is equally clear that this defence of Ammianus and his superiors is not the sole argument or function of these passages: after all, both his own and Ursicinus' actions sometimes appear in a poor light. Nor, for all of the persuasiveness of Paschoud's sceptical analyses, can the validation of his personal experiences through allusion to, or re-enactment of, earlier literature offer a full explanation for these passages. Ammianus' experiences can at times be shown to echo literary motifs closely, consistently, and self-consciously, especially during the siege of Amida, but at others the resemblance is rather distant.[101]

If I have seemed infuriatingly agnostic and non-committal on the question of veracity, it is not only because the question rarely admits of definite proof, but also because I think it is the wrong question. It is a fallacy to conclude that allusive self-presentation makes Ammianus a deviant from the tradition of Thucydides and Polybius, a 'romantic' or 'tragic' historian.[102] Not only because imposing a dichotomy between romantic and scientific historians is to accept ancient polemic unquestioned as the basis for an anachronistic categorisation: also because the impact of allusion is more complex. As I argued in Chapter 1, allusion and autopsy can both function as sources of authority for a history, and the presence of one does not invalidate the truth or relevance of the other. When a description of a battlefield shows (for example) a soldier with an arrow in his thigh or a corpse with the head cloven in two pieces, we may be reminded of Homer, Vergil or Lucan, but straightforward inference from allusion to fiction is evidently fallacious. Cloven heads and pierced thighs were likely to be found abundantly on ancient battlefields. Matthews is surely right that, despite rhetorical colouring, 'Ammianus never leaves unexplained the specific character of a battle or the strategy of a campaign'.[103]

[101] John Matthews argues reasonably that the conventional nature of siege narratives is to some degree a reflection of the regularity of the events themselves (1989, 289–90).

[102] As Paschoud does (see n. 77 above).

[103] Matthews (1989), 286. His discussion (286–301) is concerned with battle-narratives rather than first-person ones, and by 'rhetorical colouring' he means the tendency of descriptions to resemble general or particular models, something which is close rather than identical in meaning to my 'allusiveness'. He notes, however, the particular applicability of his argument to passages of autopsy: 'paradoxically in view of his personal

On the other hand, defenders of Ammianus' veracity cannot simply point to the presence of circumstantial details or the plausibility of the geography, and expect their case to be accepted unequivocally.

Whatever one's attitude to their historical truthfulness, the passages of autopsy present a literary problem. They are inconsonant with most preconceptions of what ancient historical writing should be, whether one views it as in a continuum with or as fundamentally different from its modern equivalent. N. J. E. Austin, a positivist military historian, cannot evade the fact that, alongside passages which show the historian as 'eyewitness of significant action', and 'protagonist or active participant in actions that have a direct and positive relevance to the history of the whole period', there are a great number of apparently irrelevant personal details.[104] Although he can defend these as providing 'invaluable material on background conditions presented in an exciting or interesting way', no Contribution to History can be identified. Even those who prefer a less utilitarian and more nuanced approach to ancient historiography are taken aback by the 'disconcerting . . . prominence' of such passages: as John Marincola has observed, none of Ammianus' predecessors obtrude what seems like personal memoir into grand historiography to the same degree.[105] The wide variations in the degree of the author's personal involvement also demand explanation. So I shall now turn to exploring the literary function of Ammianus' autopsy.

III Autopsy and authority

Autopsy endows the historian with authority; it emphasises his particular knowledge and superior expertise. So I have suggested in some particular instances above; in this section, and the two case studies which follow, I shall suggest that the assertion of the historian's authority is not just an occasional by-product of such passages with implications only for their immediate contexts. Rather,

involvement at Amida, it is above all in his narratives of sieges that Ammianus can most readily be suspected of writing to a structural and rhetorical pattern' (288).

[104] Austin (1983), 55, 57.

[105] Matthews (1983), 34; Marincola (1997), 203; see also Rosen (1968), 39–40.

Ammianus selects and structures instances of personal testimony with the consistent aim of buttressing the claim of his history as a whole to an authoritative and canonical status. To put it another way, seemingly personal statements also have a wider historiographical function.

This is hardly surprising. Historians had used their own personal experience to claim authority ever since Herodotus invoked his visit to Egypt, or Thucydides coolly mentioned that he himself had suffered and recovered from the plague (Hdt. 2.2.5 and *passim*, Thuc. 2.48.3). And indeed, it is clear that the personal appearances of these classic historians in their own works mattered to Ammianus, even though in many respects their influence on him was smaller than might be expected.[106] Herodotus is only mentioned by name once in the *Res Gestae*, but in a description of the Pyramids of Giza (22.15.28); one of the two citations of Thucydides is as an *exemplum* for the plague at Amida (19.4.4). The sole citation of Polybius (a passage which does not otherwise survive)[107] describes a daring assault on the gates of Carthage led by Scipio himself, in which the historian had also participated (24.2.16). The passage is striking for showing Julian as a reader of history and a conscious imitator of Scipio; yet more interesting for my purposes here is, first, the manner in which Ammianus is by implication cast as Julian's Polybius and, second, the fact that Polybius' only appearance in the *Res Gestae* is in a section of the work which shows Ammianus' own participation.[108]

The dominance of autopsy in citations of these classic Greek historians supports the presupposition that autobiographical passages are partly explicable from the Graeco-Roman historiographical tradition. In seeking an explanation from the traditions of the genre, we can also adduce the commonplace, famously encapsulated by Polybius' criticisms of Timaeus, that the man of action was best qualified to write history – which arguably offers a partial explanation for Ammianus' self-definition in the epilogue of his work

[106] See n. 108 below.

[107] It is included by Büttner-Wobst as Book 38, fr. 19a, and is also reflected at Zonaras 9.29.

[108] None of these citations can be taken to prove Ammianus' intimate or even first-hand knowledge of any of these historians. On Herodotus and Thucydides see Fornara (1992b), and on Polybius the salutary caution of den Boeft *et al.* ad 24.2.16.

as a 'former soldier', *miles quondam* (31.16.9).[109] Nevertheless, Ammianus' personal appearances are distant from generic tradition in several ways. The presence of autopsy may be precedented, but its extent, particularly in the lengthy and detailed adventures of the year 359, is not.[110] Moreover, from Thucydides onwards historians generally referred to themselves as actors in their own histories (as opposed to narrators or investigators) in the third person singular: the best known examples are Xenophon, Polybius and Caesar. When Ammianus chose to write about himself as a historical actor in the first person exclusively, he knowingly diverged from the practice of his Greek predecessors – which is not to say that he was artless. Roman historians may have used the first person more frequently than Greek ones, but our losses limit our knowledge.[111] One might argue that the introduction of the first person is occasionally influenced by earlier historiography – for example, Herodotus offers a general precedent for introducing the first person in describing Egyptian antiquities, as at 17.4.6. But the account of the year 359, in terms of genre, approaches the territory of memoir (*hypomnēma*), and its allusions to earlier literature are by no means restricted to historiography.

Ammianus' successors may offer closer parallels for the use of personal memoir as an ingredient of classical historiography than his predecessors. A study by N. J. E. Austin compares Ammianus' use of autobiography with that of Procopius of Caesarea, who, like Ammianus, frequently mentions his personal involvement, including his escapes (4.14.37–42) and special missions (3.14.1–15).[112] Also adduced are the fragmentary historians Olympiodorus

[109] See Polyb. 12 *passim* and Marincola (1997), 71–5. For further discussion of this epilogue see Section VI of this chapter, and the Epilogue below, and Kelly (2007).

[110] As John Marincola remarks of the flight from Amida in 19.8, 'there is . . . no participatory narrative in any other historian equivalent to this one' (Marincola (1997), 203. At 201 n. 125, he adduces one comparable passage, a fragment (fr. 19) from the last book of Appian's history.)

[111] Polybius sometimes uses the first person, apparently at least in part for *uariatio*. The Greek ex-consul Cassius Dio uses the first person consistently, which may well have been under the influence of the Latin tradition. There have of course been a number of attempts to identify Ammianus with characters in his narrative: in particular see pp. 127–9 below on the identification of the unnamed soldier at 25.5.5 with the historian, a suggestion supported by a perceived allusion to Xenophon. See Marincola (1997), 188–200.

[112] Procopius' appearances do not, however, suffice to compose a continuous biography – again like Ammianus (see Kaldellis (2004), 46).

of Thebes, who in a work which styles itself as 'historical material' rather than 'history' provides information on personal subjects ranging from his travels to his parrot, and Priscus of Panium, who was a member of an embassy to Attila.[113]

These are not, to digress briefly, the only grounds on which comparisons have been made between Ammianus and the following generations of classicising historians writing in Greek. For example, both he and later Greek historians use circumlocutions for Christian technical terms, from which it has been argued that Ammianus' circumlocutions are motivated by genre rather than disdain.[114] The common presence of personal memoir and periphrasis might conceivably be attributed to Ammianus inspiring his Greek successors, and in an early article Thompson went as far as to suggest 'that serious consideration be given to the view that Ammianus was the founder of the great school of fifth-century Greek historians to which Olympiodorus and Priscus belonged'.[115] It is difficult, however, to imagine that in this period a Latin author might act as the central model of Greek ones. It is hard too to postulate some unknown but influential author who might have inspired both Ammianus and Greek classicising historians of the fifth century into the inclusion of personal memoir into historiography, though Dexippus for one is sometimes thought to have participated in major events as well as recording them: specifically, the defence of Athens from Gothic attack.[116] Easier than specifying precise and directed intertextuality is to conceive of a general late-antique approach to the writing of history, a shared part of the educational and cultural background of Ammianus and the later authors rather than one specifically shaped by him.

Irrespective of scholarly controversies, it is plainly characteristic of late-antique historiography in particular that the narration of events belonging to the author's own lifetime was esteemed over

[113] Austin (1983).

[114] Cameron and Cameron (1964). Their arguments have been widely accepted, but are susceptible to attacks from two angles. First, the Christian persuasion of some of the Byzantine historians whom they cite is not necessarily clear-cut (see Adshead (1996), Kaldellis (1999) and (2004), 165–221). Secondly, Ammianus' use of generic periphrases for Christian terms is inconsistent – we may suspect, for example, that *antistes* is a more favourable term than *episcopus* (20.7.7, 9).

[115] Thompson (1944a), 52.

[116] See Millar (1969).

that of earlier events derived from written sources. It is easy to construct a dichotomy among ancient historians between those who wrote the history of their own times, like Thucydides and Ammianus, and those who wrote antiquarian history, like Diodorus or Livy: the first group writing from their own experience and interviews with witnesses, the second indulging an academic pursuit and elaborating one or a few sources to describe a distant past. The dichotomy is too easy: in parts of their texts which have been lost Livy was a modern and Ammianus an antiquarian historian. Nonetheless, in late antiquity especially there exists an underlying assumption of the genre that, though a historian might begin in ancient times, the latter stages, the description of his own times, should be accorded a privileged status. This is a perspective to be identified with readers rather than writers; it sometimes coexists with and sometimes challenges the ways in which historians claim canonical status for themselves – for example, by continuing the work of a distinguished predecessor, as Ammianus followed Tacitus.[117] Such esteem for contemporary historiography is alluded to in Ammianus' preface to Book 15; and the survival of the last three hexads of his work when the earlier books were lost may be indicative of this preference. Another example can be found in the late sixth-century Church historian Evagrius' attack on the pagan polemicist Zosimus (*HE* 3.40–1). Zosimus had alleged, quite correctly, that the emperor Constantine had killed his son Crispus. Evagrius argues against this on the grounds that Eusebius, who was a contemporary, did not mention any such act on Constantine's part, and that Zosimus could not be a reliable witness because he had lived as late as Arcadius and Honorius (the early fifth century, three quarters of a century after Constantine). Evagrius assumes that Zosimus wrote under the sons of Theodosius because it was in their time that the *New History* concluded: he was wrong, as Zosimus' work was in fact written at a much later date but left unfinished.[118] Ignore his considerable confusion on the facts: it is

[117] For the tradition of following a predecessor see Marincola (1997), 237–41, 289–92.

[118] Zosimus is conventionally placed at the turn of the sixth century (see e.g. Paschoud (2000), x–xx), though the grounds for this dating are tenuous (see e.g. Liebeschuetz (2003), 214–15).

clear that Evagrius argues from a belief in the value of contemporaneous history above later versions.

It may be argued, therefore, that it was the particular esteem of contemporary history that led Ammianus and other late-antique historians to write eyewitness testimony into their narrative, even if not strictly central to the course of events. These experiences were included in order to identify the history of their period particularly with the historian himself: in Austin's phrase, they offer a '*sphragis* of authenticity'.[119] Other modern readers will also instinctively accept the claims of an eyewitness sympathetically, more so than a historian who claims to be canonical because he inherits a literary tradition from a favoured predecessor and adds a new link to a golden chain. Those with any experience of how ancient historians transformed their literary sources for the more distant past will be easily persuaded of the historical value, comparatively at least, of unmediated eyewitness status.

But this reading, while certainly capturing one purpose of autobiographical passages, is not without problems. Austin accepts the superior expertise of Ammianus the participant unhesitatingly, but he takes little interest in the possibility that one of his author's rhetorical aims is precisely to make readers believe in his expertise. Nor does he confront the historian's allusiveness, or the enormous variations in his self-revelation across separate parts of the work. Austin offers an explanation, up to a point, for the presence of the passages, but not for their nature. Let me attempt to remedy this.

Where Ammianus allows his actions into his text, he places himself with striking consistency in two related situations: solitude and peril. First, solitude. Ammianus uses autopsy most vividly when he is alone or in small groups, particularly in the Silvanus episode and the war of 359. The observation may seem banal, but the choice was far from inevitable. His participation in the group conspiring to kill Silvanus is told in the first person, while Julian's visit to Rheims in the following year, when Ammianus was, it is likely, part of a larger garrison, does not prompt the first person. The war of 359 finds him in a small and elite group of soldiers moving at speed over the frontier-zone: the personal detail is considerable,

[119] Austin (1983), 64.

and never more so than on the three or four occasions which find him separated from his companions, and unforgettably alone. On the Persian campaign four years later, when he was part of a vast invading army, it is impossible to identify his personal role with any certainty and the first-person verbs are only intermittent. Solitariness, it has long been observed, is a feature of his persona in other ways. Momigliano's apt characterisation of Ammianus as the 'lonely historian' referred to the difficulty of finding a milieu into which to place him, but is potentially multivalent.[120] He strives, for all his occasional snobbish deference, to appear politically and socially independent; he casts doubt on whether anybody will read him; and by his decision to begin in 96 condemns the Latin historical tradition since Tacitus.

Second, and more pervasively, peril. Ammianus consistently appears when in danger of his life. The mission against Silvanus might easily have ended in torture and death, and the narrative stresses the fear that gripped Ammianus and his co-conspirators, rather than the conspiracy itself (which is in part why this episode has bewildered subsequent historians). The Persian campaign is a perilous but dazzling enterprise; his last two brief appearances in the course of the treason trials under Valens show him obscurely amidst universal terror, and the torture and death of others of high rank (29.1.24, 29.2.4). More than any other section, the war of 359 finds Ammianus imperilled, at full gallop or in a breathless crawl repeatedly fleeing the pursuit of merciless Persians. His three escapes are punctuated by other people meeting multifarious and gruesome deaths. Fleeing from Nisibis, he witnesses the Persians interrogating and killing the tribune Abdigildus' groom (18.6.12); later Ursicinus' party in turn capture, interrogate and kill a Persian spy (18.6.16). The second escape, after the ambush outside Amida, has the traumatic last encounter with Verinianus, whose chances of surviving as a prisoner seem slim, and the night spent pressed against the corpse with its head split in two (18.8.11–12). In the third escape, from the sack of Amida, Ammianus and his two companions encounter a fugitive horse pulling behind it the body of a groom, who, thrown off and unable to disentangle himself

[120] Momigliano (1974).

from the reins, has been dragged through pathless places and woods and torn to pieces: the historian has no compunction in cutting the body off and sitting in the dead man's saddle (19.8.7). Finally, Ammianus lets us know that Count Aelianus and the tribunes who had protected the walls of Amida were wickedly hung up on gibbets by the victorious Persians, and that other officers, including Ammianus' fellow *protectores*, went off into captivity with their hands tied behind their backs (19.9.2).[121] No wonder that he was despaired of in Antioch (19.8.12). Although the pages of Ammianus exhibit a remarkable variety of hideous demises, it seems clear that the arrangement of these particular deaths during the escape narratives is as deliberate as his usage of the first person singular, even when he is not strictly alone.[122] They reinforce the importance of his escape.

The implications of these choices are historiographical: the literal loneliness of Ammianus acts as a metaphor for his loneliness in the field of history. By showing himself alone, he suggests that his historical testimony is unique. And by giving prominence to the perils that he faced and to the chances that permitted his survival, he emphasises that the survival of his literary work, of the most truthful historical record of the period, had hung (to reuse Ammianus' own metaphor of the sword of Damocles) by a horse hair.[123]

This proposition is not only supported by the choice of occasions when Ammianus appears in his narrative, but also by the choice of language on these occasions. The historian introduces first-person narration quite suddenly in the treason trials in the East under Valens (29.1.24):

et quoniam addici post cruciabiles poenas uidimus multos, / ut in tenebrosis rebus confusione cuncta miscente, / summatim, quia nos penitissima gestorum memoria fugit, / quae recolere possumus / expeditius absoluemus.

And since there were many whom we saw sentenced after cruel tortures, and as tends to happen in shadowy circumstances, confusion mixes everything together,

[121] This is not, as Matthews puts it ((1983), 45), 'possibly unconscious irony'.

[122] The variety of deaths is matched by linguistic variety: Hagendahl (1921), 100–2, lists fifty synonyms for *mori* in the *Res Gestae*.

[123] 29.2.4.

we shall narrate summarily, because intimate recollection of events escapes us, and shall finish what we can recall with greater speed.

The imagery of shadows and confusion is picked up in another personal intervention a few sentences later (29.2.4):[124]

inde effectum est per orientales prouincias, / ut a dominis metu similium / exurerentur libraria omnia: / tantus uniuersos inuaserat terror. / namque ut pressius loquar, / omnes ea tempestate uelut in Cimmeriis tenebris reptabamus, / paria conuiuis Siculi Dionysii pauitantes . . .

The result of this was that throughout the eastern provinces, all libraries were burnt by their masters for fear of similar treatment [i.e. being burnt alive themselves]: such fear had fallen on everybody. For if I may speak truthfully, at that time we were all crawling about as if in Cimmerian darkness, our fears equal to those of Sicilian Dionysius' party-guests . . .

A third emotional intervention, which does not use a first-person verb and is better called implied autopsy, appears slightly later in the chapter (29.2.15):

horret nunc reminisci / quo iustitio humilitati tot rerum apices uisebantur, / et praecipue consulares / post scipiones et trabeas et fastorum monumenta mundana.

It is grievous now to remember under what sort of process so many exalted figures were seen to have been humbled, and especially former consuls, after their rods of office and robes of state and the worldwide inscriptions of the calendar.

This motif, of the painful memory, reuses the rhetoric deployed in the first of these interventions (29.1.24). There Ammianus twists the conventional historiographical claim that personal experience guarantees his knowledge of events: as soon as he has introduced his autopsy (*uidimus*), he claims that the nature of what he saw confused events and made him able to remember, and therefore to narrate, only summarily. In organisation and detail, what follows is neither confused nor a summary, and it is clear that this alleged failure of memory is a conceit meant to emphasise the horror of living through those days.[125] One way of reading this failure of memory is as part of the *Res Gestae*'s journey towards closure and the time of writing, from the mention of the unspecified dangers

[124] This imagery of darkness for woes in the political sphere is also found at 31.5.11.

[125] The clarity of the account stands out particularly when compared to the parallel narrative of magic and treason trials in Rome in the first chapter of the previous book.

of contemporary history in the preface to Book 26, to the situation implied by the sphragis when it is no longer possible to write truthful history.[126] Particularly interesting, however, are the words in which Ammianus claims that detailed memory escapes him, *quia nos penitissima gestorum memoria fugit*.

In the preface to his *Jugurtha*, Sallust defends historiography, which he calls *memoria rerum gestarum*, 'remembrance of things past' (4.1), as a worthy alternative to politics.[127] His argument closes by citing the way that the great heroes of the Roman Republic were spurred on to virtuous deeds by the *imagines* of their ancestors: not because of any quality inherent to the wax masks, but because they were inspired by 'remembrance of things past' (again *memoria rerum gestarum*, 4.6). The word *memoria* can mean both memory and the form in which memory is preserved – here, as often, history – and Sallust used its lexical slipperiness to argue for the validity of his own calling and its equivalence to statesmanship.[128] Whether or not Ammianus is alluding to Sallust with the phrase *gestorum memoria*, it has a slipperiness of meaning similar to Sallust's:[129] Ammianus cannot remember, and so he will not record, the intimate details of what happened. He describes his own memory of events in words which imply that it is identical to the historical record: so we should understand the words as meaning both 'because detailed memory of events excapes us' and 'because detailed *history* escapes us'.

This suggestion that the history itself has suffered from the awfulness of what the historian remembers magnifies the sense

[126] See Kelly (2007).

[127] Thus picking up and expanding the defence of *res gestae* found in the preface to the *Bellum Catilinae* (3–4.2).

[128] See Woodman (1973) for a case of deliberate ambiguity in the preface to Sallust's *Bellum Catilinae*. On ambiguous use of *memoria* see Kraus and Woodman (1997), 1, and Gowing (2005), Ch. 1. Examples include Cicero, *De Republica* 6.10, where his grandfather tells the dreaming Scipio *quae dicam trade memoriae*, which means both 'remember what I shall say' and 'hand what I say on to posterity', and the case from Tacitus cited in Ch. 1 n. 29. *Memoria* might reasonably be translated as 'history' in many places in Ammianus, e.g. 22.4.7, 22.16.14, 23.5.17, 25.9.11, 26.1.1, 28.4.32, 31.4.7, 31.5.10.

[129] In favour of allusion, I would argue that *gestorum* is equivalent to *rerum gestarum*. Compare the well-known phrase *cognitio gestorum* ('understanding of events') in the preface to Book 15, which is a variant on the words *cognitio rerum* in Livy *praef.* 10). *Memoria gestorum* and *cognitio gestorum* are likely to be significant concepts in a work entitled *Res Gestae*.

of his personal danger, and reinforces the link between him and his work. It is also significant, I think, that, in the second of his brief appearances in this section, he juxtaposes his and others' feelings of terror with a description of the burning of books.[130] *All* libraries are burnt, a hyperbole matched by the fear in which *all* were afflicted by terror and felt the sword dangling over their heads (*libraria omnia . . . uniuersos . . . omnes*, 29.2.4). He shows the threat to both his personal survival and, by implication and association, his literary survival.

Another linguistic feature which, I suggest, merges his roles as participant and historian is found in the narratives of the year 359. Other characters encountered during the autobiographical passages are described in language characteristically used for historians. When Ursicinus' men find the Persian spy at Meiacarire, his life-story is recounted in some detail before his summary execution. Born in Paris, he had defected from the Roman cavalry to escape punishment, had married a Persian wife and raised a family; respecting his excellent character, the Persians had sent him on spying missions. The story is introduced with the words *pandit rerum integram fidem*, 'he revealed the full truth of things' (18.6.16). The language is like that in which a historian might claim reliability and comprehensiveness, and the words can be closely paralleled in a number of places across the *Res Gestae*: most notably, Ammianus promises that his narrative of Julian will consist not of wordy falsehood but 'the full truth of things' (*fides integra rerum*, 16.1.3).[131] The spy, I suggest, is presented as a potential historian.

The same applies to Antoninus, another defector and spy. I argued earlier that Antoninus was presented as similar to both Ursicinus and Ammianus himself in the narrative of the Persian war, and that this similarity helped the historian in using Antoninus

[130] It might be tempting to think of book-burning as a peculiarly modern source of horror, associated with the Inquisition and National Socialism, but Tacitus (*Agricola* 2.1–2, *Ann.* 4.35.4–5) for one can be cited to show book-burning as a characteristic of ancient tyranny. The imagery of burning is important in these last books of Ammianus: the burning alive of the philosopher Simonides in the previous chapter (29.1.37–9) will be avenged by the death of Valens, who, in the version to which Ammianus seems to give greater credit, is also burnt alive (31.14.14–17, cf. 31.1.2).

[131] Cf. also 21.9.1, 28.6.28 and 29.5.19 for close echoes of these words. Ammianus uses *fides* of historiographical accuracy at 15.9.1, 18.6.23, 22.8.1, 22.16.13, 23.5.20, 29.1.36 and 31.4.8.

as a focaliser for the narrative and thereby explaining Persian motivations. Like Ammianus, he is bilingual in Latin and Greek, and a *protector*,[132] and therefore able to inspect the military records of the whole East and to calculate their significance. Both visit Persian territory in secret: Ammianus' friendly welcome by Jovinianus, a satrap with private pro-Roman sympathies, verbally echoes that of Antoninus at the Persian court a few pages earlier.[133] (Their common ability to move seamlessly across borders incidentally suggests that both must have been competent in Syriac and perhaps also Persian.)[134] Antoninus does not just possess ability at research. When he appears before the Persian court, his training, knowledge and rhetorical success make him a model historian (18.5.7):[135]

> For as a man trained at the centre of events, and experienced in all affairs, he gripped at his hearers' feelings, enthusiastic and keen to have their ears charmed. They did not praise him but like Homer's Phaeacians admired him in silence, as he rehearsed the history of the last forty years . . .

This presentation of Antoninus as almost an *alter ego* for Ammianus has various possible implications: it suggests that the historian, himself bilingual and a *protector*, had the same superior access to information and understanding of events. In the defector's circumstances, might Ammianus have had a similar impact on the history of his times? I would emphasise that, for the practical reason that he is a traitor and exile from Rome, Antoninus, like the spy killed by Ursicinus' men, is a historian manqué. The treatment of other characters is not so clearly redolent of the technical language of the genre, but it might be tentatively suggested that some of the numerous deaths are of those who might otherwise have had the same qualifications to write history as Ammianus himself. The presumed loss of Verinianus before Amida removed a fine witness for the suppression of Silvanus; and the execution or captivity of

[132] Antoninus seems to have been simply a *protector* rather than a *protector domesticus* like Ammianus. On the distinction see Ch. 3, Section II below.

[133] 18.5.6 *auenter suscipitur* ~ 18.6.23 *comiter susceptus*.

[134] See Ch. 3, Section II below on Ammianus' command of Syriac.

[135] *educatus enim in medio, / ut rerum omnium gnarus, / auditorum uigiles sensus et aurium delenimenta captantes, / nec laudantium sed secundum Homericos Phaeacas / cum silentio admirantium, / iam inde quadragesimi anni memoriam replicabat* . . . Cf. 15.1.1, where *uersati in medio* are named as Ammianus' sources for the history of his times. On the use of *memoria* to mean history see n. 128 above.

those Roman commanders at the siege of Amida who had not hidden and slipped out of a postern gate left only Ammianus among the Roman high command to pass these important events into the historical record (18.8.11, 19.9.2).

The suggestion that other characters are presented like failed historians may seem to some to be over-interpretation of a few linguistic oddities. But to be the 'lonely historian' is to be concerned about the inadequacies or the absence of other accounts. John Marincola argues that the epithet should not be applied only to Ammianus: 'nearly every ancient historian seeks to portray himself as a lonely seeker of truth, as the only one who has somehow understood the historian's proper task, while his predecessors . . . failed in the effort'.[136] Not only predecessors, I would argue, but also contemporary rivals.

Austin's argument that autobiographical narratives aim to identify with the historian the history of his own lifetime can be taken a step further. Ammianus' physical solitude is a metaphor for the uniqueness of his knowledge and perspective. In those places where he was present but displays less open participation in the action, his knowledge and perspective may have been less unique. Intimacy may be in inverse proportion to the existence and detail of other sources – in the sense of both witnesses and literary texts. His most involved appearances are those where he was one of very few sources, or the only possible source. Ammianus was the only person who could describe his mission into Corduene or the flight from Amida. In describing the repression of Silvanus, Ammianus was building on a tradition that already existed, as we have seen, and was accordingly somewhat less intimate, as is indicated *inter alia* by the first person plural being preferred to the singular. Still, he was describing events which had taken place on a distant frontier and of which he could doubtless offer better and more detailed information than any predecessor. In the Persian campaign of 363, his first-person narrative is only occasional, and his personal activities are never specified. We know that the flower of the Roman army and court participated in the expedition and that it was

[136] Marincola (1997), 217.

the favoured subject matter of contemporary historical narrative. Libanius' letters from the following two years exhibit several potential memoirists, and if not all of these authors brought their works to fruition, Libanius himself told the story at length in the *Funeral Oration*.[137] Other historical works dealt with this subject: Eunapius (based on a memoir by Julian's doctor Oribasius, and in disproportionate detail if Zosimus' third book is anything to judge by); Magnus of Carrhae; Eutychianus; there was also at least one epic poem, by Callistus.[138] Among this crowd of writers, and the swarms of high-ranking soldiers and officials who had accompanied Julian, Ammianus allows his presence to be felt, but he could not proclaim his uniqueness. It seems likely that, being bilingual and a voracious reader, he had read but not depended on such sources as were available. Much is often made of the similarities to Eunapius' account, which was probably available to him.[139] He did not use it as a primary source, differing, for example, on transcription of place names.[140] But it has been attractively suggested by John Matthews that, on those occasions when he may have followed Eunapius in describing the Persian campaign, Ammianus likes to add distinct details, or first-person verbs, in order to proclaim his independence (his two examples are Zosimus 3.14.4 ~ 24.1.9–10 and Zosimus 3.15.5 ~ 24.2.3).[141] If this is more than chance, it is another argument that Ammianus deploys autopsy to show himself creating, supplementing or correcting the historical tradition.

This chapter will end with a closer look at two passages in which autopsy plays a part, and, I shall argue, is used to reinforce the historian's authority: the spying mission in Corduene which leads Ammianus to see the Persian army from a mountain; and the great tsunami of 21 July 365.

[137] Philagrius had written an account (Libanius *Ep.* 1434) and Seleucus had promised to (*Ep.* 1508). Libanius gained further oral and written information from various soldiers (*Ep.* 1220.8). See Sabbah (1978), 201, and Brok (1959), 9–12.

[138] Cf. Malalas 13.21, 23; Socrates 3.21.14.

[139] Those interested in why I think that the first edition of Eunapius was probably available to Ammianus can consult (a small selection for a controversial topic) Barnes (1976), 265–7, (1978); Paschoud (1980), (1985); Banchich (1986); Liebeschuetz (2003), esp. 179–91, reviewed by Paschoud (2005b), 369–72.

[140] Fornara (1991); Matthews (1989), 169.

[141] Matthews (1989), 171–3.

IV Espionage

18.6.20 erat eo tempore satrapa Corduenae, / quae obtemperabat potestati Persarum, / Iouinianus nomine appellatus in solo Romano, / adulescens nobiscum occulte sentiens ea gratia, / quod obsidatus sorte in Syriis detentus / et dulcedine liberalium studiorum illectus / remeare ad nostra ardenti desiderio gestiebat. / (21) ad hunc missus ego cum centurione quodam fidissimo / exploratius noscendi gratia, quae gerebantur, / per auios montes angustiasque praecipites ueni. / uisusque et agnitus comiterque susceptus, / causam praesentiae meae uni illi confessus / adiuncto taciturno aliquo locorum perito / mittor ad praecelsas rupes exinde longe distantes, / unde nisi oculorum deficeret acies, / ad quinquagesimum usque lapidem quoduis etiam minutissimum apparebat. / (22) ibi morati integrum biduum, / cum sol tertius adfulsisset, / cernebamus terrarum omnes ambitus subiectos, / quos ὁρίζοντας appellamus, / agminibus oppletos innumeris / et antegressum regem uestis claritudine rutilantem. / quem iuxta laeuus incedebat Grumbates / Chionitarum rex †nobis†,[142] / aetate quidem media rugosisque membris, / sed mente quadam grandifica / multisque uictoriarum insignibus nobilis; / dextra rex Albanorum pari loco atque honore sublimis; / post duces uarii auctoritate et potestatibus eminentes, / quos ordinum omnium multitudo sequebatur ex uicinarum gentium roboribus lecta, / ad tolerandam rerum asperitatem diuturnis casibus erudita. / (23) quo usque nobis Doriscum Thraciae oppidum / et agminatim intra consaepta exercitus recensitos, / Graecia fabulosa, narrabis? / cum nos cauti uel, ut uerius dixerim, timidi / nihil exaggeremus / praeter ea quae fidei testimonia / neque dubia neque incerta monstrarunt. /

18.7.1 postquam reges Nineue, Adiabenae ingenti ciuitate, transmissa, / in medio pontis Anzabae hostiis caesis, / extisque prosperantibus transiere laetissimi, / coniectantes nos residuam plebem omnem aegre penetrare post triduum posse, / citius exinde ad satrapen reuersi quieuimus / hospitalibus officiis recreati. / (2) unde per loca itidem deserta et sola / magno necessitatis ducente solacio / celerius quam potuit sperari reuersi / confirmauimus animos haesitantium, / unum e naualibus pontem transisse reges absque ulla circumitione perdoctos.

18.6.20 There was at the time a satrap of Corduene, which was subject to the power of the Persians: he was called by the name Jovinianus on Roman territory. The young man secretly sympathised with our side for this reason, that he had been held as a hostage in the Syrian provinces and, attracted by the delights of liberal studies, yearned with a burning desire to return to our lands. (21) To him I was sent, with an exceptionally trusty centurion, to get a clearer idea of what was happening, and I journeyed through trackless mountains and precipitous passes.

[142] Seyfarth prints *nobilis* for *V*'s *nobis*, which cannot be right, both on the grounds of repetition of *nobilis* and the poor rhythm. Better sense might be to assume a word has dropped out after *nobis*. *Acerbus* (or *hostis acerbus*) might have encouraged a *saut du même au même*; *infensus* is another possibility.

And I was seen and recognised and warmly welcomed, and when I'd revealed the reason for my presence to him alone, I was attached to a taciturn fellow who knew the territory, and was sent to some lofty crags a long way off, from which, were not eyesight fallible, even the smallest object would have been visible at up to fifty miles away. (22) We tarried there for two whole days, and when the third day had dawned we beheld the whole circuit of lands spread out beneath us (what we call ὁρίζοντες) filled with unnumbered armies, and the King going before them glittering red from the brightness of his garb. And alongside him on the left went Grumbates, the king of the Chionitae, in middle age and with wrinkled limbs, but possessed of a certain grandeur of spirit and renowned for the glory of many victories; on the right, the king of the Albani, lofty in his equal position and esteem; and various leaders after them, elevated in their authority and power, and a multitude of all ranks followed, picked from the strength of the neighbouring peoples and accustomed from long experience to bearing hardship. (23) How long, storied Greece, will you tell us of Doriscum, the town of Thrace, and armies counted column by column within enclosures? When we from caution, or, to speak more truthfully, from fear, will exaggerate nothing except what creditable evidence has shown neither unsure nor uncertain.

18.7.1 After the kings had passed by Nineveh, a vast city of Adiabene, and victims had been killed in the middle of the bridge over the Greater Zab and the omens found favourable, they crossed joyfully. We guessed that the rest of the host could hardly cross until three days had passed, so having returned swiftly to the satrap we took rest and were revived by his hospitality. (2) From there we went again through deserted and solitary places, and led on by the consoling thought of necessity we returned more swiftly than could have been hoped, and gave strength to our temporising colleagues with the sure news that the kings had crossed without any detour on a single bridge of boats.

This episode, more than any other, unites the characteristic themes of autobiographical narrative in Ammianus: the historian's solitude and peril, wondrous subject matter which has provoked scepticism in modern scholars, an allusiveness which – in this case, quite openly – relates personal experience to past literature. There is a blatant melding of the personal and the literary statement, of the roles of eyewitness and historian.[143]

Ammianus' solitude on this vitally important mission is constantly implied – even though he is never shown as actually alone. When he is accompanied by a centurion on the journey to Jovinianus, and by a local guide to his lofty vantage point, the verbs are first person singular (20–1), with other individuals removed to the

[143] In writing this passage I was not able to use Lionel Mary's valuable contribution of 2003.

ablative case.[144] The emphasis on the discreet qualities of his travelling companions is no coincidence: the centurion is *fidissimus*, 'very trusty', and the guide *taciturnus*, one 'who knew when to keep his mouth shut'.[145] Ammianus reveals the reason for his presence to Jovinianus alone. The looming mountainous landscapes too emphasise the solitariness of this mission – as when he returns to Roman territory 'through deserted and solitary places' (*per loca deserta et sola*). He does not linger on the undoubted dangers of this mission – what if Jovinianus changed his mind, or if they came across enemy troops? – but they can be inferred from the landscape of *angustiae praecipites*, 'precipitous passes', words in which it is impossible to distinguish between the geographical and the metaphorical cliff's edge. By illustrating his solitary and imperilled condition, the description of his travelling companions and the landscape stresses his personal role as the conduit by which this crucial information reached Ursicinus and also implies (following my argument in Section III of this chapter) his role as a unique historical source.

Yet this is also the passage in which, more than in any other, the truthfulness of Ammianus' eyewitness testimony has been doubted by modern scholarship, once more because of a claim to have beheld marvels. Scepticism clouds the central incident of this episode, the view of the Persian army at fifty miles distance. Büdinger in 1895 called it a 'Fantasiestück' and subsequent scholarship has often agreed with this assessment.[146] Ammianus is accused of describing things that he never saw and never could have seen from such a distance: the King in bright garb at the head of his army, with a client-king on either side of him, and sacrifices as they crossed the bridge of boats. Sacrifice was not only invisible at such a distance, but also quite out of keeping with the Zoroastrian practice of the Persian court.[147]

Ammianus' reputation for truthfulness has been further damaged by mistranslation. He describes the potential view from his

[144] For my purposes here, the first person singular is important because it shows the historian as more personally involved and more solitary.

[145] De Jonge ad loc. Or could a mute be meant?

[146] Büdinger (1895), 27–9, at 28; Vogt (1963), 811; Rosen (1968), 43.

[147] See Büdinger (1895), 28–9.

vantage point on the cliffs: *unde, nisi oculorum deficeret acies, ad quinquagesimum usque lapidem quoduis etiam minutissimum apparebat.* Rolfe translates: 'from which, unless one's eyesight was impaired, even the smallest object was visible at a distance of fifty miles'. Sabbah's version is somewhat different: 'from where, were it not that [human] eyesight is deficient, even the smallest object would have been visible fifty miles away'.[148] This makes better sense than the irrelevant and pedantic introduction of the fact that some people are myopic, and concurs with Ammianus' linguistic practice. The use of the imperfect or pluperfect indicative, rather than the subjunctive, in the apodosis of unreal conditional clauses is an occasional feature in Latin of all periods, but commonplace in Ammianus. So *apparebat* is best translated not 'was visible', but 'would [or could] have been visible' (equivalent to *appareret*, or *poterat apparere*).[149] The mistranslation was allowed to persist largely because of the historian's assertion in the following sentence, that after two days of waiting he saw the Persian army filling the horizons, and the King at its head (the verb used, *cernebamus*, can have the specific meaning of 'picking out'). He did indeed see 'even the smallest object'. So while the choice of the indicative *apparebat* rather than the subjunctive makes no impossible claim in itself, it may prepare for the impossible claim that follows.

It is certainly possible to see immense distances in certain climates and from certain places, especially in pre-industrial countries: N. J. E. Austin sprang to Ammianus' defence with some examples of his own far-sightedness in eastern Rhodesia.[150] There seems little reason to doubt the possibility of seeing a large army, whose column could easily have been ten miles long or more, and the accompanying dust-cloud from a high point fifty miles away or even more. (And we need not insist that this is a precise distance,

[148] '. . . desquelles, n'eût été la défaillance de la vue, tout objet, même le plus réduit, apparaissent à cinquante milles.' Hamilton's translation (1986) runs 'if one's eyesight were good enough, the smallest object would be visible fifty miles away.'

[149] See Sabbah's discussion in the introduction to his Budé ((1970), 11 n. 6), and ad loc.: he compares 19.6.11. For indicative in the apodosis of a remote conditional see de Jonge ad 14.3.2 (*Sprachlicher Kommentar*, 80). Sabbah's translation is also supported by the description of the Colosseum at 16.10.14: *amphitheatri . . . ad cuius summitatem aegre uisio humana conscendit* ('the amphitheatre, to whose highest point human vision only barely reaches'.)

[150] Austin (1973), 332. His colonial examples are wittily parodied by Paschoud (1989), 42.

especially as Ammianus does not explicitly say that the Persian army was fifty miles away, simply that they filled the horizons.) Study of a map suggests the availability of high points from which to overlook the two rivers due north of their confluence at about twenty-five miles' distance. More probably Ammianus watched from a point around seventy miles away to the north-east or north-north-west. Peaks of 1,000 m near modern Dohuk might have provided a view down the valley of the Tigris, and there are mountains of almost 2,000 m near Yakmala, forty or so miles to the east of Dohuk, which command a view through the valley of the Khazir, which runs into the Greater Zab before its own confluence with the Tigris.[151] But the fact that Ammianus could have seen the army does not mean that he could possibly have seen Sapor's red cloak or the wrinkled limbs of King Grumbates.[152] He might have started a new sentence before describing the Persian King and his vassals, and controversy would never have happened: he chose not to do this, and to use autopsy – not for the only time in the work – to describe the incredible.

As with other depictions of extraordinary autopsy, literary allusion offers an explanation. Not only does Ammianus adduce an example from Herodotus, but another possible precedent has been identified, an *exemplum* from Roman republican history of a man who had the ability to see enormous distances.[153] Cicero (*Acad.* 1.24) and the elder Pliny (*NH* 7.85) mention the case of Strabo ('Squinter'), who claimed to be able to count the Punic fleet leaving the great harbour of Carthage from the promontory of Lilybaeum

[151] I consulted the *Barrington Atlas of the Ancient World* and *Irak 1:200,000* (a German military map of Iraq, 2nd edn, January 1942, J-38/20). It should also be noted that the Persians needed to have crossed the Great Zab before passing by Nineveh (18.7.1), which lies between the two rivers. It is possible that Ammianus may have erred on the location of Nineveh, or that he briefly confused the two rivers, and that the bridge of boats was over the Tigris not the Greater Zab (the likelier alternative, and argued for also by Rosen (1968), and, if I understand him correctly, by de Jonge ad loc.). But Dillemann (1962), 291 and Fig. XXXVII, interprets the words *transmisso Nineve* as 'bypassing Nineveh' and argues for a crossing of both rivers some way to the south of the ruined city. For further discussion of this passage, in the context of a broader look at the region's geography, see Dillemann (1962) and Matthews (1989), 49.

[152] The crucial distinction between seeing the army and the kings is rightly emphasised by de Jonge ad loc.

[153] Dillemann (1961), 101–2, Paschoud (1989), 42–3.

in Sicily.[154] The similarity is a pertinent one, both cases being concerned with espying the forces of Rome's enemies from a great distance.[155] This possible allusion to an obscure tale having been accepted as certain, Ammianus can again be convicted of shaping his narrative to fit the precedents of the great literature of the past without regard for truth or possibility.[156]

I should be last to play down the importance of allusion in Ammianus' writing (in this case the blatant comparison to Herodotus deserves more attention than the latent story of far-sighted Strabo). But critiques which see allusion as proving historical unreliability miss the point. They tend to be insensitive to the artfulness of Ammianus' writing[157] – and they also ignore the fact that he himself acknowledges the rhetorical *jeu d'esprit* which led him to stretch reality.[158] The view of the Persian army is marked out as a set piece. Ammianus' earlier rapid movements have been marked by a swift succession of first-person singular verbs and participles (*missus, ueni, uisus, agnitus, susceptus, confessus, mittor*, 18.6.21). With *morati* and the imperfect *cernebamus* (18.6.22), the movement and the first-person singular verbs cease. Everything is suddenly quite still: presented as a tableau. He does not say that he saw the army appear over the horizon, but that on the third morning he saw the horizon filled by the army.[159] He proceeds to describe the Persian marching order as statically and hierarchically as if it were a procession carved on a monument. The apostrophe to 'Storied Greece' which follows serves the structural purpose of freezing the impression of the army on the horizon; only afterwards (18.7.1) does Ammianus describe the movement of the host over the bridge of boats. This static quality gives a flavour of ecphrasis to the

[154] Presumably in the First Punic War. See also Solinus 1.99, Valerius Maximus 1.8.ext.14, Aelian *VH* 11.13, Strabo 6.2.1, Plutarch *Mor.* 1083d.

[155] Moreover, the words *acies oculorum*, which Ammianus uses for the excellence of sight which was the hindrance to seeing the smallest object, also occur in Pliny's description of Strabo (*NH* 7.85).

[156] Vogt (1963), 823 (who does not adduce the tale of Strabo), calls the result 'eine Art Jägergeschichte'.

[157] The honourable exception is Paschoud, whose aim is rather to highlight Ammianus' artfulness, though in practice he spends most of the time assaulting his veracity.

[158] Cf. Matthews (1989), 50: 'Ammianus' flourish can be accepted for what it is, without throwing his whole account into doubt.'

[159] This could be interpreted as meaning that they had not been there before or that the weather had not been adequate. See de Jonge ad loc.

passage, and it is characteristic of ecphrasis to blend what the internal viewer can see with details and information which may elude him. The shield of Aeneas is described from Aeneas' point of view, but the poet can pick out and interpret details unknown to his viewer.[160] That is more or less what we have here. In narratalogical terms, it is a change in focalisation, with Ammianus the historian taking over from Ammianus the eyewitness-participant.[161]

In turning aside to address 'Storied Greece', he adduces a historical *exemplum*, of Xerxes' army in the Persian invasion of Greece in 480 BC, which was notoriously estimated by Herodotus to have contained over five million men (7.60). *Fabulosa Graecia* is a transparent reference to Herodotus, who had been impugned for as long as he had been depended on, because he was not an eyewitness, because he invented conversations at which he could not have been present, and especially because his counting of Xerxes' army was at fault.[162] Ammianus, who has shown us that he was an eyewitness, rejects the 'fabulous' elements in Herodotus, to claim that his own account is based on sure evidence. His unwillingness to give the exact size of Sapor's army – he says that the horizons were filled with countless columns, *agminibus . . . innumeris* – contrasts notably with Herodotus. (The refusal to count the enemy is also a point of contrast with the story of Strabo counting the Carthaginian ships, and an argument for allusion to it.)

However, to see the *exemplum* purely as an unfavourable comparison of the fantasies of Herodotus against the evidence-based history of Ammianus would be mistaken. Not only the historians but the armies which they describe are compared: in this simultaneous comparison the vastness of Xerxes' army is usefully summoned up to emphasise the great size and threat of Sapor's forces. Several other factors make the criticism of Herodotus ambivalent rather than whole-hearted. The very fact of using a circumlocution

[160] On ecphrasis in later Latin literature see Roberts (1989); also Roberts (1988) and Kelly (2003), 598–9, on Constantius' visit to Rome as ecphrasis. The use of ἐναργεία ('vividness', 'brightness') is characteristic of ecphrasis, and can be seen in the focus on individual details like the colour of Sapor's clothing.

[161] The retreat from first-person singular verb in 21 to the plural *cernebamus* ('we beheld') in 22 could arguably refer to Ammianus and his silent guide, but it could equally be seen as stepping back from the role of participant into that of historian, which emerges fully in 23 (*nos . . . nihil exaggeremus*).

[162] On the reception of Herodotus see e.g. Hornblower (2006), 310–17.

like *fabulosa Graecia*, 'Storied Greece', rather than the name of Herodotus shows a wish to allude to polemic rather than indulge in it directly.[163] Moreover, the circumlocution is one that might at first sight be applied to Ammianus himself – he had just reminded readers that he was a Greek by adding and glossing the word 'horizons', and he had just made an apparently fabulous assertion. He categorises the self-restraint that differentiates him from Herodotus as caution, or, better, timidity. And at a later point in the work he is led to conclude that the extraordinary and inestimable number of the Gothic invaders in 376 shows that the common view of posterity (including, in Book 18, himself), that the vastness of the Persian host described by Herodotus belonged to the realm of fable, must now be corrected: such marvels were possible after all (31.4.7–8).[164] The *exemplum* here is confirmed by the item to which it is compared, a reversal, though not a unique one, of the expectation that past *exempla* confirm the plausibility of modern events.

The apostrophe to 'Storied Greece', among other purposes, acknowledges the rhetorical flourish of the previous sentence. He may seem close to *fabulosa Graecia*, it is implied, but in fact, and in spite of all temptation, he is not. 'We will exaggerate nothing, *except* what trustworthy testimony has shown neither unsure nor uncertain' (*nihil exaggeremus, / praeter ea quae fidei testimonia / neque dubia neque incerta monstrarunt*). He admits exaggeration but defends it. What he actually saw was the army; his pardonable exaggeration is the supplementary information about the Persian line of battle which he received from informants, from tradition,

[163] Contrast Vogt (1963), 823.

[164] 31.4.7–8 (I have printed in bold verbal reminiscences of 18.6.23): *resipiscant tandem memoriae ueteres, / Medicas acies ductantes ad* ***Graeciam***, */ quae dum Hellespontiacos pontes / et discidio quodam fabrili / mare sub imo Athonis pede quaesitum exponunt / et* ***turmatim apud Doriscum exercitus recensetos***, */ concordante omni posteritate / ut* ***fabulosae*** *sunt lectae. /* (8) *nam postquam* ***innumerae*** *gentium multitudines / per prouincias circumfusae / pandentesque se in spatia ampla camporum / regiones omnes et cuncta oppleuere montium iuga, / fides quoque uetustatis recenti documento firmata est.* ('Let those ancient histories at last be revived, those which lead the Median columns to **Greece**. While they told of bridges across the Hellespont, and sea brought to the very foot of Athos by some sort of artificial channel, and **armies counted out by squadrons at Doriscum**, they were read by the common agreement of all later ages as **fabulous**. (8) For after **numberless** swarms of nations were poured through the provinces, and spreading themselves over the great extent of the plains filled all regions and every mountain ridge, this new proof confirmed the trustworthiness of antiquity.')

from what he himself saw at Amida. He may not have beheld with perfect clarity the wondrous sights which he describes in fabulous manner, but they really *were* there, when he said they were.

This rhetorical trick acknowledges and emphasises the extraordinary and sensational nature of what the historian has seen. The massive extent of the army is indicated by the content and length of the description, by the *exemplum*, and by emotional rhetorical tropes, amplification (immediately withdrawn, or excused) and apostrophe. But the passage also says something general about what makes historians credible. The interruption of a passage of autopsy by a historiographical statement serves to proclaim the importance of autopsy to Ammianus' historical credibility: he was dealing with events which he knew better than anybody. But autopsy is not enough to sustain a history. It is juxtaposed with an alternative (sometimes additional, sometimes competing) source of authority, allusion to the classics. And by describing things which he could not have seen at the time, and then admitting his limited form of exaggeration, Ammianus acknowledges the limits of autopsy. Personal experience is inevitably a preliminary form of knowledge. A historian cannot simply use what he himself has seen, and cannot simply focalise through himself. Subsequent knowledge and subsequent events change perceptions and even memories of what he has seen; and a proper understanding needs supplementing from what others tell you, from *testimonia neque dubia neque incerta*. Being a historian involves possessing a sharpness of vision that leads you to being able to see and portray more than simply what you have witnessed.

In leaving this remarkable set piece, which is worthy of further discussion, what I would emphasise above all is its self-consciousness. Ammianus juxtaposes personal experiences and reflexions on his place in the historical canon, and draws a connection between the two. He is open about his supplementation of apparent autopsy by external testimony; readers' attention is drawn to the varying degrees of authorial involvement in autobiographical passages, and changes of focalisation within them. In fact the passage acknowledges the various narrative habits which I have been discussing throughout this chapter.

I turn now to a second detailed case study, on Ammianus' description of the great earthquake and tsunami of 21 July 365.

V The tsunami

26.10.15 hoc nouatore adhuc superstite, / cuius actus multiplices docuimus et interitum, / diem duodecimum Kalendas Augustas / consule Valentiniano primum cum fratre, / horrendi terrores per omnem orbis ambitum grassati sunt subito, / quales nec fabulae nec ueridicae nobis antiquitates exponunt. / (16) Paulo enim post lucis exortum, / densitate praeuia fulgurum acrius uibratorum, / tremefacta concutitur omnis terreni stabilitas ponderis, / mareque dispulsum retro fluctibus euolutis abscessit, / ut retecta uoragine profundorum / species natantium multiformes limo cernerentur haerentes, / ualliumque uastitates et montium, / tunc, ut opinari dabatur, / suspicerent radios solis, / quos primigenia rerum sub immensis gurgitibus amendauit. (17) multis igitur nauibus uelut arida humo conexis, / et licenter per exiguas undarum reliquias palantibus plurimis / ut pisces manibus colligerent et similia, / marini fremitus, uelut grauati repulsam, / uersa uice consurgunt, / perque uada feruentia insulis et continentis terrae porrectis spatiis uiolenter illisi, / innumera quaedam in ciuitatibus et ubi reperta sunt aedificia complanarunt, / proinde ut, elementorum furente discordia, / inuoluta facies mundi miraculorum species ostendebat. / (18) relapsa enim aequorum magnitudo, / cum minime speraretur, / milia multa necauit hominum et submersit, / recurrentiumque aestuum incitata uertigine, / quaedam naues, postquam umentis substantiae consenuit tumor, / pessumdatae uisae sunt, exanimataque naufragiis corpora supina iacebant aut prona. / (19) ingentes aliae naues / extrusae rabidis flatibus / culminibus insidere tectorum, / ut Alexandriae contigit, / et ad secundum lapidem fere procul a litore / contortae sunt aliquae, / ut Laconicam prope Mothonen oppidum nos transeundo conspeximus, / diuturna carie fatiscentem.

26.10.15 While this usurper [Procopius] yet lived, whose various deeds and whose death I have described, on 21 July in the year in which Valentinian was consul for the first time with his brother [365], fearsome terrors suddenly strode through the whole circle of the world, the like of which neither legends nor truthful ancient histories tell us. (16) Slightly after daybreak, and heralded by a thick succession of fiercely shaken thunderbolts, the solidity of the whole earth was made to shake and shudder, and the sea was driven away, its waves were rolled back, and it disappeared, so that the abyss of the depths was uncovered and many-shaped varieties of sea-creatures were seen stuck in the slime; the great wastes of those valleys and mountains, which the very creation had dismissed beneath the vast whirlpools, at that moment, as it was given to be believed, looked up at the sun's rays. (17) Many ships, then, were stranded as if on dry land, and people wandered at will about the paltry remains of the waters to collect fish and the like in their hands; then the roaring sea as if insulted by its repulse rises back in turn, and through the teeming shoals dashed itself violently on islands and

extensive tracts of the mainland, and flattened innumerable buildings in towns or wherever they were found. Thus in the raging conflict of the elements, the face of the earth was changed to reveal wondrous sights. (18) For the mass of waters returning when least expected killed many thousands by drowning, and with the tides whipped up to a height as they rushed back, some ships, after the anger of the watery element had grown old, were seen to have sunk, and the bodies of people killed in shipwrecks lay there, faces up or down. (19) Other huge ships, thrust out by the mad blasts, perched on the roofs of houses, as happened at Alexandria, and others were hurled nearly two miles from the shore, like the Laconian vessel near the town of Methone which I saw when I passed by, yawning apart from long decay.

This stunning description provides a dramatic climax to Book 26. As evidence for one of the most violent seismic events of classical antiquity, it has been the object of a great deal of scholarly attention.[165] Far less discussed have been its qualities as a thrilling and bravura purple passage, and as a specimen of Ammianus' autopsy.[166] I have aimed to compensate for the neglect of these qualities in an article entitled 'Ammianus and the Great Tsunami', which appeared in the *Journal of Roman Studies* in 2004. Much, though by no means all, of my argument there can be found in summary form here, and if I have not always avoided the twin faults of tedious repetition and of taking my previous arguments for granted, I hope that I will be forgiven. My aim in the present discussion is to concentrate on autopsy.

Many readers, however, have treated this passage simply as a piece of historical evidence, and understandably so. The tsunami was a traumatic event, unavoidably known to millions across the eastern Mediterranean. We need not reach any conclusion here on the debated question of how great and how widespread death and destruction were.[167] It may in one sense have been a more

[165] See especially Jacques and Bousquet (1984), Lepelley (1984) and (1990–1), Henry (1985), Guidoboni *et al.* (1989) and (1994), Mazza (1990–1), Baudy (1992), Waldherr (1997), Kelletat (1998), Stiros (2001), Price *et al.* (2002). For surveys and further bibliography see Guidoboni *et al.* (1994), 267–74, Price *et al.* (2002) and Kelly (2004), 143–5.

[166] Sabbah (1978), 555–8, and Kelly (2004).

[167] Sometimes it seems that archaeologists wish to link virtually any Mediterranean earthquake damage from the fourth century to a cosmic catastrophe on 21 July 365: see e.g. Rebuffat (1980), Di Vita (1980), Soren (1985). Di Vita (1990) offers the best defence of this tendency. More recently, it has been identified with the tectonic uplift of western Crete known to have occurred in late antiquity (sometimes called the 'Early Byzantine

disturbing event for contemporaries than powerful tsunami experienced in modern times, such as those of 22 May 1960 in the Pacific or 26 December 2004 in the Indian Ocean: it was more inexplicable. And in a situation in which the Mediterranean was politically unified but without modern communications, people must have learnt gradually that what had been inflicted on their community had also befallen others at unimaginable distances, that Egypt and Sicily had been struck by the same blow. A local disaster became a global sign of divine anger. It soon mingled in the memory with the other grave earthquakes of the 350s and 360s, and merged in the imagination with the political and religious vicissitudes of the period. As early as Jerome's *Chronicle* (381) it had become an earthquake 'throughout the whole world'. Eighty years on, the people of Alexandria commemorated the birthday of the earthquake with a solemn procession.[168] Dozens of ancient sources describe it;[169] and one may suspect other points at which it affected the literary imagination of the age.[170] Ammianus' is the most detailed

Tectonic Paroxysm'), which in some places raised the shoreline by up to nine metres (see e.g. Pirazzoli *et al.* (1992). However, a recent reassessment of the radio-carbon data from locations across western Crete shows that this probably occurred at a later date (Price *et al.*, 2002).

[168] Sozomen 6.3. See Croke (1978) for celebration of the anniversary of a fifth-century earthquake, in Constantinople.

[169] The earthquake, the tsunami, or both are explicitly mentioned in *Consularia Constantinopolitana* (= *Descriptio Consulum*) s.a. 365, Jerome, *Chronicle* s.a. 366, *Life of Hilarion* 40 and *Commentary on Isaiah* 15.5, *Consularia Italica* 476, the *Index of Festal Letters of Athanasius* 37, John Cassian, *Conferences* 11.3, Socrates 4.3-4, Sozomen 6.3, Bishop Constantine of Siout's *Encomium of Athanasius* 1.22–5, 27 (see Orlandi (1974)), an anonymous life of Athanasius (*PG* 25.210), Theophanes AM 5859, George the Monk 560–1 (462M). See Kelly (2004), 145: there as here I omitted certain *fontes descripti* such as Orosius. I missed Photius, *Vita Athanasii* 14 (*PG* 25.222) and Simeon Metaphrastes, *Vita Athanasii* 17 (*PG* 25.245), which are both very close to the anonymous *Vita*; John of Nikiu *Chron.* 82.21; Jacob of Edessa *Chron.* 296 (a. 365) (references from Lenski (2002b), 387 n. 9); I incorrectly omitted Michael Syrus 7.7 because I believed his account to be derived from Theophanes. His relevance is demonstrated by Bleckmann (2007) and illustrated in the Appendix below. A stemma illustrating the majority of these sources can be found in Jacques and Bousquet (1984), 461.

[170] Themistius uses a tidal wave as a metaphor for the usurpation of Procopius in a speech delivered in the winter of 366–7 (*Or.* 7.86b), and may also refer to the damage it caused in *Or.* 11.150cd, from AD 373. The *Historia Augusta* has a tsunami as a feature of an earthquake of vast expanse in the reign of Gallienus (*Gallieni Duo* 5). This could well be an anachronistic fiction (François Paschoud has pointed out to me that the earthquake follows a consular date almost certainly obtained from Dexippus; but the tsunami in particular has the air of the late fourth-century author's hyperbolic expansion of his source in proportion to Gallienus' wickedness). Finally, Claudian's early

of the early accounts, and the most useful to those attempting to reconstruct the events of the earthquake. He supplies some information which is not found elsewhere: the time of day when the earthquake struck, the ship tossed inland at Methone. To those historical geographers who read it, it must be owned that the passage is tinged, to some tastes tragically marred, by rhetoric. As Gibbon noted with disdain, and I note with pleasure, 'such is the bad taste of Ammianus that it is not easy to distinguish his facts from his metaphors'.[171]

Correspondingly, the fact that scholars have neglected autopsy in the passage is unsurprising. The author's appearance is only momentary (*conspeximus* suggesting a distant and fleeting glimpse), and only minimal biographical information can be extracted. At some point after 21 July 365 Ammianus had visited Methone, on the southern Peloponnese, and seen a shipwreck two miles inland (26.10.19). We cannot date the visit with any certainty, as he saw the results of the tsunami rather than the event itself.[172] This sort of autopsy, covering an object in a place rather than an event, might be thought more typical of digressions than the narrative proper.[173] The likeliest means for him to have passed by (*transeundo*) this part of the Greek mainland was, as John Matthews suggests, by sea, perhaps on the way to Italy and Rome.[174] But biographical speculation can be taken no further.

Nonetheless, Ammianus' description of the tsunami is worth taking seriously as autopsy. Even if his personal appearance is limited to a few words at the end, many of the traits identifiable in other cases can be found here. Although the historian does not on this occasion present himself as personally endangered, his appearance is nevertheless made to coincide with a description of the

Gigantomachia, written in Greek in Alexandria perhaps twenty-five years after the tsunami, describes thirsty giants drinking the sea and revealing the seabed (25–34): could this not have been suggested by memories of that other elemental struggle on 21 July 365?

171 Gibbon (1776–88 [ed. D. Womersley, 1995]), Ch. 26, 1.1023 n. 1.

172 Thompson (1947), 13, has him visiting Greece 'not long after' the tsunami, a misreading. Mercifully nobody has yet speculated how long it might take a wooden ship which had been cast inland to start 'yawning apart from long decay'.

173 At various points in digressions he describes what he claims in Herodotean style to have seen on his travels, e.g. 14.4.6, 17.4.6, 22.8.1, 23.6.36.

174 Matthews (1989), 17, and Henry (1985), 39. Methone was on the sea route from Asia Minor to the West (Henry (1985), 43 n. 22, cites Procopius, *Wars* 5.7.28, 32).

peril and violent deaths of others. Ammianus launches the narrative with a declaration of the unprecedented nature of the tsunami (similar terrors had been recorded in 'neither legends [*fabulae*] nor truthful ancient histories', 26.10.15); he openly refers to the revelation of wonders (*inuoluta facies mundi miraculorum species ostendebat*, 26.10.17), among which are the ship which he saw two miles inland. As we saw above with the astounding view from the cliff-top in Corduene, the sights confirmed by autopsy are often marvellous, and their marvellous nature is often associated with literary precedents. For the tsunami, precedent in either history or *fabula* is lacking and the event is unique, with the underwater mountains and valleys looking on the sun's rays for the first time: in these circumstances, it may be argued, confirmation from autopsy becomes even more important. Not only the contents, but also the manner of the description can be thought self-consciously marvellous. Rather as Ammianus describes the Persian army in closer detail than could possibly be seen from the cliff-top, the succession of fleeting images of the tsunami move beyond what one person – or any persons – could possibly see (at least, without being killed): swimming creatures stuck in the slime, great underwater mountains and valleys, individuals picking up fish from the seabed, the return of the waters, shipwrecks, dead bodies, boats on the roofs of houses or two miles inland. He does not, of course, claim autopsy until the end, but I would suggest that Ammianus was encouraged by the tradition that autopsy is used to confirm wonders, and tests his autopsy's potency with a sensational and wonder-filled description. And if the implication of the miraculous and distant view of the Persian army is that the historian has a longer view than other eyewitnesses, his kaleidoscopic view of the events of the tsunami approaches omniscience.

One clear point of contrast with those passages in the earlier books where autopsy emphasises the historian's solitariness, and by implication his unique expertise, is that he was neither the only witness of the tsunami, nor one of very few. With a great abundance of potential sources, oral or written, it is clear that, if Ammianus uses his autopsy implicitly to suggest his authority in this passage, he does not do so on the grounds of his unique experience. One of the functions of the autopsy here, I think, is to suggest that

Ammianus is a superior, as opposed to a sole, witness. That should mean that his text interacts with other accounts of the tsunami which already existed. This happened, as I have argued elsewhere, in two main ways.[175]

First of all, though precise allusions to other extant authors cannot be identified, Ammianus can be seen participating in a discourse shared by most of the other early sources to mention the tsunami. By juxtaposition and by association, most writers present the tsunami as somewhere between a providential response to and a metaphor for two contemporary events: the reign of the apostate Julian, which had ended a couple of years before (so Jerome, Sozomen), and the usurpation of Procopius, which began only two months later (Themistius, the *Descriptio consulum*, Socrates). Ammianus appears to allude to both these perspectives – the parallel to Procopius being suggested by the juxtaposition in the first sentence, and that to Julian in rather more complex ways which I shall outline later. Secondly, Ammianus has used and transformed a source which is no longer extant but whose existence can be posited by looking at the shared features of two ninth-century authors' descriptions, Theophanes and George the Monk, and is reinforced by comparison to the twelfth-century Syriac chronicler, Michael the Syrian.[176] This lost source began by describing the effects of the tsunami at Alexandria, where many of those fleeing because of the earthquake saw the harbour drained of water and, whether because they tried to plunder the ships which were now grounded, or because they were simply transfixed in wonder, were drowned when the sea returned; at the same time ships were tossed on to the roofs of houses. A second episode described the adventure of sailors in the Adriatic who experienced the disappearance of the sea and their boat coming to rest on the seabed, before they were refloated by the returning waters.[177] The identification of this source was not a concern of my article: indeed I was willing to conceive as an outside possibility that the source might have been oral, though the verbal parallels between Ammianus and the Byzantine authors make that unlikely (Bruno Bleckmann has since argued that

[175] Kelly (2004), 148–55, 163–6. [176] Kelly (2004), 148–55, Bleckmann (2007).
[177] For texts, translations and more detailed discussion of these two sources see the Appendix; see also Ch. 5, Section II.

this is the so-called 'Arian Historiographer' and suggested the intermediaries through which it was read by the Byzantine authors).[178]

The two stories of his source, the Alexandrian and the Adriatic narratives, are transformed by Ammianus. The two incidents are blended together, so that, for example, 26.10.17 shows versions both of the ship landing on the seabed in the Adriatic and the population of Alexandria walking through their drained harbour. Chronology is obviously one of the organisational principles underlying this (whatever hyperbole and fiction Ammianus may be blamed for, he demarcates the separate stages of the earthquake – the sea's reflux, its absence, its return, and its eventual retreat – with perfect clarity and a degree of suspense). But a second and equal organisational principle is generalisation. No geographical precision is offered for the greater part of the passage. The effect is to allow the disaster to seem global. The humans' characters are also transformed. Theophanes' source described crowds in Alexandria running to plunder ships which lay aground in the harbour; Ammianus has people wandering about harvesting fish. This is a self-conscious *adynaton*, matched by the paradox of ships 'perching' on rooftops (it is no chance that the verb *insido* is commonly used of birds).[179] It seems likely, not least from some of the stories attached to this event, that Mediterranean populations had sufficient folk-knowledge of tsunami to know that they should run away inland rather than on to the seabed: Ammianus focuses on the most hapless victims imaginable, those for whom the sea returned 'when it was least expected'.

Another effect of this vagueness about people and places is that the more outlandish claims of his source are cast into doubt. A ship in the middle of the Adriatic being beached on the bottom and then refloated is surely a traveller's tale. Ammianus does not explicitly endorse it: rather he describes how 'the abyss of the depths was uncovered and many-shaped varieties of sea-creatures

[178] Kelly (2004), 149; Bleckmann (2007). The relevant passages of Theophanes and Michael Syrus were included by Bidez (1913), 239, in his list of fragments of this *anonymus* (fr. 43). He did not adduce Ammianus or George. The argument that Ammianus may have been influenced by this writer elsewhere can be found in Brennecke (1997). However, Burgess (1999) has used the same evidence to argue for a source terminating in 350.

[179] See *OLD*, s.v. *insido*, 1b.

were seen stuck in the slime; the great wastes of those mountains and valleys . . . at that moment, *as was given to be believed*, looked up at the sun's rays'. An apparently unnecessary and curiously unspecific verb of seeing (*cernerentur*) is followed by an equivocal phrase which appears to distance the events described from the narrator (*ut opinari dabatur*).[180]

The climax of the narrative provides two specific place names. Most of the texts which describe the tsunami mention its impact at Alexandria, and I have suggested that much of the earlier part of Ammianus' description is in fact events at Alexandria disguised; its effects at Methone were probably first described by Ammianus, the claim of autopsy suggesting that this is his own contribution to the tradition. The rhetoric of the passage is one of increasing clarity. The reader passes from the general to the particular; from chaos to order; from things seen from uncertain perspectives by undetermined viewers (*cernerentur*, 16, and *uisae sunt*, 18, are the only hints at focalisation for the earlier narrative) to something seen from the authoritative perspective of the historian (*conspeximus*); in the last sentence, we pass from ships to a ship to the rottenness of the ship's timbers; from Laconia to Methone to Ammianus himself. The historian makes a display of his own particular ability to provide an authoritative account.

The autopsy at the close of the passage, therefore, can be seen as illustrating the way in which an eyewitness and contemporary can bring clarity to events. But rather more can be made of it than this. This instance of autopsy is made prominent by its position at the end of a book, and there is also particular significance in what Ammianus sees.

There is no need to linger here over the arrangement. The tsunami's place at the end of a book has been carefully manufactured: the events just described, the death of Procopius and the punishment of his supporters, took place in the summer of 366, nearly a year after the tsunami.[181] The personal intervention

[180] I have argued that *ut opinari dabatur* implies 'as was given to believe *by a source*' (Kelly (2004), 152–3 and n. 63). Even though the passive is generally a means to leave the agent out of account (Pinkster (1990), 9–10), both the sense of the word *do* and certain parallels (16.10.11, 30.5.18) support this interpretation.

[181] The chronological distortion is greater than it may seem at first sight. Ammianus' places the tsunami *hoc nouatore adhuc superstite* ('while this usurper yet lived'): not false but

of the historian has been carefully left until the end of the passage – which might suggest that this is a sort of authorial sphragis.[182]

What Ammianus saw was the particular fate of one ship, flung aground and yawning apart from long decay (. . . *ut Laconicam prope Mothonen oppidum nos transeundo conspeximus, diuturna carie fatiscentem*, 26.10.19).[183] I propose that we should see a commonplace of ancient thought and interpret the ship as a metaphor for the state. There is a sound basis for this inference. Not only is the image of the emperor at the helm of the ship of state a common image in contemporary panegyric, it is also a consistent presence in this part of the *Res Gestae*. For example, in the interregnum before Valentinian's appointment at the start of Book 26, Ammianus uses the metaphor of the helmsman of the ship of state (26.1.5): *diebusque decem nullus imperii tenuit gubernacula* ('and for ten days no one held the steering-ropes of the empire'). And when Procopius' revolt is introduced, there is said to have been a false rumour that Julian had named him as his heir on his deathbed (26.6.3): *placere sibi Procopio clauos summae rei gerendae committi* ('that it was his wish that Procopius be entrusted with the helm of the state'). In the main Ammianus restricts this metaphor to a narrow portion of the work: as well as these two examples in Book 26, there are three items of interest in Book 25.[184] Both this concentration and usage imply a link between the effects of the tsunami on the ship and the fall of Julian on the state. In particular, the three metaphors in Book 25, which follow Julian's death, portray him as the ideal helmsman. Firstly, in his obituary the boldness of his invasion of Persia is defended by a comparison to a shipwrecked sailor returning to sea: Julian, by contrast, could not

misleading. Procopius was alive on 21 July 365, but he was not a usurper until 28 September. I shall suggest further reasons for this chronological manipulation below.

[182] Matthews (1989), 192, compares the personal appearance of Ammianus at the end of Book 26 to the signature on a painting.

[183] We should note that this is yet another case where a description of something that the author has himself seen is expressed in allusive terms: the use of *fatisco* for a ship's timbers is an unmistakable allusion to Vergil *Aen.* 1.123, where the Trojan ships 'take in the hostile flood and yawn with cracks' (*accipiunt inimicum imbrem rimisque fatiscunt*). See further Ch. 4, Section IV.6 below.

[184] Note, however, that Constantius also compares himself to a helmsman in his last speech (21.13.10).

be blamed, as he had never known defeat (25.4.27).[185] Secondly, shortly afterwards there follows the risible elevation of Jovian, on which Ammianus remarks (25.5.7):

> If any onlooker of strict justice with undue haste blames such a step taken in a moment of extreme danger, he will with more justice reproach sailors, if after the loss of a pilot skilled at navigation, amid the raging winds and the seas, they have committed the helm which rules their ship to any companion in their peril, whoever he might be.[186]

Thirdly, towards the end of that book, in a meditation prompted by the treaty by which Jovian surrendered Nisibis, Ammianus uses the same familiar metaphor to repeat the contrast between the experienced Julian and his untried successor (25.9.7).

> In this instance you are justly blamed, Fortune of the Roman world: when the gusts were blowing the republic this way and that, you offered up the rudder, which had been shaken away from a leader tried in governing, to an unfinished youth.[187]

Polemical denigration of Jovian's legitimacy is endemic in both the structure and content of the narrative, and in the second of these three cases it is arguably reinforced by an allusion, detectable despite the cliché, to a famous image of democracy in Plato's *Republic* (488a–e), of an untrained and squabbling crew claiming their right to hold the helm.[188] Ammianus plainly viewed not merely Jovian but also Valentinian and Valens as less competent helmsmen than Julian.[189] The concentration of nautical metaphors

[185] *et cum sciamus adeo aduersus experimenta quosdam ruere improuidos, / ut bella interdum uicti et naufragi repetant maria, / et ad difficultates redeant quibus succubuere saepissime, / sunt qui reprehendant / paria repetisse principem ubique uictorem* ('And although we know that some imprudent people rush on despite their experiences, to such an extent that the defeated set out again for war and the shipwrecked for the sea, and return to those difficulties to which they have very often succumbed, there are those who criticise the fact that a prince everywhere victorious set out for more of the same.')

[186] *quodsi grauis quidam aequitatis spectator / in ultimo rerum spiritu factum / criminatur improuide, / nauticos idem iustius incusabit, / si amisso perito nauigandi magistro, / saeuientibus flabris et mari, / clauos regendae nauis cuilibet periculi socio commiserunt.*

[187] *tu hoc loco, Fortuna orbis Romani, / merito incusaris, / quae difflantibus procellis rem publicam, / excussa regimenta perito rei gerendae ductori, / consummando iuueni porrexisti.*

[188] On Ammianus' denigration of Jovian see von Haehling (1977), Heather (1999) and Lenski (2000). For identification and interpretation of the allusion to Plato see Barnes (1998), 141.

[189] For contemporary use of the image of the helmsman see e.g. Claudian *IV Cos.* 59–62 and 419–27.

after the death of Julian, then, suggests a ship in trouble after it has been taken over by inadequate helmsmen.

If my interpretation of this symbolism is accepted, there are interesting corollaries. The combination of the nautical metaphors in Book 25 with the ship thrown violently aground at the end of Book 26 supports the suggestion of Guy Sabbah that Ammianus' portrayal of the tsunami as a battle of the elements stands as a symbol for Julian's reign.[190] In that case, Ammianus engages with the discourse of those other texts which interpret the earthquake and tsunami as being, in some way, a divine response to Julian. Jerome in his *Life of Hilarion* and Sozomen exemplify this tendency. Ammianus of course dissents from the implication of these Christian authors that the tsunami was a sign of divine anger at Julian's reign: he stands closer to Libanius, whose *Funeral Oration* (*Or.* 18.292–3), although written before the tsunami of 365, saw in other earlier earthquakes both divine warnings of Julian's death and the earth's grief at it.[191]

This is not the only metaphorical interpretation to which the tsunami is open. It has also been argued convincingly that it serves as an omen and a metaphor for the disaster which would befall the Roman Empire in the years to come and which would conclude the *Res Gestae*, when the Goths would pour over the frontiers as the sea had passed over its limits. Omens are characteristic of Ammianus' historical narrative, and Adrianople, like the death of Julian, is long-portended.[192] (Indeed one credible explanation for why Ammianus moved the tsunami to the end of the book is that he wished to avoid placing it before Procopius' usurpation and therefore making it portend only a minor civil war, rather than the great calamity of that age.)[193] The next book's opening in Alamanni 'leaping over the borders' is significant (27.1.1), as are metaphors of flooding used for the Goths in Book 31.[194]

[190] Sabbah (1978), 556. He describes Julian as 'fidèle au dieu solaire', presumably implying a (somewhat fanciful) connection to the description of the sun's rays touching the seabed.

[191] Which earthquakes are referred to is a central issue in dating the *Funeral Oration*. See Jacques and Bousquet (1984), 428–37, Henry (1985), Guidoboni *et al.* (1994), 259–67. Felgentreu (2004) attempts to restore old arguments for a later date, and reference to the earthquake of 21 July 365.

[192] Lepelley (1990–1). [193] Lepelley (1990–1), 364–5; Kelly (2004), 161, 163.

[194] Kelly (2004), 162–3, esp. n. 107.

There is no contradiction between the tsunami signifying both the calamity that befell the state with the death of Julian and that which was to come at Adrianople. Indeed the same combination of metaphors which I argue is implicit in Ammianus, of helmsman and inundation representing respectively political leadership and the barbarian threat, can be paralleled in contemporary panegyrics by Themistius and Claudian. Themistius uses a metaphor of helmsmen in a storm to describe Gratian and Theodosius' responses to the Gothic threat in the early 380s (*Or.* 15.194d–195d). They had taken over the helm 'when a tidal wave [had] mounted from every quarter, the sea boiling this way and that, and the ship's sides already labouring' (195a).[195] Times of calm might permit lower ranks to steer, but the situation called for the utmost skill (195b). And indeed some of the seas had already been stilled (194d). Years later, in 398, Claudian saw Theodosius as having saved the ship of state against the barbarian threat and having prevented universal shipwreck (*IV Cos.* 59–62).[196] Claudian's use of this imagery two decades on suggests that it may have been widely used. Whether or not Ammianus was aware of Themistius' speech, he would certainly have been familiar with this assessment of Theodosius' success.[197] However, if he alludes to it, he appears, by making Julian the good helmsman, to dissent. Ammianus' logic is simple: Julian's heirs (Jovian, Valentinian, Valens . . . and Theodosius) were not his equals;[198] Adrianople and all that followed was a crisis of leadership, something which would not have happened under Julian.

I argued in my essay of 2004 that the tsunami was a *mise en abyme*, a microcosm representing the shape and central argument of the *Res Gestae*. Both the tsunami narrative and the history as a whole have globalising tendencies, claiming to cover the whole

[195] τρικυμίας ἀπανταχόθεν ἐπηγερμένης καὶ ζεούσης τῆς θαλάσσης ἔνθεν καὶ ἔνθεν καὶ τῶν τοίχων ἤδη πεπονηκότων (tr. Heather and Moncur).

[196] *nulla relicta foret Romani nominis umbra / ni pater ille tuus iamiam ruitura subisset / pondera turbatamque ratem certaque leuasset / naufragium commune manu.* ('No shadow of Rome's name would have been left had not that father of yours held up the already tottering weights and the buffeted barque and with sure hand prevented mass shipwreck.') For another ship of state metaphor see *In Ruf.* 1.275–7.

[197] On Ammianus' knowledge of Themistius see Sabbah (1978), esp. 348–66, Rosen (1992), 86, Heather and Moncur (2001), 150–2, 201.

[198] Valentinian and Valens were *nec similes eius nec suppares*, 'neither like him not in his league' (26.10.8).

oecumenē. Both focus massively on a narrow period of time – the history on the reign of Julian, the tsunami narrative on the short interval between the sea's disappearance and the return of the waves. The tsunami ends with a suggestive flood and a shipwreck, and the work closes with a leaderless empire and the barbarians flooding in. *Mise en abyme* is a difficult and subjective critical claim, which will satisfy me and some other readers, but leave some cold. I do not intend to develop or insist on that argument here. But I would restate my claim that the ship he sees is a metaphor for the battered and divided Roman commonwealth. Ammianus' autopsy clearly again identifies the history of his times with himself. He has seen the wreck of the state with his own eyes.

To conclude: I would make two claims for the importance of autopsy here. Firstly, that in this passage, as I have argued, Ammianus corrects other accounts of the tsunami – both factual narratives and providential explanations. This engagement and correction would have been visible to contemporaries, and, in rhetorical terms, the autopsy at the end marks the change from the chaos of other sources to the order imposed by Ammianus. Secondly, that I have not been digressing in focussing on the symbolism of this passage: the object seen by Ammianus the eyewitness is symbolic of the events seen and described by the historian, of the subject matter of the whole history.

On 26 December 2004, a vast tsunami struck the Indian Ocean and killed over 200,000 people. A former colleague of mine at Peterhouse, Andrew Lever, was in Sri Lanka at the time, and observed from the first floor of his hotel how 'local fishermen ran down on to the exposed sea bed and started catching the large crabs which usually they can never catch'[199] (Ammianus: 'people wandered at will about the paltry remains of the waters to collect fish and the like in their hands'). Newspapers published photographs of individuals standing on the exposed seabed and staring fixedly at the approaching waves while others fled (Ammianus: 'the mass of waters returning when least expected . . .'). The horror of the event was heightened, for readers of Ammianus, by its curious familiarity.[200]

[199] Lever (2005), 155.

[200] My article on the tsunami (Kelly (2004)) had been published about a month before.

It might be tempting to look again at Ammianus' narrative and with him claim that 'this new proof confirmed the trustworthiness of antiquity' (*fides . . . uetustatis recenti documento firmata est*, 31.4.8). It would be more accurate to say that his power of observation, his acute sense for the freakish or telling snapshot, was confirmed.[201] When we call a narrative well-observed, we do not, despite the literal meaning of 'observe', remark on whether it is a transcription of the narrator's personal experience or indeed literally true, although it may be so; rather we are identifying a satisfying, possibly unexpected, plausibility. Ammianus is noted for descriptions of what could be called heightened reality – what is often called 'baroque' or 'fantastic'. When he describes individuals picking up fish from the seabed, it typifies this fondness for portraying extraordinary and paradoxical events. It is hard to say whether he describes something that actually happened, whether fondness for the extraordinary has led him to record or to invent this image – though it is worth remembering that in some points (like the underwater valleys and mountains exposed to the sun's rays) he is unquestionably inventing. It is a far more objective judgement to say that he is aiming at a particular literary effect: the *adynaton* which actually happened. As with the tsunami, so in the rest of the *Res Gestae*: it is too easy to forget the splendour of the historian's imagination and become overly concerned with judgements about his veracity, or about his 'representation of reality', when we do not have the information with which to arbitrate.

VI Conclusion

In discussing the first-person narrative of the *Res Gestae* in this chapter I have tried to move away from the concerns of previous scholarship about whether autobiographical detail is true or not. That is not to deny either that fascinating and valuable biographical information may be inferred, or on the other hand that there are cases where personal bias, narrative strategies or patterns of

[201] He and no other ancient source mentions the 'paltry remains of the waters' (*exiguas undarum reliquias*), the pools and puddles which must have been left by the vanishing sea.

allusion to earlier literature throw grave doubt on the passage's truthfulness – and firm conclusions either way are sometimes possible (Section II). It might have been easier to adopt a position of thorough-going scepticism like that of Paschoud. But I would rather stress the literary function of the autopsy.

We should begin with by noting the selectiveness of autopsy (Section I), the light and shade in the portrayal of the eyewitness-narrator, and how much he does not let his readers know. As the next chapter will emphasise, we are ignorant of his birthplace, parentage, family life, social status, and, except in the years between 353 and 359, his military rank. And even in that period, autopsy has not been offered at every point where self-revelation was possible. The selectiveness of autopsy helps it to form an essential part of his claims for the authority of the work. By relating his experiences in absorbing detail (including some which do not reflect well on himself, such as the deception of Silvanus or his escape from Amida), Ammianus leaves it open to readers to think they are getting a detailed and honest account; by showing himself in solitude and peril, amidst the deaths of others, he can give the impression of being a unique witness or a sole survivor. And (I have suggested) other interventions serve to emphasise his greater authority in comparison to other sources. Whether dealing in central historical events or apparently minor details, autopsy provides a reason why his version of his own times should become canonical (Sections III–IV).

It is not unprecedented for historians to use autopsy to make an open boast or a covert assertion of their quality and qualifications as historians. Such an approach can be found as far back as Herodotus and Thucydides. Ammianus' allusions make it clear that he wrote in full consciousness of the traditions of classical historiography, as when he compares and contrasts his sighting of the Persian army entering the Roman Empire with Herodotus' lack of autopsy of Xerxes' invasion (Section IV). Many cases of detailed memoir can be found in other late-antique historians, giving a '*sphragis* of authenticity' to their contemporary narrative.[202] But in the context both of classical historiography as a whole and

[202] Austin (1983), 64 (see n. 119 above).

of its late-antique development, Ammianus' autopsy seems highly unusual. He stands out both for the intense detail of some passages in which he appears as a character, for the consistency with which autopsy is in a virtually metaphorical way interpretable as a claim of authority, and for the frequent coincidence of autopsy with striking allusions to the classical past. How distinctly individual this technique was is impossible to say, as so many ancient literary histories have perished.

The quasi-metaphorical autopsy of the tsunami narrative (the eyewitness sees a shipwreck, the historian has seen the calamity of the state) suggests that autopsy is not only momentarily valuable but justifies the historian's view of the whole age (Section v). Another passage also suggests that what he had seen on individual occasions gave authority to the whole work. In his conclusion Ammianus claimed to have written *ut miles quondam et Graecus*, 'as a soldier once and a Greek' (31.16.9). The phrase is pregnant and multivalent, allusive to rather than identical with the simple and precise description of origins and status which one might expect to find in earlier historians. Whatever else *Graecus* may suggest (opposition both to barbarism and to Christianity has been mooted), to Ammianus it certainly meant careful scholarship.[203] He had called the historian of Gaul Timagenes 'a Greek in language and diligence' (15.9.2), and here was arguably asserting the qualities as a researcher which enabled him to offer both encyclopaedic digressions and a history of the Roman Empire for well over 200 years before his own time. In claiming to write as a former soldier, he alludes to the qualities of the man of action, which traditionally made historians suitable to tell the history of their own age, and draws his readers' memory back to the military experiences of his youth. Having been a soldier was a qualification for Ammianus to write history. But it is telling that soldiery is paired with learning, or, to put it another way, that autopsy is inseparable from allusion.

[203] Stoian (1967), supported by Barnes (1998), 80, and opposed by Rosen (1982), 44–5, and Matthews (1989), 551 n. 23. Further discussion of this passage in Guzmán-Armario (2003a), Paschoud (2004) and Kelly (2007).

CHAPTER 3

THE LIMITS OF BIOGRAPHY

The career, connections and opinions of Ammianus Marcellinus have long been extrapolated from his history and from a few supposed external references. Scholarship over successive generations has shown both continuity and stark contrasts. E. A. Thompson's book of 1947, in many other ways revisionist, conveniently summarises centuries of scholarship on Ammianus' biography, beginning from Claude Chifflet and Henri de Valois in the early seventeenth century, through Gimazane and Seeck in the late nineteenth, up to Enßlin in the early twentieth.[1] The scholarly consensus when Thompson wrote may be summarised as follows:

Ammianus Marcellinus was born into a Greek-speaking pagan family of high standing in Antioch in about 330. Numerous factors suggest that he was a member of the city's curial class, that 'oppressed and oppressive' bourgeoisie of hereditary city councillors. He supported the profiteering Antiochene Senate against Gallus and Julian's attempts to avert food crises; he complained of Julian's legislation on the councils; he was intimate with their champion, Libanius, and often expanded on their troubles in disproportionate detail.[2] He entered the army as *protector domesticus* at a young age, and became very attached to his commanding officer from 353/4–60, Ursicinus. After leaving the army in 363 he may have practised at the bar, and this period probably saw him visit Egypt and Greece, though he was back in Antioch during the treason trials of 371/2.[3] Having moved to Rome, he was disappointed in the senatorial nobility, who refused to treat him with due respect; indeed, in 383 he and other foreigners were expelled during a famine.[4] If the prefect at the time was Anicius Auchenius Bassus, it would explain his contempt for members of the Anician family.[5] The mutual respect that subsisted between Ammianus and some senators (in particular Q. Aurelius Symmachus,

[1] The works of Chifflet and Valesius can most easily be found in the edition of Wagner and Erfurdt (1808), lxxiii–cxxv; Gimazane (1889), Seeck (1894), Enßlin (1923).

[2] 14.7.5–6, 22.14.2 (support of Antiochene Council); 21.12.23, 25.4.21 (disagreement with Julian's legislation); Libanius *Ep.* 1063; 19.9.3–8, 25.9.3, 28.6.4, 10, 18, 29.2.27 (woes of decurions).

[3] 30.4.4 (inference of bar practice); 17.4.6, 22.15.1 (Egypt); 26.10.19 (Greece); 29.1.24, 29.2.4 (Antioch).

[4] 14.6.19. [5] *PLRE* I, s.v. Bassus 11; 16.8.13, 27.11.

who sent him a letter (*Ep.* 9.110), but also Vettius Agorius Praetextatus, Flavius Eupraxius, Sextus Aurelius Victor, Flavius Hypatius)[6] does not suggest intimate friendship. Nevertheless, the success of his recitations spread his fame far and wide, and led Libanius to write to him from Antioch in late 392.

In the sixty years since the publication of Thompson's book, about the only details of this picture which have not been questioned are those simplest ones of dates extrapolated from Ammianus' own appearances in the *Res Gestae* – his approximate date of birth, his known service in the army between the early 350s and 363, his presence in Antioch in the 370s and Rome in the 380s. Alan Cameron's boldly revisionist article of 1964 can be seen as a starting point: he argued that there was little evidence to link Ammianus with Symmachus, and indeed that his temporary expulsion from the city should be dated to Symmachus' Prefecture of Rome in 384.[7] For Momigliano and Sabbah, meanwhile, the expulsion is unlikely to have affected a man of elevated status like Ammianus.[8] John Matthews' magnum opus of 1989 tempers with a tone of judicious circumspection a fundamentally positivist attitude towards biographical extrapolations (for example, his reconstruction of Ammianus' travels after his departure from the army).[9] Importantly he argued that Ammianus' precocious entry to the *protectores domestici* makes it likely on prosopographical grounds that his family's military distinction went back at least one generation. Antioch, an imperial capital for much of the fourth century, had a large resident administrative and military class: a context which makes Ammianus' fluency in Latin less surprising. His sympathies for curials do not preclude his insistence that those who had risen out of the class should not be forced back.[10]

Ammianus was soon wrenched even further from the curia of Antioch by the argument of Charles Fornara that the letter written

[6] *PLRE* 1, s.v. Symmachus 4; Praetextatus 1; Eupraxius; Victor 13, Hypatius 4.

[7] Cameron (1964a); his arguments are almost universally accepted.

[8] See n. 121 below.

[9] According to Matthews (1989), 16–17, his travels after leaving the army seem likely to have taken him to Constantinople and Thrace in the early 380s and thence (perhaps via Greece) to Rome, as a necessary preliminary to writing his history. The visit to Constantinople is inferred from 27.5.10 (dubiously, but see n. 171 below), that to Thrace from 31.7.16 (also dubiously: see Ch. 1, Section I above), that to Greece from 26.10.19 (see Ch. 2, Section V above).

[10] Scepticism about Ammianus' curial status can earlier be found in Momigliano (1974), 1401, quoted below n. 78.

by the Antiochene sophist Libanius to one Marcellinus (*Ep.* 1063) was addressed not to the historian but to a young sophist: Ammianus' origins were therefore open, and places as diverse as Alexandria or Thessalonica could be suggested, though Timothy Barnes argued that his apparent knowledge of Syriac implies an origin in Syria or Palestine.[11] Barnes' book of 1998 combines radical new interpretations with inherited and revived views: he is, for example, sympathetic to the old suggestions that Ammianus was the son of Marcellinus, *comes orientis* in 349, and that his references to Hypatius, the consul of 359 who was summoned from Antioch to be Prefect of Rome in 378, suggest that he may have moved to Rome in his entourage.[12] But Barnes also argues against the traditional view that he was a religious moderate. Rather, the historian shows constant hostility to Christianity, yet also conceals a detailed knowledge of Christian technical language: he may well have been one of those Christians who apostasised under Julian, in which case his career suffered under the Christian régimes that followed.[13]

Between all the contradictory opinions about Ammianus' career, friends, sources, and religious opinions, there is also a unanimity of approach. It is believed that by a careful reading and sifting of the history, which both calls on the explicitly autobiographical passages and identifies personal reference elsewhere, we can move to a closer understanding of the historian as an individual, which in turn illuminates the study of his oeuvre. To claim, as Barnes does, that 'his presentation of events depends on antecedent prejudices that almost always have a personal basis' might be too bold for some tastes, but Ammianus' personal status and experiences are generally seen as both knowable and central to interpretation.[14]

A biographical approach, then, has been very popular, even if argument has raged about the *minutiae*. The desire to infer

[11] Reassessment of Libanius' letter first published in Fornara (1992a): he proposes Thessalonica as Ammianus' birthplace; Bowersock (1990), who had read Fornara's manuscript, argued for Alexandria; for further bibliography see below n. 31. On Ammianus' knowledge of Syriac see Matthews (1989), 69–70, Barnes (1998), 60–1, and p. 117 below.

[12] Gimazane (1889), 25–7, Barnes (1998), 57, 122.

[13] Barnes (1998), 63, 79–94. He is not the first writer to see Ammianus as a militant anti-Christian, but he makes the argument with great force and consistency.

[14] Barnes (1998), 197.

biographical detail or personal information from passages which are not explicitly autobiographical is certainly understandable. More than is the case with the other three great Roman historians, Ammianus' work as it survives is the history of his own times, and both the extent of the autobiographical passages, and their disarming frankness – the way in which they can sometimes present the historian in an unfavourable light – could support the view that self-revelation should be sought elsewhere in the work. As we have seen, the passages of memoir display a strongly partisan attitude in favour of his old commanding officer, Ursicinus;[15] the *Res Gestae* more widely abounds in forceful opinions both about policy and about individuals in its enormous cast-list of 485 contemporaries.[16] The time-period covered in the work is also very well attested. Ammianus was the contemporary, even if he may not have been the correspondent, of Libanius in Antioch and Symmachus in Rome; letters from them to many of his characters are extant.[17] There are strong temptations for the prosopographer.

This chapter is concerned with the grave problems of biographical interpretations. I shall argue that certain information on Ammianus' life is not necessarily available to us and that to rest theories about his work on what we know of his life is to build a house on the sands. My argument is founded on the last chapter's demonstration that his first-person narrative is severely disadvantaged as evidence for his life and opinions. Close detail is very limited in its chronological scope, with exact information about his movements occurring only between AD 354 and AD 363; and even when often reasonable doubts about their veracity are set aside, it is clear that these scenes are carefully calculated to show the historian in a limited set of circumstances, in particular, in scenes of peril and solitude. Ammianus, then, is both reticent and literary. And although the robustness and vigour of his opinions about individuals may seem to reveal personal experience, such harsh condemnation or praise of characters is also a strategy characteristic of historiography.

[15] On Ursicinus see Ch. 2, Section II.1. [16] The number is that of Frakes (2000a).
[17] On Libanius' correspondents in Ammianus' work see Sabbah (1978), 249–53. The two authors often diverge sharply in their attitudes to individuals.

After all, a crucial aim of the genre is to show 'what you may imitate, what avoid'.[18]

It will emerge that the external evidence for Ammianus' life is simply not good enough to rely on (Section I), that some reconstructions of his career are based on repeatedly taking as fact one of many possible solutions, and tend to disregard the evidence of his rank as a *protector domesticus* (Section II), and that others are pure surmise (Section III). And although some probable conclusions can be drawn, the search behind his virulent and admiring remarks about individuals for a social milieu, an audience, patrons and oral sources, in an age marked by social fluidity and physical mobility, is perilous in itself, and particularly so when the historian is eager to show his independence. Mention of individuals in a historical work does not usually provide conclusive evidence that the historian knew and spoke to them – which is not to deny that particular linguistic usages, or reference to individuals' successes in the period after the history's conclusion, may suggest it. Prosopography is better directed at identifying the *sort* of people whom the historian knew and consulted (Section IV). There is a long tradition, from Thompson making Ammianus a bourgeois to Barnes making him a bigot, of scholars extrapolating anecdotes from particular incidents to support particular broad theories. Inferences drawn more widely from the text, and a concern with general probabilities rather than specific possibilities, can provide a picture of greater nuance and objectivity (Section V).

My overall conclusion is, in historical terms, largely negative: though some genuine strides have been made in the scholarship of the last century, many of the biographical assumptions which have been made about Ammianus turn out to be unreliable, or (more precisely) conjectural.[19] But as with the openly autobiographical passages discussed in the previous chapter, it is rewarding to shift from perceiving naïve self-revelation to seeing a carefully crafted literary persona.

[18] Livy *praef.* 10.

[19] However, my discussion of Ammianus' social status and career (Section II) will owe much to the deep understanding of late Roman society exhibited in their biographical chapters by Matthews (1989) and Barnes (1998). And despite any criticisms I may make of the nuances (Section V), Barnes' interpretation of Ammianus' religious views is a compelling one.

I Ammianus in Rome and Antioch: external and internal evidence

Ammianus wrote in Rome. This inference from his work is impossible to deny. He conceives of Rome as 'here', he explains the eccentricities of Rome to such outsiders as should happen to read his work, he worries that his audience should object to his portrayal of their own woes in the magic and treason trials of the 370s.[20] Ammianus also wrote, in a sense, *for* Rome. He returns to Rome for the least relevant City Prefectures, he digresses on features of Roman topography, his finest set pieces are centred on Rome.[21] His presence in the city can be relatively securely dated to the late 380s, but indications abound that his residence was more than a brief visit, and probably began rather earlier. There are five references to specifically Roman events and office-holders in the period after the formal terminus of the *Res Gestae* in 378.[22] In general, the apparent breadth of both written and oral sources suggests that his residence in Rome was crucial to the composition, as well as the publication, of the *Res Gestae*.[23]

The time of writing is both well documented and glamorous. Jerome and Augustine flitted through the city in the 380s; in 395 the most talented Latin poet since Ovid arrived from Alexandria to begin his brief career.[24] In the late fourth century the city had seen a powerful artistic renaissance. The reformulation of the old doctrine of *Roma aeterna* in the period may have betokened a modest political revival, but it was also a necessary response to the ongoing creation of a New Rome on the Bosporus.[25] The trauma of the city's sack by Alaric did not destroy this idea: it preserved it as an object of faith. Romans of the 380s did not know that they were

[20] 22.15.24, 14.6.2, 28.1.3–4.

[21] E.g. 17.11.5 (prefecture); 15.7.3, 17.4 (topography); 14.6, 16.10, 28.4 (set pieces).

[22] The expulsion of foreigners in 383 or 384 (14.6.19); Aurelius Victor's Prefecture of the City in *c.* 389 (21.10.6); an unnamed senator who had bribed his way out of condemnation for magic in 363–4 and paraded ostentatiously in the streets 'to this day' (26.3.5); Rusticus' prefecture, in 387–8, during the tyranny of Magnus Maximus (27.6.1); Hypatius' prefecture of 379 (29.2.16). It is unclear whether Syagrius, referred to at 28.2.5, held the Praetorian or the Urban Prefecture.

[23] See Section IV below.

[24] I discount Christiansen's (1997) attempt to argue that Claudian was of Latin origin.

[25] For the relevance of Constantinople see MacCormack (1981), 39–40, and Kelly (2003).

living at the end of an age, whatever may have been suggested by the increasing persecution of the traditional *cultus deorum*. But it was to seem so when, almost fifty years later, Macrobius chose to write so nostalgically in his *Saturnalia* of the great pagan aristocrats such as Praetextatus, Symmachus and Flavianus.[26]

It was precisely in the context of such famous senators and their circle that Ammianus used to be placed. Symmachus, it was claimed, had written a letter to a historian (*Ep.* 9.110): the missing name of the addressee was easy to supply. Ammianus' happy participation in the Circle of Symmachus, bruited about in the writings of ever more scholars, was brutally terminated by Alan Cameron's article of 1964 entitled 'The Roman Friends of Ammianus'. There was no good reason to think that the letter was addressed to Ammianus (or indeed to a historian), or that he admired Symmachus, a man he never mentioned, about whose father he repeated malicious gossip, and whose father-in-law he judged uncultured, who may even as Prefect of the City have been responsible for his expulsion in a food shortage in 384.[27] The relationships blithely assumed were based on very little, other than the wish to engineer a relationship between famous contemporaries.[28] Cameron indeed later suggested that Macrobius' idealised picture of Symmachus and friends in the *Saturnalia* was a defence against Ammianus' powerful satires on the uncultivated nobility.[29] More generally it has been realised that Ammianus is in no way an unthinking spokesman for the Roman senatorial class, and in any case that the image of a unified senatorial class (or a pagan senatorial 'party') struggling against emperor and court is simplistic and anachronistic.[30]

Antioch, 'the beautiful summit of the East' (22.9.14), has generally been assessed as equal in importance to Rome in the genesis

[26] I follow Cameron's (1966) dating of Macrobius.

[27] 27.3.4 (elder Symmachus), 14.6.1 (Orfitus); the dating of the expulsion to Symmachus' prefecture is not certain: see below n. 115.

[28] Others had come separately to have doubts about the Circle of Symmachus (e.g. Thompson (1947), 16, Pack (1953), 183 n. 5, 187 n. 22, 189, Kohns (1961), 174), but Cameron (1964a) was the first to publish a sustained critique.

[29] Cameron (1966). On the satirical passages see Section III below.

[30] There were limited objections to Cameron's arguments by Seyfarth (1969) and Selem (1971–2). For a fine piece of recent scholarship weakened by the belief in Ammianus' adherence to a 'senatorial' view, see Vitiello (1999), which I overlooked in Kelly (2003), 603–6.

of the *Res Gestae*. Here too, however, old scholarly certainties have of late been shaken. Whatever Ammianus' relationship to Rome and its nobles (to which I will return in Sections III and IV), his residence, and completion there of the *Res Gestae*, is not in doubt. It once seemed equally secure that he was born and bred a citizen of Antioch. However, thirty years after Cameron had so severely cut down the number of Ammianus' Roman friends, C. W. Fornara eliminated his Antiochene friend Libanius.[31] In late 392, the eighty-year-old Libanius addressed a letter to an Antiochene named Marcellinus who was enjoying literary success in Rome (*Ep.* 1063): Fornara argues that this was not, as is usually supposed, written to the historian but to another Marcellinus.[32] If this case is accepted, the definitive evidence that Ammianus was a citizen of Antioch vanishes; Fornara also suggests that more general claims about his social status as a decurion and situation in a Greek cultural milieu seem less clear-cut as a consequence (I will discuss these in Section II below).

The relevant part of the letter (1–4) runs as follows:

Καὶ σὲ ζηλῶ τοῦ Ῥώμην ἔχειν κἀκείνην τοῦ σέ· σὺ μὲν γὰρ ἔχεις ᾧ τῶν ἐν γῇ παραπλήσιον οὐδέν, ἡ δὲ τὸν τῶν ἑαυτῆς πολιτῶν, οἷς πρόγονοι δαίμονες, οὐχ ὕστερον. (2) ἦν μὲν οὖν δή σοι μέγα καὶ τὸ μετὰ σιγῆς ἐν τῇ τοιαύτῃ διάγειν καὶ τὸ λόγους ὑπ' ἄλλων λεγομένους δέχεσθαι – πολλοὺς δὲ ἡ Ῥώμη τρέφει ῥήτορας πάτρασιν ἀκολουθοῦντας – νῦν δ', ὡς ἔστιν ἀκούειν τῶν ἐκείθεν ἀφικνουμένων, αὐτὸς ἡμῖν ἐν ἐπιδείξεσι ταῖς μὲν γέγονας, ταῖς δὲ ἔσῃ τῆς συγγραφῆς εἰς πολλὰ τετμημένης καὶ τοῦ φανέντος ἐπαινεθέντος μέρος ἕτερον εἰσκαλοῦντος. (3) ἀκούω δὲ τὴν Ῥώμην αὐτὴν στεφανοῦν σοι τὸν πόνον καὶ κεῖσθαι ψῆφον αὐτῇ τῶν μέν σε κεκρατηκέναι, τῶν δὲ οὐχ ἡττῆσθαι. ταυτὶ δὲ οὐ τὸν συγγραφέα κοσμεῖ μόνον, ἀλλὰ καὶ ἡμᾶς, ὧν ἐστιν ὁ συγγραφεύς. (4) μὴ δὴ παύσῃ τοιαῦτα συντιθεὶς καὶ κομίζων οἴκοθεν εἰς συλλόγους μηδὲ κάμῃς θαυμαζόμενος, ἀλλ' αὐτός τε γίγνου λαμπρότερος καὶ ἡμῖν τοῦτο δίδου. τοιοῦτον γὰρ πολίτης εὐδοκιμῶν· κοσμεῖ τοῖς αὐτοῦ τὴν πόλιν τὴν ἑαυτοῦ.

I envy you for possessing Rome and Rome for possessing you. For you possess a thing to which there is nothing similar on earth, and Rome one not inferior to her own citizens, who descend from demi-gods. (2) It would, therefore, have been

[31] He argued this in Oxford in 1987 (his arguments are referred to in Matthews (1989), 478–9 n. 1, and Bowersock (1990)) and eventually published it in 1992 (Fornara 1992a). Converts include Bowersock (1990), Barnes (1993a), 57–61, (1998), Ch. 6, Seager (1999b). For opposition see Barceló (1993), Matthews (1994), Rota (1994) and Sabbah (1997).

[32] The identification of Marcellinus with the historian was first made by Henri de Valois in the introduction to his edition of 1636 (= Wagner and Erfurdt (1808), lxxvi–lxxvii).

a great thing for you to live in such a city in silence and to listen to speeches delivered by others: Rome produces many orators who follow in the footsteps of their forefathers. But in fact, as one can learn from those who arrive from there, you yourself (I gather) have given some public recitations and are going to give more, since your work has been divided into many sections and the praise bestowed on what has already appeared invites another instalment. (3) I hear that Rome herself is crowning your labour and has rendered a verdict that you have shown yourself superior to some and not inferior to the rest. This adorns with honour not merely the author, but us too to whom the author belongs. (4) Please do not stop composing such things and taking them from the study to literary salons, and do not weary of being admired, but become still more famous yourself and give us fame. For it is a mark of a truly celebrated citizen to adorn his native city with his achievements.[33]

Libanius then informs his correspondent of the deaths of his illegitimate son Cimon, and of his assistant-teacher Calliopius.

Barnes' translation, which I have used here, renders with 'work' and 'author' the words συγγραφή and συγγραφεύς, which previous translations rendered as 'history' and 'historian'. Surveys of how Libanius and his contemporaries use the words elsewhere show that though they commonly refer to history, the words can equally indicate other prose works, including for instance panegyrics.[34] Once it is accepted that translating these words as 'history' and 'historian' is based on a far from certain presupposition about the addressee, the fact emerges that the rest of the vocabulary ('silence', 'speeches', 'public recitations', 'crowning your labour') suits rhetoric in general better than history specifically. Libanius is interested in a work divided into many parts, of which excerpts have been performed and others may be forthcoming – an odd, though not unimaginable, description of a literary history in thirty-one books. Moreover, the letter is clearly more appropriate for a younger man, who has recently arrived in Rome to complete his studies, than to one who has been there for a number of years; the tone could appear patronising addressed to a man of sixty-odd such as Ammianus.[35] And indeed, Marcellinus being not an

[33] Translation from Barnes (1998), 55.

[34] Matthews (1994), 263–4; Barnes (1998), 57, who points out that Theodoret *HE* 2.30.11 uses συγγραφεύς of the Syrian poet Ephraim.

[35] A point reinforced by Seager (1999b); it is worth noting, however, that though Ammianus was old, Libanius was a generation older (Sabbah (1997), 96).

uncommon name, Glen Bowersock has been able to propose an alternative identification with just such a younger man.[36]

The view that this Marcellinus was indeed the historian can best be saved by assuming that Libanius had no clear idea what his fellow countryman had done. If the haziness of Libanius' prose reflects his lack of contact with and knowledge of Marcellinus' work, a number of problems with identifying Marcellinus as Ammianus the historian evaporate. The way that the details of Libanius' family life are glossed could suggest that the recipient knows him only a little. We need no longer worry that he seems to understand his countryman's success as a rhetorical one. The absence of the name or any suggestion of Julian, the central hero of the *Res Gestae* and a subject dear to Libanius' heart, is no longer suspicious. Nor is there any need to worry at his exhortation that Marcellinus carry on writing at least a year after the best evidence suggests the *Res Gestae* had been completed.[37]

Such an assessment may remove the problems of the letter, but it also removes its advantages. John Matthews claims that the letter raises the difficulty that it must be either central or of no importance whatsoever:

> The one course that is not open to [the student of Ammianus] is a sort of proportionate scepticism, expressing in practice exactly the degree of confidence that he may feel. Either the letter is relevant or it is not; there is no halfway house . . . we should continue to give it pride of place in our understanding of the historian.[38]

A proportionate sceptic, I have a quarrel with this. Even if we do conclude that the letter was addressed to Ammianus, it should

[36] Bowersock (1990), 247–8. There is nothing surprising in more than one Marcellinus having written in Rome at the same time, *pace* Matthews (1994), 267: it is no odder than Julian having appointed Praetorian Prefects named Sallustius and Salutius, than Valentinus having risen as a usurper against Valentinian, or than two men named Flavius Syagrius having been Praetorian Prefects and consuls in successive years under Gratian.

[37] On the dating of the *Res Gestae* see p. 8. Matthews, who supports both a date of *c.* 390 for the *Res Gestae* and Ammianus as recipient of Libanius *Ep.* 1063, suggests that Libanius' request that Ammianus continue producing his work is a playful interaction with the *recusatio* of Ammianus' sphragis (Matthews (1994), 258). One may compare Symmachus *Ep.* 3.47, addressed to Eutropius, which engages playfully with the *Breuiarium*'s closing *recusatio*. Earlier, in his book of 1989 (26), Matthews hinted at the view expressed here, that, assuming Ammianus is his correspondent, Libanius appears ignorant of the detailed compass of his work. The extent of Libanius' knowledge of his correspondent is also questioned by Cameron (1971), 262, and Naudé (1984), 85 n. 7.

[38] Matthews (1994), 269.

hardly be given pride of place: the information gleaned can be mostly be inferred from elsewhere. We would not otherwise know that Ammianus gave public readings, but this is neither surprising nor important, and in any case is perhaps suggested by various features of the work.[39] That he published in instalments might not otherwise have been argued, but, though suggested by the letter, it is not a necessary inference: Matthews himself is able to argue very persuasively against such a view.[40] The great acclaim of the Roman cognoscenti which Libanius mentions was probably a matter whose measurement was rather subjective: but the work's success could perhaps be gauged in any case by its reflexions in Jerome, Claudian and the *HA*.[41] (Conversely Fornara's claim that his reassessment of Ammianus' origins casts his curial status and Greek education into doubt is also wide of the mark: these assumptions could be and have been undermined without debating whether or not he was an Antiochene.)[42] The most important contribution of the letter, if the addressee were the historian, would doubtless be in establishing that he was a citizen of Antioch ('. . . become still more famous yourself and give us fame. For it is a mark of a truly celebrated citizen to adorn his native city with his achievements.').

It is worth setting the letter aside for a moment, and considering what we know otherwise about Ammianus' links to Antioch. There is in fact excellent cumulative evidence that he was a resident of the city, whether or not he was a citizen. The scale of the narrative naturally expands on reaching Antioch, it has been observed; and on several occasions the historian shows knowledge of what appear to be Antiochene oral traditions (23.5.3, 22.12.8).[43] His two

[39] The *Res Gestae* characterises itself both as text and as speech. See e.g. 14.6.2: *et quoniam mirari posse quosdam peregrinos existimo / haec* ***lecturos*** *forsitan, si contigerit, / quamobrem cum* ***oratio*** *ad ea monstranda deflexerit / quae Romae geruntur* . . . ('and since I think it could be amazing to some outsiders, who **will** perhaps **read** this work (should that befall), why, whenever my **speech** turns to demonstrating what's happening at Rome . . .')

[40] Matthews (1989) does not quite rule out publication in instalments (26) but adduces strong arguments against (204–5). Publication in instalments is sometimes inferred from 26.1.1, against which see Fornara (1990).

[41] See e.g. Maenchen-Helfen (1955), Cameron (1970), 333–4, Syme (1968), Chs. X–XIII, Birley (1991).

[42] For doubts about Ammianus' curial status see Section II below; on Latin and Greek in Ammianus see Fornara (1992b).

[43] See Sabbah (1997), 102–4; Rohrbacher (2006a), 121–2.

major first-person narratives, the Persian War of 359 and Julian's expedition of 363, both end with his return to Antioch (19.8.12, 25.10.1).[44] In the former case, the language strongly implies Antiochene residence: *Antiochiam reuisimus* ***insperati***, '**unhoped-for**, we saw Antioch once more'. Only a very forced reading of the narrative of the treason trials of the 370s (29.1–2) could reach the conclusion that Ammianus' personal engagement was not centred at Antioch – even though he rhetorically expands the woeful scenes across the entire East. And at the very end of the work, the last event to be described takes the narrative from the disasters in Thrace across the Taurus mountains, to the *magister militum* Julius' salutary and timely massacre of Gothic recruits in the eastern cities (31.16.8): Julius was based in Antioch. In the immediately following words, Ammianus describes his own status as a former soldier and a Greek (31.16.9), and it is tempting to see this carefully moulded conclusion as a return to the city where the historian had lived and where his military career had been centred.[45]

There are also various indicators suggesting that his residence in the city dates to his youth: he enjoyed the patronage of Ursicinus, who owned a house in Antioch (18.4.3); he was a friend of the Kurdish prince Jovinianus, who had lived in Syria as a hostage and student of the liberal arts, very likely at court in Antioch (18.6.20). But these two connections also direct us to a separate point about Antioch. For much of Ammianus' lifetime, from his childhood on, the city was an imperial capital and a base for the Persian War.[46] The governing class flocked there. John Matthews aptly cites Ursicinus' house at Antioch as 'a sign of his membership of this class – and incidentally, also of the social aspirations of the court eunuch [Eusebius] who was said to covet it (18.4.3)'.[47]

[44] 19.8.12; 25.10.1.

[45] Sabbah (1997), 98–9, cf. *PLRE* 1, s.v. Iulius 2. Zuckerman (1991) has demonstrated that the massacres did not solely take place on the Syrian side of the Taurus range: the testimony of Eunapius and the Cappadocian Fathers combines to show that some at least of these Goths were killed in cities of Pontus and Cappadocia. This makes Ammianus' use of the words *trans Taurum* all the more striking. He appears to underestimate the complexities of the situation to focus solely on the diocese of Oriens. See further Kelly (2007) and p. 27 above.

[46] Constantius is attested as wintering in Antioch in almost every year from 337/8 to 349/50 (Barnes (1993b), 219–20).

[47] Matthews (1989), 79.

Libanius in his *Antiochicos* praises his city for being so attractive to a vast array of talented immigrants (*Or.* 11.164–80): there are a number of individuals in this group who may have been friends and oral sources for Ammianus (see Section IV below).

One distinguished resident of Antioch who certainly seems to have been a friend of Ammianus was Hypatius, who had been consul in 359 with his elder brother Eusebius (this sympathy also affects his account of their sister, Constantius II's empress Eusebia).[48] When Ammianus laments the indignity of treason charges being brought against them under Valens, he breaks out in praise for 'our Hypatius' (29.2.16), who was subsequently to add to the glory of his ancestors with a double prefecture (he was summoned by Gratian in 378/9 to be Prefect of Rome and subsequently of Italy, and it has sometimes been argued that Ammianus travelled to the West as part of his entourage).[49] *Noster Hypatius* might be thought to imply that both men were citizens of Antioch – but in fact Hypatius' family came from Thessalonica.[50] One cannot even be certain that this is a reference to their 'common Antiochene background'.[51] Both had lived in Rome as well as in Antioch; *noster* might conceivably suggest literary patronage on Hypatius' part.[52]

In a city which was so proud to be a 'melting-pot', residence certainly did not imply citizenship. There is a telling example of the difficulty even a resident had in distinguishing between natives and immigrants in Ammianus' reference to the man responsible for Julian's restoration of the temple in Jerusalem. Alypius had been educated in Antioch, resided there and sent his son to study with Libanius, but Ammianus may well have erred when he called him an Antiochene (23.1.2).[53]

It is hard to reach any judgement on whether Ammianus was a citizen of Antioch or not. A man may have more than one home, and in the context of the social and physical mobility enjoyed by the administrative and military elites of the fourth century many

[48] See Tougher (2000). [49] See Section IV below.
[50] See n. 52 below. [51] Matthews (1994), 256.
[52] On Hypatius see Matthews (1994), 256–7, Sabbah (1997), 105, Barnes (1998), 60, 122, Tougher (2000).
[53] See *PLRE* 1, s.v. Alypius 4. That he was not an Antiochene is inferred from Libanius *Ep.* 324 by Seeck (1906b), 56–7. Brok (1959), 23–4, disagrees.

did. If Ammianus' origins were elsewhere, however, it is hard to say where. Suggestions have included Thessalonica,[54] and Alexandria,[55] or one of the cities of Phoenicia.[56] But some limiting factors do appear. Ammianus is a Semitic-sounding name.[57] Moreover, he seems to have known Syriac, the lingua franca of the fertile crescent. During the war of 359 he hints at his ability by glossing the Syriac place-name Meiacarire ('which gets its name from cool springs', 18.6.16); his selection for a dangerous solo mission in frontier territory shortly afterwards would also argue for his ability in the vernacular.[58] Knowledge of Syriac argues for his origin in Palestine or Syria (though it by no means compels it, as he could have learnt the language in those areas in youth or early manhood).[59] Barnes argues that his idiosyncratic habit of referring to the Syrian provinces in the plural (*Syriae*) suggests an origin somewhere in the Syrian provinces other than Antioch, perhaps in Phoenicia.[60] But it would be possible, less subtly, to use Ammianus' apparent knowledge of Syriac as yet another likely indicator for his Antiochene origins. It seems that no firm conclusion can be reached on Ammianus' origins.

That granted, the question as to whether Ammianus was the recipient of a letter from Libanius must equally remain open. The historian's links to Antioch, sketched out above, are obviously an item in favour, but their significance is actually rather greater than that of the letter. Scholarship has been misdirected in focusing on whether he was a citizen of Antioch, or the recipient of an unrevealing letter from Libanius; instead, as Guy Sabbah (somebody who has himself argued forcefully and at length that Libanius' correspondent is Ammianus) has suggested, we should wonder what

[54] Fornara (1992a), 339, on the grounds that he calls Hypatius *noster*.

[55] Bowersock (1990). [56] Woods (1998b). [57] Barnes (1998), 62–3.

[58] The importance of linguistic ability is suggested by the tale Ammianus tells of a similar cross-border mission undertaken in the West in the same year by a *tribunus uacans* named Hariobaudes (18.2.2–7): his name suggests Germanic origins and he is described as knowing the language of the Alamanni well (*sermonis barbarici perquam gnarus*, 18.2.2).

[59] Ammianus would never conceive, however, of mentioning Syriac. See Matthews (1989), 69–70, and Barnes (1993a), 59–61, (1998), 56, 60. Drijvers (1996), 537, suggests tentatively that Musonianus' *facundia sermonis utriusque* ('fluency in both languages', 15.13.1) might be understood to refer to Greek and Syriac. Woods (2001) justifiably casts doubt on this.

[60] Barnes (1998), 60–1.

his experience of Antioch brought to his history.[61] In the sections that follow, Ammianus' experience and status in both Antioch and Rome will be recurring themes. To a greater extent than with the letter of Libanius, we shall see that possible, rather than certain, conclusions about the historian's personal experiences or connections have been allotted excessive credence and importance.

II *Honoratior aliquis miles*: Ammianus' social status and career

The search for Ammianus' social status often begins with an anecdote (discussed for other reasons in the last chapter). When Amida was sacked by the Persians the historian slipped out of the city with two unnamed companions. Ten miles on foot left him fatigued, and he remarks that he was unused as a gentleman to excessive walking (*ut insuetus ingenuus*, 19.8.6). When a horse was fortuitously obtained, it was Ammianus, rather than either of his two anonymous companions, who got the use of its back. He displays, whether with insouciance or frankness, the social confidence of the officer class. Contrast to this hauteur an expression which he uses twice in the later books. When he attacks the aristocratic Praetorian Prefect, Petronius Probus, he comments of his possession of vast multinational property holdings that 'whether [he possessed them] justly or unjustly is not a question for my humble judgement' (*iuste an secus, non iudicioli est nostri*, 27.11.2). The same words of disavowal are found in the Roman digression of the following book, where Ammianus would not want to explain why aristocrats' literary interests were restricted to Juvenal and Marius Maximus (28.4.14). Readers have long been tempted to see in Ammianus an archetypal bourgeois, lofty towards his inferiors, cringing towards his superiors.[62] (Typical of this approach, and among the issues to be confronted below, is his possible status as a member of the curial class, that is, a hereditary town councillor.) In fact, my examples of superiority and inferiority are far from straightforward. It is hard to see whether the incident with the horse shows the author

[61] Sabbah (2003), 45. [62] The historian gives a similar assessment of Probus (27.11.2).

as haughty or self-depreciating, whether it is subconscious or calculated. His humility in treating Probus is only apparent. He fails to veil the audacity and cheek of what he was alleging – that a great noble might be thought to have acquired his inherited wealth unjustly – and the diminutive *iudicioli* oozes irony. And it may be that attitudes to both social superiors and inferiors in the *Res Gestae* have more to do with the historiographical aim of asserting the author's independence than with unconscious revelation of his social anxieties.

The investigation of the historian's career goes hand in hand with that of his status. As well as defining himself as *ingenuus*, Ammianus also defined himself as a former soldier and a Greek (31.16.9). The exegesis of the second of these epithets has attracted more attention than the first. But beyond rehearsing the exciting details of such parts of his career in soldiering as he has vouchsafed to us, it is worth asking what being a young *protector domesticus* in the 350s meant. What can we learn from it about Ammianus' origins and social status? And what does it imply about his military role and his movements in those periods (notably between 360 and the Persian expedition of 363, and after the end of the Persian expedition) in which he does not vouchsafe his activities? The second question will prove difficult to answer, but the first, as both Matthews and Barnes have noticed, could have rather important implications.[63] He is likely to have come from an influential family to become a *protector domesticus* at a young age (known to have been a *domesticus* from at least 353, he was still an *adulescens* in 357). Moreover, this precocious office-holding and other factors together make unlikely the often-repeated suggestion that he was a member of the curial class.

The office of *protector* has its origins in the mid-third century: the title, sometimes expanded to *protector Augusti*, 'defender of the emperor',[64] was characteristically given to men who had risen through the ranks and who were put in command of medium-sized formations. Abinnaeus, the details of whose career are preserved in a papyrus archive, was promoted to *protector* after

[63] Matthews (1989), 75–9; Barnes (1998), 59.

[64] See e.g. *CIL* III.3424, III.327, cited by Frank (1969), 35. For a detailed list of epigraphic evidence see Mommsen (1884).

thirty-three years service, and may not have been untypical.[65] It was an honourable office, enough to merit adoration of the imperial purple on appointment (*CTh* 6.24.4). *Protectores* reported to regional military commanders. *Protectores domestici*, who were organised into *scholae*, and the officer at court to whom they were subordinated, the *comes domesticorum*, are not firmly attested until the mid-fourth century: indeed Ammianus may well have been in the very first generation.[66] The distinction between the two equivalent ranks, *protector* and its subset *protector domesticus*, is easy to elide.[67] To use the terms interchangeably may have been common by the end of the fourth century, and Ammianus has sometimes been thought to do so himself.[68] In fact, straightforward *protectores* are never called *domestici* in the *Res Gestae*; I can find only two examples where he refers to those who were certainly *protectores domestici* simply as *protectores*, and in each case he has previously given the full rank (15.3.10–11, 25.5.8, cf. 21.16.20 and 25.5.4).[69] *Protectores domestici* were, it seems, young men of high family, usually military – and both their youth and their parentage must have meant that their chances of promotion were higher than those

[65] Jones (1964), 636; Trombley (1999); on Abinnaeus see Bell *et al.* (1962).

[66] See Mommsen (1884), 131–2, Trombley (1999), Barnes (1998), 58–9. Some cases where *protectores domestici* have been identified before the mid-fourth century should be excluded: the description of Diocletian as ruling the *domestici* in Aurelius Victor 39.1 is a case of anachronistic titulature either by Victor or more likely by his source, the *Kaisergeschichte*, both dating to the late 350s; the error is picked up by *HA Carus* 13.1 and by the source of Zonaras 12.31. An inscription found at Split (*CIL* III.12900) mentions . . . *atiani pro]tectoris d]omestici*. Gratian, the father of Valentinian and Valens, is known to have served as a *protector* from Amm. 30.7.3, but the identification is utterly speculative. *PLRE* 1 puts the *protector domesticus* Bitianus in the late third or early fourth century on the grounds that his father had been *praefectus uehiculorum*, an office which disappeared in the 330s or 340s, but the inscription on the tomb which he dedicated to his parents after both had died in old age (*CIL* III.14412[4]) could easily belong in the mid- to late fourth century. *PLRE* 1's Anonymi 195 and 196 are pious Christian fictions or semi-fictions of a later period.

[67] Trombley's study (1999) does not differentiate between the two, and his calculations on the career patterns of *protectores* cannot reasonably be applied to *domestici*, who were generally much younger.

[68] Frank (1969), 86; Jones (1964), 1265–6.

[69] In the latter instance, where the newly acclaimed emperor Jovian is described to Sapor by a Roman defector as *adhuc protectorem*, the failure to give his rank more specifically – he was after all the *primicerius domesticorum*, the senior member of the *schola* – derives from the implied speaker's hostility (den Boeft *et al.* ad 25.5.4). That said, the fact that the voice is not the author's does not preclude its being part of a strategy to denigrate Jovian's claim to the purple (Barnes (1998), 52, 140).

of other *protectores*. Out of twenty named *domestici*, other than Ammianus himself, who certainly or probably date from the fourth century, the exact parentage of thirteen is unknown (though several appear to have been of barbarian origins, and two, Memorius and Vitalianus, are known to have been promoted from the ranks).[70] The rest came from successful or very distinguished stock. Bitianus was the son of a *praefectus uehiculorum* (*CIL* III.14412[4]); Herculianus was son of Hermogenes, the *magister equitum* killed by rioters in Constantinople in 342 (14.10.2); Masaucio was son of Cretio, *comes Africae* (26.5.14); Paulus was son of Innocentius, a high court official under Constantius (Palladius *Hist. Laus.* 54); Hariulfus was son of a chieftain of Rome's Burgundian allies (*CIL* XIII.3682). Finally, the sons of the successful generals Varronianus and Gratianus, both of whom were enrolled in the corps, became the emperors Jovian and Valens. Such a catalogue would suggest that Ammianus might well have been the son of a distinguished soldier, or possibly a high civilian official. We cannot prove, but should not rule out, Gimazane's suggestion that Ammianus might be the son of the Marcellinus who was *comes orientis* in 349.[71]

Lofty origins are likelier to be recorded than humble ones, and attention would not naturally be drawn to the origins of those who in joining the regiment had escaped the curial order. Despite the lack of any positive evidence, it cannot be ruled out that men of curial origin entered the corps of the *protectores domestici* at some point. Legislation of 357 forbade decurions from lurking behind the *protector*'s dignity.[72] (It is possible, though very far from certain, that the defector Antoninus, whose rank of *protector* had not saved him from crippling financial oppression, may have been a

[70] See *PLRE* 1, s.v. Fl. Aurelius 7, Callistus 1 (author of an epic on Julian's Persian expedition, Socrates 3.21.14), Gabso, Eareter, Leontius 6 (enrolled by Julian: *Ep.* 152 (Bidez), = 22 (Hertlein), = 11 (Wright)), Fl. Moco, Fl. Memorius 2, Stephanus 3, Teutomeres, Valentinus 3, Valerianus 6, Verinianus, Vitalianus 3.

[71] Gimazane (1889), 25–7, given serious consideration by Barnes (1998), 59. This Marcellinus may well have been a Christian (see *PLRE* 1, s.v. Marcellinus 7), though Barnes is scrupulous in not using this to support his theory that Ammianus was an apostate. Jannaccone (1960), 10, speculates less plausibly that Ammianus was a relative of the Marcellinus who crushed Nepotianus' rebellion for Magnentius (see *PLRE* 1, s.v. Marcellinus 8).

[72] *CTh* 12.1.38.

victim of this law.)[73] However, Constantius II was noted for his preservation of distinction between military and civil authority, and the introduction of the corps of *protectores domestici* in about 350 looks like an attempt to provide a career-path for the sons of the military elite. Those fleeing the councils were probably likelier to look for careers simply as *protectores*, rather than in a new, centralised, and highly visible, *schola*.

Further support for the idea that Ammianus came from a military or administrative background rather than a curial one could be extrapolated from the language with which he praises Constantius for not putting military commanders in the Senate (21.16.2):

. . . nec sub eo dux quisquam cum clarissimatu prouectus est. erant enim, **ut nos quoque meminimus**, perfectissimi.

. . . nor in his reign was any military commander exalted with senatorial rank. They were, **as I too remember**, *perfectissimi*.

Ammianus himself was too young to be a *dux* under Constantius, but there might be a reference to a member of his family. The inference is far from certain (after all, the words which I have translated 'as I too remember' could equally be rendered 'as I have also mentioned'), but more valid than in the many cases where biographical inferences have been made with no first-person verb present.

The assumption that Ammianus was from a military or administrative background would sit comfortably with his residence, and perhaps also that of his parents, in Antioch, home to a huge number of courtiers and soldiers. (This of course implies nothing about whether he possessed Antiochene citizenship.) Such a background would also sit comfortably with his bilingualism. For an easterner Ammianus is unusual in his mastery of Latin language and literature; it will become apparent in later chapters that Ammianus' Latin, though tinged with Graecisms of which he was surely conscious, displays a voracious vocabulary and a vast range of

[73] This is speculative on several counts: the identification of Antoninus with a fugitive decurion (or landowner?) mentioned in Libanius *Ep.* 210 (= Norman 33) has often been criticised (e.g. Seeck (1906b), 78); Ammianus gives no evidence as to whether Antoninus was a decurion or not. Assuming that he was not, Petit (1955), 159–62, followed by de Jonge ad 18.5.1, suggests that he was subjected by the *curiales* of Nisibis to two *munera extraordinaria*, for which non-decurions were liable.

reading. Latin was not a rare skill in the Greek East in the fourth century, but the son of a soldier or administrator would have been likely to be brought up to a high degree of articulacy in the language of the army and the civil service. The question of what part Latin played in his education is an open one (though much more in the history suggests a thorough Latin literary education than the Greek equivalent).[74] But a literary education in Latin was not irrelevant to Ammianus' career. At one point he shows his education in action as a soldier. In 359 the notary Procopius sent a secret message from the Persian court, concealed in a scabbard and requiring the translation not only of cipher but also of its allusions to Roman history, presumably obtained from Sallust's *Histories* (18.6.17–19). The expectation that staff-officers would be able to interpret such a message is telling.[75] Ammianus, it may be noted, was not the only *protector domesticus* to turn to literature: Callistus wrote an epic poem on Julian's Persian campaign, and in the early fifth century a young nobleman corrected two manuscripts of Persius at Barcelona and Toulouse, writing in his subscription both *protector domesticus* and *uir clarissimus*.[76]

The elevated social context within which Ammianus therefore seems likeliest to belong does not rule out his membership of the wealthy and prestigious council of Antioch, or that of some other eastern city. Curials in Antioch lived on equal and comfortable terms with the upper classes imported from outside and those natives who were exempted from curial duties, administrators and soldiers. The supposition that Ammianus was of curial status is, however, unnecessary and in several ways unlikely. It yields to the temptation to look for a specific class below the Senate but of sufficient rank to cohere with his self-definition as *ingenuus*, 'genteel'. But simply picking on the *curiales* fails to acknowledge the complexity and variety of late Roman social structures. It is also to accept a view of the fourth century which relies excessively on the perspective offered by the survival of Libanius' enormous oeuvre.

74 That Latin was dominant in Ammianus' education has been argued by Fornara (1992b) and more recently Colombo (1999). For a different emphasis see Barnes (1998), 65–78.

75 Blockley (1986).

76 On Tryphonianus Sabinus see e.g. Clausen (1963). Both subscriptions date from 404 but come from different locations, suggesting that Sabinus had time to combine his literary pursuits with his profession.

A focus on the woes of the curial class is entirely typical of Libanius, and in fact relatively rare in Ammianus: occasionally he sides with local councils against overbearing emperors (14.7.2, 22.14.2, 27.7.6–7) or mentions their suffering in the course of local crises brought on by earthquake, invasion, the kidnap of their kin, or the oppressive actions of state officials (22.9.4, 28.6.4, 10, 18.10.1, 28.6.18). But the mention of curial rank in those places does not stand out from the narrative or argue a particular fascination on Ammianus' part. Personal interest has particularly been inferred in his repeated objections to aspects of Julian's policy on the councils. It involved recruitment of new decurions through foul means or fair, 'even if [a recruit to the council] were protected by special privileges, by length of service, or by clear proof that his origin was elsewhere altogether' (22.9.12, cf. 25.4.21).[77] One reading, particularly associated with E. A. Thompson, has seen these repeated criticisms of Julian, and Ammianus' other complaints about suffering decurions, as evidence that he was a curial historian (which for a Marxist like Thompson means a bourgeois historian).[78] Barnes draws an opposing conclusion. For him, the stress falls heavily on the word 'origin' (*origo*). He argues that

> Ammianus claimed exemption from curial obligations both on the grounds of his own service as a soldier and because his father or grandfather had removed himself from the curial class and the attendant obligations by entering imperial service.[79]

Barnes may be right, but similar criticism can apply both to his and to Thompson's speculation. It is possible for a historian to complain of injustice without the complaints necessarily relating to his own experiences. Nobody considers Ammianus to have been personally

[77] . . . *licet priuilegiis et stipendiorum numero et originis penitus alienae firmitudine communitus* (tr. Barnes (1998), 58). Ammianus' also mentions Julian's tendency to force individuals to participate in councils at 21.12.23 and 22.9.8.

[78] Thompson (1947), 2, referring to Enßlin (1923), 5; see Thompson's further remarks: 'We must try to find out what social class he came from, for his social origins will be found to have a definite bearing on his outlook' (xii); 'it is to the credit of the only middle-class Roman historian of consequence whose works have survived that he provides facts which are of the utmost importance to us if we are to understand those great events to which he himself had almost found the key' (133, the conclusion). The belief that Ammianus was a decurion was criticised by Momigliano (1974), 1401: 'his sympathy for the *curiales* is rather one of the various elements of his conservative outlook'.

[79] Barnes (1998), 59.

affected by Julian's law forbidding Christians to teach, though he twice attacks it (22.10.7, 25.4.20); and Libanius too spoke up for the curial class, though personally exempted from such duties, and keen to exempt others.[80]

Ammianus' rank of *protector domesticus*, suggestive in discussion of his origins and status, is of less use in filling in the lacunae in our knowledge of his adult career. Attention concentrates on what he did between the Persian invasion of the Roman Empire in 359 and the Persian expedition of 363, his role on that expedition, whether he remained in the army thereafter, and therefore whether his travels to Egypt and Greece, which probably belong in this period, were connected to military service. Attempts to identify his military specialities (which usually focus on the Persian expedition) are manifold, but also tend to founder.

The question of his activities in the period after the sack of Amida in 359 and Ursicinus' retirement the following year illustrates the general uncertainty. A letter of Libanius in 360 mentions the 'fine Ammianus' (ὁ καλὸς Ἀμμιανός) who is carrying the letter to Cilicia: he is described as a 'soldier in dress but in deeds a philosopher' (*Ep.* 233.4). Some have identified this Ammianus with the historian and conjectured a posting to Isauria.[81] Others have supposed that in the autumn of the same year he was with Constantius at Bezabde, because of the alleged vividness of the narrative.[82] One scholar has concluded confidently that his detailed knowledge of Constantius' plans to deal with Julian means that Ammianus must have served in the army in 360–1.[83] For others a period of eclipse following Ursicinus' dismissal seems likelier.[84] There is nothing to be gained from judging between these weakly competing cases.

The diverse attempts to identify Ammianus' precise role in the Persian campaign of 363 (and therefore the area of his military expertise) are no better. A speciality in artillery has been posited because of the digression on siege engines – though in fact such an expertise seems highly unlikely to anybody who has read the

[80] Such as his son Cimon Arabius. See also Kopaček (1974), 327–34, on Firminus.

[81] Büdinger (1895), 9; Enßlin (1923), 4–5; Thompson (1947), 10–11; Syme (1968), 45; Barnes (1998), 61–2. Seeck (1906b), 374, believes that the reference is to a court official rather than a soldier.

[82] Thompson (1947), 11; but cf. Dillemann (1962), 84–5.

[83] Austin (1979), 16, 88.

[84] Crump (1975), 11.

digression closely (23.4).[85] (Earlier, Ammianus is seen readying siege-engines for action at Amida, but appears to be concerned with their positioning rather than their operation, 19.7.6.) The belief in his involvement on the supply side of the expedition has seemed less implausible, but repeated mentions of the fleet on the Euphrates and the abundance of food only indicate that the historian and participant was showing an interest in the aspect of the expedition which would ultimately bring the Roman army to its knees.[86] W. R. Chalmers put forward the view that Ammianus, whom we know to have been a horseman (15.5 and 18.6), belonged to the cavalry. Chalmers deduces this by discovering a small reconnaissance mission, described in the first person plural, in which only cavalry can have participated (23.5.7). But this trip is an invention, founded on a misunderstanding of the chapter's structure: Ammianus deliberately delays Julian's speech to the soldiers on entering Persian territory.[87] For N. J. E. Austin, various pieces of information 'prove' that 'Ammianus was a member of the headquarters staff on the Expedition': he understands the strategic concept of dividing the troops between the main army and a smaller group under Procopius and Sebastian (23.3.5); he is aware of Julian's concerns that the siege of Maiazomalcha might delay the expedition (24.4.18); he knows the names of the three soldiers who first broke out of the tunnel into the city to bring the siege to an end (24.4.23).[88] But these last two examples of supposed expertise in fact contain information found independently in other sources: Zosimus, who follows Eunapius, preserves Julian's concern at the momentum of the expedition being lost at a different point in his narrative (3.15.2); Zosimus also offers (with slight variations) the names of the three soldiers who led the sortie into Maiazomalcha (3.22.4), one of whom is also found in an anonymous fragment

[85] See e.g. Mackail (1920), 104, approved by Thompson (1947), 11. Rightly rejected by Dillemann (1961), 97; den Hengst (1999) gives a realistic assessment of Ammianus' knowledge of siege engines.

[86] Dillemann (1961), 96–7 and 143, argues for involvement in the fleet; by contrast Matthews (1989), 172, makes an argument about Ammianus' autopsy based on his non-involvement.

[87] Chalmers (1959); Matthews (1989), 131–3, 178–9, argues persuasively for chronological manipulation at this point.

[88] Austin (1979), 17–18.

preserved in the Suda, the Byzantine encyclopedia.[89] In general, to infer from the knowledge or understanding displayed at particular points by Ammianus the historian that Ammianus the soldier participated in a particular role is desperately optimistic. In each case, the insightful view that could have come about through being an intelligent and well-connected officer who spoke to colleagues, or through reading the accounts of other participants, is arbitrarily turned into personal experience.[90]

In fact the best attempt to identify a personal role for Ammianus in the Persian narrative occurs in a place where no first-person verb is used. The leaders of the army were attempting to choose a new emperor, and the favoured candidate was Saturninius Secundus Salutius, Praetorian Prefect and pagan theologian (25.5.3):

quae dum ambiguntur, / nulla uariante sententia / itum est uoluntate omnium in Salutium, / eoque causante morbos et senectutem / honoratior aliquis miles / aduertens destinatius reluctantem / 'et quid ageretis', ait, 'si id bellum uobis curandum / commisisset absens, ut saepe factum est, imperator? / nonne posthabitis ceteris / militem instantibus aerumnis eriperetis? / id nunc agite et, si Mesopotamiam uidere licuerit, / utriusque exercitus consociata suffragia / legitimum principem declarabunt.'

While this was in doubt, without contradictory opinion the vote went by common consent to Salutius, and when he gave the excuse of diseases and old age, a certain soldier of high status pointed to him as he showed determined resistance and said: 'And what would you do if the war had been entrusted to you to carry out by an absent emperor, as has often happened? Would you not put all else to one side and snatch the soldiery from the dangers hanging over them? Do that now, and granted that we see Mesopotamia again, the joint votes of both armies will declare a lawful emperor.'

No answer is made, and the narrative proceeds to the fortuitous and risible elevation of Jovian. The idea that this senior soldier might represent Ammianus himself was first expressed in a footnote of Gibbon.[91] Since then support has been intermittent. But the case is not a bad one. The failure to name the soldier is striking. Ammianus certainly thought of himself as an *honoratior miles* (cf. 19.8.6). It was certainly his opinion that the Romans should have

[89] Suda, s.v. ἀνάσχουσα (A2094 Adler). See Norman (1957), Chalmers (1960), Cameron (1963).
[90] Austin (1979), 16, 80, 88.
[91] Gibbon (1776–88 [ed. D. Womersley, 1995]), Ch. 24, 1.946 n. 100.

attempted to return to Roman territory as quickly as possible: later, when Jovian had sent envoys to treat with Sapor, he lamented the failure to use the four days of delay to begin a gradual evacuation of the Romans towards the safety of Corduene (25.7.7–8). His belief that withdrawal was possible has been seen as highly eccentric (perhaps because he has been misinterpreted as saying that Roman territory was only four days away).[92] This unnamed soldier shares with him this distinctive belief in the importance of the army's escape before all else. With antiquarianism characteristic of Ammianus, the soldier remarks that such expeditions had been delegated in the past. He also emphasises the selection of a legitimate emperor. Ammianus, it is no secret, was minded to deny that epithet to Jovian.[93] So far, this is a case for his agreement with the soldier rather than that he was the soldier. What argues for the identity is the anonymity. An allusion to Xenophon's *Anabasis* 2.4.19 has been suggested, where 'a certain young man of those present' intervenes.[94] Beyond any verbal similarity, a similarity of situations is notable. It describes (in the third person) how Xenophon saved a Greek army from military disaster in the middle of Persia when its generals had been killed. The young man's intervention, coming at a point before Xenophon emerges as the chief character, has often been identified as a self-reference.[95] Such identifications are helped along by the fact that the *Anabasis* was published anonymously or pseudonymously: in the *Hellenica*, Xenophon attributes it to 'Themistogenes of Syracuse' (*Hell.* 3.1.2).[96]

It is sometimes objected that Ammianus was not senior enough to be a participant in such a council – though it might be pointed out that the second-person plural address to the generals and their staff implies that the anonymous officer 'did not belong to the highest echelons of the army'.[97] Ammianus had begun his career in an important *schola*, notable for the flexibility and range of its activities and indeed for producing emperors. (It has been powerfully argued, indeed, that it was the *protectores domestici* who

[92] See den Boeft *et al.* ad loc. [93] Heather (1999), 108. [94] Brakman (1919), 108–9.
[95] Von Haehling (1977), 353–4, argues that the *miles* is in fact a supporter of Procopius: see den Boeft *et al.* ad loc.
[96] See also Plut. *Mor.* 345e, McLaren (1934), Marincola (1997), 186, Gray (2004), 130–1.
[97] Den Boeft *et al.* ad loc.

were responsible for pushing the candidacy of Jovian, and that Ammianus suppressed the fact.)[98] The objection follows an unjustifiable assumption that Ammianus would have found it irresistible to reveal his participation in so important a council. Insignificance might be the cause of his reticence, but the limited number and the selective circumstances of those occasions on which Ammianus gives us an account of his participation in great events render such a conclusion doubtful.[99] In this case, certainty is not possible. The *honoratior miles* might be an invention of Ammianus, aimed at conveying his opinion. This conclusion would acknowledge both the similarity of the soldier's views to Ammianus' and the allusion to Xenophon. All that is denied is that such a salutary proposal was actually made.[100]

The army's arrival at Antioch (25.10.1) is the last time that Ammianus describes its movements using the first person plural. But as will be evident from the last chapter, the absence of the first person proves nothing, and he may well have continued across Asia Minor with the emperor as the Dutch commentators suggest – though the inside information and vivid testimony which they adduce for this could have come from any number of informants.[101] His residence in the East in the period after 363, including during the treason trials of 371/2, is clear (29.1.24, 29.2.4, 30.4.4). Other activities that may belong to these years are also attested in the *Res Gestae* – travel to Egypt most probably belonged in this period (see e.g. 17.4.6, 22.15.1)[102] and the visit to Methone in Greece

[98] Lenski (2000). [99] Chapter 2, esp. Section 1 above.

[100] The opinions of the *miles* are offered in response to the refusal of the imperial office by Salutius. Zosimus records that the empire was offered to him on Jovian's death, but not after Julian's (3.36.1). Ammianus records such an offer only at Julian's death. While in all probability both accounts are true (den Boeft *et al.* ad 25.5.3), some have sought to deny one or the other. If the whole story of the empire being offered to Salutius on Julian's death is a fiction of Ammianus', as suggested by Barnes (1998), 141, then the suggestion that the *miles* may be an authorial invention would become a certainty.

[101] Den Boeft *et al.* ad 25.10.1: 'both the detailed information about official reports on the situation in Gaul in §6–10 and the vignette of Jovian's young son wailing in protest against being carried in the *sella curulis* on January 1, 364 (§11) seem to bear the stamp of an eyewitness account'.

[102] That Ammianus' travels in Egypt belong after 363 is by no means certain, but this seems more probable than the period before he undertook military service or between 357 and 363, when the tense state of affairs on the eastern frontier would have placed considerable demands on members of the military stationed there. Barnes (1998), 101–2, points out a description of the resistance of Egyptian peasants to torture (22.16.23),

came some time after the great tsunami of 365 (26.10.19). None of these passing references can be used to date his travels, or to offer definitive proof that he remained a soldier, even if that would fit well with them. Speculation is possible (see Section IV below) but no more. It was probably at some point between the mid-370s and the mid-380s that he moved to Rome. Some of the fragmentary glimpses of his activity have been identified with the move to Rome, whether genuine (did he visit Methone on the way to Rome and the West?) or the product of optimistic inference (did he pass through Constantinople in the early 380s, see battlefields in Thrace, travel with Hypatius to Rome?) Some of these questions I have mentioned above, others I shall consider in Section IV; none are impossible and none are demonstrable.

The *protectores domestici* was a regiment largely composed of young men, being trained for other positions; we have examples of sackings (15.3.10–11), of swift and regular promotions (16.10.21),[103] and of lengthy periods of leave (Valens, most notably).[104] Knowing whether Ammianus was sacked or sidelined, or promoted to Tribune and *dux*, is impossible. Julian reduced the size of the regiment to prevent membership being treated as a sinecure, and perhaps also to remove Christians.[105] The suggestion that Ammianus might have been an apostate and a victim of Christian reprisal under a subsequent régime is pure and unsupported speculation.[106] It is equally possible (though perhaps unlikely) that he reached some other office that carried senatorial rank. His presence in Rome would then be explained by membership of the Senate. The lack of *testimonia* to his personal activities in the second half of the *Res Gestae* is only an argument from silence that this

which he suggests expresses the historian's personal experience. Those who wish to believe this will deduce that he visited Egypt as a member of the military rather than as a private citizen.

[103] See also Jones (1964), 638–9.

[104] Valens' military inexperience, combined with considerable experience of farming, suggests to me a largely honorific appointment interrupted by long periods of leave. Lenski (2002b), 52–3, prefers to think that Valens was not appointed *protector domesticus* till 359, when he was 31. Both our interpretations are speculative. Valens' imperial predecessor Jovian offers another example of a *protector domesticus* whose career may not have consisted of continuous service: the fact that he was *primicerius domesticorum*, the senior member of the regiment, when he became emperor at the age of 32, may imply that he had been appointed well before entering active service.

[105] *CTh* 6.24.1, cf. Lenski (2002a), 275. [106] Barnes (1998), 63; Woods (2000), 704–5.

was not the case. Again *ex silentio*, and more persuasively, Alan Cameron points out that almost all contemporary authors who were senators are designated *u. c.* (*uir clarissimus*) in the manuscripts. The *Res Gestae* is of course transmitted through a single line of manuscripts, so that need not be definitive.[107]

What we know for sure is that, as a former *protector domesticus*, Ammianus would have held the rank of *uir perfectissimus*. The perfectissimate was the highest rank of Roman *equites*, and largely a creation of Constantine I, whose rescripts display his determination to increase its size and prestige. Like the Senate and the *comitiua*, it suffered from rampant rank inflation in the course of the fourth century: a law of 384 shows that it was eventually divided into three classes.[108] But mentions in rescripts of the 360s and later imply its continuing significance. How *protectores* and *domestici* ranked within the perfectissimate is uncertain, but it is worth considering that the senior members of those regiments became senators in legislation of 414 and 416, and ten years before that Sabinus, the corrector of Persius, had subscribed two manuscripts with his rank of senator and his office of *protector domesticus*.[109] The juxtaposition speaks for the kudos of the regiment: Ammianus' personal kudos was probably the highest possible beneath the senatorial order.

From the start of the fourth century, in a change associated particularly with Constantine, the state's patronage of members of the elite had massively increased.[110] The distinctions between the traditional senatorial class and the administrative class of equestrians were blurred more speedily than before. The short-term effects included massive expansion of senatorial membership to administrators, as well as the old senatorial class finding incentives to engage in the government of the empire. Such changes offered remarkable scope for social mobility, but they also had the effect that once genuine offices turned into sinecures. Primarily to honour the military, Constantine had formalised the status of individuals

[107] Cameron (1964a), 16.

[108] *CTh* 6.30.7 (see esp. sections 2–8, 11–13, 15–17). See Jones (1964), 526.

[109] See *CTh* 6.24.7–9 (AD 414–16). On Tryphonianus Sabinus see e.g. Clausen (1963).

[110] Constantine's abundant patronage was recognised by contemporaries (Eusebius *VC* 4.1.1–2; Amm. 16.8.12). For modern views of fourth-century social mobility see Hopkins (1965), Marcone (1998) and Potter (2004), 364–400.

as the emperor's friends or companions into the intricate system of the *comitiua*, the order of counts; but the later fourth century saw senatorial rank spreading to soldiers as well, and eventually becoming part of the currency of military honours. Throughout the period, the effect of rank inflation was surely also that what might once have seemed like ranks of signal honour lost their status. In the period of Ammianus' retirement, when length of service as *protector domesticus* did not yet carry senatorial rank, old members of the regiment may to some degree have looked like a group left behind by social hyperinflation. A possible suggestion of this comes in a law of 387 (*CTh* 6.24.4), which confirms the right of osculation (kissing as equals) for *domestici* and *protectores* on meeting *uicarii*. We have no context for this law, and it is impossible to know whether this is a protection of privileges (did their status need protecting by law?) or whether indeed it marked their extension.

It is, therefore, possible to fit apparent anxieties in Ammianus into a larger picture of the late fourth century as an age of increasing social stratification, and Ammianus as a bourgeois oppressed by the growing dominance of the aristocracy. But care must be taken that the picture does not become caricature or cliché. For example, the idea that he was a curial is not impossible but is unsupported. There is also a danger in misreading his apparent cringing to the powerful and feelings of superiority to the humble. We may miss a determined effort, imposed by the genre, to demonstrate independence of mind and the absence of favour to any: in other words, the image of the lonely historian. The case for suffering at the hands of the powerful is most often made in the context of his alleged expulsion from Rome in a famine. It is to this inference that I now turn in the next section.

III Ammianus and the Romans

In two memorable digressions, Ammianus expands wittily upon the frivolity and shallowness of the inhabitants of Rome (14.6, 28.4). The Roman digressions are central to understanding the role of the city in the *Res Gestae*, but though they may seem revelatory, they

are not, at least not openly, autobiographical. But they have been interpreted as such. In 383 or 384 the prospect of a famine led to the expulsion of *peregrini* (foreigners) from the city of Rome (in a world-empire of Roman citizens, the technical term maintained the honoured status of the natives of the city by identifying residents who had come from outside). Ammianus refers to this event (14.6.19) in the first Roman digression:

Postremo ad id indignitatis est uentum / ut, cum peregrini ob formidatam haud ita dudum alimentorum inopiam / pellerentur ab urbe praecipites, / sectatoribus disciplinarum liberalium impendio paucis / sine respiratione ulla extrusis, / tenerentur mimarum asseculae ueri quique id simularunt ad tempus, / et tria milia saltatricum ne interpellata quidem cum choris totidemque remanerent magistris.

Finally things have reached such an pitch of unseemliness that, when quite recently foreigners were driven headlong from the city on the grounds of a feared shortage of provisions, devotees of the liberal arts, who were very few in number, were bundled out with no breathing-space, but mime-artists' attendants were kept on (both the real ones and those who pretended to be temporarily), and 3,000 dancers stayed behind without even being interrupted, along with their choruses and the same number of teachers.

It is the work of a moment for modern scholars to decide that Ammianus was himself among those expelled.[111] Private rancour towards the Prefect of the City who ordered the expulsion is also commonly inferred. It was traditionally dated to 383 because the letters of Symmachus and Ambrose on the Altar of Victory (late in 384) refer to the food shortages of the previous year. E. A. Thompson pointed out that if Anicius Auchenius Bassus was the prefect responsible it would concur with Ammianus' disdain for the Anician family (16.8.13, 27.11).[112] But a reassessment of the date, which has proved far more popular, places the expulsions in the prefecture of Q. Aurelius Symmachus, which lasted from the middle of 384 to early 385.[113] This too is interpreted as evidence

[111] First suggested by Seeck (1894), 1846, and then backed by Thompson (1947), 14, and subsequently supported by most of those who have written on the subject: among others Cameron (1964a), 27, Matthews (1989), 13, Barnes (1998), 2. More nuanced views are to be found in Enßlin (1923), 6–7, and Rosen (1982), 25 For opposition see n. 121 below.

[112] Thompson (1947), 14.

[113] Palanque (1931), accepted *inter alios* by Ruggini (1961), 119 and n. 318, Kohns (1961), 158–82, Cameron (1964a), 27–8, Fauré (1965), 528 (rather less confidently: see the reservations of n. 22), and Matthews (1989), 13.

of a personal grudge, and perhaps an explanation for Ammianus' total failure to mention Symmachus.[114] That silence is, in fact, only very surprising to those who make the assumption that the historian and the orator were friends or soul mates. Nor is the dating of the expulsions to Symmachus' prefecture quite as unquestionable as it has become in the scholarly literature.[115] If the expulsion were dated (say) to the prefecture of Aventius Sallustius, who preceded Symmachus in office, an opportunity to identify Ammianus' personal bias would be lost.

I do not think it remotely likely that Ammianus was expelled from Rome in a food shortage, but that said, it is not a completely baseless guess.[116] Most likely, he was at Rome at the time. His tone is outraged. He was himself of foreign origin and could, at a stretch, have been described as a *sectator disciplinarum liberalium*.[117] Moreover the word *peregrinus*, and arguably the character of a *peregrinus*, has appeared twice before in the digression. First (14.6.2) in reference to the reader to whom the digression is addressed; Ammianus suggests that foreigners may wonder why, when the narrative turns to Rome, it tells of nothing but riots, taverns and other vulgarities. Next, for a visitor to Rome of honourable status (*honestus aduena*), who has an embarrassing time paying court to a great noble (14.6.12–13): the traditional rituals

[114] Cameron (1964a), 24–5.

[115] The principal problems with dating the expulsion to Symmachus' prefecture lie in surprising silences. Symmachus' mention of the expulsion, in a letter to Flavianus (*Ep.* 2.7), is remarkably impersonal, and neither requires nor imposes a dating in his own prefecture. It is also surprising that so controversial a step on Symmachus' part is absent from his own *Relationes*, from Ambrose's letters on the Altar of Victory and from the same author's *De Officiis*. The *Relationes*, to be sure, are not without some indications of a crisis in the *annona*, but deliberate and violent suppression of an embarrassing incident must be assumed. The Altar of Victory debate might have preceded the expulsions, but Ambrose's lack of hints as to the identity of the prefect in *De Officiis* is surprising given the back-story. Palanque (1931) attributes it to politeness towards Symmachus, while McLynn (1994), 273, interprets the passage as malicious towards him.

[116] An ambitious display of guesswork by Sivan (1997) suggests that, although Ammianus had not been thrown out of the city in the food crisis, he had a sympathy for exiles. She identifies him with the Ammianus (*PLRE* 1, s.v. Ammianus 4) who was *comes rerum priuatarum* in 383, inventing a long and complicated story of his alleged exile and recall.

[117] It is not clear to me what this expression means. *Sectator* is closer to 'student' than to 'professor', which is Hamilton's translation. Better admit the imprecision as do Rolfe ('those who practised the liberal arts') and Galletier ('hommes attachés aux études libérales').

of patronage within the city of Rome are amusingly described. Here, too, the authentic experience of the author has been felt, and when *peregrini* are mentioned a third time, at their expulsion, the persistence of the theme helps some interpreters to believe in its personal application.

Support for this feeling is found in the contents of the second digression (28.4), where further polemic is fuelled by how the Romans treat visitors. For example, Roman noblemen refuse to greet strangers as equals with a kiss on the cheeks, and dodge away, offering to their flatterers instead their knees or hands (*adulatoribus offerunt genua suauianda uel manus*):[118] they turn their heads like threatening bulls (28.4.10). It is not implausible that such vivid descriptions are based on experience. But those who propose biographical readings do not like to hedge. The digressions are in general based on his experience of Rome, the argument runs. One can compile a complete little story of Ammianus' vicissitudes: the best example is a brief essay written by Edward Thompson for *Greece and Rome* in 1942, in which every detail is turned into autobiography, and Ammianus himself is the butt of sarcasm, complaining among other things of 'their preference of music and dancing to good literature (dreadful crime)'.[119] The relative lack of interest shown by the nobility in literature and littérateurs becomes part of the story: their libraries were shut like tombs (14.6.18); the only books they read were Juvenal and Marius Maximus (28.4.14). Ammianus is accused of failing to understand why the company of frivolous gossips and frivolous literature could be preferred to his own.

A number of objections, both general and specific, can be raised against reading the digressions as a catalogue of contemporary woes with a basis in distressing personal experience. I shall not go into detail here on intertextual or generic questions, but note simply that Ammianus does not argue from the perspective of an outsider;[120] that the digressions reflect long-standing literary

[118] Note how *genua* ('knees') puns on the expected *genas* ('cheeks').

[119] Thompson (1942), 133.

[120] As Sabbah (2003), 53, has pointed out, in the sentence immediately following the expulsion of the followers of the liberal arts and the retention of the dancing girls, Ammianus describes the appearance of the dancing girls (*et licet . . . spectare*, 14.6.20).

traditions; that Ammianus might have written in this vein without reflecting his own experiences; and that it might be possible to laugh with him rather than at him. Reflection of literary tradition does not of course mean that the digressions cannot also reflect personal experience. When senators dodged away from being kissed, was this a slice of Ammianus' own experience? The law of 387 (*CTh* 6.24.4) to which I referred above, confirming the right of *protectores* and *domestici* to be kissed as equals on meeting *uicarii*, might suggest precisely that the ill-manners of the present age are being condemned. Or should the passage be read as imitation of a work of literature over two centuries old, Lucian's *Nigrinus*, where a Greek philosopher resident in Rome describes the Roman nobility's insistence on Persian-style obeisance, of being kissed on the chest or hands (21)? Both are valid interpretations, and they are not necessarily mutually exclusive. My intention is to deal briefly here with the suggestion that Ammianus was thrown out of Rome in a food shortage. The story reconstructed seems to contradict what can be gathered about Ammianus, and the expulsions, from elsewhere.

As I have argued above, Ammianus' appointment as a *protector domesticus* implies high inherited status; his formal rank as an ex-*domesticus* was at the very least that of a *uir perfectissimus*. It strikes me, as it has struck others, as unlikely that a man of distinguished equestrian rank would have been expelled from the city in any crisis.[121] T. D. Barnes argues that Ammianus' humiliating expulsion from the city 'is plausibly inferred from the bitterness with which he refers to the event'. But Barnes goes on to argue much more plausibly on broad prosopographical grounds that Ammianus was of high status, and that he had a powerful friend in Hypatius (a former consul, Prefect of Rome, and Praetorian Prefect of Italy), factors which render his expulsion unlikely. The paradox in identifying Ammianus with the *peregrinus* is well expressed by Barnes: 'in what has always been regarded as a transparent piece of autobiography (14.6.19), Ammianus reveals that he

It is not implied that the narrator is among those who have been made to leave. I hope to write in greater detail on these digressions elsewhere.

[121] E.g. Momigliano (1974), 1396, Sabbah (1978), 125 and n. 50, 126 and n. 52, (2003), 53 and n. 35.

was initially welcomed, but then scorned, presumably because he could not win social acceptance for himself, although he was the protégé of an eastern *nobilis*'.[122] In methodological terms reaching conclusions from general prosopographical studies is inevitably uncertain. It seems to me, however, that it is nonetheless preferable to reading between the lines of the text.[123] Sometimes readings between the lines contradict each other.

The most detailed contemporary source for the expulsions is Ambrose, a passage of whose *De Officiis* (3.45–52) has been adduced as support for the view that men of high rank were among those expelled. In *De Officiis* Ambrose argues from a Christian perspective that right behaviour coincides with utility. The theme of the expulsion of strangers, like much else, is taken up from Cicero's dialogue of the same name. Cicero (*Off.* 3.47) remarks on the inhumanity of denying foreigners access to a city, while Ambrose (3.45–52) talks of two particular events, one very recent, when an expulsion of foreigners had taken place (that of 383 or 384), and another when it had been avoided by the action of the Prefect of the City in collecting funds from senators (usually dated to the prefecture of Aradius Rufinus in 376).[124] Far more attention is given to the occasion when the expulsion did not take place.

[122] Barnes (1998), 2, 58–9, 122.

[123] It is a pity that Cameron (1964a), in rejecting the latter type of reading as evidenced by the invention of Ammianus' participation in the Circle of Symmachus, did not also see that the whole story of the expulsion was of the same type.

[124] For the identification of the prefect as Aradius Rufinus see e.g. Palanque (1931), 349, Ruggini (1961), 118–19 n. 316, Noy (2000), 40. The argument is not very strong. It is based in the first instance on the age of prefects in the period before the composition of *De Officiis*, since Ambrose mentions his hero as being *prouecta . . . aetate* and calls him a *sanctissimus senex* (3.46, 48). The description *sanctissimus* is unlikely on Ambrose's lips if Aradius Rufinus was a pagan (see *PLRE* 1, s.v. Rufinus 11). The problem is resolved by von Haehling (1978), 382–4, by assuming that Rufinus was a late convert, which is tenuous but tenable. It is sometimes argued that Ambrose refers to an imperial visit shortly afterwards (*hic . . . uere potuit imperatori dicere: . . . hos tibi omnes reseruaui*, 'This man . . . could say truthfully to the emperor: ". . . all these I have saved for you"', *De Off.* 3.48: see Palanque (1931), 349, and the cautious Ruggini (1961), 118 n. 316). But *potuit* need not refer to a real situation, nor *dicere* to immediate presence. In any case, it is evident from Themistius *Or.* 13, the *Erotikos*, that Gratian's planned visit to Rome for his Decennalia in August 376 did not take place: perhaps because of the food shortage. Barnes (1999) also concludes, in contrast to Barnes (1975), that Gratian never visited Rome. Cecconi (2002), 161–2, points out that Rufinus' predecessor, Furius Maecius Gracchus, may still have been in office in the early summer of 376; he is known to have been old enough to be called *senex* and bigoted enough to be called *sanctissimus*.

Ambrose makes the elderly and virtuous prefect give a speech in the Senate (46–7) urging the upper classes and the wealthy men (*honorati*, *locupletiores uiri*) to club together and buy grain rather than allow such a bestial policy as expulsion.

An influential analysis by Lellia Cracco Ruggini has been taken to support the possibility that this expulsion affected the higher levels of society.[125] She uses the passage as evidence for the existence in the late fourth century of a free-market trade in corn between the Po valley and the city, which supplemented the corn that arrived from North Africa and Egypt. She picks on a number of details within the account to reach a conclusion about the identity of those expelled: they included both farmers and traders ('how many people were lost to their own city, who were wont to help it, whether in bringing aid or increasing trade', 3.46).[126] Those excluded had been accustomed to provide food (3.46). The normal conclusion was that Ambrose referred to market-gardeners working in the properties of senators, and perhaps to the merchants like the *pantapōlae*, of whose recall after an expulsion we hear in a law half a century later (*Nov. Val.* 5, 440). But Ruggini noticed further details: Ambrose pointed out that a successful harvest meant that the *Itali*, whose sons were expelled, could have brought aid when the ships did not come (3.48). For Ambrose *Itali* usually means the inhabitants of the northern Italian provinces. Furthermore, there was evidence that some individuals of high status had been thrown out. *Nostra illic familia, plerique etiam nostri parentes sunt*, says the prefect ('our own household is there, many of them are even our relatives', 46), and later Ambrose, equally rhetorical, exclaims *seruum retines, trudis parentem* ('the slave you keep back, you cast out the relative', 48). Were some of those cast out relatives of the *honorati* in the immediate audience?[127] Finally, Rome had been deceived of the aid of the *corporati* (3.50). Taking all these pieces of evidence together Ruggini proposed that Ambrose's prime focus was the expulsion of members of northern Italian elites who had

[125] Ruggini (1961), 112–46; see also Fauré (1965), Durliat (1990), 518–24, McLynn (1994), 272–5.

[126] *quantos urbi suae perire qui solerent adiumento esse uel in conferendis subsidiis uel in celebrandis commerciis.*

[127] Ruggini (1961), 126. *Parens* can have a looser sense than the literal 'parent', rather as *frater* need not mean 'brother' literally: cf. modern Italian *parente*.

banded together to form a *corpus* for the trade of corn, and that Symmachus had expelled them alongside other foreigners rather than purchase corn from them at market rates.[128]

The thesis is an impressive one, but not all aspects of it are as secure as others. It seems likely that Ambrose of Milan should focus on specifically northern Italian resentment. But the reference to *corporati* in context appears to be concerned with the ship-owners of Rome, rather than any group based in Milan.[129] Nor does it seem likely that relatives of senators were expelled from the city. The speech is fervent and rhetorical, and more universal than specific. The characterisation is not strong, and the words that the prefect utters are imbued with Ambrose's wisdom from after the event: he is made covertly to criticise the expulsion of 383/4, which of course happened later. Though the prefect is ostensibly speaking in the Senate, his argument very much duplicates Ambrose's, which focuses both on shared humanity and on shared citizenship (*communia iura*, 3.45). It is rightly pointed out that, in this moralising context, he is talking of the relatives of all the Roman people.[130] Connections (of whatever sort) of the *clarissimi* do not seem to coincide with the economic groups named in Ambrose's argument, farmers and traders. He repeatedly expresses the fear that some of those expelled might starve to death ('with so many ploughmen dead, so many farmers falling', *tot cultoribus exstinctis, tot agricolis occidentibus*, 3.46). This also renders more unlikely the already dubious claim that the relatives of *honorati* were expelled. It is hard to avoid the conclusion that even if certain regional resentments are being aired, everything is subordinated to the rhetorical purpose of urging that honourable behaviour is also self-interested. Like Ammianus, with his theatrical types and scholars (neither of whom appear in *De Officiis*), Ambrose chooses those who best fit his arguments, without much concern at self-contradiction. It is powerfully argued by Durliat that Ambrose treats Rome as if it were an ordinary city that relied on the produce of its hinterland; hence the reference to economic relationships with non-citizens from round about.[131]

[128] Ruggini (1961), 112–52. [129] Fauré (1965).
[130] Fauré (1965), 530, responding to Ruggini (1961), 125–6.
[131] Durliat (1990), 518–23, at 522.

There should be nothing surprising in Ammianus' mention of an expulsion which did not affect him. It was a cause célèbre. Besides Ambrose and Ammianus, it was reproved by Themistius and lamented by Symmachus (*Ep.* 2.7). Not that inhospitality was a new charge, however. Expelling strangers was, it appears, a habit of the Romans.[132] Although no other specific wholesale expulsions before this one are known since Augustus' reign,[133] there were expulsions of particular unpopular groups: Jews, worshippers of Isis, astrologers.[134] And general expulsions must have occurred in less well documented periods in between, as this is almost a topos. The sources for 383/4 refer unspecifically to other expulsions. And thirty years before Ambrose and Ammianus wrote anything of the expulsion of 383/4, Libanius wrote in praise of Antioch (*Or.* 11.174):[135]

> We have never had occasion to violate the divine laws of hospitality through any bias against foreigners, though we have the example of Rome, where times of dearth to the necessities of life are altered to abundance by the expulsion of foreigners.

The Romans cast visitors out whenever there was a shortage. It might be implied rhetorically that what happened once was a habit; but unless this is a later addition to the speech, it proves that at least two events are to be assumed, one in 383 or 384, the other before the composition of the *Antiochicos* in 356.[136] Like Libanius, Themistius, Prefect of Constantinople, is praising his own city when he criticises Rome; he too implies more than one expulsion, indeed says they were continual (*Or.* 18.222a): οὔκουν δεῖ ἡμῖν

[132] See Noy (2000), 37–41.

[133] He expelled *uenalicias et lanistarum familias peregrinosque omnes exceptis medicis et praeceptoribus partimque seruitiorum* ('the slaves for sale, and the schools of gladiators and all foreigners with the exception of physicians and teachers and some slaves') (Suetonius, *Augustus* 42.3). See also Dio 55.26.1. The event is dateable to AD 6. Cicero, *Pro Sestio* 30, says that such expulsions occurred very rarely (*perraro*).

[134] See Suetonius, *Tiberius* 36; also Tacitus *Ann.* 2.85.4, Josephus *Ant. Iud.* 18.3.5; Suetonius, *Vitellius* 14.4.

[135] οὐδεπώποτε τὸν Ξένιον ἠναγκάσθημεν ἀδικῆσαι Δία διὰ τῆς περὶ τοὺς ξένους ὠμότητος, καίτοι τὸ παράδειγμα τῆς Ῥώμης ἔχοντες, ἢ τὴν τῶν ἀναγκαίων σπάνιν, ἡνίκα ἂν τοῦτο συμπέσῃ, τῇ τῶν ξένων ἐλάσει πρὸς ἀφθονίαν μεθίστησιν (tr. Norman).

[136] Ruggini (1961), 119 n. 317 and 156 and n. 441, suggests that this refers to an event during the unrest of Orfitus' first prefecture, perhaps because of the dramatic date of Ammianus' digression. Ammianus refers only to a shortage of wine (see Kohns (1961), 112–19). A similar error is found in Noy (2000), 40.

ξενηλασίας συνεχοῦς, καθάπερ τῇ μητροπόλει ('we have no need for continual expulsions of strangers, as happens in the mother city'). Ambrose, as we have seen, refers to one expulsion as having happened (that of 383/4) and to another occasion when the Urban Prefect (a *sanctissimus senex*) had vigorously and successfully opposed such a move.[137] Ambrose refers to the demand for expulsions as if it were quite normal (*De Off.* 3.46):[138]

quanto ille rectius, qui cum . . . famem toleraret ciuitas atque (**ut in talibus solet**) peterent uulgo ut peregrini urbe prohiberentur . . .

How much more properly did *he* act, who when . . . the city was enduring hunger, and (**as tends to happen in such circumstances**), there was popular agitation for foreigners to banned from the city . . .

Though the standpoints of the men who objected were different, they all offer testimony that these expulsions did not simply happen on one occasion.

In conclusion, it seems historically unlikely that Ammianus was expelled from Rome in a food shortage, and that he mentions the expulsion should in no way prove that he was one of its victims. Although as a specific contemporary reference it stands out in the digression, it was both a criticism that would have been almost impossible to omit and one which had become a commonplace. A biographical reading also underestimates the humour of the passages. It can be stated with some firmness that the figure of the *honestus aduena* is *not* obviously biographical, but *is* obviously literary.

IV *Versati in medio*

In the quest for biographical information, Ammianus' personal relationships have also received attention. Scholarship has tended to focus on two areas: the identification of those of his contemporaries who supplied him with information; and the detection of bias in favour or against individuals on personal grounds (that they had done good or ill to him or those he favoured). This second category is in some instances very clear. Ammianus knew and

[137] See n. 124 above. [138] Cf. 28.4.32.

admired Ursicinus; because of this he criticises violently those who thwarted him, such as the venomous eunuch Eusebius, Constantius' chamberlain, or the martyr-worshipping midget Sabinianus, who replaced him as eastern *magister equitum*.[139] (These are individuals whom he very probably or, in the latter case, certainly encountered.) But in most cases – the obvious example being Ammianus' admiration of Julian and corresponding enmity to those who thwarted or denigrated him – the strong opinions of the historian are not demonstrably personal as much as political. Strong opinions of individuals are a standard feature of the genre of history, and are applied to many among the huge cast of the *Res Gestae*.[140] The identification of definitively personal prejudices in these cases is hard, though general trends may be traced.

Before that, however, I will look at the first category: possible oral sources. Like the story of the expulsion from Rome, these need to be read between the lines. The plausibility of such readings can vary wildly. We have already had cause to look in Section 1 of this chapter at two contemporaries long assumed to have been the historian's friends in Rome and Antioch, though neither is named in the *Res Gestae* as extant. The long-standing focus of scholarship on the historian's links to the fabled Circle of Symmachus and to Libanius responds to an understandable wish to place him in the context of famous and distinguished co-religionists and fellow conservatives, but the first case wishfully reads between the lines what is most unlikely to be there, and the second is highly questionable.

E. A. Thompson's book of 1947, however, put forward an argument which gave his successors a more exact motivation for linking the historian to his contemporaries. Thompson reacted strongly against the source-critical approach to Ammianus which had been taken by scholars such as Otto Seeck.[141] He stressed not written sources but the experience and the vast acquaintance of Ammianus personally. The core text for such an argument, of course, is the opening of Book 15: Ammianus drew attention to two sources of information, what he himself had seen in the course of his life and

[139] E.g. 18.4.3, 18.5.5, 18.6.7, 20.2.3.
[140] Two virtually random examples: Tacitus *Ann.* 3.75, 4.20.2–3.
[141] Thompson (1947), 20–41.

what he had learned by detailed questioning of those in the thick of things (*ea quae uidere licuit per aetatem uel perplexe interrogando uersatos in medio scire*, 15.1.1). He had relied on an outstanding and diverse range of informants; indeed his whole life had been a preparation for his history (journals or notebooks are sometimes conjectured for his early career).

This is an attractive thesis. The *Res Gestae* does read like a life's work – intentionally so.[142] The reference to autopsy and witnesses is a historiographical cliché going back to Thucydides, but that does not make it an inaccurate description of Ammianus' working methods (it is likely to be a partial description, omitting as it does reference to textual sources). One of the most striking features of the work is the enormous range of characters named: as mentioned above, 485 have been counted in the extant books, of whom a significant majority are soldiers and administrators.[143] Contrast that to one of Ammianus' sources for the second and third centuries, another contemporary history written in full awareness of the traditions of the genre.[144] Herodian was a Greek provincial writing a history of the years 180 to 238. In a work about half the length of Ammianus' as it survives, there are, excluding members of the imperial family, a total of thirty-one named characters, and the focus is far more purely on the history of the emperors, a difference no doubt reflecting the times as well as the social status of the authors.[145] The fact that Ammianus' history constantly narrates the experiences of those *uersati in medio*, 'in the thick of things', makes it a reasonable assumption that he was dependent on their testimony – though to what extent is much more debateable.

It is important to be aware, however, that the attempt to investigate the historian's informants and acquaintances is conditioned, one could say hindered, by the traditions of the genre as Ammianus interpreted them. There are cases where we are inevitably made aware of whom he knew. In all his detailed adventures he is a

[142] Note the suggestion of the sphragis that old age has led the historian to call a halt.
[143] Frakes (2000a).
[144] On Ammianus' use of Herodian as a source see Ch. 5, Section III.
[145] Sidebottom (1998), 2789–91. Of Ammianus' 485 characters, twenty-one are emperors or their close relatives.

protector domesticus attached to the staff of Ursicinus. As such he twice names his colleague Verinianus (15.5.22, 18.8.11), and is sent on a secret mission to the Kurdish satrap Jovinianus (18.6.20).[146] It is obvious that he knows these individuals. The centurion who accompanies him to see Jovinianus, and the two others who escaped from Amida with him, are not named. It is clear in these cases (and in the rest of the *Res Gestae*) that discrimination on the grounds of social status affects who is named. But outside the autobiographical passages, Ammianus almost never makes it clear which of the individuals he mentioned he had personally encountered. These include some whom he seems very likely indeed to have met; for example, the two prominent defectors of the year 359: Antoninus was a fellow *protector* and Craugasius a decurion of Nisibis, where Ammianus had been stationed five years before. Personal acquaintance would offer some explanation for the notable detail in which they are described, but he does not tell.[147] The *Res Gestae* is of course a brilliant resource for prosopography and the history of Roman government, but in this respect there is a striking generic difference between history and, for example, epistolography. The point need not be laboured, but for obvious reasons Libanius' correspondence gives a more or less clear picture of his relationships, while the *Res Gestae* provides very little on the historian's relationships.[148] There is also a contrast with other genres of historical narrative. The biographies of the *Historia Augusta* consistently advertise the sources of the authors' knowledge, even if informants and authors alike are fictional.[149] Ammianus' very real research is all but invisible.

Accordingly, except for the handful of individuals such as Ursicinus with whom Ammianus is actually shown as interacting, reasonably certain identification of informants can only be managed in a limited number of cases.[150] There are several possible criteria:

[146] On whom see above p. 115.

[147] For the assumption that Craugasius was known to Ammianus see Thompson (1947), 2. On Antoninus, see Ch. 2 above, Sections II.1, III.

[148] The new annotated translation by Bradbury (2004) is a valuable resource for studying Libanius' developing relationships with individual correspondents.

[149] Cf. e.g. the instances mentioned by Syme (1968), 101–2.

[150] There are also cases where information is said to have been confided to anonymous individuals, such as an emperor's friends or *proximi* (e.g. 15.8.1, 20.5.10).

(1) when an individual's actions, for which that individual is the only possible source, are described;
(2) when an individual is eulogised;
(3) when high offices he will later hold are listed, especially those held after the terminus of the history in 378;
(4) when his activities are described in surprisingly abundant detail.

None of these criteria are definitive (the 'only possible source' could have told somebody else, for instance, or recorded his experiences in writing), but, encouragingly, individuals often appear in more than one of these categories.

Thus, for example, Julian sent the *notarius* Philagrius on a secret mission to entrap the Alamann king Vadomarius, who had been raiding Gaul at the encouragement of Constantius (21.4.2–6). The operation is narrated in considerable detail, from Philagrius' point of view, with information which would have been known to Philagrius alone. When he is first named Ammianus indirectly praises his character (Julian had chosen him for the task because he had long experience of his *prudentia*); he also mentions his later tenure as *comes orientis*, in which office he is attested in 382. Although *comites orientis* were based in Antioch, Ammianus' old home town, it is not an office of such distinction that he usually mentions the names of those who would hold it in the future, and this is relatively rare as a reference to an office held after the formal end-date of the *Res Gestae*. We learn from a letter of Libanius that Philagrius served on the Persian expedition and wrote an account of it. The cumulative evidence for Philagrius as a personal source and as somebody the historian admired is very persuasive.[151] Still greater certainty can be found in another case, that of Julian's chamberlain Eutherius. Ammianus lauds him at length as the brilliant exception to the rule that nothing good could be said about a eunuch (16.7.4–7). He is described as living in retirement in Rome and admired by all classes; significantly for his value for the historian he is praised for his trustiness (*fides*, 16.7.6) and for his powerful memory (*immensum quantum memoria uigens*, 16.7.5). The *Res Gestae* nowhere comes closer to indicating an oral source. Eutherius is very probably (it would be hard to say

[151] See *PLRE* 1, s.v. Philagrius 2, Sabbah (1978), 226–7, Matthews (1989), 162 and 376–7. For a markedly different interpretation see Woods (2000).

demonstrably) the source for the anger which Constantius showed towards the embassy Julian sent in the aftermath of his usurpation (20.9.2).[152]

In the case of other individuals who may have known and supplied information to Ammianus, the supporting evidence is notably more slender. Other than those already named, I shall focus on two groups, which between them cover most of the individuals proposed as informants. First, a number are high-ranking army officers or, like Philagrius, members of the corps of *notarii* (civilians who worked closely with the military and held military ranks).[153]

- Teutomeres, like Ammianus a *protector domesticus*, may have been the source for the banquet of Africanus (15.3.7–9). He was exiled when a prisoner under his guard committed suicide, but was later pardoned (15.3.10–11). Significantly, a colleague in the same situation is unnamed. He later seems to have participated in the Persian expedition, and was a correspondent of Libanius.[154]
- Laniogaisus, a *tribunus*, is shown giving the advice which made Silvanus turn to usurpation (15.5.17). Ammianus had described in a lost book how he had been the last person left with Constans before his death in 350.[155]
- Abdigildus was a tribune at Nisibis in 359; Ammianus witnessed him fleeing the Persians, who captured, interrogated and killed his groom (18.6.12). He may be the same as the Count Aligildus who informed Julian of Constantius' death (21.15.4, 22.2.1).[156]
- Discenes, a tribune and *notarius*, is named for calculating, on a somewhat idiosyncratic basis, the numbers of Persians killed at Amida (19.9.9).[157]
- Sophronius, a *notarius*, brought Valens swift news of Procopius' uprising (26.7.2). Ammianus mentions his later Prefecture of Constantinople, probably in 382; this is an office he is not generally inclined to

[152] On Eutherius see e.g. Syme (1968), 95, Sabbah (1978), 228–30, Matthews (1989), 25, Barnes (1998), 128. Yet again Woods has a very different view (1998c).

[153] On military ranks among the *notarii* see Jones (1964), 103, and Teitler (1985), 19–21. See also Sabbah (1978), 194–5, on Hariobaudes, and 224, on Valentinus.

[154] *PLRE* I, s.v. Teutomeres; Libanius *Ep.* 1117; Sabbah (1978), 223–4.

[155] Sabbah (1978), 225–6.

[156] At 18.6.12 *V* gives *abdigit dum*, Gelenius (probably following a conjecture in *E*) gives Abdigidum; Abdigildum was proposed by Heraeus. The identification of Abdigildus with Aligildus may be suggested by Ammianus' reference to Aligildus and his fellow envoy Theolaifus as *tunc comites* (21.15.4). They are not mentioned again, so *tunc* may be a signal that one or both of them had been mentioned before. On this possible identification see Sabbah (1978), 226 and n. 24.

[157] See Sabbah (1978), 126–9.

mention.[158] As *magister officiorum* in the early 370s, he would have lived, like Ammianus, in Antioch.

- Syagrius, a *notarius*, was cashiered by Valentinian after being the only survivor of a disastrous military expedition (28.2.5–9). Ammianus mentions (5) his later prefecture (of Italy from 380 to 382) and consulate (in 381) and concludes *nec indicaturus gesta superfuit quisquam praeter Syagrium* ('nor did anybody survive to report these events save Syagrius', 9).[159]

The second group of those who have been identified as informants of Ammianus all have in common that they were Prefects of Rome.

- Hypatius was Prefect of Rome from late 378 or early 379; he later held the Prefecture of Italy in 382–3.[160] Ammianus opens Book 18 with a flattering reference to his joint consulship with his brother in 359, and later describes his misfortunes in the trials at Antioch in the early 370s, referring to *noster Hypatius*, 'our Hypatius', praising his character and mentioning his later prefectures (29.2.16).
- Ammianus describes how Aurelius Victor was given a governorship and a bronze statue by Julian (21.10.6). He praises his morals and refers to his much later Prefecture of Rome (388/9), and indicates that this is the Victor who wrote the *Liber de Caesaribus* by introducing him as *scriptor historicus*.[161] But John Matthews suggests that 'Ammianus' real interest in Aurelius Victor was surely that, being at Sirmium when Julian advanced upon it in 361, he was able to furnish information about the advance, and especially about the attack on nearby Bononia, which found the general defending it in an embarrassing state of unpreparedness'.[162]
- Praetextatus' Prefecture of Rome in 367 is described favourably (27.9.8–10); he seems to be indicated as a source for Julian's ostentatiously civil behaviour in Constantinople (22.7.1–6): 'Present at all these events was Praetextatus, a senator of outstanding character and old-fashioned seriousness, whom Julian had found in Constantinople

[158] *PLRE* 1, s.v. Sophronius 3. See Matthews (1989), 195. Sabbah (1978), 203, prefers to think that Ammianus is basing himself on an official report authored by Sophronius.

[159] *PLRE* 1, s.v. Syagrius 3; Sabbah (1978), 157–9.

[160] He may also have been *uicarius urbis Romae* in 363 (see *PLRE* 1, s.v. Hypatius 2 and 4).

[161] He does not so identify two other breviarists whom he mentions, Eutropius (29.1.36) and Festus (29.2.22–8), although there is more evidence of his having read their works than Victor's. Parallels with Eutropius are discussed below in Ch. 5 Section IV. See Mommsen (1881), 605–9, for dependency on Festus.

[162] Matthews (1989), 457–8.

by chance on a private matter, and on his own initiative put in charge of Achaia with the power of proconsul' (6).[163]

- The account of Eupraxius' prefecture in 374 must be presumed to have been lost in the lacuna of Book 29, but his appearances elsewhere as Valentinian's *magister memoriae* and *quaestor* are exemplary (27.6.14, 27.7.6, 28.1.25), which leads to conjecture that he was a source for these passages and Valentinian's reign more generally.[164]

The proposition that some, most or all of these individuals were informants of Ammianus is very likely. But it is rarely provable. Guy Sabbah, for example, proposes that Ammianus read the official reports of the two *notarii* Sophronius and Syagrius, and argues that Hypatius is nowhere designated as a source, rather than an individual with whom Ammianus was proud to have a relationship.[165] The deeds which Praetextatus witnessed were seen by many others; and other explanations for his appearance are possible than the indication of a source: an attempt (one of several, cf. 21.12.24, 23.1.4) to make something of Julian's disappointingly minimal relationship with pagan aristocrats from Rome?[166] And the fact that most of the individuals with connections to the city of Rome who have been identified as possible witnesses were Prefects of the City (Eutherius is the notable exception) could conceivably suggest that the historian's recurring interest in that office, rather than personal acquaintance with them, explains their appearance.

If we can assume that most of these individuals were contacts and informers of Ammianus, what does it tell us about the historian and the history?

About the historian, the answer is 'not a great deal'. Those characters in the history who seem likeliest to have been his acquaintances turn out to have been active front-line army officers, and

[163] *aderat his omnibus Praetextatus, / praeclarae indolis grauitatisque priscae senator, / ex negotio proprio forte repertus apud Constantinopolim, / quem arbitrio suo Achaiae proconsulari praefecerat potestate*. See Sabbah (1978), 230–1. Praetextatus' traditionalism is in stark contrast to Julian's somewhat cheap bids for popularity. This passage also implies a negative opinion of the upstart Senate of Constantinople: a man of Praetextatus' distinction would not have been a senator there.

[164] Sabbah (1978), 231–4, is nuanced but conjectural. On missing prefectures see Barnes (1998), 237–40.

[165] Sabbah (1978), 157–9, 203.

[166] See also the scepticism of Cameron (1964a), 22–3, on Ammianus' acquaintance with Praetextatus and Eupraxius.

to have had connections with Antioch and Rome – a reassuring but perhaps circular conclusion.[167] There is little suggestion that Ammianus' fortunes overlapped with theirs, with two exceptions. One, obviously, is Ursicinus (Ammianus' bias is discussed in Chapter 2 above) and another, far less obviously, is Hypatius.

There is evidence, albeit of a purely circumstantial nature, to support the suggestion that Ammianus moved to the West in Hypatius's entourage.[168] The implied familiarity with him (*noster Hypatius*) is unparalleled. Hypatius was summoned from Antioch by Gratian to become Prefect of Rome shortly after Adrianople (and before Theodosius' accession in January 379, judging by the fact that he is attested as prefect on 5 April).[169] He later served as Gratian's Praetorian Prefect of Italy. In between his two prefectures, in late 381, he is attested in Constantinople, perhaps as an emissary from Gratian to Theodosius.[170] All the evidence implies that Ammianus travelled from Antioch to Rome in the period between the mid 370s and the mid 380s. If Hypatius was a friend, and perhaps a literary patron, that might also go some way to explaining Ammianus' generally positive attitude to Gratian.[171]

[167] Among 'friends' of Ammianus with Antiochene connections we can list Ursicinus, Philagrius, Hypatius, Jovinianus (?), Sophronius, and (at a pinch) Teutomeres; two other individuals whom Ammianus is often assumed to have known are Alypius (*PLRE* 1, s.v. Alypius 4, 23.1.2, 29.1.44; but see Section 1 above) and Julius (*PLRE* 1, s.v. Iulius 2), the *magister militum* whose efficient mass murder of Gothic teenagers is praised in the last few sentences of the *Res Gestae* (31.16.8). Roman 'friends' would include the four prefects named above and Eutherius.

[168] First suggested by Gimazane (1889), 174–6. See also Sabbah (1978), 220, and, too assured, Barnes (1998), 122: 'it was surely his friend Hypatius who encouraged him to come to Rome and who introduced him to Roman society'.

[169] Cf. Libanius *Or.* 1.179–81.

[170] Greg. Naz. *Ep.* 96 and *PLRE* 1, s.v. Hypatius 4.

[171] Against the grain of my argument I will let conjecture go further. It has been suggested that Ammianus might have travelled to Constantinople with Hypatius in 381 (Barnes (1998), 122 n. 14). It has separately been suggested that Ammianus may have witnessed the Gothic leader Athanaric's funeral in Constantinople on January 381, an event after the formal ending of the *Res Gestae* to which the historian looks forward (27.5.10: see Matthews (1989), 16). Another breach of the temporal limits is the reference to Sophronius' Prefecture of Constantinople (26.7.2), which can provisionally be dated to 382 (*PLRE* 1, s.v. Sophronius 3). Ammianus is not inclined to refer to the tenure of that office, so a visit with Hypatius to the city in 381–2 might explain this unusual feature. This is a tenuous argument. The grand reception and funeral accorded to Athanaric was much publicised (presumably for propaganda purposes) and found its way into many sources. Vivid language alone cannot prove autopsy, and *ambitiosis exsequiis, ritu . . . nostro* ('with splendid rites, after our fashion') is not so vivid. Ammianus' point

This is very far from conclusive. Any effect that the friendship of Hypatius had on the history itself was limited. Ammianus' objections to over-zealous treason trials like those under Valens which led to Hypatius being exiled can be found throughout the work. One test of the strength of the historian's bias comes in the treatment of Hypatius' sister, the empress Eusebia, which is clearly contradictory. At her first appearance she intercedes for the young Julian (15.2.8); subsequently she entices his pregnant wife Helena to Rome and has her given a drug which leads her to miscarry (16.10.18). But the reference at her death is complimentary (21.6.4):

> eodem tempore Faustinam nomine sortitus est coniugem / amissa iam pridem Eusebia, / cuius fratres erant Eusebius et Hypatius consulares, / corporis morumque pulchritudine pluribus antistante / et in culmine tam celso humana, / cuius fauore iustissimo / exemptum periculis declaratumque Caesarem rettulimus Iulianum.
>
> At the same time he chose a wife called Faustina, having lost Eusebia somewhat earlier, whose brothers were the ex-consuls Eusebius and Hypatius. She had been outstanding in the beauty of her body and character, and in so lofty a peak was humane: I have told how through her most just support Julian was saved from danger and declared Caesar.

This, it has convincingly been argued, is present as a compliment not so much to Eusebia as to Hypatius.[172] But even if his respect for Hypatius is apparent so is the limited effect which this will have on his history. He is the only source to convey as bald fact information highly discreditable to his supposed friend and patron's sister.

As for what the list of possible informants tells us about Ammianus' historiographical technique: he explicitly states, and the mention of so many members of the governing class suggests, that interviews played a significant part in the collection of material for the history. This claim, importantly, seems to be backed up by

could equally have been attributed to a desire to mention a prominent pagan ceremony (which is how *ritu . . . nostro* should be interpreted) in an archetypally Christian city: see Kelly (2003) for the historian's hostility to Constantinople, at least partially on religious grounds.

[172] Tougher (2000); see also Barnes (1998), 121–2.

suggestions in the text when some individuals are mentioned. But it must equally be acknowledged that the names above are very far from a comprehensive list of his oral sources, most of whom are simply unidentifiable. Nor can we tell what proportion of his work was based on interviews with men *uersati in medio*, and what from documentary sources or other literary works.

I now move to look briefly at possible instances of Ammianus' personal bias. Tacitus claimed in the *Annals* to write without anger and partisanship, because of his distance from the events described (*sine ira et studio, quorum causas procul habeo*, *Ann.* 1.1.3); Ammianus, equally judgemental, was a contemporary of the events he described, and in some cases his anger and partisanship are clearly personal. His blatant favour to Ursicinus, as I suggested above, is paired with opposition to those who stood in his way. What we could think of as networks of bias, where individuals are admired or disdained because of their connections to other individuals, can be found throughout the work. Scholars have long pointed out the seesaw tendency in which the aggrandisement of Julian goes hand in hand with the denigration of those who stood in his way while alive, as well as his imperial successors after death. And the same process has been used to explain Ammianus' favour or hostility in other places. But the fact that his biases, unlike Tacitus', could have had a basis in personal experience, does not mean they did. Other explanations are available.

When one looks at the most prominent villains of the *Res Gestae*, for example, they are all safely dead; for the most part, they are individuals like Paul 'the Chain' or Maximinus, whose careers had ended in execution when the régime changed. The most remarkable criticisms are probably those of the Anician family and of its head Petronius Probus; the evidence seems to be that Ammianus was waiting for Probus' death, in about 389. But these attacks can also be paralleled in another author whose viewpoint can generally be expected to have been very different. Jerome's *Chronicle* (s.a. 372) contains a vitriolic attack on Probus' administration of Illyricum.[173]

[173] See also Barnes (1998), 117–19.

Timothy Barnes has attempted to survey Ammianus' attitudes to individuals by looking as a sample at the Prefects of Rome whose tenure of office he describes. He pinpoints a number of reasons for favourable treatment: Leontius he knew from Antioch, where he had been quaestor under Gallus; perhaps his father, who came from Berytus, had helped Ammianus' career? Ampelius was also known to Ammianus from Antioch, by Barnes' reckoning; Viventius had earlier acquitted friends of Julian of plotting against his successors; Maximus and Apronianus were Julian's appointees; Tertullus, the elder Symmachus, Praetextatus and Claudius were all notable pagans.[174] But these explanations of favour on closer inspection turn out to be arbitrary. Barnes cannot demonstrate that Ammianus had prior acquaintance with any given person, only that he could have met him; any particular personal or political motivation inferred for favourable treatment can only be one of an indefinite number possible. And though Barnes has elsewhere demonstrated Ammianus' disdain for Christianity beyond doubt, there are also problems with identifying religious attachment *tout court* as a reason for personal admiration or disapprobation. Ammianus attacks pagan prefects like Orfitus and Lampadius, and favours undoubted Christians like Leontius.[175] If one extends the survey to look at those later Prefects of Rome whom I identified as possible friends and sources of Ammianus, Aurelius Victor was almost certainly a polytheist, and Eupraxius' religion is unknown. But an admiring letter from Gregory of Nazianzus, and his sister's marriage to Constantius II, suggest that Hypatius was almost certainly a Christian.[176] Abundant other examples show that religious affiliation in itself cannot predict Ammianus' attitude, even if it seems likely that a survey of people of whom the historian approved and disapproved would have a disproportionate number of pagans in

[174] Barnes (1998), 113–15.

[175] Barnes (1998), 116–17, rightly argues that Ammianus' disdain for C. Ceionius Rufius Volusianus *signo* Lampadius could go back to the year 355, where Lampadius had been Praetorian Prefect and one of those whose plotting destroyed Silvanus. But though Ammianus was personally affected by the consequences of the conspiracy, Barnes seems unjustified in treating this as a personal, rather than a political, dislike. He speculates on whether a curious incident early in Lampadius' career (116) is indicative of a conversion to Christianity under Constantine. Other known biographical details render this unlikely, and for a persuasive interpretation see Ruggini (2003), 375–6.

[176] See Greg. Naz. *Ep.* 96, von Haehling (1978), Salzman (2002).

the former category and Christians in the latter (and perhaps there would be value in such a survey).[177]

Another bias, at least as consistent as that on religious grounds, can be observed, which applies both to the individuals whom I listed as possible contacts and to the cast-list of the *Res Gestae* as a whole. Of the five potential 'Roman' friends of Ammianus, all except Praetextatus were immigrants to the city. The evidence for those individuals whom he knew or might have known in Antioch again shows a bias towards outsiders. It might be tempting to interpret this as evidence of Ammianus' lack of sympathy with the Roman senatorial class, and adduce the Roman digressions as confirmation of this, and also to see confirmation that Ammianus was himself an immigrant to Antioch rather than a citizen. A conclusion that can be drawn with somewhat more security, I think, is that this tallies with the general bias of Ammianus' coverage in the history. A prosopographical study of the *Res Gestae* by Robert Frakes has listed the 485 contemporaries who are included in its pages. Frakes notes the dominance of civil administrators (161 or 32 per cent) and of soldiers (146 or 30 per cent). His inclination is to take this as evidence that Ammianus' intended audience consisted of Latin-speaking administrators; he notes the observations of Cameron, Rike and Matthews which link the completion of the *Res Gestae* to the first visit of Theodosius and his court to Italy in the late 380s.[178] The inference of audience from subject matter is not compelling (indeed, 'audience' seems to me an unhelpful concept both in historical and literary terms for an author as multivalent and manipulative as Ammianus, who in several places implies multiple audiences).[179] It is equally not compelling to infer from the predominance of civil administrators that they played a role as Ammianus' sources. Nevertheless, an argument in general terms can be made.

As I have already discussed, the fourth century is a period of remarkable social change. One of the main engines of this is the

[177] Barnes' instincts on religious prejudice in the treatment of Urban Prefects could perhaps be confirmed in other ways. For example, the treatment of Praetextatus echoes a number of themes in contemporary religious polemic.

[178] Frakes (2000a), 397–402.

[179] On the constructed audience in the *Res Gestae* see Ch. 4 below, pp. 179–83.

expansion of Roman government both in terms of the number and of the rewards of administrators. In consequence we can see the growth of an international bureaucratic class, of startling social and geographical diversity; some individuals managed to rise to a remarkable degree, like Aurelius Victor, born in Africa in the country of a humble and uneducated father, who became a provincial governor and later Prefect of Rome.[180] The extraordinary contrast between Herodian in the middle of the third century and Ammianus at the end of the fourth is testimony to this process of the Romanisation (and Latinisation) of provincial elites. Ammianus' history as a whole is conditioned by the existence of an international governing class. It would have been impossible for him to have such an in-depth knowledge of events in distant provinces without the papyrus-trail of the bureaucratic state or the physical mobility of administrators. Interestingly, for a former soldier, he is hostile to the political dominance of soldiers or their advancement in civilian ranks.[181]

Forty years ago, the instinct of scholars was to explain the curious questions of why Ammianus moved to Rome and why he wrote in Latin rather than Greek in terms of his admiration for members of the senatorial aristocracy in Rome; the current inclination is to see him in the context of the international bureaucracy. It should be emphasised that these are descriptions of amorphous and overlapping groups, that bureaucrats were often senators and vice versa. With those caveats, this shift in understanding seems broadly justifiable.

V Conclusion

Ancient biographers and critics of Vergil compensated for their ignorance by surmise. They extracted from his works the story that he had lost his farm in the confiscations of the 40s BC, that he loved the slave boy Alexander, or that he was prone to blushing.[182] There were problems in maintaining such interpretations consistently. 'In the character of Tityrus we should understand

[180] *De Caesaribus* 20.5; *PLRE* 1, s.v. Victor 13. [181] See e.g. 21.16.1, 22.3.8.
[182] See Horsfall (1995), Ch. 1, for a survey.

Vergil here', writes Servius (*ad Buc.* 1.1), 'not everywhere but only where the sense demands it.' Such biographical readings of ancient pastoral are not so much wrong as speculative and distracting, I would argue; and the same holds for other genres. Modern scholarship has treated Ammianus very much in the same way as ancient biographers treated Vergil, events described by the author being arbitrarily assumed to have affected him. The story of the historian's expulsion from Rome (Section III), like that of the confiscation of Vergil's lands, might conceivably be true, but there is no positive evidence for it, other inferences are possible, and more certain and more interesting things can be said about the text from which each story is inferred.[183]

Read with care, the text of the *Eclogues* can supply us with some biographical information about Vergil, for example, that Pollio rather than Maecenas or Octavian was his first patron.[184] Nor is it impossible to make deductions from his work about Ammianus, though they should be hedged about with qualifications.

He was an easterner, probably from Syria or Palestine, probably son of a man who had been a successful soldier or administrator. From youth, and perhaps from birth, he spent much of his time in Antioch. His width of knowledge of Latin literature is impressive, but we do not know whether it dates from his education; the evidence for knowledge of Greek literature is naturally less clear. He may well have known Syriac. He was in the army from the early 350s to 359 as a *protector domesticus*, and thereafter till at least 363, when he participated in the Persian debacle, and maybe much longer, though we do not know in which ranks. He travelled as a soldier in the 350s from Mesopotamia to Gaul and back; other travels to Egypt and to Greece cannot be so clearly dated. He was in Antioch in 371/2 and in Rome in the 380s. He finished the *Res Gestae* between 389 and 391. News of his work may belatedly have reached Libanius in Antioch and prompted him to write a letter, though it is equally likely that Libanius wrote to somebody quite different. Throughout his life he could have met countless soldiers and administrators, read official reports, or historical works by

[183] Perhaps there is more evidence for Vergil's defenestration. The theme is a persistent one and there may have been some limited generic precedents for bucolic disguises.

[184] An observation which was indeed made by a superior ancient scholar, Suetonius.

contemporaries. But the names of only a few of his oral or written sources can be identified.

When open statements about himself are not available (which is usually the case with Ammianus) the safer extrapolations are from a wide range of evidence. Such evidence can be cumulative (exemplified by the examination in Section I of references to Antioch from across the work instead of the dubious evidence of Libanius' letter) or comparative (examination of the careers of other known *protectores domestici*, as in Section II). I believe that it is methodologically preferable to look at the sort of people whom Ammianus appears to have known, rather than to focus exclusively on individuals (Section IV). But hitherto Ammianus scholarship has tended to prefer precise dubious conclusions about the author's person to objectively sounder conclusions about his text. Let me give one example, though others are possible, of a major biographical question only lightly touched on in this chapter.

Ammianus was for long seen as a religious neutral.[185] Although evidently a polytheist, he was willing to criticise the intolerance of Julian's teaching decree, or his excessive devotion to sacrifice; the absence of reference to Christianity or to religious conflict at points where it might seem expected could be attributed to lack of interest. This interpretation had long come under scattered attack: at individual points the omission of Christian themes seemed too pointed or in some way conscious, or the language of anti-Christian polemic could be identified, or apparent expressions of tolerance towards Christianity coincided with vigorous attacks on its adherents.[186] His exposure as an enemy of Christianity, albeit one of far greater subtlety and wit than others, is the most important advance in modern Ammianean scholarship; and the most comprehensive and cogent expression of it appears in Timothy Barnes' book of 1998. But Barnes' view of the historian contains one detail which has not been generally accepted, in that he proposes that Ammianus was brought up as a Christian and apostasised like his hero

[185] The view fundamentally maintained, with wrinkles, in Matthews (1989); for earlier bibliography see the summary in Rike (1987), 1–5.

[186] Among those who can be mentioned with honour in this area are Angliviel de la Beaumelle (1974), Elliot (1983) and Rike (1987).

Julian.[187] There are two main grounds of argument: that despite occasional use of elaborate periphrases, he is far more at home in the language of Christianity than he appears; and that for all his apparent resentment of Christianity there is occasionally a Christian underlay to his thought, the most cogent example of this being his praise of Julian's celibacy. (A third, lesser and altogether uncompelling argument, is the fact that we hear nothing of his career after Julian's death, which might suggest that he was punished for his apostasy.) Ammianus' apostasy from Christianity is certainly a possible explanation for these phenomena, but it is not the only one. One could equally conclude that he was a man brought up in a religiously mixed society, where Christian language and thought was prominent, and that he himself read Christian literature.[188] Praise of Julian's celibacy could either be seen as a response to Julian's own pride in it or be read as evidence that Christian modes of thought on sexual self-control percolated syncretistically into contemporary pagan thinking.[189] Nor, of course, was celibacy unknown as a pagan religious practice.

Barnes' biographical inference is useful to think with: it draws attention to the genuine and major contradiction inherent in the presentation of Christianity in the *Res Gestae*. But it is only one possibility among many. In rhetorical terms it was not a success. Reviewers could comment that seeing Ammianus as an apostate was an interesting possibility, and did not really have to engage with the compelling evidence for his consistent hostility to Christianity and its practitioners.[190]

I suggest that the time has come for scholarship on Ammianus to move away from the author. This is not because of any theoretical allegiance on my part, it is rather a practical response to circumstances: because the work itself obscures the author, because his portrait is for the most part intolerably conjectural, and because ideas as to his character tend to prejudice interpretation.

[187] Barnes (1998), *passim*, but see esp. 49–53, 79–94, 121.

[188] On his possible allusion to a Church historian see the Appendix below.

[189] See Seager (1999b). The latter conclusion is not improbable: see for example the polytheist Aurelius Victor's praise of the Christian-friendly emperor Philip for his attacks on male prostitution (28.6–7).

[190] See e.g. Averil Cameron's and Michael Whitby's reviews of (1999) and (2000) respectively.

One of the reasons why Ammianus' apparent religious neutrality so gulled his readers was the perception, carefully nurtured by the text and repeated in scholarship, that he was a plain-speaking soldier. Could 'an officer and a gentleman', as Mackail called him, have been so underhand as to manipulate the historical record against Christianity?[191] (It is likely, incidentally, that such a characterisation has also assisted the tendency to depreciate his Latinity and literary scholarship.) The assumption that he was a bitter apostate offers an obvious explanation for his hostility to Christianity, but sits uneasily with the fact that his hostility is very subtle – to the extent that many otherwise observant readers have not seen it at all. The alternative is that a fourth-century pagan possessed a considerable knowledge of the Christian religion, that he disapproved of it, particularly when influential in politics, and that he exercised his disapproval of politicised Christianity in large part through dissimulation of what he knew. This is an equally plausible and perhaps more interesting explanation.

In the chapter which follows, and the remainder of this book, the focus of interpretation will turn away from the real or imagined experience and autopsy of the author towards the rich, diverse and meaningful textual relationships which the text displays with earlier authors and traditions.

[191] Mackail (1920), 106.

PART II

THE ALLUSIVE HISTORIAN

CHAPTER 4

AMMIANUS' INTERTEXTUALITY

The preceding chapters have been dedicated to examining those parts of the *Res Gestae* where Ammianus Marcellinus includes passages of autobiography, or passages which have been so interpreted. A surfeit of speculative biographical attention has attached to these sections in the past; we have also seen that the rich and variegated allusions which tend to be prominent in such passages have suffered a corresponding neglect. The shift from the biographical interpretation is now complete; instead of being a constant motif and interpretative tool, allusion will henceforth take the central role. The following text will attempt to survey the nature, extent, methods and meaning of allusion in Ammianus.

Huge numbers of allusions have been identified in Ammianus by successive generations of philological scholarship, without ever being satisfactorily melded into historical scholarship. The range as well as the number is remarkable. Homer, Hesiod, Greek lyric poets, Herodotus, Thucydides, Xenophon, Plato, Isocrates, Polybius, Plautus, Terence, Cicero, Caesar, Sallust, Livy, Justin, Tacitus, Florus, Apuleius, Vergil, Horace, Ovid, Lucan, Silius Italicus, Statius, Juvenal, Valerius Maximus, the elder Pliny, Gellius, Solinus, Herodian, Plotinus, contemporary orators and breviarists in both languages.[1] Allusions, and other features which send the reader to an external text or texts, like quoted *sententiae*, *exempla*, and historical references, are frequently found in pairs or groups and the combination (and often contamination) of Latin and Greek authors and examples is a particularly notable feature.[2] This is

[1] Hertz (1874a), 258: like the Pharisee, Ammianus thanks God he is not like other people: 'er hatte viel, sehr viel gelesen . . .' Hertz lists his estimations of Ammianus' reading at 265–6. For another list see Hagendahl (1921), 1–2; of works detailing a multiplicity of allusions to various authors one might pick out Fletcher (1937) and Owens (1958). I detail those responsible for the identification of allusions in the notes below, both as an act of *pietas* and because it is potentially interesting in its own right.

[2] Covered insightfully by Classen (1972).

not to say that all allusions are blatant. It is often necessary to ask whether an allusion is really an allusion, and even when a textual link is certain there can be problems. In some quotations from named authors (Greek lyric poets, for example), Ammianus behaves like a true name-dropper, and sometimes, like many name-droppers, shows familiarity with little beyond the name and the quotation. Scholars sometimes doubt the reality of Ammianus' learning, and though they are in general wrong, they are not entirely without evidence. More broadly speaking, the voraciousness of Ammianus' intertextuality is characterised by the way in which he swallows up features of both the Latin and the Greek historiographical traditions to produce a Latin history with the full technical vocabulary and with Hellenising digressions on learned subjects.

Relationships with other authors naturally play a major part in assessments of Ammianus' style. He has been given less literary than historical attention, and literary attention has been warped by disdain for 'unclassical' elements, especially in his language. Negativity has been found not least among historians who have written on Ammianus: perceived literary incompetence has been almost a guarantee of honesty.[3] (The view is neatly reversed by T. D. Barnes: he impugns Ammianus' veracity but exalts him as having 'secured a permanent place in the select group of really great historians' because he exhibits 'the creative and imaginative powers of a novelist'.)[4] When it comes to intertextuality, Ammianus has been scoured at great length though by no means exhaustively for allusions; early studies often emphasised the mechanical nature and irrelevance of some 'borrowings'.[5] Despite some sympathetic

[3] There have always been exceptions, such as Stein's much quoted estimation of Ammianus as the greatest literary genius between Tacitus and Dante (see below p. 176); two further bold estimations of Ammianus' quality can be found in Seager (2004), 159 ('[Rome's] greatest historian'), and Mitchell (2007), 20 ('. . . has a claim to be the finest Latin historian of any period'). But see Thompson (1947), xi, with the claim that Ammianus has been neglected in comparison to Sallust, Livy and Tacitus because of his literary failings, or recently, in a perceptive article, Fornara quoted below (p. 163). See also the tempered if critical remarks of Rowell (1964), 33 (= (1967), 293), quoted below p. 261.

[4] Barnes (1998), 198.

[5] Exemplified by Schneider (1879), on whom see further Section III. Blockley (1996), 461, remarks: 'furthermore [the] authors [of studies of parallels] . . . were not so much interested in the uses to which Ammianus put the borrowed words or phrases, but rather with the process of borrowing itself. Thus, when the phrase in Ammianus differs from the original (as is often the case), the tendency was not to ask why Ammianus had introduced

modern studies,[6] the stain has not been removed, and a perceptive reader could still come to the judgement that

> the problem with Ammianus . . . concerns not the authenticity of his knowledge . . . but the sanity and balance of his aesthetic and literary principles . . . Ammianus suffered from the illusion (not uncommon in the fourth century) that his history, in order to qualify as a literary production, needed to be a mosaic containing precious older material.[7]

There is much to disagree with in this view. First, the implied opposition between history and literature. Secondly, the metaphor of the mosaic, to which I will return, and which appears to imply that the allusions are irrelevant to the effect of the picture, mere *tesserae*.[8] Thirdly, the implicit rejection of the aesthetic of an entire age. The most eloquent attempts to deal with such perceptions tend to stress the different aesthetic of the age, very often using the analogy to late-antique art: Michael Roberts came up with the apt name of the 'Jewelled Style'.[9] But although the comparison to contemporary works of widely divergent genres can be helpful, my investigations also suggest that Ammianus can be understood with the same interpretative apparatus as earlier Latin literature. Fixing too much emphasis on the 'late-antique' elements may obscure this possibility, and instead accept an unjustifiable periodisation.

It will be evident from the previous chapters, one aim of which has been to relocate intertextuality and allusions into debate on Ammianus, that I do not conceive of allusions as being exclusively discrete and decorative linguistic features. They can undermine or reinforce political arguments. And since my views are at variance with others' assessments of Ammianus' intertextuality (or at least have a different emphasis), I shall need to give consideration to previous conclusions on the subject, which will doubtless seem overlong to some readers.

Two of my disagreements with received opinion, then, are that the meaningfulness and the (sometimes political) relevance of

> the change and for what purpose. Rather, the assumption was made that Ammianus has borrowed either to display his learning (which should imply no change from the original) or to help in the construction of a satisfactory Latin sentence (which he could not otherwise do).'

[6] Fontaine (1977), Salemme (1989), Blockley (1996). [7] Fornara (1992b), 438.
[8] In fact Fornara is in practice willing to argue for the relevance of some allusions.
[9] Roberts (1989).

Ammianus' intertextuality has been understated, and that he has been placed in a late-antique context (whether one interprets that positively or not), rather than in the mainstream of Latin literature. A third point of difference is that individual allusions and general intertextual relationships have been understood too narrowly. Scholars have been overly concerned with identifying and maximising the individual allusions and the general relationship of Ammianus with one other (more classical) author; an allusion may be disproved or complicated by allusions to other passages or other authors, but these are ignored. In general the presence of *contaminatio* (the melding of two or more source-texts into a single new passage) has been very much underestimated. Proof of allusion has often been focused too strictly on lexical similarities, which are not invariably convincing. The point and the function of allusions is usually ignored. Other types of textual influence have been passed over. 'Sources' have been seen as a completely different category, though often treated with equal simplicity and reductionism.[10]

In this chapter I shall begin with the problems of definition, looking both at the language which can be used to define intertextuality/allusion, and at how we separate those categories from other sorts of resemblances (Section I). It will emerge that what scholars between the seventeenth and twentieth centuries were looking for when they identified intertextual connections between Ammianus and his predecessors affected how they understood what they found: they tended to look for formal verbal similarities rather than meaningful ones and so created the idea that the historian used allusion as a linguistic crutch, a secret game, or a hoarding of beloved fragments (Section II). Though the first two sections will have introduced several examples of intertextual relationships, a detailed survey will then begin: in Section III I look at the unpromising subject of whether individual choices of vocabulary can be meaningfully allusive; in Section IV at seven characteristic types of Ammianean allusion. The argument that his manner of allusion

[10] For the case of Livy and Tacitus see Section I below, pp. 175–8; for more detailed discussion of source relationships see Ch. 5 below.

is characteristically late-antique is, at the least, a simplification (Section v). And the potential meaningfulness of his allusion will be examined in the following chapters (5–7) through study of use of sources, *exempla*, and internal allusions.

I Defining intertextuality and allusion

Definition and indeed differentiation of intertextuality and allusion is called for, as well as consideration of how to identify them. Although identification of sources and textual relationships is a general strength of Latin studies, most, and to my knowledge the best, discussions of Latin allusion and intertextuality are concerned with poetry, especially with Vergil. This is a reflection of the extraordinary, multi-faceted, and visible intertextuality of the poems in question, rather than a lack of allusiveness in other Latin literature.[11] It is therefore appropriate to acknowledge that my thoughts have in large part been stimulated by the likes of Gian Biagio Conte, Richard Thomas, R. O. A. M. Lyne and Stephen Hinds. My divergence from traditional approaches to Ammianus' intertextuality should therefore cause no surprise.

The choice between intertextuality and allusion is ideological for some. Intertextuality is certainly the more modish word, but the state of 'Cold War' that is alleged to have subsisted between the users of the two terms is somewhat overstated, and they differ sufficiently in meaning to justify the use of both.[12] Rather as physicists understand light as both a particle and a wave, so meaningful similarities between texts can be understood both as a natural and intrinsic feature of language, and as a purposed literary trope; and since any given textual similarity may not be easily placed in this continuum, it seems absurd not to use both terms.

[11] Though some scholars of other genres are reluctant to stress allusion in the same way. See for example the constant negativity of F. D. R. Goodyear in his commentaries on Tacitus *Ann.* 1–2 (Goodyear (1972), (1981)), including the very obvious Vergilian allusion adduced in Ch. 1, p. 16 above (Tacitus *Ann.* 1.61.2 ~ Vergil *Aen.* 12.35–6. He omits to remark on two blatant allusions to famous opening words: Tacitus *Ann.* 1.12.4 ~ Lucan 1.1; *Ann.* 1.13.4 ~ Cicero *Cat.* 1.1.

[12] Kennedy (1995), 86, quoted by Hinds (1998), 17.

Intertextuality covers a wider range of processes and I shall argue below that 'Ammianus' intertextuality' can usefully describe a unified artistic process which speaking of allusion might lead one to ignore. In general, however, I describe the simple process as allusion, though the term has many detractors. The association with playfulness led one traditional philologist, Richard Thomas, to propose 'reference' instead, with overtones of 'sending the reader back'; the author is seen as marshalling his texts with serious deliberation, rather than playing with the overwhelming legacy of tradition. The 'art of reference' has not caught on, even in Thomas' own subsequent articles.[13] Enough to say that I speak of allusion without implying concealment or playfulness. 'Allusion' is conveniently precise and elegant (at least compared to 'intertext').[14] It also has the advantage of limitation: it can be defined as the way a text redeploys or is influenced by an earlier text; the conscious or at the very least subconscious use of words, ideas or associations from an earlier text in a way that can be recognised by an outsider. Allusions imply authorial intention (defined loosely), and depend on the sharpness, or the imagination, of their readers.

What is sufficient for something to be an allusion? The two texts usually require some similarity or opposition of ideas, and, by an unwritten convention, connections between at least two identical or related words in each text, though a single word may suffice if particularly rare, and more evidence may be desirable if the words in question are relatively common.[15]

In Ammianus' second Roman digression, in a satirical context, there is common subject matter at 28.4.24 with a passage in Juvenal *Satire* 6 (572–81, esp. 572–8) about Roman aristocrats who use

[13] Thomas (1986), 172 n. 8 (= (1999), 115 n. 8): 'I hope it will become clear in the pages to come that Virgil is not so much 'playing' with his models but constantly intends that his reader be 'sent back' to them, consulting them through memory or physically, and that he then return and apply his observation to the Virgilian text; the word *allusion* has implications far too frivolous to suit this purpose.' He is subsequently less dogmatic (Thomas (1999), 1–2).

[14] I should note that I occasionally use 'allusion' to refer not to individual allusions ('intertexts') but to allusiveness ('intertextuality') more generally: this usage should be obvious from the context.

[15] Allusions with no word in common at all are a possibility: cf. for example Vergil *Georg.* 3.481 to Lucretius 6.1140 (Thomas (1986), 180).

astrology to check the advisability of performing the most mundane activities:

28.4.24 Multi apud eos
negantes esse superas potestates
in caelo, / nec in publicum
prodeunt / nec prandent nec
lauari arbitrantur se cautius
posse, / antequam **ephemeride**
scrupulose sciscitata didicerint, /
ubi sit uerbi gratia signum
Mercurii, / uel quotam cancri
sideris partem / polum discurrens
obtineat luna.

Many of them who deny that there are higher powers in the heavens, neither appear in public nor dine out nor think they can sensibly visit a bathhouse until, having diligently scrutinised the **almanack**, they have learnt the position of, say, Mercury or what part of the sign of Cancer the moon has reached on her journey through the sky.

Juvenal 6.572–8
illius occursus etiam uitare memento,
in cuius manibus ceu pinguia sucina tritas
cernis **ephemeridas**, quae nullum
consulit et iam
consulitur, quae castra uiro patriamque
petente
non ibit pariter numeris reuocata
Thrasylli.
ad primum lapidem uectari cum placet,
hora
sumitur ex libro . . .

Remember too to avoid her approach, in whose hand you see, as if precious amber, worn **almanacks**: she consults nobody and is now consulted herself, when her husband sets off for camp or for home she won't go along if she's held back by Thrasyllus' calculations. When she wants to go to the first milestone, the time is chosen from the book . . .

The single word shared by the two passages, *ephemeris* (in the sense of an astrological almanack), is extremely rare. Pliny uses it (*NH* 29.9), but glosses it with the adjective *mathematicus*.[16] The rarity of the word and its unique meaning at this point virtually guarantee the allusion.[17]

More typical allusions may be seen in a neighbouring passage, in which some of the difficulties raised by identification of allusions are exemplified:[18]

[16] That it was not a normal usage is indicated by Juvenal's scholiasts, S2: *membrana mathematicorum* [S3 *uel actos diurnos*]. The normal meaning in Latin is diary; for example, it is so used by the *HA* for various invented sources.

[17] First identified in 1609 by Lindenbrog ad 28.4.24. It is worth noting here that though I sometimes attempt to reflect in my English translations the rarity of the Latin word in question, this is not always possible. Other Juvenalian allusions include 14.6.9 *sudant sub ponderibus lacernarum* ~ Juvenal 1.26–30; 14.6.13 ~ Juvenal 1.97–99; 27.3.5 ~ Juvenal 3.106–7; 29.2.18 ~ Juvenal 6.221.

[18] Both these allusions are identified and discussed by Salemme (1989), 15–16.

28.4.23 alius cum dignitate licet mediocri **ceruice tumida** gradiens / notos antea **obliquato** contuetur **aspectu**, / ut post captas Syracusas existimes reuerti Marcellum.

28.4.23 Another with an official post, however middling, walks **with swelling throat** and looks on previous acquaintances **with sideways glance**, so that you'd think Marcellus was returning after taking Syracuse.

Cicero *Vatin.* 4 repente enim te tamquam serpens e latibulis oculis eminentibus, inflato collo, **tumidis ceruicibus** intulisti.
Apuleius *Met.* 3.2 **obliquato** tamen **aspectu** rem admirationis maximae conspicio.

Cicero *Vatin.* 4 For suddenly you rushed in like a snake from its lurking-place with eyes standing out, with neck blown up, **with swelling throat**.
Apuleius *Met.* 3.2 But **with sideways glance** I catch sight of a thing of great remark.

There should be little doubt about *obliquato aspectu*, 'with sideways glance'. The participle is very rare outside Apuleius, who has it five times (twice in the combination *obliquata ceruice*). The related pairing *obliquo aspectu* is found at 28.1.45, presumably echoing Apuleius *Met.* 1.12. In 28.1.37 can be found an allusion to the immediately preceding chapter of the *Metamorphoses*.[19] Another *iunctura* from Apuleius is found two sentences before this passage (28.4.21).[20] If there is a difficulty, it is identifying what point if any the allusion brings. It risks over-interpretation to see reference to the Apuleian context of the vivid phrase: the phrase follows Lucius' arrest at the Festival of Laughter, when out of the corner of his eyes he sees people laughing at him and cannot comprehend why. Identifying a point to the Ciceronian allusion (*ceruice tumida* ~ *tumidis ceruicibus*, 'swelling throat') is much easier: it is one of Ammianus' animal comparisons, and the man conceals a snake beneath his haughty posture.[21] The change from plural to singular is regular: Ammianus will very often be found to alter the number, to change superlative to positive and vice versa, to negate or remove negation.[22] But a problem arises

[19] 28.1.37 *heiulando casus . . . eadem replicando* ('bemoaning their fates . . . repeating the same'), 27.12.7 *heiulante . . . muliere . . . fortunas* ('while the woman bemoaned her fortunes'), Apuleius *Met.* 3.1 *haec identidem mecum replicans fortunas meas heiulabam* ('I kept constantly repeating this to myself and bemoaning my fortunes'). Identified in Owens (1958), 210.

[20] *amicitiae . . . sociales* ('friendships . . . [which are] companionable'), cf. Apuleius *Met.* 5.28 (Hertz (1874a), 274).

[21] Salemme (1989), 16.

[22] Hertz (1874a), 296, and see below p. 200.

in that three other authors have used the *iunctura*. Lucan (9.701) has *tumida ceruice* and Silius (6.233) *tumidis ceruicibus*. Both are authors whom Ammianus had read, and, satisfyingly, both use it of snakes; he alluded to Lucan's catalogue of snakes in 22.15.27.[23] But in Florus (*Epit.* 2.21.12), whom Ammianus had also read, *tumidae ceruices* refers to the haughty necks of conquered peoples.

The two allusions seem correct at first sight, but that to Apuleius offers an apparently unimpeachable demonstration that Ammianus has read and alluded in a way in which the Ciceronian allusion, for all that the ease of applicability is greater, does not. Three of the four writers who have used *tumida ceruix* use it of snakes, which makes an allusion to one or more of them (which of them is unknowable) appealing as well as likely, and preserves meaningfulness if not certainty. Certain identification is therefore often a function of the rarity of vocabulary. Ammianus has a good deal of rare vocabulary, which may in part account for how many allusions have been identified; ease of identification is not invariably consistent with ease of interpretation.[24] There are of course factors other than vocabulary involved in identification: the sound of words, their order, or their position in the text (so in verse metrical position or line number,[25] in prose placement at the start or end of a book, a section, or a speech).[26]

[23] Cf. Lucan 9.704–5 (Valesius ad 22.15.27) See den Boeft *et al.* for further allusions in the same chapter. For allusions to Silius cf. e.g. Hagendahl (1921), 15 n. 1.

[24] Cf. Wills (1998), 277: 'In general, there seem to be two approaches to these questions: formal and thematic. The formal approach tries to establish the multitude of overlapping features in the two texts and the infrequent combination of these features outside of the two texts . . . The second or thematic approach asks how our interpretation benefits from pairing two texts . . . In the end these two approaches must go together.'

[25] A well-known example is the way in which Vergil refers to the Euphrates six lines from the end of *Georgics* 1 and 4, and *Aeneid* 8, following Ἀσσυρίου ποταμοῖο μέγας ῥόος six lines from the close of Callimachus' second *Hymn* (2.108). Identified by Scodel and Thomas (1984).

[26] Cf. Ammianus' use of Tacitus for transitional phrases at the beginning of books: *struebat iam fortuna in diuersa parte terrarum initia causasque imperio . . . Vespasianus . . .* ('Fortune was now arranging in a different part of the earth the beginnings and causes of empire . . . Vespasian . . .', Tacitus *Hist.* 2.1.1); *dum haec in diuersa parte terrarum Fortunae struunt uolubiles casus, Iulianus . . .* ('While the mutable phases of Fortune arranged these events in a different part of the earth, Julian . . .', 22.1.1). Both come in contexts of civil war. See Conte (1986), 35, on the particularly allusive character of beginnings.

The two allusions also show how identification of allusions is easier if the alluding author is known from other allusions to have read the text supposedly alluded to. Cumulative evidence makes it easier to argue that Ammianus alludes in a particular place to Vergil than to Persius, for example.[27] There are other ways in which evidence can be cumulative: allusions to the same author in the vicinity, or allusions elsewhere to the same passage, as with the example of Apuleius above. Allusion is a usefully decisive term: to state that Ammianus has alluded to Caesar, but nowhere with any certainty to Lucretius, is a decisive assertion of literary affiliation: it might be disproved but is fundamentally objective. But in one sense, the passages that prove that Ammianus has read a particular author may not seem allusive. The examples above show that the possibility of reading some point to allusions is important to their identification. To put it in Thomas' words, interpretability is one of the criteria for 'determining when a reference is really a reference'.[28] In practice both the certainty of interpretation and the depth of meaning involved are variable. The purpose of allusions will often be far from clear, though they will not seem equal in obscurity to all readers.[29] Ammianus probably has more allusions to more generically divergent texts than most other authors, and purpose will be harder to divine.

Some may find my opinion that the office-holder's *tumida ceruix* is an allusion overstated, when there are four texts (Cicero, Lucan, Silius, Florus) to which it could conceivably allude. Suppose that we possessed a few more texts which referred to swelling throats, a *tumida ceruix*, or a *tumidum collum*, or an individual *tumidus ceruice(m)*. Suppose that they did not refer to snakes, but offered

[27] I know of no evidence which suggests that Ammianus had read Persius.

[28] Thomas (1986), 174 (= (1999), 116).

[29] A *locus classicus* is adduced by Lyne (1994), 187–93: when Aeneas' *inuitus, regina, tuo de litore cessi* ('unwilling, queen, I parted from your shore', Vergil *Aen.* 6.460) echoes Catullus' *Lock of Berenice* (*inuita, o regina, tuo de uertice cessi*, 'unwilling, o queen, I parted from your head', 66.39), many scholars have refused to allow an allusion. Reference to Alexandrian court poetry has often been considered an unacceptable frivolity for Aeneas' words to Dido in the underworld. Lyne provides an exemplary elucidation of the allusion in that case, and moves on to arguing for the use of 'intertextuality' rather than 'allusion'; intertexts may evade the comprehension of scholars, but should not therefore evade their consideration. For further study of the same allusion see Wills (1998), esp. 287–302.

either an alternative implication, or simply muddied the waters. It would then be considerably harder to call Ammianus' usage an allusion. Or suppose that we possessed a dozen other texts referring to the swollen necks of venomous snakes. This would be a cliché, and many scholars would find it hard to call it an allusion. This may be hypothesis, but is no fantasy: most classical literature has perished.

Let me give an example of such border territory in Ammianus, in a persistent metaphor of branding, seemingly derived from Cicero:

22.12.1 gentem asperrimam per sexaginta ferme annos inussisse orienti caedum et direptionum monumenta saeuissima.
29.5.42 ubi saeua inusserat monumenta facinorum pessimorum.
29.6.8 magnas inussisset rei publicae clades.
30.5.3 inusta rei publicae uulnera.

Cicero *Fam.* 1.9.15 monumentum uero senatus hostili nomine et cruentis inustum litteris esse passi sunt.
Sest. 17 uulnera . . . inusta rei publicae.
Phil. 2.117 malis quae . . . rei publicae sunt inusta.[30]

22.12.1 That this most harsh nation over nearly sixty years had branded on the east the most savage memorials of their slaughters and pillagings.
29.5.42 Where he had branded savage memorials of his wicked crimes.
29.6.8 He would have branded great disasters on the republic.
30.5.3 The wounds branded on the republic.

Cicero *Fam.* 1.9.15 Indeed they suffered a monument belonging to the senate to be branded with the name of public enemy, and that in bloody letters.
Sest. 17 The wounds branded on the republic.
Phil. 2.117 The ills which are branded on the republic.

One might justly see in 30.5.3 an allusion to Cicero *Sest.* 17; one might see in 22.12.1 or 29.5.42 allusion to *Fam.* 1.9.15, but the passages in Ammianus are more similar to each other than they are to Cicero. Should one see a network of allusions or rather see a metaphorical use of *inurere* (originally Ciceronian) which appeals to Ammianus to the extent of being a cliché of his style?[31] How meaningful is the allusion?

[30] Allusions identified by Michael (1874), 27, 30, and Owens (1958), 103. Cf. also Cicero *Cat.* 2.20, *Mur.* 8, *Verr.* 2.163, *Phil.* 11.38.
[31] Cf. e.g. 14.5.6.

Sometimes the debatable aspect in such cases is simply whether the allusion is good enough. Is Ammianus' complaint at Taurus' exile an allusion to Plautus' *Amphitruo*?

22.3.4 quid enim deliquit, / si ortum turbinem ueritus, / ad tutelam principis sui confugit?	Plautus *Amphitruo* 817 quo ego tibi deliqui, si, quoi nupta sum, tecum fui?[32]
For what was his sin, if, fearing the whirlwind which had arisen, he fled to the protection of his prince?	For how did I sin against you, if I was with you, to whom I am wed?

The question (*quo* and *quid* meaning the same here) is followed by the same verb, and the conditional protasis, both times in the perfect. A rhetorical question is an unusual device for Ammianus' narrative, and this is the only case in the *Res Gestae* of a conditional clause with perfect indicative in both protasis and apodosis. Ammianus refers to the flight of Taurus, Praetorian Prefect of Illyricum, from Julian's advance back towards Constantius in the East. In Plautus, Jupiter has disguised himself as Amphitruo to sleep with Alcmena, who defends herself against her husband's accusations. The allusion is unexpected, but not unfitting. Taurus' confusion as to who was his *princeps* is like that of Alcmena as to who was her husband. Taurus as pleading wife is an engaging comparison. What may clinch the allusion is Ammianus' fondness for casting the officials of Constantius in the language of Plautine comedy.[33]

[32] Allusion observed by den Boeft *et al.* ad 22.3.4.

[33] Though I discuss some of these instances elsewhere, it will be as well to collect them in one place. 14.5.7 (Paulus) *perquisitor maleuolus* ('ill-willed scrutineer') cf. Plautus *Stichus* 385 *maliuoli, perquisitores auctionum, perierint* ('Those ill-willed men, scrutineers of auctions, can go to hell'); 15.3.5 (Mercurius) *ut clam mordax canis interna saeuitia / summissius agitans caudam* ('like a dog that's secretly a biter and savage on the inside who placidly wags his tail') cf. *Bacchides* 1146 *clam mordax canis* ('a dog that's secretly a biter'); 15.13.3 *hunc Prosper adaequitabat / pro magistro equitum agente etiamtum in Galliis militem regens, / abiecte ignauus / et, ut ait comicus, arte despecta furtorum rapiens propalam* ('Prosper was fully on the same level (he commanded the soldiers in place of the *magister equitum* who was still serving in Gaul): he was a wretched coward and, as the comic poet says, despised the skill involved in thefts and plundered openly') cf. *Epidicus* 12 *minu' iam furtificus sum quam antehac – quid ita? – rapio propalam.* ('"I'm less a sneak-thief than before." "How so?" "I plunder openly"'); 18.7.7 (Sabinianus) *quasi fundata cum mortuis pace nihil formidans* ('as if he'd established a peace with the dead, fearing nothing') cf. *Mostellaria* 514 *nihil ego formido, pax mihi est cum mortuis* ('I fear nothing, I am at peace with the dead.') (n. 62 below); 19.12.13 (Paulus) *quasi e promptuaria cella* cf. *Amphitruo* 156 *quasi e promptaria cella* ('as though from a storeroom').

In this case there is verbal similarity, but it could well be fortuitous. The existence of similar texts on the same lines does not in this case appear to intervene, but is another of the problems that may beset allusions. The allusion can cope with some complication, such as when two or more texts are alluded to (*contaminatio*), but it finds increasing difficulties against this and other weaker vessels. To cover these and to cover much else, a broader term than allusion or reference is useful.[34]

'Intertextuality' is a neologism, which some will associate with the worst jargoning introspection of the Academy. Gian Biagio Conte defines it attractively as a 'phenomenon by which, in literature, each new text enters into a network of relations with other, already written texts (recalling them, imitating them, parodying them, in short, presupposing them)'.[35] The author is occluded, and a process or a phenomenon takes his place – for Conte intertextuality is a feature of language comparable to metaphor.[36]

The problem, and advantage, of 'allusion' was its narrowness, and the opposite is the case for 'intertextuality'.[37] Almost anything can be defined as a text,[38] and the number and variety of relationships between texts is perhaps infinite. It is impossible to cut down on these and make sense of textual relationships without applying personal judgement. This may mean not only the exercise of one's training and discretion but also the imposition of one's personal deafnesses or ignorance. As well as lacking the pretence of understanding the author's intentions, 'intertextuality' does not attempt to bestow privilege on either the source-text or the receiving text.[39]

[34] This is the central thrust of Hinds (1998). He speaks (xii) of the 'excitingly enlarged universe of intertexts', words quoted with some sarcasm by Thomas (1999), 6 n. 10. It is worth remembering that the chances of survival have interposed. Not only have we lost many allusions, but, conversely, if we had more of Latin literature, more apparent allusions would perhaps be judged chance resemblances.

[35] Conte (1994), 812, quoted by Thomas (1995), 197 (= (1999), 229).

[36] Conte (1986), esp. 53–69.

[37] Thomas (1999), 2: 'I have adopted the now conventional term *intertextuality*, precisely because it implies less than any other term and functions as a larger receptacle for the processes involved in these studies.'

[38] Thomas (1995), 197 (= (1999), 229), supplements Conte with the point that text means not only the written but also the visual and the oral: 'Indeed it will be my thesis that intertextuality is a phenomenon whose workings may be observed in all media and in all registers of expression.'

[39] Intertextuality could also define the influence of a later text on (the reception and interpretation of) an earlier one. See Lyne (1994), Appendix 3 (200–1).

Words such as 'recall', 'imitate', 'parody' (Conte's suggested synonyms) characterise the lexical range covered by 'intertextuality' (one might add 'echo', 'cite', 'invoke'); but these, unlike 'intertextuality', hint imprecisely that the reader can define precisely the relationship of the texts. Perhaps particularly troublesome in this context are 'borrowing', and the German noun *Benutzung* ('use'). To say that Ammianus borrows from or uses authors suggests little more than a form of automatic writing, and in his case is perhaps to be linked to the usual prejudice that his Greekness weakens his Latinity. It is useful, therefore, to have a word which can be used undaunted by a multiplicity of texts, or by multiform textual relationships.

There are also various other textual relationships, of which some, whilst allusive, might not normally be called allusion: the umbrella of intertextuality will more easily cover them. The quotation is an obvious example, an acknowledged and ideally unaltered rendering of another text. *Exemplum* is another form of intertextuality, particularly prominent in Ammianus' text. An *exemplum* alludes to historical information usually contained in a range of texts, though an individual source-text can often be identified. Some *exempla* consist of memorable sayings (Blockley calls them '*sententiae* in the form of quotations'),[40] usually attributed to a person, but again often alluding to a range of texts (see on *exempla* Ch. 6 below). It is also important not to neglect the potential significance of internal textual relationships.[41] When it is said of Petronius Probus, the aristocratic Praetorian Prefect, that he was 'timid before the bold, and lofty against the timid' (*interdum timidus ad audaces, / contra timidos celsior*, 27.11.2), it echoes what was said of the crocodile in the excursus on Egypt (22.15.20): 'and the crocodile is a bold monster to those who run away, but when it senses somebody bold, exceptionally timid' (*audax tamen crocodilus monstrum fugacibus, / ubi audacem senserit, timidissimum*).[42] The comparison anticipates the famous image in the next sentence of Probus out of office as a 'fish out of water'. If this description of Probus were not an internal allusion, but rather an allusion to Solinus, Ammianus'

[40] Blockley (1975), 195, cf. 166.
[41] See notably Woodman (1979) and (1988), 176–9, on Tacitus' internal intertextuality.
[42] Allusion identified by Fontaine (1996) (= introduction to Budé III), lix and n. 56.

source on the crocodile and the other fauna of Egypt (it is not),[43] it would probably go unrecognised. As the earlier parts of the same text can generally be presumed to have been read by any reader, internal allusions (intra-textuality) will have particular significance and will deserve particular attention (see Ch. 7 below). A further category: the use of written sources of information, such as Solinus in the digressions, or Herodian for early third-century history, or panegyrics for details of the history of his own time – what would traditionally come under the heading of 'source criticism' – must also be understood as a form of intertextuality (Ch. 5 below). Ammianus adapts contemporary documents with allusive art.[44]

'Intertextuality' also serves better than 'allusion' in covering the way that relationships between texts can function on several levels. That relationships with models are likely to work on various scales is a basic premise of literary criticism, but it has not always been adhered to in Ammianus' case, and the semantic breadth of the term 'intertextuality' helps to correct this. In the Roman digressions (14.6 and 28.4) Ammianus appropriates and emulates Juvenal and Roman satire in a number of ways, but there are only a handful of close verbal echoes; structural and thematic links are notably more prominent, but hardly easily described under the rubric of allusion. This can be also exemplified by the various levels on which Ammianus can be seen to imitate his historiographical predecessors, Tacitus and Livy.

Case study: Tacitus and Livy in Ammianus

It became fashionable in late nineteenth-century Germany to consider Ammianus an imitator (*Nachahmer*) of Tacitus. This aspect had been neglected in earlier scholarship though it had obvious truth in several ways. Ammianus' work had begun where Tacitus stopped, and there are no surviving contemporary histories of any depth between them. (This is *not* to say, by the way, that it is certain that Ammianus began in AD 96 because Tacitus had stopped there, or that there were major similarities between the early books

[43] Solinus 32.27 *nam haec monstra fugientes insequuntur, formidant resistentes* ('for these monsters pursue those who flee and fear those who stand against them').

[44] See Sabbah (1978), esp. 179–217 and 243–372, and below pp. 213–14.

of Ammianus and the portions of Tacitus that had preceded them, or, as is often alleged, that no Latin histories had been *written* for 270 years. Tacitus' terminus probably had an influence on Ammianus, but was not the only factor; the early books were surely on a far more compact scale than Tacitus' last books; and Ammianus may be interpreted as suggesting that the last worthy or canonically accepted Roman history was Tacitus'. But it beggars belief that nobody had made the attempt).

Wölfflin, who originally bestowed the epithet of *Nachahmer*, used philological argument to make the point: his pupil Gerber had trawled for close linguistic parallels.[45] But Ammianus as *Nachahmer* was also interpreted in other ways. Hugo Michael deduced that the lost thirteen books were a tight fit for over 250 years of Roman history, and proposed that Ammianus had published two works not one.[46] The model is plainly the two works of Tacitus, and the intention to render the two historians as similar as possible. Reconstruction of the lost books is still frequently based on the alleged similarity to Tacitus. T. D. Barnes proposes that the *Res Gestae* was structured in hexads (groups of six books), just as has been supposed of Tacitus' two major works (rather more controversially, he extends this to the lost books and argues that there were thirty-six not thirty-one).[47] Others have pointed to the thirty-one books as approximating to, but surpassing, Tacitus' thirty. The commonplace English description of Ammianus as 'the heir of Tacitus' is especially liable to mutate into a judgement of the work's value. Ammianus' many admirers often feel the need to defend their admiration: this is the source of, among others, the most famous and most quoted juxtaposition of the names of Tacitus and Ammianus, the words of Stein: 'the greatest literary genius, in my view, whom the world knew between Tacitus and Dante, whom probably no subsequent historian has surpassed, or even equalled, in the art of moving the reader's heart'.[48] E. A. Thompson and Ronald Syme link the two historians in similar ways: 'How then does Ammianus compare with the best of the older imperial

[45] Wölfflin (1870).

[46] Michael (1880); the suggestion was last revived by Rowell (1964), 16–21 (= (1967), 276–81), (1966). Further bibliography in Barnes (1998), 27.

[47] Barnes (1998), 20–31. [48] Stein (1928), 331 (= 1959, 215) (my translation).

historians, that is, with his model, Tacitus?'[49] 'The heir of Tacitus, in every sense, is Ammianus Marcellinus.'[50] Here we see particularly clearly the ambiguity that all too easily insinuates itself between a value judgement and a declaration that one author is a major influence on another.

There are various ways in which the intertextuality of Tacitus and Ammianus could be analysed. Allusions can be identified; information contained in *exempla* or digressions can be ascribed to the reading of Tacitus. In the first of these cases, a reasonable number of allusions seem incontrovertible, even if others which have been suggested are undemonstrable or unjustifiably given privilege over allusions to other authors (one might exemplify with the whitening bones on the battlefield of Ad Salices, closer to the *Aeneid* than to the *clades Variana*).[51] Sometimes a chapter of Tacitus seems to share a number of details with a similarly prolonged passage of Ammianus.[52] As far as concerns historical references, it will be discovered that nowhere is it obviously demonstrable that Tacitus is a source: this reflects partly the relative paucity of *exempla* from the period, and partly the possibility of other sources when *exempla* do occur.[53] Investigations of Tacitus' influence on Ammianus now tend to look more to broader historiographical aspects. This larger-scale intertextuality is hard to prove. For example, in his account of the Persian invasion of 360, Ammianus mentioned a rumour that, on an embassy to the Persian King, the bishop of Bezabde had betrayed the city by pointing out the weak parts of the walls. Ammianus absolves the bishop of blame, but then explains why many found the case against him persuasive (20.7.7–9). This was often read as testimony to Ammianus' fair-mindedness.[54] By contrast, T. D. Barnes rejects such an interpretation: 'Ammianus chose to include the story because he had learnt from Tacitus how to use rumors to suggest disreputable conduct or a dishonourable

[49] Thompson (1947), 121.
[50] Syme (1958), 503 n. 8. Syme (1976), 340, looks like a change of mind.
[51] See Ch. 1 above.
[52] Tacitus *Ann.* 1.65 has been identified as intertextual with 18.2.10 and 22.15.22–3 (Owens (1958)). The latter allusion (in a passage on hippopotamus-hunting derived from Solinus) seems illusory.
[53] The passages suggested by Cornelius (1888), 22, do not inspire confidence (14.8.2, 15.2.5, 23.1.2, 18.4.5, 15.5.35).
[54] E.g. Matthews (1989), 436.

motive while taking no authorial responsibility for the dubious information thus conveyed.'[55] Certainly this is a far more interesting and credible reading, and the connection which Barnes suggests with Tacitus seems intuitively apt. But confirmation of this intuition is difficult, and further examples, though helpful, would not constitute proof. But were there only a handful of identifiable allusions to Tacitus, or none at all, there would be serious doubt about Barnes' view.[56]

Livy offers another, simpler, example. In his 1904 dissertation on Ammianus' sources for discussion of Roman republican history in *exempla* and digressions, Finke played the normal game of cutting Ammianus' learning down to size by postulating intermediate sources. Allusions to Pliny or Solinus were really to the *Chorographia Pliniana* (in this he followed Mommsen);[57] a common source for Ammianus, Florus and the breviarist Festus was proposed (an assertion of independence from Mommsen, who had pointed out Ammianus' dependence on Festus);[58] finally and most notably, Livy was not admitted as a source for Ammianus' knowledge. Use of intermediate sources was a sad consequence of the times and his own faulty Latinity, we are given to understand.[59] In fact there are a number of *exempla* where Livy is a very likely source (18.5.6, 25.1.15 and 30.8.5), but what really corrects this absurd conclusion is the abundance of undeniable textual allusions to Livy, widely spread across the *Res Gestae* and drawn from across the surviving books of the *Ab Vrbe Condita*.[60] Setting up a conceptual distinction between allusions and *exempla* in this case led to a mistake that the broader term of intertextuality might have helped avert.

[55] Barnes (1998), 88. Indeed Ammianus explicitly withholds authorial support from the accusation against the bishop.

[56] The bibliography on Ammianus and Tacitus is oversized: the most complete survey is Neumann (1987). This is a far from comprehensive list: Wölfflin (1870), Wirz (1877), Cornelius (1888), Weinstein (1913–14), Arnaldi (1967), Tibullo (1969–70), Flach (1972), Wilshire (1972–3), Blockley (1973), Hind (1975), Roselle (1976), Borszák (1976), Taisne (1992), Fornara (1992b), Williams (1997).

[57] Mommsen (1895), xix–xxiv, Finke (1904), 46. The Dutch commentators (e.g. on 22.15–16) have to my mind shown fairly conclusively that he alludes to both, though their approach is cautious.

[58] Finke (1904), 50. [59] Finke (1904), 70.

[60] Cf. Livy 22.51.4, 27.49.1, 9.16.17–19. See e.g. Wirz (1877), 634, Fletcher (1937), 383–6, Owens (1958), Fornara (1992b), 433–5.

Intertextuality and allusion, then, bring different nuances in expressing a range of linked ideas. As I have already suggested, there is no need to see a choice of Hercules between the two terms. Nor, for my present purposes, is it worth dallying over their relationship to the problematic but obviously meaningful concept of authorial intention.[61] However, one related problem on which I shall linger briefly is that of the nature of Ammianus' audience, and whether his allusions were likely to be recognisable or meaningful to its members. This is a historically reasonable question, though ultimately, in my view, not a real problem.

In the war of 359, that odious midget and wretched excuse for a *magister equitum*, Sabinianus, was responding to military crisis by hanging around the martyr-tombs of Edessa (Ammianus is characteristically unexplicit about the Christian context). In attacking Sabinianus, he also echoes comic tales of haunted houses:

18.7.7 quasi fundata cum mortuis pace nihil formidans.	Plautus, *Mostellaria* 514 nihil ego formido, pax mihi est cum mortuis.[62]
As if he'd established a peace with the dead, afraid of nothing.	I fear nothing, I am at peace with the dead.

If as certain an allusion as that above went unrecognised or at any rate unremarked through three centuries of modern scholarship, was it likely to have impacted on many or any of Ammianus' original readers or hearers? There are many allusions less blatant than

[61] See Fowler (2000), 115–37, esp. 117, for an opposing argument. Most such debate seems simply to involve wielding theoretical handbags rather than to speak of serious differences in the way that allusions are recognised and interpreted: not that the debating scholars reach the same conclusions, but that there is a broad similarity and consensus in how they reach them. Thomas (1999), 6 n. 10, speaks not unreasonably of such a broad consensus, though the context is a polemic against Hinds (1998) for misrepresenting him. Thomas' confident declarations on authorial intention are as self-consciously provocative as Conte or Hinds pontificating against it. In practice, Thomas is sensitive to the difficulties raised by authorial intention, and Conte has been known to invoke what Vergil or Catullus meant to imply (whether intentionally or not is hardly for me to judge). Hinds (1998), 50 n. 64, thinks intentionally, though in studiously unintentionalist language.

[62] An allusion first noted by Steele (1922), 24. The context is rich in theatrical metaphors, and the verbal similarity is extremely close. The allusion is part of the complex display of contempt for Sabinianus in the Persian War of 359. Likening Constantius' creatures to comic figures is standard (see n. 33 above); here it helps to emphasise Ammianus' distaste for the Christian cult of martyrs and the complacent conduct of the war. See also Szidat (1991), and Ch. 2, n. 61 above.

this one. Could an audience be expected to appreciate them? Many of Ammianus' readers have expressed concern about this. An influential article by Hertz, to be discussed below, discovers numerous allusions to Gellius less obvious than that above, but which show constant play with the original: they often negate or contradict or intensify, sometimes an original phrase becomes a divided allusion, neatly split between two separate places. Hertz was impressed by the fun which a dull investigation of the reception of Gellius' text had given him, but saw no way that the allusions could have been noticed by contemporaries unless the author had given them the key.[63] Ammianus' allusions were hidden. Salemme's investigations try to identify more order ('a most refined technique') in the choice and adaptation of allusions but have the same problem with the audience: 'allusions of lofty erudition, these of Ammianus, comprehensible only by an especially learned addressee, who was in a position to recognise beyond a highly personal diction and new and unaccustomed images, a distant echo'.[64] The 'technique of concealment' ('tecnica dell'occultamento') raises a problem about their worth.[65] Do they mean anything if nobody, or almost nobody, can see them?

One may start by noting that such an attitude probably derives to some extent from unexamined, or underexamined, assumptions about the period in which Ammianus wrote. (In fact, concern at the inability of audiences, or 'most readers', to identify and comprehend allusion is a common phenomenon, and could be alleged in the audiences of Greek tragedy, or Hellenistic and Roman poetry, but in those fields the scholarship and learning of authors and readers are more likely to be taken for granted.) However, it is clear from studies of other contemporary authors that Augustine and Ambrose, for example, demonstrate an intimate knowledge of Vergil, Cicero and Sallust, even when they write consciously Christian literature.[66] It

[63] Hertz (1874a), 302.

[64] 'Una finissima tecnica . . . Allusioni di remota erudizione, quelle ammianee, comprensibili solo da un destinario particolarmente dotto, che fosse in grado di riconoscere, al di là di un dettato personalissimo e di immagini nuove e inconsuete, un'eco lontana.' Salemme (1989), 32.

[65] Salemme (1989), 35.

[66] See e.g. Hagendahl (1958) and (1967). Such studies tend to have a high burden of proof and to leave out some very probable allusions.

is one thing to point to an imagined first audience and assert (reasonably) that their educational backgrounds would probably give allusions to, say, Vergil, Cicero and Sallust an especial significance and interpretability. But what of close and potentially significant allusions to Tacitus? Here is an author generally considered to have had few readers in antiquity, even if he became more fashionable at the end of the fourth century. Does this make Ammianus' allusions a personal game, or even a crutch to help his writing? One might equally answer that Ammianus' allusions to Tacitus prove that there was an audience to whom his allusions to Tacitus would have been recognizable and meaningful.[67] Moreover, at one point he expresses the thought that there may be in his audience a 'painstaking reader of the classics' (*scrupulosus . . . lector antiquitatum*, 16.7.9), and the constant interplay between glossing the recherché detail and leaving it to be filled in offers the same invitation to his readers.[68]

This is of course to assume that the notion of an 'audience' for Ammianus' work is helpful or definable.[69] It is doubtless sometimes true that works of literature are written with a particular audience in mind, and it may even sometimes be the case that they are read by that singular, intended audience and it alone. This is perhaps particularly the case with technical or sectarian works, and those written in times and places when literacy is particularly limited, and books are little copied and little travelled. But Ammianus wrote under the Roman Empire, not in the early Middle Ages. Other than that it required a certain degree of learning, I do not think that the notion of an intended audience for Ammianus' work is a particularly helpful one. In writing classical historiography, he was producing an eternal possession, and not an ephemeral performance, aiming to establish the *Res Gestae* as the canonical historical

[67] So Fornara (1992b), 432–3.

[68] Itself an allusion (Fletcher (1937), 394): *forte scrupulosus quidam lector antiquitatum* ('perhaps some painstaking reader of the classics') cf. Apuleius *Met.* 9.30 *forsitan lector scrupulosus* ('perhaps a painstaking reader').

[69] The Vergilian critic R. O. A. M. Lyne argued powerfully that the potential failures of imagined audiences are no reason for denying the validity of literary criticism, and decried such an approach as the 'Fallacy of Audience Limitation'. Quite simply, if an allusion is there and can be interpreted, the attempt should be made, even if that interpretation contradicts or lies uneasily with what one perceives to be the overt sense of the passage. Lyne (1994), 196–8.

account for distant posterity as much as for contemporaries. Inasmuch as the *Res Gestae* imagines a contemporary audience, that audience is diverse. Ammianus suggests the potential of a foreign audience who will read his work to discover what Rome is like, at the same time implying that he needs to excuse himself to a Roman audience (14.6.2). He might be read by the politically involved, whether at the court, in the army, or in the public life of the city (26.1.1), by those who had seen the disasters which had befallen Rome in the magic and treason trials (28.1.5). He might be read by nobody at all (31.5.10). Even if the imagined audience within the text were less diverse, that would say nothing about the real audience, over the composition of which the text had no control.[70] Those persons whom we know to have read Ammianus in antiquity can be listed: Jerome, the author of the *HA*, Claudian, Priscian, Cassiodorus. They have in common the fact that they were themselves writers, whence our knowledge of their reading, but little else.[71]

In fact, the best reason for keeping some conception of the audience in mind is precisely this diversity. We should constantly have in mind the possibility that the work might arouse different reactions in different audiences (and that that might have been precisely the intention of the historian). So, for example, the *Res Gestae* has recently proved open to widely disparate views of its attitude to Christianity, in a way which plausibly reflects an attempt to appeal in different ways to different groups of contemporary readers.[72] Similarly in understanding allusions: they may or may not have been visible to individual readers and must have had varying significance to different readers – though one can evade the audience by calling this feature multivalence or polysemy.

The presence of intertextuality is less nebulous than the reconstruction of an authentic audience. So better to shift attention from

[70] This is not to disprove attempts such as that of Frakes (2000a) to argue that the *Res Gestae* assumes a readership of civilian administrators, rather to indicate the limitations in what can be proved. The concept of a homogeneous real or intended audience is deeply problematic, especially for a work like this.

[71] For Jerome, the *HA* and Claudian see Ch. 3, n. 41; for Priscian see *Inst. Gramm.* 9.51; for Cassiodorus see Heather (1993).

[72] To put it in other terms, unlike Eunapius or Libanius or Symmachus, Ammianus' language was sufficiently coded for many readers to think him religiously neutral.

the abilities of imagined readers to the allusions themselves. Rather than looking at the unknowable variations in readers' abilities, it seems preferable to me to look at variation in the visibility and openness (which is related to but not quite identical to 'interpretability') of allusions. Some allusions are marked as such. The extreme case of visibility (almost the apogee of allusion) is quotation by name or by unmistakable periphrasis (e.g. *ut Mantuanus uates praedixit excelsus*, 'as the lofty bard of Mantua announced', 15.9.1): whether precise or not, it signals itself. But ways in which allusions are signalled in lesser degrees can be noted. Proverbs are sometimes accompanied with words such as 'as the old proverb says' (*ut prouerbium loquitur uetus*, e.g. 14.11.12), or 'as they say' (*ut aiunt*, e.g. 18.5.6, 28.1.26). Ammianus twice marks allusions to Roman comedy with the words 'as the comic poet says' (*ut ait comicus*, 14.6.16, 15.13.3); an allusion to Tacitus is accompanied with a parenthetic 'so to speak' (*ut ita dixerim*, 28.1.57).[73] An *exemplum*, got from Valerius Maximus' *Memorable Deeds and Sayings*, is arguably identified as from that source with the words *memorabilis . . . facti* ('memorable deed', 24.4.24).[74] There is a hierarchy in what is permitted quotation by name. Homer and Vergil and, above all, Cicero have obvious prestige, other authors are named only in digressions (Herodotus, Thucydides, Menander, Sallust, Timagenes, Hermapion).[75] Vergil appears to be the latest Latin author of sufficient prestige to be quoted by name. In the surviving books Ammianus never mentions Livy, Tacitus or Gellius, authors of evident centrality for his project.

In the same way as a quotation, an *exemplum* is visible and indeed draws attention to itself; but even *exempla* can be visible and explicit to different degrees, and can require varying amounts

[73] *is urbanarum rerum status, ut ita dixerim, fuit* ('such was, so to speak, the standing of city affairs') cf. Tacitus *Ann.* 1.16.1 *hic rerum urbanarum status erat, cum Pannonicas legiones seditio incessit, . .* ('this was the standing of city affairs, when mutiny befell the Pannonian legions . . .'). *Rerum status* is a historiographical cliché, and *urbanarum rerum status* could perhaps have occurred in, say, the lost books of Livy, but it looks like a clear allusion, marked by *ut ita dixerim*. It was first noted by Fornara (1992b, 437–8): he also compares 20.8.9 and Cicero *Cat.* 4.23.

[74] The *exemplum* of Luscinus comes from Valerius Maximus 1.8.6. See now Rohrbacher (2005).

[75] 22.15.28; 19.4.4, 23.6.75; 21.14.4; 15.12.6; 15.9.2; 17.4.17 (of these only Menander and Hermapion are directly quoted rather than paraphrased).

of external supplement. The very fact that other allusions, however obvious, are not marked with this sort of attention illustrates that openness varies. Openness depends in part on whether texts are quoted, which in turn is dependent on prestige and antiquity more than anything else. Another mark of allusion is the use of the Greek language,[76] yet another is the presence of markers like *ut ita dixerim* ('so to speak'). But the greater or lesser visibility of allusions depends on their length and their rarity, how many and how uncommon are the words which the texts share, whether unusual features of the original are preserved (for example a *clausula* irregular for Ammianus, or a historic present).[77] Some intertextuality may have been deliberately concealed by Ammianus, though authorial intent is a matter of no more certainty here than elsewhere.[78] One may cite the geographical digressions, where attempts at analysis have often been repulsed by Ammianus' tendency to contaminate sources or alter them in a way which distracts attention from the extent of his derivation. Or one may cite an *exemplum* in a digression on the Apis bull, who is said to reject some of those who approach him with adverse signs, *ut offerentem cibum aliquando Germanicum Caesarem, **sicut lectum est**, auersatus portenderat paulo post euentura* ('just as, when once Germanicus Caesar offered food, **according to my reading**, he turned away and portended what would befall a little later', 22.14.8). Here an allusive marker (*sicut lectum est*) appears to point to a particular source-text. But Tacitus and Suetonius have nothing to say on this particular omen of Germanicus' death, and like the rest of the passage it comes from Solinus (32.17–21, at 19); the marker might be viewed as no more than an ostentatious feint.

The existence of other more discreet types of intertextual marker has been mentioned previously: there are allusive passages where the quality of allusiveness is implied in a way more integrated into the text. When the battlefield of Ad Salices is said to be 'still now', *nunc usque*, white with bones, these words arguably signal

[76] A list of Greek quotations can be found in Blockley (1975), 195.

[77] Irregular clausulae, e.g. 14.6.8 *ambigere bonos*. 19.6.10 *portae panduntur* is present tense because it alludes to Vergil *Aen.* 2.27; 6.574.

[78] The *Historia Augusta* might be a good place to look for deliberate concealment of allusions.

the Vergilian allusion:[79] so too when the satirical commonplace of weighing items of food is introduced to the second Roman digression (28.4.13). The way that the repetitive prolixity of hosts weighing their fish, fowl and dormice is complained of (*saepius replicata*, 'too often repeated') also ironically comments on the existence and repetitiveness of the Latin satirical tradition which makes much of the weighing of luxury foods.[80] Such features, which play with their identification as allusions, are more remarked upon in earlier classical literature,[81] and their presence argues for continuity from the past in Ammianus' approach to allusiveness. They also support the view that allusion is an intentional and meaningful feature rather than a chance convergence of texts.

II What you seek is what you get

So far, this chapter has dwelt on questions of how intertextuality and allusion are defined and identified. If I have concluded that some of the debate on issues such as authorial intention can be passed by, it is not because I doubt that definition, or the approach taken to intertextuality, will affect the results. Intertextuality has appeared as a broad range of different types of textual relationship, has been seen as action or phenomenon, proof of reading or purposed reference, has ranged from generically marked vocabulary to *exemplum*, to the extent that it might be thought difficult to find more to say about the nature of intertextuality than that it is diverse, and, in Ammianus, plentiful. The situation calls for a concise summary of the presuppositions and results of those who have previously studied Ammianus' intertextuality.

Early commentators, such as Lindenbrog or Henri and Adrien de Valois, passed through the whole text with eyes of polymaths. Though historical learning was at the centre of their commentaries, they noted down such allusions as they recognised, or just as often parallels, that is, places of which a passage reminded them or which contained the same information or imagery. Sometimes the direct

[79] See p. 18 above. [80] Horace, *Serm.* 2.2.33–4; Juvenal, *Satire* 4 *passim*.
[81] See e.g. Hinds (1998), Ch. 1.

relationship was proved, more often left unstated.[82] Since then, Ammianus' intertextuality has suffered less nonchalance. It was in late nineteenth-century Germany that investigation of allusion mushroomed. One possible reason is that enthusiasm for lexicography was at its height, and the very breadth of Ammianus' vocabulary made him interesting.[83] Another is the increasingly comprehensive and scientific approach towards the editing of texts. Comparison enabled the emendation of both Ammianus and his sources.

The impact of both lexicography and textual criticism can be seen in Hertz's article on Ammianus' allusions to Gellius: the original purpose was examination of the reception of Gellius' text.[84] Though he based one emendation on this reading,[85] the fruit of his study was unexpected. Despite the distance in time, it is worth pausing on Hertz' article, as it is not only original, insightful and influential; it is also confused about its conclusions and this confusion has spread.

Beyond the long and expected list of allusions, Hertz observed the eccentricities of their incorporation, uncertain whether to see madness or wit, cleverness or corruption. Ammianus consistently twisted the meaning of borrowed phraseology, negated the positive and changed the direction of phrases. His manner of allusion was what later generations might have described as surreal. If one quotes out of context the more memorable of Hertz's conclusions and no more, it is nothing but condemnation. He theorised that Ammianus had used a card-index of his reading in Latin in order to supply himself with ready-made phrases.[86] Allusions were introduced in the fashion of a carnival.[87] The problem was one which could be described as 'psychological'.[88] These quotations are not

[82] The preferred reading of the commentators made a considerable difference; Lindenbrog's fondness for Plautus is evident from his annotations, some of which are plainly allusion and others of which have a more dubious status (cf. e.g. 15.12.1 ~ Plautus, *Captiui* 795–7).

[83] Wölfflin (1870), which first laid emphasis on Ammianus' debt to Tacitus, was a *parergon* of his pupil Gerber's work on the *Lexicon Taciteum*.

[84] Hertz (1874a), 302. [85] Hertz (1874a), 283–4 n. 6. [86] Hertz (1874a), 265.

[87] Hertz (1874a), 301: 'the way in which he does it has revealed itself to us as so utterly carnivalesque . . .' ('die Weise in der er es thut, hat sich uns als eine so absolut faschingsmässige enthüllt . . .').

[88] Hertz (1874a), 302.

entirely representative. The card-index which Hertz proposes is one which, to judge by some of the double allusions he later identifies, would necessarily be of enormous complexity, which is not to say that it did not exist. (It is however worth recalling, and raising an eyebrow at, the proviso on which the card-index is founded – 'if we are not to attribute to him an extraordinary memory'.)[89] The carnivalesque contribution is not randomness or unthinking use of the card-index: rather allusions are introduced consciously and purposefully (if not entirely rationally), and the carnival is in the pleasure and wit with which they are altered, by an E. T. A. Hoffman-like ghost concealed within the lines.[90]

The assumptions which helped Hertz to his conclusions are characteristic of his period and worth detailing. The very first words ('in the wasteland of secular Latin literature . . .') establish that the period is assumed to be decadent, and the conclusion, that Ammianus should not be blamed if in some ways he adopts the practices of his period, confirms this.[91] In a brief sketch of the history of Latin literature, Hertz points out that derivativeness and narrowly linguistic imitation had been characteristic from the start. Learning declined, but still existed in a few authors. It is nowhere made altogether clear how the age of Ammianus, Ausonius and Claudian differed from the republic or the early empire.[92] At the end of Hertz's article the simplicity and directness which make Ammianus seem to stand out from the vices of his age are proved illusory.[93] Hertz consciously refutes the distinction between Ammianus and his age; the article also has the less intended effect of undermining the distinction between his age and earlier ages.

Hertz displays another assumption equally characteristic of his period, namely that Ammianus' Greekness (as proved by Graecisms) cast doubt on his Latinity, which in turn meant that imitation was an essential tool for Ammianus in writing Latin prose.[94] This assumption too might be thought, at the very least, threatened by the verbal dexterity he demonstrates in Ammianus.

Hertz tries to avoid certain types of anachronism: he clears Ammianus of impropriety in not citing his references. The Romans

[89] Hertz (1874a), 265. [90] Hertz (1874a), 302. [91] Hertz (1874a), 257, 301.
[92] Hertz (1874a), 261–4. [93] Hertz (1874a), 301.
[94] Hertz (1874a), 264 and (implied) 301.

lacked quotation marks.[95] But he attributes to Ammianus a card-index, the tool of a nineteenth-century scholar.[96] When Hertz lists Ammianus' allusions to Gellius, the arrangement is by book and chapter of Gellius. Giving greater importance to the source rather than the alluding text is of course understandable, since Hertz's main interest was Gellius. But its effect is to be more concerned with how Ammianus looks several times to the same passages of Gellius rather than how he contaminates diverse passages of Gellius, how the source-text is changed rather than what the allusion does in its new context. Typical of the approach of viewing the allusion as 'use' is the speculation on the distribution of allusions in Gellius. Many more allusions to the earlier books of the *Noctes Atticae* than to the later are identifiable: Hertz suggests that the lost books of Ammianus made more use of the later books. A curious but not of course an impossible conclusion; a similar suggestion had been made by Wölfflin concerning Ammianus' more frequent allusions to the *Histories* rather than the *Annals* of Tacitus.[97] The best example of such patterns of allusion, which was perhaps at the back of Wölfflin's and Hertz's minds, is the *Aeneid*, with its Odysseian and Iliadic halves.

Hertz's basic observations are not without cumulative force. Sometimes different parts of the same passage are alluded to in separate parts of the *Res Gestae*: the effect is very much as if Ammianus were using up his card-index, though as a purposed aesthetic choice it might be called divided allusion.[98] It was perhaps the originality of his discoveries that helped Hertz produce the conclusion that allusions are 'hidden'.[99] Whether he thought the allusions did much, beyond participating in a curious game of *imitatio*, is not clear. Sometimes texts do seem pointless as models, though we are perhaps less likely than Hertz to think it pointless if Ammianus says of Constantius what Suetonius had said of Tiberius.[100]

The complexities and contradictions of Hertz's argument were not generally considered by his successors, and so his assumptions

[95] Hertz (1874a), 265. [96] Hertz (1874a), 265. [97] Wölfflin (1870), 560.
[98] See Wills (1998). [99] Hertz (1874a), 260 and *passim*.
[100] 20.11.31 *super his urebat eius anxiam mentem, quod* . . . ('beyond this it burnt his anxious mind, that . . .' cf. Suetonius *Tiberius* 66 *urebant insuper anxiam mentem uaria undique conuicia* ('moreover, various reproaches from all sides burned his anxious mind'). Hertz (1874a), 296, originally Gronovius ad loc.

as well as his influence loom large in the many essays of the period concentrating on Ammianus' allusions or sources. Schneider's pages on Ammianus' use of Herodian are modelled on Hertz to the point of providing a *reductio ad absurdum*.[101] A greater number of allusions to the earlier part of Herodian's work are identified than to the later: rather than demonstrating that Ammianus' interest in Herodian waned or that his own diligence fell off, he suggests that Ammianus 'used' the later books of Herodian in the earlier part of his own work. The debt to Hertz's idiosyncratic suggestion, mentioned above, is striking.[102] But the real absurdity comes in this idea of 'use' of a Greek historian. Ammianus' phraseological 'borrowings' from a historian writing in Greek are supposed to have helped a Greek historian write Latin. When actually examined closely it appears that most (though not, as some have suggested, all) of the allusions are unconvincing, commonplaces of historiography or descriptions of the same type of event.[103] The problem is intensified by the fact that Herodian's work is in Greek, making allusion perhaps a little harder to prove, but Schneider's methodological subservience does underline the difficulties with Hertz's article. Many other examples could be cited from the end of the nineteenth and beginning of the twentieth centuries. Ammianus was a particularly appropriate author for a young scholar. His research could concentrate on Ammianus' relationship with individual authors, and the allusions were often fairly obvious. Ammianus could be shown to have imitated Sallust,[104] Cicero,[105] Livy,[106] Gellius,[107] Valerius Maximus, Herodian,[108] above all Tacitus.[109] The studies, and their identification of allusions, are of varying quality. The risk in this is that a single-minded explanation will be sought out: Ammianus is the heir of Cicero/Tacitus/Greek historiography. The same phenomenon could be seen in the study of his sources, where the historian was divided into constituent parts: Latin source and

[101] Schneider (1879), 46–60. Brok's refutation ((1976–7), 199–200) quotes his description of Hertz as 'dux noster certissimus nobilissimusque' (Schneider (1879), 59).
[102] Schneider (1879), 60.
[103] Brok (1976–7), 201–2. For discussion of Ammianus' relationship with Herodian see Ch. 5, Section III.
[104] Hertz (1874b), Wirz (1877), 628–33, Weinstein (1913–14). [105] Michael (1874).
[106] Wirz (1877), 633–4. [107] Hertz (1874a), esp. 275–302. [108] Schneider (1879).
[109] Wölfflin (1870), Wirz (1877), 634–5, Cornelius (1888), 17–22, Weinstein (1913–14).

Greek source, annalistic source and Thucydidean source.[110] Otherwise the common features are the assumption that Ammianus' Greekness and lateness implies lameness in Latin, and that *imitatio* is a crutch for a cripple.

Twentieth- and twenty-first-century investigations improved on their inheritance, though it must be said that the assumption that allusion is an artistic weakness is not exclusive to nineteenth-century scholarship. Though there is no unanimity on the subject of written sources, Ammianus' control of his source-material is almost universally acknowledged.[111] Likewise his control of the Latin language: it may still be argued that 'Ammianus thought in Greek' (though the view is certainly far from universal), but his learning in Latin literature and his linguistic inventiveness are not therefore scorned.[112] More nuanced appreciation of Ammianus' relationship with earlier texts has been possible, and the idea of Ammianus as the failed heir of Tacitus has receded, or at any rate been sensibly qualified. The same uncertainty as to what exactly an allusion implies could sometimes be found. An article by G. B. A. Fletcher in 1937 had only the following text before the list of parallels which comprised the rest of the article: 'The evidence for Ammianus' knowledge of earlier Latin authors is more abundant and extensive than has been pointed out.' But Fletcher, like Hagendahl, Owens and Fontaine, investigated Ammianus' intertextuality without damaging presuppositions, and identified allusions more reliably and with a greater range. Commentaries have made advances without the biases of single-author studies, and more general investigations into Ammianus' language and intertextuality have been made.[113] Particularly important studies are

[110] Seeck (1906a). For a good summary see Dillemann (1961), 110–15.

[111] The demolition of the idea of Ammianus' slavish indebtedness to sources is the particular achievement of Thompson (1947), praised and developed by Dillemann (1961), 118.

[112] T. D. Barnes does not doubt Ammianus' learning, but holds the assured view that he 'thought in Greek' (Barnes (1998), viii and *saepius*). He bolsters the position with the names of Wilamowitz, Leo, Norden, Fraenkel, and other great men. The assertion sits uncomfortably with, though perhaps it does not contradict, detailed philological studies. Ammianus is constantly seen to have used Latin sources for both Greek and Roman *exempla*, and the overall complexity of his Latin intertextuality contrasts with apparent shortcomings in his knowledge of Greek literature (Fornara (1992b), and also de Jonge and den Boeft *et al. passim*).

[113] Hagendahl (1921), Fletcher (1937), Owens (1958). Jenkins (1985) shows signs of diminishing returns. Of commentators, de Jonge is rather trigger-happy in hunting parallels,

those of Fontaine and Roberts.[114] Both compare Ammianus to other authors of the late fourth or early fifth century, a comparison less likely to be rendered invidious by expectations of linguistic classicism. A yet more detailed examination of Ammianus and allusion is that of Carmelo Salemme.

Salemme's is the most thorough attempt to re-engage with the views of Hertz. His keen eye has spotted a number of unnoticed allusions, and this helps to undermine some of the pessimistic estimates of Ammianus' learning. Likewise he is perceptive and persuasive in his identification of *contaminatio*, and untangles many complicated webs, in such a way that proves that Ammianus' card-index would have been a very well-constructed and detailed one indeed. But his search for allusions sometimes takes him too far. How to deal with the boundary between the allusion and the parallel is an old problem, of course. Salemme's unconvincing answer is the hidden allusion, the delicacy of which is so refined that only the most cultivated eye can find it (a flattering self-image).[115] Many of Salemme's hidden allusions, however, tend towards the fanciful. That an occluded allusion is possible is not in doubt, but an emphasis on this to the exclusion of other forms of reference (*exempla*, quotations, more visible allusions) is misleading. When Salemme complicates allusions with *contaminatio*, the additional allusions do not necessarily render the old ones more difficult to perceive.

Salemme's concern is with Ammianus' style and his learning, with identifying amidst the madness his 'method' of allusion. He stresses the uniqueness of this method of incorporating fragments of ancient texts, which is seen as different from the ways in which those texts alluded to their own predecessors. In Salemme's view, what is absent from Ammianus' relationship to his predecessors is *aemulatio*: rather than being rivals, they are precious fragments.[116] The metaphor which he uses several times in emphasising the novelty and originality of this art, and which gives him unnecessary difficulties, is that of the mosaic.[117] The intellectual background

but he and his successors in the Dutch commentary, and Jacques Fontaine among others in the Budé commentary, have identified very many new and relevant allusions.

[114] Fontaine (1977) and his Budé editions, Roberts (1988).

[115] Salemme (1989), 15, 32 and *passim*. [116] Salemme (1989), e.g. 37, 58.

[117] Cf. Fornara (1992b), 438, quoted above p. 163. For a critique of this metaphor see below Section v.

to Salemme's argument, and to an even greater degree to those of Fontaine and Roberts, is the growing significance accorded to the study of 'late antiquity' as a meaningful and unified period, and interest in its visual and literary arts as something worthy of attention in their own right.

We are still left with what might seem an aesthetic problem: thousands of allusions accused, variously, of disconnection, of a decorative function, of an eccentric rationale. An investigation of them one by one would be impossibly lengthy, but one may look at broad types of allusion. So in the pages that follow I shall look at a number of examples of Ammianus' intertextuality. I shall begin (Section III) with what by its nature might seem to be the least 'referential' and specifically interpretable type of intertextuality, common vocabulary; then I shall move on (Section IV) to a number of examples of larger allusions, grouped according to the manner of allusion (places where the original is reversed, where the original is split into different parts of the text, punning alterations, cases where words are preserved and contexts transformed, 'glosses' on the original, 'window allusions', exemplary allusions). These categories overlap and the groupings could be questioned. The sample will inevitably be a small one, and will focus on intertexts which I find interesting. However, in a conscious effort to confront points of view like Hertz's, I have tried to include allusions of the sort which have proved so baffling.

III Vocabulary

At the risk of over-simplification, it could be suggested that most scholarship in the field has been more interested in demonstrating the fact, rather than illustrating the technique, of Ammianus' reception of earlier literature. The proof-texts have very often been discovered by lexicography, without necessarily showing any concern with the issue of whether the author meant anything by allusion to that particular text (or, in non-intentionalist terms, whether the text adduced makes any identifiable contribution to the interpretation of Ammianus). I have already mentioned the fact that the ease with which allusions are identified is increased by the rareness of

their vocabulary. Yet there is also a tension in that the most easily identified allusions often seem less secure as allusions because of the apparent lack of purpose. It is often difficult to think of single words (however rare) as allusions without other similarities of substance (as with the example of the Juvenalian *ephemeris*, 28.4.24).[118] Alternatively, the inclusion of rare words is seen as a purpose in itself.

My own approach in this study has been to adduce such texts as show how allusion is central to Ammianus' aesthetic, and how it engages readers and subtly opens up the possible interpretations of the *Res Gestae*. Attempts such as these to promote allusions as relevant (as 'reference', to use Richard Thomas' word) have not only been introduced by different scholars for different ends, but have also in the main focussed on different source-texts from those deployed in 'lexicographical' investigations. I am unlikely to argue for the political significance of vocabulary derived from Gellius.

But even though different texts are adduced by different scholars, the two approaches I mention are not mutually exclusive. One of the virtues of Hertz's study is a concern both for demonstrating Ammianus' reading and for the techniques of allusion. Before exploring the allusions to Gellius, Hertz mounts an exploration of Ammianus' vocabulary. In practice this means tracing the sources of unusual words. It is a phenomenon worthy of attention that Ammianus, like Apuleius, has a number of unusual words found otherwise only in Plautus, or indeed that he has a number of words for which Apuleius is the only apparent source. So Hertz records that Ammianus has from Plautus *fundito, diffundito, illecebrosus, impetrabilis, perquisitor, proiectare, pugnaculum, sospitalis, unanimans, uoluptabilis*;[119] other pieces of vocabulary might have come from either Plautus or Apuleius, others from Apuleius, and individual examples from Cicero and Ovid.[120] The vocabulary from Gellius or authors quoted by Gellius will also be significant.[121] (Hertz judges intertextuality with Gellius by the three categories of vocabulary, factual connections and *iuncturae* or 'Verbindungen'.)

[118] See above pp. 166–7.
[119] Hertz (1874a), 267.
[120] Hertz (1874a), 267–9.
[121] Hertz (1874a), 280–1.

But of what significance? How are we to interpret Ammianus' 'use' of this mostly eccentric vocabulary? I would suggest that four interpretations are possible.

First, one could see the appearance of Plautine vocabulary in Ammianus (and presumably Apuleius) as a matter of chance. Many of the words listed above show after all the impact of relatively productive suffixes, and it could merely be a matter of a common fondness for iterative or frequentative verbs, or adjectives in *-bilis*. It could be that Ammianus, like Plautus, uses Vulgar Latin vocabulary that was absent from Classical Latin.

Chance is likely to be responsible in some cases (Ammianus has a number of words previously unwitnessed in Classical Latin, either vulgarisms or neologisms). But not every case can be fortuitous. Ammianus surely alludes in places to Plautus. He uses the word *perquisitor* in just such an instance: *ut saltem id metuens* ***perquisitor maleuolus*** *tandem desineret quieti coalitos homines in aperta pericula proiectare* ('so that fearing that, at any rate, the ill-willed scrutineer should stop casting men committed to quiet into open dangers', 14.5.7) must allude to Plautus, *Stichus* 385 ***maliuoli perquisitores*** *auctionum perierint* ('Those ill-willed men, scrutineers of auctions, can go to hell'). As well as the common use of *maleuolus*, another Plautine word, *proiectare*, is found in the same sentence (though as part of an allusion to Vergil *Aen.* 11.360–1, *quid miseros totiens in aperta pericula ciuis / proicis*, 'why do you so often cast wretched citizens into open dangers').[122] These are the only two extant uses of *perquisitor* in Latin.

The second possible explanation for Ammianus' allusive vocabulary would be to let the lexicographers take over and forge him into their own image. In the examples of the last paragraph, as with those places where a single rarity is found, Ammianus, it can be argued, is using a dictionary or handbook rather than Plautus. His reading of earlier authors has often been reduced to the level of indirect knowledge culled from secondary works, whose exact nature is rarely determined, and in this vein a recent contribution decided to deny altogether his reading of Plautus.[123] The most

[122] Plautus, *Bacchides* 567 (though most editors now print *prolectas*, not *proiectas*). Ammianus' Vergilian allusion identified by Hagendahl (1921), 5.

[123] Jenkins (1985), Ch. 1.

easily recognised Plautine allusions are, it is true, the linguistic rarities. It is, moreover, all but certain that when Ammianus alludes to lines of Ennius and Lucilius they are at second hand: in these cases the intermediate source can be identified.[124] It is also true that some of Ammianus' *exempla* come from 'handbooks'.[125] But it is a sizeable number of scattered and interpretable allusions to Plautus and Terence which are all said to go back to 'handbooks' (they show a particular bunching in the earlier books, and a particular applicability to Constantius' officials). Fortunately sanity can prevail, thanks to an allusion which contaminates two portions of text forty lines apart. This would imply either direct reading of Plautus or that the excerpts preserved were long – so long that Ammianus might as well be considered a reader of Plautus.

28.4.34 digitos praerodentes, / dum patinae deferuescunt.	Plautus, *Pseudolus* 884 ipsus sibi faciam ut digitos praerodat suos. *Pseudolus* 840–1 ubi omnes patinae feruont, omnis aperio, is odos dimissis manibus in caelum uolat.[126]

Nonetheless, even if Ammianus is not seen in this minimalist and minimising way as a reader of dictionaries, a third viewpoint will still be to consider him, not unreasonably, as a lexicographer, a searcher after rare words for their own sake. Hertz calls him a verbal innovator and thief of old words (*nouator uerborum* and *fur priscorum uerborum*), alluding to the accusation made against Sallust.[127] The extent of Ammianus' interest in Aulus Gellius, an

[124] 23.5.9 (Ennius *Ann.* 6.174) is probably taken directly from Cicero *Div.* 2.116; and 26.9.11 is not from Lucilius (fr. 1299–1300 Marx), but Cicero *Fin.* 5.92.

[125] See Ch. 6, Section II below.

[126] 'Chewing their fingers in anticipation, while the saucepans lose their heat.' ~ 'I'll make him chew his fingers in anticipation.' 'When all the saucepans grow hot I open them all up. That smell flies to heaven with outstretched arms.' See Salemme (1989), 18. Salemme points out a change of meaning, *deferuesco* being the opposite of *feruere*. The smell is also present in Ammianus (*praeeunte nidoris indagine*, 'the circling vapours going before')

[127] Hertz (1874a), 260. Suetonius, *De Grammaticis* 15.1–2: 'Lenaeus, the freedman of Pompeius Magnus, displayed such great love towards the memory of his patron that he attacked Sallust the historian with the bitterest satire because he had written that Pompeius was upright in speech and shameless in mind: he called him debauchee and gorger and airhead and toper, monstrous in life and writings, and moreover a most uncultivated thief of Cato's and old-fashioned vocabulary' (*praeterea priscorum Catonisque uerborum ineruditissimum furem*).

author very much concerned with linguistic curiosities, will support this – one might observe Ammianus' use (30.1.5) of the Sallustian genitive *die*, perhaps mediated through Gellius.[128]

The fourth view is that Ammianus' use of single rare words can be treated as allusion, as a potentially meaningful reference to their original contexts. Identification of the original contexts is perhaps riskier than normal. The Juvenalian *ephemeris* ('almanack', 28.4.24) is one clear example (but it is supported by the nature of the text in which it belongs). The Plautine word *sospitalis* ('health-giving') is used a number of times in Ammianus, and whereas I can see no link between Ammianus' usage and its precise context in Plautus, its presence in the first Roman digression (14.6.23), otherwise indebted to Roman comedy and satire, may surely be seen as at least interesting.[129] Likewise in other places language will seem particularly characteristic of a particular author, and perhaps be mingled with definitive allusions. One may exemplify with the vicinity of the passage concerning the escape of King Pap of Armenia. Beside the irregular genitive *die*, one may identify two certain allusions to Sallust's *Histories* (30.1.10 cf. Sallust *Hist.* 4.16,[130] 30.1.12 cf. *Hist.* 3.84).[131] It is not in this case insignificant if Pap's escape is *uitabundus* ('evasive', 30.1.13), a word found in Livy and Tacitus but most often in Sallust, and twice of Jugurtha (perhaps an allusion to *Jug.* 38.1 in particular). One can justly describe it, and the genitive *die*, as, at the least, Sallustian colour.[132] Indeed, the elusive Pap, a client-king fallen from the Romans' favour, plainly gains from the Jugurthine colouring.

[128] *pleraque die parte emensa* ('with the greater part of the day spent') cf. Sallust *Jug.* 97.3 *uix decuma parte die reliqua* ('with scarce the tenth part of the day remaining') and Gellius 9.14.26. Hertz (1874a), 301, points out that Ammianus has preserved the meaning of Sallust but reversed the meaning of the individual words. The genitive form *die* is also used at 24.2.11.

[129] For comedy in the Roman digressions see 14.6.16, 28.4.12, 27, 34 (n. 126 above). There are also a number of other instances of characteristically comedic vocabulary.

[130] Fesser (1932), 19. [131] Hertz (1874b), 10.

[132] For *uitabundus* cf. Sallust *Hist.* 3.19, Livy 25.13.4, Tacitus *Hist.* 3.37.2, Sallust *Jug.* 60.4, 101.19 and *Hist.* 3.37 (Hertz (1874b), 10). Cf. in particular *Jug.* 38.1 *ipse quasi uitabundus per saltuosa loca et tramites exercitum ductare* ('he himself as though hiding led the army through woody places and by-ways', a parallel noted by Valesius ad 30.1.13). Other passages in the later books notable for the general impact of Sallust include the war against Firmus (29.5), on which see Seager (1997b).

Of these four views, I think the third and fourth (idiosyncratic personal search for rare words, and purposeful allusion) have most validity. But with cases like these, with the use of individual words, the difficulties with intention come most to the surface. It is one thing to say that a coincidence of a single item of vocabulary is significant, intertextual, a purposed and calculated usage. But that given, it may be more difficult to identify what the purpose might be. Does the lexicographical lepidopterist in Ammianus obstruct the view of the allusive artist?

Analysis of such usages might conclude that antique and obscure words were being hoarded, that precious fragments from the ancient past were being preserved (this is the language of 'decline and fall').[133] The problem with this approach, rather as with the associated tendency to identify awareness of decline in historiography, is that such hoarding is nothing new. Sallust could be cited (Hertz does cite him)[134] for the taste for the novel and the recherché in vocabulary. In his fondness for coinages and archaisms Ammianus in a way resembles Sallust more closely than if he had embarked on a pastiche of the Sallustian style like his contemporary Aurelius Victor. The precedents are not only historiographical. A fascination for the *hapax legomena* of others can equally be identified in Hellenistic and Neoteric poetry.[135]

Looking at individual items of vocabulary warns us that intertextuality is not inevitably meaningful, or alternatively that it may be meaningful in a way which does not coincide with every reader's aesthetic. It must be questioned whether the use of a single word which has sense and significance in its context can really bear the weight of referring 'intentionally' to other uses; and if intention is assumed, the extent to which its nature is debatable and irrecoverable shines out. Larger allusions can also offer the same minimal interpretability. For example, compare Ammianus' *ut heiulans baiolorum praecentor* ('like some carriers' moaning chorus-leader', 14.7.17) with a passage from Apuleius (*De Mundo* 34–5):

namque eos qui, principio fragoris territi, sensum tamen clementiae misericordiaeque retinebant et grandaeuos parentes ereptos uolucri clade suis ceruicibus

[133] Salemme (1989). [134] See n. 127 above.
[135] E.g. Thomas (1986), 171–2 (= (1999), 114).

sustinebant, illa flammarum fluenta divino separata discidio, quasi duo flumina ex uno fonte manantia, locum illum ambire maluerunt obsidione innocenti, ubi erant boni **baiuli** religiosis sarcinis occupati. (35) postremo quod est in triremi gubernator, in curru rector, **praecentor** in choris, lex in urbe, dux in exercitu, hoc est in mundo deus . . . uideasque illam ciuitatem pariter spirantem Panchaeis odoribus et graueolentibus caenis, resonantem hymnis et carminibus et canticis, eandem etiam lamentis et ploratibus **heiulantem**.[136]

From a longish passage of Apuleius' *De Mundo* 34–5, Ammianus has filched and juxtaposed three unconnected words, all of them rarities. It is an allusion presumably discovered and perhaps also created by lexicographical investigations: the resulting phrase is admittedly striking, but it is hard to see how the source-text (a discussion of divine providence at work in the world) can create meaning. When one moves from individual items of vocabulary to larger allusions in the next section, lack of interpretability can also create unease – though I think this unease can be mitigated. Again, I begin from two of the more prominent categories in Hertz's article on Ammianus and Aulus Gellius.

IV Seven types of allusion

1 Opposites

28.4.8 ut sine diritate ominis loquamur.	Gellius 4.9.10 propter ominis diritatem.[137]
28.6.28 iussas abscidi linguas . . . ut prodigas. 29.1.8 linguam non infrenem.	Gellius 1.15.17 quorum lingua tam prodiga infrenisque sit.[138]

[136] [An example is taken from an eruption of Etna] 'For those who, though terrified when the noise started, nevertheless preserved their sense of clemency and mercy, and who snatched their elderly parents from fast-moving destruction and bore them on their shoulders, those flows of flames were split in two by a godly division, like two rivers flowing from one source, and preferred to encircle with a harmless siege that place where those good **carriers** had been occupied with their holy baggage. (35) Finally, what a helmsman is in a trireme, a driver in a chariot, a **chorus-leader** in choirs, law in a city, the commander in an army – that is what God is in the world . . . and you may see that city equally redolent of the scents of Araby and foul-smelling ordure, resounding with hymns and poems and ditties and the same also **moaning** with laments and ululations.' Owens (1958), 210.

[137] 'If we may speak without the grimness of the omen.' ~ 'Because of the grimness of the omen.' Noted by Hertz (1874a), 283.

[138] 'Their tongues were ordered to be cut out as prodigal.' 'A tongue not unbridled.' ~ 'Whose tongue is so prodigal and unbridled.' See Hertz (1874a), 298.

16.12.57 spumans denique cruore barbarico / decolor alueus [i.e. Rhenus] insueta stupebat augmenta.[139]

Ovid, *Tristia* 4.2.42
decolor ipse suo sanguine Rhenus erat.[140]

29.1.25 . . . ad ipsius Theodori causam, quasi ad **Olympici certaminis** puluerem, peruenitur. / (26) eodem die inter complura alia hoc euenerat triste / quod Salia, thesaurorum paulo ante per Thracias comes, / cum de uinculis educitur audiendus / et calceo inserit pedem, / **quasi ruina incidentis immensi terroris repente perculsus**, / **animam** inter retinentium **manus efflauit**.

Gellius 3.15.3 Diagoras [saw his sons triumph in the Olympic Games] in stadio inspectante populo in osculis atque **in manibus** filiorum **animam efflauit**. (4) [a mother whose son, reported killed at Cannae, returned alive] anus **repente** filio uiso copia atque turba et **quasi ruina incidentis inopinati gaudii oppressa** exanimataque est.[141]

16.4.2 clausa ergo urbe **murorumque intuta parte firmata** / [Iulianus] ipse cum armatis **die noctuque** inter propugnacula uisebatur / et pinnas ira exundante substridens, / cum erumpere saepe conatus / paucitate praesentis manus impediretur.

Tacitus *Hist.* 3.76.1 praeerat . . . Iulianus . . . Apollinaris . . . lasciuia socordiaque gladiatorum magis quam ducum similes. (2) non uigilias agere, non **intuta moenium firmare; noctu dieque** fluxi et amoena litorum personantes, in ministerium luxus dispersis militibus, de bello tantum inter conuiuia loquebantur.[142]

[139] Blockley (1977), 221 n. 14, suggests that the river into which the Germans were driven at Strasbourg may have been the Ill; the implication of 17.1.1, as of this allusion, is that it was the Rhine.

[140] 'Finally, foaming with barbarian gore, the discoloured river-bed [i.e. the Rhine] stood astonished at its unaccustomed increase.' ~ 'The Rhine himself was discoloured with his own blood.' Hertz (1874a), 272.

[141] 'Then it got to the case of Theodorus himself, as if to the dust of an **Olympic contest**. (26) That same day saw the following sad event among many others: that when Salia, shortly before Count of the Treasuries in Thrace, was led from his chains to be heard and inserted his foot into his shoe, **hit as it were by the stroke of great terror that suddenly fell on him, he breathed his last in the hands** of those who restrained him.' ~ 'Diagoras . . . , in the stadium and with the people looking on, **breathed his last** among the kisses and **in the arms** of his sons. (4) . . . The old woman on **suddenly** seeing her son was overcome and driven from life by the abundance and shock and **as it were by the stroke of the unhoped-for joy that befell her**.' Hertz (1874a), 287 and 300.

[142] 'So having shut the city and **strengthened the weak part of the walls** [**Julian**] himself could be seen with his soldiers on the battlements **day and night**, gnashing with overflowing anger, since though he often tried to break out he was prevented by the paucity of the troops there.' ~ 'In charge . . . were **Iulianus** and Apollinaris, . . . in profligacy and sloth more like gladiators than leaders. They did not keep watches, **they**

Ammianus' fondness for reversing the direction of the original in allusion attracts particular attention from Hertz, who pointed out the rather contrived example of the 'not unbridled tongue' (note, incidentally, the nearby use of the other adjective from the same passage, this time changed into the plural, *prodigas linguas*, 'prodigal tongues'), and the reversal of *propter ominis diritatem* to *sine ominis diritate*.[143] In this case the formal opposition of the words conveys the same basic meaning (avoiding ill-omen). One could add the example of the use of the Sallustian genitive *die*, cited above, where *pleraque die parte emensa* (30.1.5) and Sallust's *uix decuma parte die reliqua* (*Jug.* 97.3) have fundamentally the same meaning ('the greater part of the day spent' ~ 'scarce the tenth part of the day remaining'). There is a similar case when the Rhine flows red with blood after Strasbourg: in Ammianus the river is discoloured with barbarian gore, in Ovid's original with its own (i.e. barbarian) blood. The verbal contrast points to linguistic correction rather than semantic opposition: Ammianus is perhaps claiming the Rhine as Roman. It is neat, indeed almost Ovidian, to personify the river but add a touch which seems almost to pretend that the allusion does not exist (that the river 'wondered at its **unaccustomed** increase', ***insueta*** *stupebat augmenta*).[144]

The next example is a more straightforward case where the allusion marks a substantial contrast, making an ironic comparison between Salia's death from fear and the exemplary instances of death from joy. The contamination of two adjacent passages shows what will be a constant feature, and the comparison in the previous sentence of the trial of Theodorus to an Olympic contest is a further pointer for the reader to the story of Diagoras. In Ammianus' allusion at 16.4.2 to the canonical *Histories* of Tacitus there are

did not strengthen the weaknesses of the walls; **day and night** dissipated and filling the pleasure-spots of the shores with din, they scattered their soldiers to minister to their luxury, and spoke of war only at feasts.' Noted by Fornara (1992b), 436.

[143] There is an irony – or perhaps added point – to this change, as Gellius explains that ominous days are called *religiosi* which are avoided for the opposite reason (*ex contraria causa*) 'because of the grimness of the omen'.

[144] It is worth remarking that another case of passive wonder is conveyed with exactly the same word a couple of chapters earlier, when Constantius' reaction to Rome is described (16.10.6 *stupebat*, cf. 16.10.13 *obstipuit*).

three points of contact – most notably the coincidence of names between the ineffective commander Iulianus and Julian, efficacious and present in the midst of his troops[145] – against which the essential contrast is measured.

2 *Divided allusion*

14.7.8 dignus execratione cunctorum. 14.11.3 digna omnium ordinum detestatione exoso.	Gellius 2.6.3 [Busiris] detestatione execrationeque totius generis humani dignus.[146]
22.14.3 ridebatur enim [Iulianus] ut Cercops, / homo breuis umeros extentans angustos / et barbam prae se ferens hircinam / **grandiaque incedens**, tamquam Oti frater et Ephialtis, / quorum **proceritatem** Homerus in immensum extollit. 25.10.14 **incedebat** autem [Iouianus] motu corporis graui, / uultu laetissimo, / oculis caesiis, / **uasta proceritate et ardua**, / adeo ut diu nullum indumentum regium ad mensuram eius aptum inueniretur.	Gellius 9.11.5 (= Quadrigarius fr. 12 Peter) dux interea Gallorum **uasta et ardua proceritate** armisque auro praefulgentibus, **grandia ingrediens** et manu telum reciprocans **incedebat**, perque contemptum et superbiam circumspiciens despiciensque omnia uenire iubet et congredi, si quis pugnare secum ex omni Romano exercitu auderet.[147]

Another piece of potential evidence for the mechanical nature of Ammianus' allusions needs to be confronted. This is his

[145] Fornara (1992b), 436: 'The presence of *die noctuque* in the same part of the sentence in which Tacitus gives *noctu dieque* announces the textual filiation. The very artificiality of the double allusion, each of which unites in pointing a substantial contrast in the meaning of each passage, is beyond coincidence.'

[146] 'Deserving of universal execration ' 'Loathed with the deserved hatred of all classes.' ~ '[Busiris] deserving of the hatred and execration of the whole human race.' Hertz (1874a), 285 and 298.

[147] 'For Julian was ridiculed as Cercops, a short man spreading his soldiers wide and displaying a goat's beard, **and "walking with mighty gait"** like the brother of Otus and Ephialtes, whose **loftiness** Homer [*Od.* 11.305–11] raises to a great height.' 'And Jovian **walked** with a heavy movement of his body; he had a cheerful face, light blue eyes, and **massive and steep loftiness**, so that for a long time no royal garment could be found suitable for his size.' ~ 'Meanwhile a leader of the Gauls, of **massive and steep loftiness** and with weapons gleaming with gold, **walked** up and down, **striding with mighty gait** and shaking a spear in his hand, and looking about with contempt and pride and despising everything he bade some one come and meet him, if any from the whole Roman army dared fight with him.' See Hertz (1874a), 291, with further discussion 300.

habit, made much of by Hertz, of alluding to the same passages repeatedly: and, moreover, alluding to different parts of the same passage in different parts of the work, as if using up the information from his card-index. An example in miniature can be seen in the first group of passages above, where two epithets applied to Gallus Caesar in Book 14 seem to allude to the same passage of Gellius: one might also cite here the unbridled and prodigal tongues split between the end of Book 28 and beginning of Book 29 (Section IV.1 above). These cases may well be evidence of the (semi-conscious?) effect of Ammianus' reading at the time of composition (one might also adduce the bunching of his only parallels with Cicero's *Timaeus* in Books 21 and 22).[148] The variation from exact verbal repetition in such instances is not something that should surprise.

It is not untypical of Ammianus to contaminate a Homeric allusion with one to Gellius (or in this case Gellius quoting Quadrigarius).[149] The reminiscence of Gellius has been brought in with noteworthy care. It was observed by Valesius that in the words *grandiaque incedens* (which I have rendered 'and walking with "mighty gait"'), Ammianus was adding further Homeric allusion. The words are a precise calque on μακρὰ βιβάς, an oft-repeated Homeric epithet.[150] Ammianus' translation of Homer alludes to Gellius/Quadrigarius on the giant Gaul (indeed, one might say, recognises and contaminates a Homeric allusion in Quadrigarius,

[148] 21.1.1 *terroris incutiendi gratia* ('for the sake of striking fear') cf. Cicero, *Timaeus* 37 *terrorem incutiens* ('striking fear'); 22.2.3 *properabat exinde sublimior uti quodam Triptolemi curru, quem ob rapidos circumgressus* ***aeriis*** *serpentibus et* ***pinnigeris*** *fabulosa uetustas imponit* ('he hastened thence more exalted, as if in some chariot of Triptolemus, on which, because of its speedy progress, ancient legend bestowed airy and winged serpents') cf. Cicero, *Timaeus* 35 [*animantium genera*] *quorum unum diuinum atque caeleste, alterum* ***pinnigerum*** *et* ***aerium*** ('[the types of living things], of which one is godlike and heavenly, the second is winged and airy') (Hagendahl (1921), 70 n. 4); 22.8.9 *quantum potest cadere sub aspectum* ('as far as can fall within vision') cf. Cicero, *Timaeus* 11 *omnia quae sub aspectum cadunt* ('all that falls within vision'), 15 *ut sub aspectum . . . cadat* ('so that it fall within vision'), 52 *sub oculorum aspectum cadere potuissent* ('it would have been able to fall within the vision of the eyes') (Fletcher (1937), 380). None seems particularly meaningful, and I would suggest that they are probably subconscious. On subconscious repetition cf. e.g. Laughton (1950) and Gries (1951).

[149] Cf. also 19.3.3, 22.6.2, and Salemme (1989), 71–3.

[150] Alexander *Il.* 3.22, Ajax *Il.* 7.213, Achilles' ghost *Od.* 11.539.

but corrects it so that it scans as the first half of a hexameter). The mockery of Julian's size and his dedication to sacrifice is not uttered in the authorial voice (though Ammianus criticises Julian's sacrifices in his obituary, and his physique is not admired in the same manner as, say, Valentinian's).[151] What makes the comparison to Gellius interesting is that a passage which had been deployed negatively towards Julian is also employed in one of the few passages to be favourable to Jovian. There is certainly not enough similarity between the passages to comprise an internal allusion without the help of the Gellius passage. The precise import of these allusions may not be obvious, but it looks to be more than simply using up a card-index. There is an intriguing contamination of Gellius/Quadrigarius and Homer, a correction of Quadrigarius, and an intra-textual contrast between Julian and Jovian.[152]

3 Punning alterations

14.6.25 aut pugnaciter aleis certant, / turpi sono fragosis naribus introrsum reducto spiritu concrepantes.	Cicero *Acad.* 2.65 aut certare cum aliis pugnaciter.[153]
28.4.5 tanta plerosque labes insanabilium flagitiorum oppressit.	Sallust *Cat.* 36.5 tanta uis morbi atque uti tabes plerosque ciuium animos inuaserat. *Jug.* 32.4 tanta uis auaritiae in animos eorum ueluti tabes inuaserat. *Hist.* 1.77.19 si tanta torpedo animos oppressit.[154]
14.6.13 aetatem . . . in stipite conteres summittendo.	Cicero *Leg.* 1.53 aetatem in litibus conterere.[155]

[151] 30.9.6.

[152] Indeed the passage is also the source for the positive *exemplum* of Corvinus (24.4.5).

[153] 'Or aggressively they contend with dice, dinning with a vulgar sound as they draw in breath through their thunderous nostrils.' ~ 'Or to contend aggressively with others.' Allusion observed by Michael (1874), 31. See discussion in Blockley (1998), 311.

[154] 'So great was the stain of incurable ills which had overwhelmed most people.' ~ 'So great a force of disease and as it were plague had invaded most of the citizen's minds.' 'So great a force of greed had invaded their minds like a disease.' 'If such great sluggishness has overwhelmed your minds.' Owens (1958). Some manuscripts of the *Histories* have *obrepsit* ('has crept into').

[155] 'You'll waste your . . . life submitting to the blockhead.' ~ '. . . To waste their life in quarrels.' Parallel noted by de Jonge ad loc., and punning by Blockley (1998), 311 n. 34.

19.6.2 abiecta uiuendi cupiditate.	Cicero *Fam.* 4.7.2 cum spe uincendi simul abiecisti certandi cupiditatem.[156]
31.16.9 pro uirium . . . mensura.	Cicero *De Or.* 3.183 aurium mensura.[157]
27.9.2 transferendae . . . in alios inuidiae artifex.	Tacitus *Hist.* 2.86.2 serendae in alios inuidiae artifex.[158]
15.8.13 audendi in tempore consideratus hortator.	Livy 7.32.11 . . . qui audiendus dumtaxat magnificus adhortator sit, uerbis tantum ferox, operum militarium expers.[159]
26.7.9 promissis uberrimis inhiantes.	Cicero *Tusc.* 5.19 philosophiae promissum uberius. *Cat.* 3.19 uberibus lupinis inhiantem.[160]

4 Alterations of context

19.1.7 contemplator peritissimus [of managing a catapult].	Apuleius, *Florida* 182 Thales . . . astrorum peritissimus contemplator.[161]
31.2.11 [Hunni] flexiloqui et obscuri.	Cicero *Div.* 2.115 oraculis . . . flexiloquis et obscuris.[162]
22.4.3 [temple-robbing courtiers of Constantius] nec largiendi nec rapiendi nec absumendi tenuere aliquem modum.	Suetonius, *Nero* 30.2 [Nero's extravagance] quare nec largiendi nec absumendi modum tenuit.[163]

[156] 'With the desire for living cast away.' ~ 'Together with the hope for winning you cast away the desire for competing.' Blockley (1998), 311 n. 34. Cf. the double meaning of *uictura*, 14.6.3.

[157] 'According to the measure of my strength.' ~ 'By the measure of the ears.' Blockley (1998), 306.

[158] 'A craftsman when it came to transferring ill-will to others.' ~ 'A craftsman when it came to sowing ill-will in others.' Fornara (1992b), 433.

[159] 'A thoughtful encourager of daring at the appropriate time.' ~ 'The sort who, worth hearing for sure, is a splendid encourager, fierce only in words, ignorant of military operations.' Fornara (1992b), 434.

[160] 'Gaping for fruitful promises.' ~ 'The fruitful promise of philosophy.' 'Gaping for wolves' teats.' See Michael (1874), 33; Owens (1958), 35: 'Is it possible, in view of the examples given above, that Amm. also has in mind here Cicero *in Cat.* 3.19 *uberibus lupinis inhiantem*, where *uberibus* is from the noun *uber*, "teat", "udder", instead of the adjective *uber*, "copious"?'

[161] 'A most skilful observer.' ~ 'A most skilful observer of the stars.' De Jonge ad loc.

[162] '[The Huns] tongue-twisted and obscure.' ~ 'Oracles tongue-twisted and obscure.' Cf. 18.5.6.

[163] 'Nor did they observe any restraint in extravagance, robbery and theft.' ~ 'Therefore he showed restraint neither in extravagance nor squandering.' Den Boeft *et al.* ad loc. wonder whether Ammianus here understands Suetonius; he apparently uses *absumendi*

Allusions such for as the one that contrasts the Tacitean Iulianus to Ammianus' Julian (quoted above Section IV.1) display an anarchic logic. But the punning alterations could be interpreted as the most striking examples of the way in which Ammianus' art of allusion involves redeploying the texts of the past as little more than building blocks.[164] He appears to play deliberately with the possibility of misreading, a form of *uariatio* far more threatening to the possibility of keeping allusion under control than any difficulty in identifying it. To be associated with the puns are those passages where an exact form of words is preserved and the meaning is altered: in one example above it is even suggested that this is the result of miscomprehension.

Most of the punning alterations which Ammianus imposes are *lectiones difficiliores*, where the 'original' has been turned into something more unusual. To contest aggressively in dicing (*aleis*) is more striking than aggressive competition with others (*cum aliis*); dicing aggressively is a surprising image. *Stipes* ('block') is a rarer word than *lis* ('quarrel') – as a term of contempt it is rarer still – and to wear out your existence in quarrels is less striking than doing so on a blockhead. The eagerness of the soldiery for the riches promised by Procopius (*promissis uberrimis inhiantes*) contaminates and warps in sense two quite distinct passages of Cicero. It is worth pointing out that *promissis* can be either substantive or adjective, so, beyond the actual meaning 'gaping at the abundance of promises', the possibility of misreading *uberrimis* as *uberibus* would provide the image of hanging on dangling (or promised) udders. The latter image, the misreading, is less metaphorical than the actual text, 'gaping at [or hanging on] fertile promises'. All of these punning alterations push the language further towards the metaphorical. The same process is arguably taking place when the Huns become *flexiloqui et obscuri*

to mean robbery when Suetonius uses it to mean squandering. The error is possible, but equally likely is purposeful correction of the original.

[164] Another example: Hertz (1874a), 297, would like a description of Gallus as *Gallum suopte ingenio trucem* (14.11.3) to be a play on some Gaul in Ammianus' literary predecessors, though such a text has not survived ('Gallus/the Gaul, by his very nature savage').

('tongue-twisted and obscure'), words which Cicero had used of oracles.[165] The use of the physical as a metaphor for the emotional (the direction of many of these changes) is peculiarly apt in an author in whom physical representations are so often a window into character. The process of allusion has sometimes been compared in its effects to metaphor, and here we have examples of allusions which draw attention to the metaphorical nature of Ammianus' language.

It must be noted that the punning allusions do not merely draw attention to the metaphorical nature of Ammianus' language, but also draw attention to themselves as allusions. They are apt to their contexts, and invite comparison with the source-texts. The allusion to Sallust which introduces the second Roman digression offers a possible model in the moralising digressions of Sallust's monographs, and comes amid a number of other Sallustian allusions.[166] The Roman digressions contain a number of allusions to Cicero's philosophical works (in particular there are two virtual transcriptions of the *De Amicitia* in 28.4.12, quoted below, and 28.4.26); as the digressions deal with the misinterpretation of friendship by the Roman Senate and people, misreadings of philosophical texts are not out of place.

[165] *Flexiloquus* is only in Ammianus and Cicero. *Obscurus* is sometimes, but untypically, used of persons.

[166] 28.4.3 cf. Sallust *Jug.* 89.7. It might be questioned whether Ammianus' *labes* ('blot, stain') should not simply be emended on the basis of the Sallustian comparanda to *tabes* ('plague') (Owens (1958)). The metaphor of plague is appropriate to the *insanabilium flagitiorum*, 'unhealable sins', which follow it, and the *exemplum* of Epimenides (*ut nec Epimenides ille Cretensis, si fabularum ritu ab inferis excitatus redisset ad nostra, solus purgare sufficeret Romam*, 'so that not even that Cretan, Epimenides, if in the fashion of tales he was aroused from the dead and returned to our times, would suffice by himself to heal Rome', 28.4.5): Epimenides had woken from a seventy-nine-year sleep and cleansed Athens from plague. But a stain or a slippage may also be *insanabilis*, and punning alterations in the first Roman digression must be taken into account too. So must two places in Livy also adduced by Wirz (1877), 629, though the integrity of the text might be again questioned here: 39.9.1 *huius mali labes . . . Romam uelut contagione morbi penetrauit* ('the blot of this evil spread to Rome like the contagion of a disease') and 42.5.7 *contagione uelut tabes in Perrhaebiam quoque id peruaserat malum* ('by contagion, like a plague, this ill had also spread into Perrhaebia').

5 *Glossing*

28.4.12 horum domus otiosi quidam garruli frequentant, / uariis **assentandi** figmentis / ad singula ulterioris fortunae uerba plaudentes, / **parasitorum in comoediis facetias** affectando. / ut enim illi sufflant **milites gloriosos**, / obsidiones et pugnas contra **milia hostium**, / isdem ut **heroicis aemulis** assignantes, / ita hi quoque columnarum constructiones, / alta fronte suspensas mirando, / atque parietes lapidum circumspectis coloribus nitidos / ultra mortalitatem nobiles uiros extollunt.

Cicero *Amic.* 98 nec **parasitorum in comoediis assentatio faceta** nobis uideretur, nisi essent **milites gloriosi**.

Plautus, *Miles Gloriosus* 46 septem **milia** [men killed].
Miles Gloriosus 61–2 rogitabant: 'hicine **Achilles** est?' inquit mihi. 'Immo eius frater' inquam 'est.'[167]

30.4.11 hi uelut fata natalicia praemonstrantes, / aut **Sibyllae oraculorum interpretes**, / **uultus grauitate** ad habitum **composita** tristiorem, / ipsum quoque uenditant, quod oscitantur. / (12) hi ut altius uideantur iura callere, / **Trebatium** loquuntur et **Cascellium** et **Alfenum** / et **Auruncorum Sicanorumque** iam diu leges ignotas, / **cum Euandri**

Gellius 4.1.1 uocisque et **uultus grauitate composita** tamquam **interpres** et arbiter **Sibyllae oraculorum**.
Gellius 1.10.1 Fauorinus philosophus adulescenti ueterum uerborum cupidissimo et plerasque uoces nimis priscas et ignotas in cotidianis communibusque sermonibus expromenti: 'Curius' inquit 'et Fabricius et Coruncanius, antiquissimi uiri, et his antiquiores Horatii illi trigemini plane ac

[167] 'These fellows' homes are frequented by certain chattering idlers, who applaud the individual words of loftier status with various pretences at **agreement**, adopting **the witticisms of parasites in comedies**. For just as these puff up **haughty soldiers**, attributing to them sieges and battles against a **thousand** foes just as to their **heroic rivals**, so too their counterparts marvel at the engineering of columns erected with lofty aspect and walls gleaming with the eye-catching colours of precious stones, and exalt aristocratic men above ordinary mortals.' ~ 'Nor would the **agreement of parasites in comedies** seem **witty** to us, did there not exist **haughty soldiers**.' The Ciceronian echo was first observed by Valesius ad loc. But the passage echoes, as well as Plautus' title, his parasite's claim of 'seven **thousand**' men killed and 'they kept asking questions: "Is this fellow **Achilles**?", she says to me. "In fact his brother", I say, "that's who".' (Seyfarth (1969), 454. Salemme (1989), 32, also compares *Miles Gloriosus* 1054–5). The allusion to *milites gloriosi* may be inspired by Cicero, but Ammianus refers beyond the cliché to what might be regarded as the original, Plautus. The passage should be seen in the context of the various allusions to Roman comedy in the Roman digressions (above n. 129).

matre abhinc saeculis obrutas **multis**.

dilucide cum suis fabulati sunt neque **Auruncorum** aut **Sicanorum** aut Pelasgorum, qui primi coluisse Italiam dicuntur, sed aetatis suae uerbis locuti sunt; (2) tu autem, proinde quasi **cum matre Euandri** nunc loquare, sermone **abhinc multis annis** iam desito uteris, quod scire atque intellegere neminem uis, quae dicas.'[168]

Trebatius cf. Horace *Serm.* 2.1.4.
Cascellius cf. Horace *AP* 371.
Alfenus Varus cf. Horace *Serm.* 1.3.130.[169]

These two passages of Ammianus are both from digressions in a satirical vein. The original texts to which they allude in turn point towards the other texts with which they are contaminated (a form of what are sometimes called 'window allusions').[170] In the first case, characteristics of the Plautine characters of the sycophant and *miles gloriosus* are imposed on latter-day nobles and their flatterers. Both allusions are pointed. Cicero, analysing warped forms of friendship, uses a theatrical metaphor to point out how sycophancy feeds on vanity. Ammianus is much concerned with abuses of friendship in the Roman digressions,[171] but his real

[168] 'These men, as though revealing fatal horoscopes, or **the translators of the Sibyl's oracles, carefully arrange their serious faces** into a gloomy expression and even sell the very fact that they yawn. (12) In order to seem experts on the law, they talk **Trebatius** and **Cascellius** and **Alfenus** and legislation of the **Auruncians** and **Sicanians**, long-lost and buried **with Evander's mother many centuries ago**.' ~ '**With the seriousness of his** voice and **face carefully arranged, as if he was the translator** and master **of the Sibyl's oracles**' (the story is of a pompous grammarian, satisfyingly deflated by Favorinus: Favorinus thus links this passage with Ammianus' other source-passage in Gellius). 'Favorinus the philosopher addressed a young man who was very fond of old words and used to uncork many excessively hoary and unknown phrases in everyday commonplace conversations: "Curius and Fabricius and Coruncanius, the most ancient of men, and those three Horatii, yet more ancient than these, would discourse simply and pellucidly with their own contemporaries; they didn't speak with the words of the **Auruncians** or **Sicanians** or Pelasgians, who are said to have been the first inhabitants of Italy, but with those of their own time. (2) You, however, since you are now speaking as if **with Evander's mother**, are using language that was outmoded **many years ago** because you want nobody to know and to understand what you are saying."' Lindenbrog ad loc. identified the allusions; Salemme (1989), 45, points out Favorinus as a common feature.

[169] Cf. Salemme (1989), 46. [170] See Section IV.6 below.

[171] Cf. also the quotation from *De Amicitia* 79 at 28.4.26.

parasites are more obviously acting (*uariis . . . figmentis, . . . facetias affectando*) than the characters from comedy with whom they are compared. Ammianus intensifies (as it were annotating) Cicero's suggestion at the Plautine original by adding details of the flattery, and then a contrast is introduced between the old sycophants and the new: instead of praising military exploits and introducing dubious heroic *exempla*, they bathetically laud their boastful patrons 'beyond mere mortality' (*ultra mortalitatem*) for the size of their columns and the variegated colours of their walls.

The latter passage displays the anarchic spirit of carnival which Hertz discovered in Ammianus. Carmelo Salemme has observed that two passages from Gellius containing anecdotes about the philosopher Favorinus are joined. Favorinus comments on a young man's using words obsolete for many years: Ammianus corrects this from his own perspective to many centuries. One might also call it rhetorical *amplificatio*, intensification of a topos.[172] But to change the subject matter of Gellius from words to laws he has to replace three archaic and non-legal names, Curius, Fabricius and Coruncanius. It has been observed that the three names he chooses, Trebatius, Cascellius and Alfenus, are mentioned in Horace as roughly contemporary jurisconsults. Why Horace? Because in Gellius the three names are followed by *et his antiquiores Horatii illi trigemini* ('and yet more ancient that these, those three Horatii'). It appears that Ammianus has decided on an elaborate and jocular misreading of *Horatii* as a genitive ('and older than/preferable to these, those triplets of Horace's'), and consequently inserted three names obtained from Horace.[173]

6 *Window allusion*

26.10.19 et ad secundum lapidem fere procul a litore / contortae sunt aliquae [i.e.	Vergil *Aen.* 1.120–3 iam ualidam Ilionei nauem, iam fortis Achatae, et qua uectus Abas, et qua grandaeuus Aletes

[172] Cf. Hinds (1998), 34–47, on the hundred mouths topos.

[173] The connection from Gellius to Horace might alternatively, or additionally, have been suggested by the fact that, in the same satire in which Horace mentions Alfenus, he like Ammianus uses Evander to denote extreme antiquity (*Serm.* 1.3.91) (Salemme (1989), 46).

naues], / ut Laconicam prope
Mothonen oppidum nos
transeundo conspeximus, /
diuturna carie fatiscentem.

uicit hiems; laxis laterum compagibus omnes
accipiunt inimicum imbrem rimisque
fatiscunt.

Ovid, *Tristia* 5.12.27–8

uertitur in teneram **cariem** rimisque de**hiscit**
siqua **diu** solitis cumba uacauit aquis.[174]

Where Cicero had referred to *milites gloriosi*, Ammianus expanded his reference to the passage with allusions to Plautus' *Miles gloriosus*. This is an example of what is sometimes called 'window allusion': an allusion to two separate but already related texts which recognises and draws attention to the earlier relationship.[175] It has long been recognised that Ammianus alludes to Vergil at the end of Book 26. Though there is only one word in common, the use of *fatisco* for a ship's timbers is particularly rare.

As often in personal descriptions, Ammianus includes a Vergilian allusion: in this case to the storm in *Aeneid* 1 (120–3). Such an allusion is not, on reflection, inappropriate to the implicit metaphor by which the storm-tossed ship represents the battered Roman state. But I shall draw attention here to two further features of the allusion. Firstly, that *diuturna* can be read as an embedded marker of intertextuality. That is to say, beyond the literal meaning that the boat had been rotting for a long time, *diuturnus* also implies the antiquity of the image of the 'yawning' boat.[176] Secondly, closer inspection reveals that Ammianus alludes to Ovid's allusion to the same passage in *Tristia* 5.12.27–8. The Ovidian passage shares the idea that wood in beached ships gapes apart with decay: specifically it shares the vocabulary of rotting (*caries*), length of time (*diu* ~ *diuturnus*), and the ship splitting apart (*fatiscunt* ~ *dehiscit*). When Ovid replaced Vergil's *fatisco* with *dehisco*, he was recalling

[174] 'And others [i.e. ships] were hurled nearly two miles from the shore, like the Laconian vessel near the town of Methone which I saw when I passed by, yawning apart from long decay.' ~ 'Now the stout ship of Ilioneus, now of brave Achates, and that wherein Abas sailed and that of aged Aletes, the storm has mastered: with side-joints loosened, all take in the hostile flood and yawn with cracks.' 'If any barque has long been out of its accustomed waters, it turns to soft decay and gapes with cracks.'

[175] See Ch. 1, n. 27 for bibliography.

[176] For further discussion of such phenomena see Hinds (1998), Ch. 1, and above pp. 18, 184–5. The fact that such markers are 'embedded' does of course make it hard to prove their existence, since in every case they also have a literal function in the text.

the etymology *fatim hisco* > *fatisco*.[177] Ammianus recognises the double allusion and 'corrects' Ovid by bringing his language closer to that of his model.

7 *Exemplary*

17.9.4 'Quo trahimur spe meliorum abolita, / olim quidem dura et **perpessu asperrima** / per niues tolerantes et acumina crudelium pruinarum? / sed nunc (pro nefas!) cum ultimis hostium **fatis instamus**, / **fame ignauissimo mortis genere** tabescentes. / (5) et nequi nos turbarum existimet concitores, / pro uita loqui sola testamur, / non aurum neque argentum petentes, / quae olim nec contrectare potuimus nec uidere, / ita nobis negata, / uelut **contra rem publicam tot suscepisse labores et pericula confutatis**.'

Sallust *Hist.* 2.98.1 (*Epistula Cn. Pompei ad Senatum*) si **aduorsus** uos **patriam**que et deos penates **tot labores et pericula suscepissem**, quotiens a prima adulescentia ductu meo scelestissumi hostes fusi et uobis salus quaesita est, nihil amplius in absentem me statuissetis quam adhuc agitis, patres conscripti, quem contra aetatem proiectum ad bellum saeuissumum cum exercitu optume merito, quantum est in uobis, **fame miserruma omnium morte**, **confecistis**.[178]

Cicero *Tusc.* 2.20 o multa dictu grauia, **perpessu aspera**.[179]

Silius Italicus 1.268 ergo **instat fatis** . . .[180]

[177] See Servius ad *Aen.* 1.123: *fatim hisco* = to open plentifully (*fatim* is a hapax, comparable to *affatim*), *fatisco* = to gape.

[178] '"Where are we being dragged off to, robbed of the hope of better things? We have long endured a life that's tough and most harsh to endure amidst the snows and the pinch of cruel frosts. But now, for shame, we are **pressing upon the** final **fates** of the foe, while wasting away **from hunger, the most shameful type of death**. (5) And nobody should think that we are rabble rousers: we swear we're speaking for our lives alone, and ask neither for gold nor silver – those we have not been able to see or touch, they have been denied us as though we had been **convicted of undertaking all those toils and dangers against the republic**."' ~ 'If it had been **against** you and **the fatherland** and the ancestral gods **that I had undertaken all those toils and dangers**, whenever from first youth under my command the wickedest of foes have been routed and safety achieved for yourselves, you could not have decreed anything more severe against me than you are now doing, fathers of the Senate. Thrown despite my age into a most savage war with a very well deserving army, you have, as much as you could, destroyed me with **hunger, the wretchedest of all deaths**.' Hertz (1874b), 11, Fesser (1932), 18, Owens (1958), 182. Cf. 25.7.4 *fame ignauissimo genere mortis* ('from hunger, the basest type of death'), 19.10.1 *famem ultimum malorum omnium* ('hunger, the utmost of all evils').

[179] 'O much that's hard to speak of, harsh to suffer.' Fletcher (1937), 379. Cf. also Cicero *Tusc.* 2.29 *asperum est . . . difficile perpessu, triste, durum* ('it [pain] is harsh, difficult to suffer, miserable, cruel') (Owens (1958), 144), Cicero *Fin.* 4.72 *eum asperum et difficilem perpessu . . . esse* ('that it is harsh and difficult to suffer') (Owens (1958), 127).

[180] 'Therefore he presses on the fates.' Fletcher (1937), 389.

This double allusion to the letter of Pompeius, a famous part of the ultra-canonical *Histories* of Sallust, is blatant to a higher degree. In Sallust, the complaint of Pompeius to the Senate at the under-provisioning of his troops barely covers the implicit threats. The beginning and the end of the long first sentence of Sallust's letter are taken up (note also how the last word *confutatis* echoes the sound of *confecistis*), but the differences and the omissions are also crucial to the situation. In Ammianus the complaints are in the mouths of the troops, are addressed to Julian, and are preceded by insults ('calling him an Asian, a Greekling and a deceiver, and a dullard with the appearance of wisdom', *Asianum appellans, / Graeculum et fallacem, / et specie sapientiae stolidum*, 17.9.3). It is subsequently made clear (17.9.6) that the blame is not his, but that of the distant authority of Constantius. There are significant differences: the threat of rebellion is (on the surface) absent, and anger is directed by the troops at the local authority of Julian rather than at Constantius, at whom it would rightly be aimed. Likewise Pompeius' pride in his achievements (*quotiens a prima adulescentia ductu meo scelestissumi hostes fusi et uobis salus quaesita est . . . quem contra aetatem proiectum ad bellum saeuissumum cum exercitu optume merito*) is absent, but is very easily applicable to Julian and reminiscent of some of the language Ammianus uses of him elsewhere.[181] By removing what would be justifiable pride on Julian's lips altogether, and shifting the justifiable but misdirected complaint to the lips of his troops, he prepares the way for the fact that Julian *will* rebel, as Pompeius had threatened to. Unlike the morally dubious Pompeius, Julian makes no threats or boasts, and his eventual rebellion will be presented (by Julian, and by Ammianus) as the doing of his troops. Ammianus' presentation of Julian's usurpation has been seen as tendentious and exculpatory, though (consciously or not) it shows better than any other account how Julian allowed it to happen, in such a way that he could be represented as reluctant.[182] This allusion – close to *exemplum* – seems to foreshadow the usurpation and the way it will be presented. It also helps justify it.[183]

[181] E.g. 16.1.5, 20.5.4. [182] Tomlin (1980), 269.
[183] This is not the only case of subtle justification of Julian's usurpation: see Kelly (2005).

23.5.17 [Julian speaks] nec errauere diu manes inulti, quod ueluti librante Iustitia, omnes qui in eius [sc. Gordiani] conspirauere <perniciem> cruciabilibus interiere suppliciis.	Julian *Caes.* 313B [on the killers of Alexander Severus] ἀλλ' ἔγωγε, εἶπεν ἡ Δίκη, πάντας αὐτούς, ὅσοι μεταίτιοι γεγόνασι τούτων, κολασθησομένους παραδώσω.[184]

The speech which Julian makes as the army embarks on the Persian expedition abounds in *exempla*, aptly enough for a ruler *antiquitatum peritus*, expert on antiquities (23.5.21). One of the more developed of these is that of the emperor Gordian III, whose death at the hands of the faction of Philip, the treacherous Praetorian Prefect, prevented Roman victory. I shall not focus here on the very interesting implications of this *exemplum* for Julian himself (these will be discussed below in Chapter 7).[185] Julian's additional comment, about the punishment of his killers by Justice, is conventional enough;[186] but it has escaped notice that the words Ammianus gives Julian in his sequence of *exempla* of Roman history derive from Julian's own reduced Roman history at the start of his Menippean satire, the *Caesares*. The presence of personified Justice, the preservation of the order of the sentence, the placing of the example in Julian's speech rather than elsewhere, all militate against a chance resemblance. Ammianus has carefully shifted the subject matter of treacherous death and divine punishment away from Alexander Severus on to Gordian III, a better *exemplum* for Julian, for reasons that will become apparent below. In this sense Ammianus corrects Julian, and in another: Julian's *Caesares* leaves out the emperors from Alexander to Valerian (perhaps the emperor was avoiding the difficulty of Philip the crypto-Christian and Decius the persecutor). Ammianus draws attention to this 'mistake' by changing Julian's reference to another ruler who fell within that gap.[187] This allusion

[184] 'Nor did his spirit wander long unavenged, because as though Justice was weighing them, all those who conspired for his <destruction> perished with torturous punishments.' ~ '"But I", said Justice, "will hand over all those who shared the guilt in this for punishment."' This is an editorial correction of the manuscripts' εἶπε τῇ Δίκῃ. The manuscripts' reading may be right, in which case it will mean either '"But I", said he [Silenus], "will hand over to Justice . . ."' or, differently punctuated, '"But I", said Silenus to Justice, "will hand over . . ."'

[185] See below Chapter 7, Section 1.

[186] See den Boeft *et al.* ad 23.5.13.

[187] *HA Gord.* 33.5 has a similar statement regarding the destruction of Gordian's assassins, so it may be that Ammianus' correction also brings Julian closer to the historiographical

should act as a reminder that relationships to contemporary works and historical sources (which the *Caesares* surely is for the character of Julian) do not operate in a way fundamentally different from other forms of intertextuality.

V A late-antique aesthetic?

If there is a constant in Ammianus' technique of allusion in these examples above, it is in the fondness for contamination, for bringing together diverse texts and different passages of the same texts. We saw in the first chapter the bones at Ad Salices uniting two pieces of Vergil with Tacitus, Silius, the exegetical tradition, and Libanius.[188] This investigation also has thrown together a few examples which bring together more startlingly varied texts (Homer and Quadrigarius, Horace and Gellius).[189] These madder combinations might seem to support the argument of Hertz. But it must be emphasised that in many places this contamination is consistent, from within a single work, author, or genre. Enshrining such intra- and intertextual connections in his text appears an obsession with Ammianus.

On the grander scale too, when one moves from individual allusions to questions of genre (which might be defined as intertextuality on a massive scale), diversity and contamination of influences are constants. The *Res Gestae* can obviously be defined as an example of grandiose classical historiography, but thereafter definition becomes harder. There is a tendency to say that the *Res Gestae*'s model is Tacitus, or Greek historiography, or that it is a history which has formed a union with the Ciceronian or the biographical tradition. These attempts do not satisfy. The absence of any obvious and major model doubtless makes the diversity of the many minor models stand out all the more. On the small scale and the grand, his intertextuality can appear voracious and promiscuous rather than directed. (This image matches what else we know about

tradition. However, the punishment of evil-doers in this fashion is a topos (see e.g. den Boeft *et al.* ad loc.), so too much should not be read into this passage. Compare also Zosimus 1.65 on Probus' revenge on the killers of Aurelian and Tacitus.

[188] See pp. 16–24 above. [189] Section IV.2, 5 above.

Ammianus: the multiplicity of his sources of information, his globalising and encyclopedic digressions; his emphasis on the benefits, whether in himself or others, of wide knowledge in both languages (e.g. 15.13.1, 18.5.1). His geographical *excursus* concern themselves with provinces and cities and their Hellenic and Roman founders and colonisers: so what matters in Gaul is both Hercules and the Roman conquest (15.9.10). His historical examples belong equally to the two cultures, the Greek and the Roman. Such universalism of course excludes, amidst much else, Judaism, Christianity, and the many regional languages of the Roman Empire.)

This great variety and great mixing of source-texts has led a number of Ammianus' readers to use the metaphor of the mosaic to describe his work. It was deployed among others by Thompson (in the context of source criticism)[190] and by de Jonge,[191] but it is most elaborated by Salemme, who speaks of the '"method" of Ammianus, who loves to take his cue from various sources, then to hide them as though in a composite mosaic'.[192] Furthermore, the comparison to late-antique art has an analogy in what Michael Roberts has called the 'Jewelled Style'. Roberts was mainly dealing with late-antique Latin verse, and mainly Christian verse: he was attempting to justify its overly episodic nature and odd structures by comparing it to late-antique art, an aesthetic with a fondness for the purple patch. He perceived a meta-poetic quality in ecphrases of jewelled objects. Roberts fittingly applied his theories of a late-antique aesthetic to Ammianus' famous description of Constantius II's *aduentus* to Rome in 357, an impressionistic ecphrasis which darts swiftly and without obvious logic from one to another of the various dazzling details of the literally jewelled procession, and produces an entirely admirable whole (16.10).[193] The metaphor of the jewelled style is of course stylistic rather than specifically intertextual; but then, for Salemme, the individual allusion, often preserved in something like its pristine state, can also be seen as a decorative and dazzling jewel as much as or more than a reference

[190] Thompson (1947), 33: 'His work, therefore, in so far as it depended on written sources, was a mosaic.'

[191] De Jonge ad 15.3.11: 'Here again one of the numerous flowers of speech, with which Amm[ianus] embellishes his Byzantine mosaic of style, while he slightly changes it.'

[192] Salemme (1989), 26. [193] See Roberts (1988), and Kelly (2003), 598–600.

imparting meaning. The mosaic too will work as metaphor for stylistic purposes, and it is a true and valid observation that old materials are often combined to make quite new images. The picture that Ammianus builds up is made of fragments from a variety of sources, and he has a taste for the eye-catching fragment, the glinting *tessera*.

The metaphor is not invariably used politely. I have already quoted Fornara on 'the illusion (not uncommon in the fourth century), that his history, in order to qualify as a literary production, needed to be a mosaic containing precious older material'.[194] It is true, of course, that one can interpret 'older material' – whether that means verbal archaisms, *exempla*, quotations from Cicero, allusions to Sallust – as 'decorative'. But the metaphor breaks down when one goes beyond the narrow confines of vocabulary. The origins of the material become identifiable and suggestive. The broken glass and fragments of gold that go to make a mosaic do not speak of their origins. In the end, I see little difference between Ammianus as Hertz's card-indexer and as Salemme's mosaicist, whatever Salemme's protestations.[195] The main difference is that the metaphor of the mosaic implies appreciation for the beauty of the end result. Salemme is willing to use other metaphors: an archive, a library, a collage.[196] Alongside this assemblage of fragments, it is important for Salemme to stress the concealment of allusions, and the absence of traditional *imitatio/aemulatio*. The recovery of the library 'has a precise cultural valency in the commemoration of the past in the only form possible in the fourth century'. The authors of the past are recalled and echoed, perhaps, with nostalgia fitting for a pagan author in the new world which was being built. He concludes by calling the *Res Gestae* a building formed on the detritus of a past which must at all costs be made to live again.[197]

This cultural history is familiar (indeed the term 'nostalgia' has been used of Ammianus in a similar manner by T. D. Barnes).[198]

[194] Fornara (1992b), 438. [195] For polemic see Salemme (1989), 44.
[196] Salemme (1989), 37, 58.
[197] Salemme (1989), 58 ('ha una precisa valenza culturale di rievocazione del passato nell'unica forma possibile nel IV secolo . . . nostalgia che non doveva essere estranea al pagano Ammiano nel contesto di un nuovo mondo che si stava edificando').
[198] Barnes (1990), 83–4.

Salemme is right to perceive the importance of the exclusion of the Christian past. But the impression of the fourth century as an age of ruins and the collapse of pagan culture, though it has the benefit of hindsight, strikes me as fundamentally overstated, indeed false. It seems to swallow naïvely two old narratives of the Roman Empire, 'Christian triumphalism' and 'decline and fall', both of which attempt to back-date to the fourth century what indubitably happened in the fifth. As for the supposed absence of *aemulatio*, or imitation as rivalry, the traditional *imitatio/aemulatio* seems present in many of the examples which I have raised. (As the need to insert a slash between the words implies, the distinction of *aemulatio* from *imitatio* is problematic, because it suggests that the critic who defines it has insight into the alluding author's precise view of the author to whom he alludes.) Ammianus' modesty and respect towards the past has generally been overestimated:[199] it certainly does not preclude *aemulatio*, rivalry, with past authors. Beyond one small-scale example of *aemulatio* above (correcting Quadrigarius' Homeric allusion to make it scan), I showed in Chapter 1 how Ammianus in describing the bones on the battlefield of Ad Salices probably brings an allusion to Tacitus back towards its Vergilian original: in the same place he glosses the Vergil with a further Vergilian allusion and accompanies it with a correction of the exegetical tradition. Ammianus here is reacting to the text of Vergil in precisely the same manner as Silius Italicus and Tacitus reacted to the same passages.[200] The Roman digressions (14.6, 28.4) adopt a relationship of *aemulatio*, since with both the detailed and larger-scale intertextuality of these set pieces he reverses Juvenal's contempt for foreigners and turns it back on the native Romans, even including a gnomic remark on Juvenal (28.4.14).[201] The same remark challenges Marius Maximus, source for part of the period Ammianus covered. And his historical rivalries are a constant theme, with his disdain for certain (unnamed) ways of writing history.[202] In 359 he gazed from a

[199] As well argued by Blockley (1998), esp. 308–9. [200] See pp. 20–4 above.
[201] See e.g. Rees (1999); I intend to write on these passages elsewhere.
[202] 15.1.1, 21.16.7 (though Frakes (1994) argues that *dicta saepius*, 'things said rather often', refers entirely to earlier parts of the history, I suspect a reference to the abbreviated tradition); 26.1.1, 27.2.11, 28.1.15.

height at the Persian army on the horizon and compared himself to Herodotus: it would be forced to see modesty in his language, as he contrasts his own autopsy with the fables of Greece (18.6.23).[203] The main way in which Ammianus can be argued to lack *aemulatio* is in that he does not have one main model.

Hertz's card-index, Salemme's mixed metaphors on mosaics, Roberts' 'Jewelled Style', all these approaches share a common periodisation. Admittedly one man's decline of the classical world is another's late antiquity. But both approaches seem to follow on from an acceptance that the Latin literary canon ends with Juvenal (or sometimes Apuleius). The most perceptive critics of *The Jeweled Style* (anticipated by Roberts himself) have pointed out that the focus on the purple patch in contrast to the whole, and the meta-poetic representation of this style in ecphrases, are characteristic of Latin literature long before Late Antiquity, and that they are typical of the so-called 'Silver Age'.[204]

Ammianus is of his age in abundant ways, some of which relate to allusion. Blending genres and blurring their boundaries is by no means exclusively a late-antique feature, but one can agree with Fontaine that it is characteristically so, and that the *Res Gestae* evidences this trend.[205] So Ammianus openly brings satire and comedy into his criticisms of the mores of the Roman people, or digresses at a length unparalleled even in Greek historiography on geographical subjects – and also exhibits a greater willingness to insert the recherché or the grandiose fragment from elsewhere into the fabric of his narrative. The extent to which poetic vocabulary has been observed by Hagendahl is serviceable enough confirmation (though poetic vocabulary is a feature of Latin historiographical prose from Sallust on, and at the most what can be asserted to vary in Ammianus is its extent).[206] It is also my impression that Ammianus' allusions often reproduce the original rather more exactly than earlier writers might have done.

[203] See Ch. 2, Section IV, and Ch. 6, Section II.

[204] Roberts (1989), 61–3, and Hall (1991), 360. See e.g. Williams (1978), 246–53, on the 'cult of the episode' in the Silver Age.

[205] See especially Fontaine (1992).

[206] Hagendahl (1921), Ch. 2. It is also of course possible that our lack of Latin historiography from Tacitus on makes Ammianus seem more distinct in this field.

For all that, the fact that Ammianus preserved items close to Vergilian half-lines and lived in an age when centos were written does not make him unclassical. It must be restated that he is also a polytheist writing under the Roman Empire, a man learned in classical Latin and Greek literature. In explaining the expansiveness of Ammianus' intertextuality, and especially the more idiosyncratic or uninterpretable allusions, my answer has been that when looked at carefully, they are very often interpretable and compatible with 'classical' expectations, no odder than what has been labelled 'Alexandrianism' in other periods.[207] A further explanation is that we are dealing with a mirage of literary history.

The late fourth century is a turning point in the history of Latin literature. The political and religious changes in the western Empire in the fifth and sixth centuries – what used to be called the 'decline and fall', and is still sometimes called the 'fall', of the Roman Empire – were unfavourable to secular, let alone pagan, letters.[208] These events and a technological change, the copying of books in parchment codices rather than papyrus rolls, mean that what survives for us to read tends to accord with the taste of the late fourth century. Exemplary are the *Satires* of Juvenal, whose vogue in the later empire contrasts with their untidy and lacunose transmission through the second and third centuries;[209] though his subsequent survival is by the thinnest of threads, Tacitus supplies a similar example, having been barely read until that period, as is suggested by the disrepair of his texts.[210] The survival of Sextus Aurelius Victor, Eutropius and Festus, and a generation later the *Epitome*,

[207] Fontaine (1977), 466, makes the comparison. He observes 'the endurance and renewed vitality of a very ancient trend in Hellenistic literature: that of a period of Greek literature which had at the same time in learned fashion applied the labels of an exact and diverse terminology for literary genres, and taken a sort of malign pleasure in denying the separateness of these genres in practice, by trying within the frame of a given work to make them interfere and communicate with each other.' ('La permanence et la vitalité nouvelle d'une très ancienne tendance de la littérature hellénistique: celle d'une époque de la littérature grecque qui avait tout à la fois savamment étiqueté une terminologie précise et diversifiée des genres littéraires, et pris une sorte de malin plaisir à renier pratiquement la spécificité de ces genres, en s'efforçant dans le cadre d'une œuvre donnée de les faire interférer et communiquer entre eux.') Blockley (1996), 465, approves.

[208] The 'decline' of Gibbon's title (1776–88) was rightly and simultaneously excised by Ward-Perkins (2005) and Heather (2005). Cultural decline was the result, not the precursor, of political collapse.

[209] See e.g. Reynolds (1983), 200.

[210] See e.g. Reynolds (1983), 407–11, Cornelius (1888) and Haverfield (1916).

contrasts with the loss (because superseded?) of their common source, the *Kaisergeschichte*. Ammianus comes near the end of pagan Latin literature, and he is learned and allusive: his reading has coincided more with what has survived than that of other classical authors. Moreover, the nature of Latin studies, skewed as they are towards intertextual relationships and to an admiration of the 'classical' and the canonical, has meant that Ammianus is seen very much in terms of his predecessors and models. This is why such a wide range of allusions have been sought and found. This is why there are such a disproportionate number of eccentric allusions. This is why his dictionary sources survive for us to identify them, as they don't for most early imperial writers – we can trace antiquarian lore to Gellius, examples to Valerius Maximus, geography to Solinus. This is also why we can see his use of panegyrics, letters and breviaries which, along with other decorative or utilitarian publications, survive in quantities far greater than comparable ephemera from preceding ages (though willingness to identify these among his literary or narrative sources has been less marked). This survival, in part at least, of so many of his sources explains the extraordinary degree of *contaminatio* which I have been emphasising. Although Ammianus' encyclopedising approach to the past and his consciousness of his own belatedness make it easy to read nostalgia into his history, it should not be forgotten that nostalgia is equally present in much Latin literature, especially historiography, of an earlier date. One may exaggerate the extent – at least comparatively – of Ammianus' dependence on other texts because he comes from an age whose canon has formed our own.

VI Conclusion

Ammianus' intertextuality can provide us with evidence of his intimate knowledge of a wide range of texts: as the very considerable degree of contamination of linked texts suggests, this knowledge is genuine, not acquired dictionary fashion. Which texts Ammianus knew is of course interesting more broadly for the question of how earlier literature was received in the fourth century; it may also lead one to draw conclusions about the historian's education and Latinity.

Not every textual similarity is necessarily meaningful, and in some cases the function of allusions might best be described as ornament or ostentation. But for all that, the allusions can draw meaning from their source-passages. The source-passages are sometimes roughly treated, wrenched into meaning something quite different, but in these cases the evidence is very much that this is not ineptitude but a textual expression of Ammianus' control, just as when his allusions add a forceful negative to the original. And though this can help to create the 'unique and essentially metaphorical' style to which Blockley refers,[211] it also suggests that the original is not irrelevant. Allusions also characterise, introduce themes of importance, make links within the text. They should not be treated in isolation, or as a matter purely relating to the form rather than the content of the work.

These points will now be elaborated in studies of three particular types of intertextual relationship: the first is the relationship of Ammianus with 'source-texts'. Irrespective of whether we are meant to be able to see the relationship with sources of factual information, such intertextuality as we can detect is unquestionably meaningful (Chapter 5). The second category is *exempla*, a signature feature of Ammianus' work and one which invites readers to consider external information, and very often specific texts (Chapter 6). The third is the internal allusion: I shall examine how internal textual similarities bring unity to the work (Chapter 7).

[211] Blockley (1996), 465: 'in a truly Vergilian manner he is harnessing the cumulated power of words and phrases forcefully and successfully adapted and built up by his predecessors, and out of this has created a new and unique, and essentially metaphorical language'.

CHAPTER 5

SOURCES

In scholarly discussion the categories of allusion and source criticism are generally considered separately. This is obvious enough in an academic world where literature and history are thought to be the spheres of different individuals, often in different departments; it is also often a useful distinction. Thus, Timothy Barnes' *The Sources of the Historia Augusta* (1978) identified six historical works from which he believed that the *HA* got the sum of its factual information. In a later work, he defined his terms:

> I take 'the sources of the Historia Augusta' to mean the sources of the authentic information which the Historia Augusta reproduces about the period which it covers, not the sources of the author's inspiration for fiction or flights of fancy, even if those sources of inspiration were historical writers, nor the sources of his general knowledge of geography, Republican history or Greek and Latin literature.[1]

Such a distinction makes very good sense in the difficult terrain of *HA* studies, though it may inevitably be difficult to distinguish between 'authentic information' on the one hand, and 'fiction' and 'flights of fancy' on the other, and scholarly understanding will therefore have to extend to both. The *HA* is not contemporary with the events it is describing. Its author could conduct no interviews, he could consult few or no archives, he could read few or no panegyrics or similar ephemera: instead he had to invent them.

Ammianus' text, though perhaps less bewildering, is immensely more complex than the *HA*. Attempts have been made to identify the sources of Ammianus in the same way that Barnes identified those of the *HA*, but they do not convince.[2] It would certainly

[1] Barnes (1995), 3. See 16–17 for his lightly revised conclusions.

[2] Seeck (1906a) argued for the dominant influence of two major contemporary sources, but such arguments have waned, especially since Thompson's demolition of Seeck on this point (1947). Extended dependence by Ammianus on contemporary historical

be hard to argue that he had a mere six sources! Had the earlier books survived, some consistent and extended dependence on particular sources would presumably have been evident (and indeed some sources can be identified even from back-references).[3] But as it survives, the *Res Gestae* is a contemporary work, and fragments of official and semi-official documents as well as earlier historical works of all shapes and sizes contributed to it without necessarily dominating it. Above all the possibility of information at any point coming from the historian's own experience or from oral sources, or being corrected by such opinions, ought to puncture excessive confidence.

In a work as contemporary and original as Ammianus', I shall argue, a distinction between the separate approaches of source criticism and intertextuality ceases to be useful. The study of Tacitus points the way. Tony Woodman has argued that the historian's engagement with inscriptions should not be regarded as the mining of a source (as a modern historian might use an archive or a medieval charter), but as something for which intertextuality is a useful description. It was an engagement potentially visible and meaningful to readers rather than simply a way of obtaining facts.[4]

sources is now given little credence. Two exceptions: Bowersock (1978), 6–9, argued that Ammianus' dependence on Eunapius damaged his credibility as a source for Julian. But if Ammianus had read Eunapius, he was not so feeble-minded as to be utterly compromised by this (see Tomlin (1980) and Bowersock's apparent change of mind on the dating of Eunapius (Bowersock 1990, 247)). Paschoud (1992) imagines Nicomachus Flavianus' *Annales* to have been influential in Books 26–30, but though for other authors a fervent advocate of Flavianus' influence, he is careful to attribute independence to Ammianus. Bleckmann (1992) considers the possibility of Ammianus' indebtedness to Flavianus (whom he identifies as the late fourth-century source behind the sixth-century Peter the Patrician, and thus the source of Zonaras) at various points in Books 14–25. For a selected sample of the school of Nicomachus Flavianus, see Schlumberger (1974), Paschoud (1975), (1992), (1994), (1998); Bleckmann (1992), (1995); Festy (1997), (1999); Ratti (1997). Picking up any volume in the second series of *Historiae Augustae Colloquia* will supply further examples. See A. D. E. Cameron (1999) for an example of an opposing view.

3 See e.g. Section III below.

4 Kraus and Woodman (1997), 97–102. The idea that there is such a thing as an ancient documentary historian sometimes comes in for ridicule, but it is striking that historiographers who insist on the differentiation of the ancient historian from his modern equivalent also provide neat demonstrations of use of documents. Claudius' speech on admitting Gauls to the Senate has famously been compared to Tacitus' version: Tony Woodman adds the *Res Gestae Diui Augusti*, and the *Senatus Consultum de Cn. Pisone Patre* (Kraus and Woodman (1997), 98–102, and Woodman and Martin (1996), 114–18). The ancient

In Ammianus, we have already seen a couple of odd in-between examples of source use. His description of the bones on the battlefield of Ad Salices in 377 echoes Libanius' emotive picture of the aftermath of Adrianople, the following year. The speech which Julian gave when the army had crossed into Persian territory borrowed one of its examples from Julian's own *Caesars* – but then applied it to a different emperor.[5]

I shall examine source relationships through four case studies. The first two (on both of which I have written elsewhere) are contemporary sources with which the text interacts only briefly: the first is a verse inscription on the obelisk set up in Rome in 357 on Constantius' orders (*ILS* 736), with which Ammianus appears to engage in his own description of the obelisk's erection (17.4.12–15); the second is a now lost Greek text, probably an ecclesiastical history, whose account of the great tsunami of 21 July 365 is transmuted into the remarkable passage at 26.10.15–19 (already discussed in Chapter 2, Section V).[6] The third and fourth case studies are more complex: both are extant literary histories, and, moreover, Ammianus' intertextual relationship with both has sometimes been called into question. Section III is dedicated to Herodian, a third-century Greek historian who writes on the period from 180 to 238, and Section IV to Eutropius, a contemporary of Ammianus who wrote a breviary of Roman history from Romulus and Remus down to the accession of Valentinian and Valens. Herodian was a source, it is presumed, for the lost books, identifiable as such in flashbacks and *exempla*: it might be expected that Ammianus' relationship would in such a case be more dependent than one with contemporaries. The interest in Ammianus' relationship with Eutropius, on the other hand, lies in his engagement with an abbreviated source whom he does not need for information. None of these relationships are with 'principal' sources (though that is what Herodian may have been in some of the lost books), and I shall reflect in the conclusion (Section V) on whether there is any possibility of identifying such sources.

historian's appropriation of the source-text is not, however, that of an idealised modern archival historian, but of an allusive artist.

[5] See Ch. 4, Section IV.7 above. [6] Kelly (2003), 603–6, (2004), 148–55.

I The obelisk

When Constantius II visited Rome in 357, he deliberated on how to leave his mark on the city and decided to donate an obelisk from Thebes to stand in the Circus (16.10.17). Ammianus describes the erection of this obelisk, which appears to have taken place later in the same year, in the following book (17.4).[7] The narrative is preceded by a digression on the history of the city of Thebes (which he had himself visited), its obelisks, and the nature of hieroglyphics (17.4.2–11); then follows the story of how this obelisk came to be erected in Rome (12–15); and the description is closed with a Greek translation of the inscriptions on another Roman obelisk (17–23).

When Constantius' obelisk was re-erected where it still stands outside the Lateran Basilica on the orders of Pope Sixtus V, Michele Mercati, author of a work on the obelisks of Rome (*De gli obelischi di Roma*, 1589), transcribed an inscription carved on the four sides of the obelisk's base (*ILS* 736, *CIL* VI.1163). The stone was already disintegrating at the time and the inscription has now disappeared. A twenty-four line hexameter poem, it too described how the obelisk had come to Rome. The fact that its version of events differs significantly from that of Ammianus has encouraged the creation of a small scholarly industry.[8]

Ammianus begins by saying that Constantius' flatterers had told him that Augustus had brought many other obelisks to Rome but had left this one from awe at its size. The historian forcefully corrects this (17.4.12):

. . . discant qui ignorant / ueterem principem / translatis aliquibus / hunc intactum ideo praeterisse, / quod deo Soli speciali munere dedicatus / fixusque intra ambitiosi templi delubra / quae contingi non poterant / tamquam apex omnium eminebat.

Let me inform those who do not know it that the ancient emperor, after bringing over several obelisks, passed this one by untouched because it was consecrated

[7] Orfitus was still prefect (17.4.1); this is the last event described by Ammianus under the year 357.

[8] See Mercati (1589), Mazzarino (1951), 125–6, Češka (1965) and (1969), Fowden (1987) and (1991a), Baglivi (1995), 55–67, and Kelly (2003), 603–6. Bibliography which I missed in Kelly (2003) includes Fowden (1991b), Vitiello (1999) and Henck (2001b).

as a special gift to the Sun God, and because being placed in the sacred part of his sumptuous temple, which might not be touched, it towered aloft like the peak of the world.

Then, slightly surprisingly, the focus changes to Constantine (17.4.13), who had taken little account of such restraints, and uprooted the obelisk 'since he rightly thought that he was committing no sacrilege if he took this marvel from one temple and consecrated it at Rome, that is to say, in the temple of the whole world'. Sincerity or irony is hard to measure in this difficult passage; in particular the suggestions that Constantine understood the holiness of Rome, and that erecting the obelisk in Rome was a religious dedication, have caused understandable bewilderment. The narrative continues with a polished and poetic account of the difficulties in installing the obelisk; first, before Constantine's death, it was taken down the Nile to Alexandria, where a special ship was built; but after Constantine's death the matter waned, and it was only much later that it was carried over the sea, up the Tiber, and with difficulty erected in the Circus (17.14–15).

By contrast the inscribed poem praises Constantius, both in comparison to his deified father and to the despised tyrant Magnentius, for having been able to raise the mighty hulk into position. Constantine had intended it not for Rome but for Constantinople and had uprooted it, but had been warned of the impossibility of moving it. Following a description of the sea voyage, the poem seems to suggest that the obelisk was sent to Rome when Magnentius was 'laying the city waste', but that 'the emperor's gift, and enthusiasm for erecting it, was grounded, not spurned through pride, but since none believed a work of such mass might rise into the upper air' (*ILS* 736.15–17).

There are, therefore, some contradictions. (1) Did Constantine intend to send the obelisk to Rome (so Ammianus) or to Constantinople (so the inscription), and accordingly, did Constantius follow or alter his father's intentions? (2) Was the obelisk sent to Italy in the course of 357 (Ammianus) or during or before Magnentius' usurpation in 350–3 (the inscription)? It is not my intention to probe the answer to these contradictions in detail here. In answer

to the second it seems unlikely that Constantius would have sent the obelisk to Italy when it was under his brother Constans' control (337–50), let alone during the usurpation of Magnentius.[9] As for the first contradiction, both authors had motives for deception. The poet of the inscription wished to emphasise Constantius' especial generosity to Rome, while Ammianus wished to play down Constantius' role and to portray the first Christian emperor as having wished to dedicate a monument to the Sun God in the eternal city. The fact that there existed another obelisk which was subsequently sent to Constantinople suggests that there was scope for either to play loose with the truth.[10]

My focus here, however, is on the relationship between Ammianus' account and that of the inscription. The contradictions might be thought to rule out the idea that Ammianus had read the inscription; but Guy Sabbah and Garth Fowden have rightly argued that he had read it and was correcting it; indeed he can be said to have used it as a source.[11] It is a sound apriorism that a contemporary historian based in Rome had read the inscription on a central Roman monument, and the textual evidence justifies such a view.

The poem begins by lauding Constantius for the uniqueness of his gift, while Ammianus' narrative of the obelisk's history begins with the sycophants puffing up Constantius with the grandeur of the task (17.4.12), as if signalling that engagement with the official version has begun. Then, as in the poem, comes the sudden mention of Constantine, Ammianus insisting that the obelisk was intended for Rome. In both Ammianus and the poem, Constantine's action in ripping the obelisk from its foundations is described in similar terms (***auulsam*** *hanc* ***molem*** *sedibus suis*, 17.4.13 ~ *caesa Thebis de rupe* ***reuellit***, *ILS* 736.6, *Caucaseam* ***molem***, 9). Ammianus' language is yet more closely reminiscent of lines later in the poem, when the obelisk is lauded as 'a work of such mass' (*tantae* ***molis*** *opus*, 18) shining again as if freshly ripped from the red rocks

[9] See Mercati (1589), 305–7.

[10] See Julian *Ep.* 48 (Wright), 58 (Hertlein), 59 (Bidez). This is the obelisk which eventually arrived in Constantinople during the reign of Theodosius and still stands in the Hippodrome there.

[11] Sabbah ad 17.4.14 (1970, 169 n. 32) and Fowden (1987), 54–5.

(*ueluti rufis* ***auulsa*** *metallis*). Both authors describe how it lay long on the ground, but Ammianus' account has this happening in Egypt, correcting the inscription's allegation that it happened at the Italian end (***iacere*** *diu perpessus est*, 17.4.13 ~ *Augusti* ***iacuit*** *donum*, *ILS* 736.16). Both historian and inscription have a general focus on the difficulties of erecting the thing (17.4.15 ~ *ILS* 736.17–18). But the most conclusive evidence of a textual link is the personification of the Tiber. Ammianus developed the *Tiberi mirante* of the poem (14) into a full-scale contrast of Tiber and Nile (17.4.14).[12]

17.4.13 uerum **Constantinus** id parui ducens, / **auulsam** hanc **molem** sedibus suis / nihilque committere in religionem recte existimans, / si ablatum uno templo miraculum Romae sacraret, / id est in templo mundi totius, / **iacere diu perpessus est**, / dum translationi pararentur utilia. / quo conuecto per alueum Nili / proiectoque Alexandriae, / nauis amplitudinis antehac inusitatae aedificata est / sub trecentis remigibus agitanda. / (14) quibus ita prouisis / digressoque uita principe memorato / urgens effectus intepuit, / tandemque sero inpositus naui / per maria fluentaque **Thybridis** / **uelut pauentis** ne, quod paene ignotus miserat Nilus, / ipse parum sub meatus sui discrimine moenibus alumnis inferret, / defertur in uicum Alexandri, / . . . (15) sola post haec restabat erectio, / quae uix aut ne uix quidem sperabatur posse compleri . . .

ILS 736.5–9, 13–20
. . . hoc decus ornatum **genitor** cognominis urbis
esse uolens caesa Thebis de rupe **reuellit**,
sed grauior diuum tangebat cura uehendi,
quod nullo ingenio nisuque manuque moueri
Caucaseam **molem** discurrens fama monebat.
. . .
. . . et placido <uexerunt aequora flu>ctu
litus ad Hesperium <**Tiberi**> **mirante** carinam.
interea Romam ta<et>ro uastante tyranno
Augusti iacuit donum studiumque locandi
non fastu spreti, sed **quod non crederet ullus**
tantae **molis** opus superas consurgere in auras.
nunc ueluti rursus ruf<is> **auulsa** metallis
emicuit . . .

[12] The name of the river here, *Tiberi*, is admittedly a conjecture, and Mercati, its author, cites Ammianus in justification ((1589), 304). But it is rightly preferred to the obviously alternative *populo*, since after the mention of the Italian coast a geographical feature more specific to Rome is what is wanted.

But **Constantine** thought little of this, and **ripped** this great **mass** from its place, since he rightly thought that he was committing no sacrilege if he took this marvel from one temple and consecrated it at Rome, that is to say, in the temple of the whole world; he allowed it **to lie grounded** for a long time, while gear for transporting it was prepared. When it had been carried along the channel of the Nile and unloaded at Alexandria, a ship of unprecedented size was built, to be propelled by 300 rowers. (14) When these preparations had been made the aforementioned prince departed this life and the matter grew less pressing, and at long last it was placed on a ship, and it was borne over the seas and the flows of **Tiber** (**who** almost **feared** that he could barely bring against the perils of his stream to his foster-child's walls what the almost unknown Nile had sent) and taken to the *uicus Alexandri* . . . (15) After this only erecting it was left, which was **expected to be barely or less than barely possible** to achieve.

His **father**, wanting this to be an ornament of the city named after him, **ripped** it from the cut rock at Thebes. But the sainted emperor was touched by the heavier care of how to lift it, because fleeting rumour said that no intellect, striving or hand could move the Caucasian **mass** . . . and <the seas bore it> on peaceful waves to the Hesperian shore, <**the Tiber**> **marvelling** at the hull. Meanwhile, as the hateful tyrant laid Rome waste, Augustus' gift and enthusiasm for erecting it **was grounded**, not spurned through pride but because **nobody believed** a work of such **mass** could rise into the upper air. Now as if **ripped** afresh from the red metals it shone . . .

What is the nature of the relationship between these two texts? Ammianus had a number of additional possible sources for his information, whether written or oral: he lived in Rome and had visited Thebes and Alexandria. External information, possibly supplemented by his own prejudices, led him forcefully to correct Constantius' propagandistic version, as told, among others, by the obelisk's inscription.[13] He downplayed the suggestion that the obelisk's erection represented an achievement of Constantius', and, while flattering Rome, he suppressed all mention of Constantinople: both tendencies can be paralleled elsewhere in his work.[14] Whether the inscription is called a source of Ammianus is

[13] Ammianus probably engages with another written source, perhaps a panegyric, when he says that flatterers congratulated Constantius on having moved the obelisk which Augustus had not moved (17.4.12).

[14] See Kelly (2003) for Ammianus' relationship with Constantinople.

a matter of personal taste, but it is clear that his version of events is carefully constructed so as to respond to it. He treats the inscription with all the same freedom to disagree as he might treat an allusion, and arguably the effect on readers is much the same as an allusion might have. To readers who observed the intertextuality with the inscription, Ammianus' correction was visible; but it was not made obtrusive to those who could not spot it. For some readers, therefore, it might be visible that Ammianus was denying the relevance of Constantinople; others might have no conception that anybody had ever suggested sending the obelisk there, or that anything was missing.[15]

II The tsunami again

In an article of 2004, I suggested that Ammianus' narrative of the great tsunami of 21 July 365 was loosely based on a now lost Greek source of which we can see traces in later authors.[16] I have discussed this in greater detail elsewhere in this book (both in Chapter 2, Section v, and in the Appendix), and here do not propose to unfold the details again, but merely to restate the nature of the relationship which Ammianus had with this source.

The source, which I did not attempt to identify, has been plausibly identified by Bruno Bleckmann with an anonymous Church historian of homoean opinions, who is conjectured to have written in Antioch in around 380. Though the source itself is not central to my argument, this is notably not the sort of writer whom an avowedly secular historian like Ammianus might be expected to use. If Bleckmann is correct, as I believe he is, it is indicative of the remarkable breadth of Ammianus' reading. (It should be noted that this source had been tentatively suggested as an influence on Ammianus at one other earlier juncture.)[17] Whoever he was, what Ammianus will have found in the source is a description of the tsunami's effects at Alexandria: ships were lifted on to the roofs of

[15] This process is, I believe, analogous to the way in which Ammianus plays down the significance of Christianity in Roman politics by using allusive and coded language. Those who understood the code might be expected to approve, while those who could not would not be in a position to detect bias.

[16] Kelly (2004), esp. 148–55. [17] Bleckmann (2007); Brennecke (1997).

houses; the harbour was drained of water, causing many to run to plunder the ships or stare at the sight in amazement; but they were drowned when the wave returned. The wave sent a bore up the Nile and threw ships miles inland. The source concluded with the tale of how some sailors in the Adriatic had experienced the disappearance of the sea, had landed on the seabed, and promptly been refloated when the sea returned. The transformation which Ammianus exercised on this was considerable. The separate stories were reordered and amalgamated into a single chronologically coherent narrative; foolish tales of sailors landing on the seabed were not included; other events were disassociated from Alexandria in an attempt to make the disaster seem global, and, as I have argued, a metaphor for political events. To modern readers whose principal concern is with veracity, the changes combine both responsible and utterly irresponsible reportage.

The relationship with the source is a complex one: its order changed and its details suppressed. Dependence on it might be invisible even to those who had read it, and although there are, in my view, hints at the existence of a source, they are slight.[18] On the other hand, as the stories are of a sort likely to have been known from oral tradition, appreciation of Ammianus' allusiveness may have been possible without knowledge of his source; and ignorance of the source would only limit, rather than prevent, appreciation of the passage. Its implications are not dependent on the relationship to the source. The effect of the changes might best be described as *aemulatio*: an assertion of Ammianus' authority and literary superiority.

III Herodian

The history of Herodian covers the period from the accession of Commodus in 180 up to the civil war of 238. His history was certainly available in late fourth-century Rome (it is the principal source for several lives in the *Historia Augusta*, though the author sometimes muddies the waters by capriciously calling him

[18] Kelly (2004), 152–3.

Arrianus). It can confidently be stated that Herodian was also a major source for Ammianus' history of the period from 180 to 238, even though the relevant books are lost. Ammianus refers back to the period in *exempla* and cross-references frequently, and though cases of straightforward imitation are harder to identify between authors writing in different languages, allusions also exist.

Discussion of intertextuality between these authors is not without some methodological problems: if a reference to the period covered in Herodian's history closely resembles Herodian, it need not tell us how or whether that subject was covered in the lost books (though such information is sometimes divulged by a cross-reference), and it cannot tell us how the intra-textual relationship worked – whether Ammianus' primary allusion is to his own lost books or to Herodian, or indeed to some other text. However, the problem more often raised is whether Ammianus had actually used Herodian as a source. An intertextual relationship had been indicated by Valesius in his edition of 1636, and Schneider's thesis of 1879 was generally cited in support; but in an article of 1976–7 M. F. A. Brok attacked Schneider's methods and conclusion (the first attack justified, the second not), and a recent article has accepted the argument that Ammianus did not use Herodian.[19] A re-examination of the texts will show clearly that he did, but also explain how it was possible, though wrong, to reach the opposite conclusion. I adduce three passages in particular as definitive.

Firstly, a section passing judgement on the emperor Gratian (31.10.18–19): he was 'a young man of outstanding character, eloquent and restrained, and warlike and forgiving, well on the way to rivalling the choicest princes' (*praeclarae indolis adolescens, / facundus et moderatus / et bellicosus et clemens, / ad aemulationem lectorum progrediens principum*). But under the influence of his associates, he devoted too much attention to the empty pursuits of Commodus Caesar, albeit without shedding human blood. The comparison is potentially an interesting one (both Commodus and Gratian being the young sons of successful military emperors

[19] Schneider (1879); Brok (1976–7); ignorance of Herodian is accepted by Rohrbacher (2006a), 117–19, though the true situation was acknowledged by Barnes (1998), 213, following Gilliam (1972) and Emmett (1983).

who inherited the empire but fell victim to assassination), but the particular reference is to Gratian's fondness for big-game hunting, in the enclosures known as *uiuaria*. Ammianus explains why he had mentioned Commodus (31.10.19):

. . . ille, quia perimere iaculis plurimas feras / spectante consueuerat populo / et centum leones in amphitheatrali circulo simul emissos / telorum uario genere / nullo geminato uulnere contruncauit, / ultra hominem exsultauit.

Because he'd been accustomed to slay many wild beasts with darts before the watching people, and he cut down a hundred lions in the circle of the amphitheatre, all sent out in one go, with a variety of weapons, and never had to inflict more than one wound, he rejoiced beyond human measure.

An unbiased reading would conclude that this *exemplum* is very likely to derive from Herodian 1.15.1–6. The passage as a whole (too long to quote in full here) details Commodus' amphitheatrical shows of AD 192, the popular interest in Commodus' participation and marksmanship, and the various animals which he felled, deer, gazelles, lions, leopards and ostriches (1–5). The particular episode which Ammianus seems to refer to is described in 1.15.6:

λεόντων δέ ποτε ἐξ ὑπογαίων ἑκατὸν <ἅμα> ἀφεθέντων ἰσαρίθμοις ἀκοντίοις πάντας ἀπέκτεινεν, ὡς ἐπὶ πολὺ κειμένων τῶν πτωμάτων δι' αὐτὸ τοῦτο ἐπὶ σχολῆς πάντας ἀριθμῆσαι καὶ μηδ' ἓν ἰδεῖν περιττὸν ἀκόντιον.

And once a hundred lions were sent out <simultaneously> from the subterranean traps, and he killed them all with the same number of spears. The bodies lay in a long line where they fell for everybody to count at leisure and see that not a single extra spear had been used.[20]

The crucial details in which the texts coincide are two. Firstly, the 'hundred lions' are only found in Herodian and Ammianus. At the equivalent point in his narrative, Cassius Dio, the other principal surviving source, has a hundred bears (73.18.1). (The thought that Ammianus' words *simul emissos*, 'simultaneously sent out', seem an exact calque of ἅμα ἀφεθέντων is unfortunately problematic as evidence, as this is Reiske's conjecture for the manuscript reading ἀναρριφθέντων, and is based in part on the comparison to Ammianus.) Secondly, the two authors share the fact that Commodus never had to repeat a wound: although the vocabulary with which

[20] Tr. Whittaker (adapted).

it is expressed is somewhat different, Ammianus' words *nullo uulnere geminato* is close to a phrase earlier in Herodian's account: οὐδέ τις εἶδεν ἀκόντιον δεύτερον οὐδὲ τραῦμα ἄλλο πλὴν τοῦ θανατηφόρου ('one never saw a second shot nor any wound except the fatal one', 1.15.3). Further confirmation comes from Ammianus' next words: that this happened at a time when, if Marcus Aurelius were ruling the empire, he could scarcely have softened the grievous blows buffeting the state without like colleagues and great sobriety of counsel (31.10.19).[21] This accords both with the general approach of Herodian, over whose work Marcus looms as the supreme *exemplum* whom his heirs had failed to live up to, and with the fact that he explicitly contrasts Commodus to his late father very shortly afterwards, in 1.15.7.[22]

A second passage certainly derived from Herodian comes at 22.9.5–6: as Julian makes a detour to Pessinus on his journey from Constantinople to Antioch, Ammianus mentions how the image of the Magna Mater was brought from Pessinus to Rome in the Second Punic War, and refers back to his account of the reign of Commodus, where he had digressed on the subject. A very likely prompt for such a digression would have been the fact that Herodian had a digression on the same theme in his own account of the reign of Commodus (1.10). One crucial difference must be acknowledged, however, that Ammianus rightly attributes the statue's arrival to Scipio Nasica, unmentioned in Herodian.[23] Ammianus's next words also look likely to be based on Herodian:

22.9.6 quam autem ob rem hoc nomine oppidum sit appellatum, / uariant rerum scriptores: / (7) quidam enim figmento deae caelitus lapso, / ἀπὸ τοῦ πεσεῖν, quod cadere nos dicimus, urbem asseruere cognominatam. / alii memorant Ilum, / Trois filium Dardaniae

Herodian 1.1.1 . . . τὴν δὲ προσηγορίαν λαβεῖν τὸν τόπον ἐκ τοῦ πεσόντος ἀγάλματος ἐξ οὐρανοῦ . . . (2) ὡς δὲ παρ' ἑτέροις εὕρομεν, Ἴλῳ τῷ Φρυγὶ καὶ Ταντάλῳ τῷ Λυδῷ πόλεμον ἐκεῖ γενέσθαι λέγουσιν, οἱ μὲν περὶ ὄρων, οἱ δὲ περὶ τῆς Γανυμήδους ἁρπαγῆς·

[21] Cf. the *exemplum* of Marcus at 31.5.13.
[22] Comparison adduced by Valesius.
[23] Julian *Or.* 5.159c could have prompted the subject, though he does not mention Scipio Nasica. Livy 29.11.7, who does, describes not a *simulacrum* but rather a stone.

regem, / bello cum <plurimi ibi cecidissent, inde locum> sic appellasse: / at Theopompus non Ilum id egisse / sed Midam affirmat, / Phrygiae quondam potentissimum regem.

But as to why the town is called by this name, historians differ. (7) For some have argued that the city is named from the image of the goddess which *fell* from heaven, 'apo tou pesein', which we call 'falling'. Others say that Ilus, son of Tros and king of Dardania, since in a war <many had *fallen* there>, so named <the place for that reason>; but Theopompus asserts that it was not Ilus who did this but Midas, once the most powerful king of Phrygia.

ἰσορρόπου δὲ ἐπὶ πολὺ τῆς μάχης γενομένης ἑκατέρωθεν πεσεῖν ἱκανούς, καὶ τὴν συμφορὰν ὄνομα δοῦναι τῷ χωρίῳ.[24]

. . . that the place takes its name from the statue which *fell* from the sky . . . (2) But as we find in other writers, they say that a battle happened there between Ilus the Phrygian and Tantalus the Lydian, some say about borders, others about the seizure of Ganymede. The battle being evenly matched went on a long time and many *fell* on each side, and the disaster gave its name to the place.

There are also differences here, to which I shall come shortly: in particular, the detail about Theopompus, the fourth-century BC historian, does not come from Herodian. But for the rest, Herodian seems an obvious source: he has the same statement about variant interpretations, and the same two explanations for why Pessinus was so called. The lacuna in the text of Ammianus arose from a *saut du même au même*. The words from *bello cum* to *locum* were omitted by the scribe,[25] but have been brilliantly restored here by Valesius on the basis of the comparison to Herodian. There is, however, enough information in the text as it stands (the name of Ilus and the reference to war) to mean that this is not simply a circular argument for Ammianus' use of Herodian. Ammianus has added Theopompus' alternative for the second reason from external knowledge, whether direct or indirect. It is worth noting that Herodian's reference to other writers has been made more specific in

[24] Allusion observed by Valesius ad loc., and cautiously supported by den Boeft *et al.* ad loc.

[25] In fact the manuscript reading is *uello cum*.

Ammianus, who refers to *rerum scriptores*, historians. This could be explained as an acknowledgement of both Theopompus and Herodian, the latter left unnamed, following Ammianus' general habit for all writers later than Vergil. In this case, too, the links with Herodian seem to work on a multitude of levels (lexical, subject matter, above all the fact that both digressed on the same subject in the reign of Commodus), but it should be noted that Ammianus is also frequently willing to add information from external knowledge.

Thirdly, the latter half of Book 26, which describes the usurpation of Procopius in 365–6, shows the influence of Herodian on a number of levels. The clearest example is when Ammianus compares the sluggishness that beset Procopius after the initial success of his usurpation to that of Severus' rival, Pescennius Niger (26.8.15):

> . . . ut quondam Pescennius Niger, / ad subueniendum spei rerum extremae / a Romano populo saepe accitus, / dum diu cunctatur in Syria, / a Seuero superatus in sinu Issico (qui est in Cilicia, / ubi Dareum Alexander fudit) / fugatusque in suburbano quodam Antiochiae gregarii manu militis interiit.
>
> As once Pescennius Niger, often summoned by the Roman people to support them at the end of their hopes, while he delayed long in Syria, was vanquished by Severus at the gulf of Issus (which is in Cilicia, where Alexander routed Dareus); put to flight he perished in a suburb of Antioch at the hands of a common soldier.

The details, including the gloss about Alexander and Dareus, are from Herodian 3.4.[26] Other *exempla* from the period of Herodian's works can be found in this part of Book 26. For example, Valens' minister Petronius is compared to Cleander and Plautianus under Commodus and Severus (26.6.8), though here the *exemplum* itself is far too general in itself to demonstrate a relationship with Herodian. The elevation of Procopius is compared to that of Didius Iulianus in 193 (26.6.14), a comparison which prepares alert readers for the certain allusion at 26.6.16–17 to what followed that emperor's acclamation, as described by Herodian:

[26] Valesius ad loc.

26.6.16 . . . processit in publicum, / **multitudine stipatus armorum**, / signisque sublatis, / erectius ire pergebat, / circumclausus horrendo fragore scutorum lugubre concrepantium, / quae **metuentes ne a celsioribus tectis / saxis uel tegularum fragmentis conflictarentur, / densius ipsis galearum cristis aptabant**. / (17) huic intimidius incedenti / **nec resistebat populus nec fauebat**; / accendebatur tamen insita plerisque uulgarium / nouitatis repentina iucunditate . . .

Herodian 2.6.13 ἐν μέσοις αὐτοῖς ἔχοντες τὸν ἴδιον βασιλέα, ὑπέρ τε τῆς κεφαλῆς αἰωροῦντες τὰς ἀσπίδας καὶ τὰ δόρατα μή που καὶ λίθων τις βολὴ ἀπὸ τῶν δωμάτων ἐπὶ τῇ πομπῇ γένοιτο . . . μηδενὸς τῶν δημοτῶν μήτε ἀντιστῆναι τολμῶντος μήτε μὴν εὐφημοῦντος . . .

He processed into the public space, **surrounded by a multitude of weapons**, and with standards raised was proceeding more confidently, shut in by fearful din of shields miserably clanging together: **afraid that they'd be pelted from the rooftops with rocks or pieces of tiles, they fitted them closely to the crests of their helmets**.

(17) And as he went on more untimorously, **the people neither resisted him nor favoured him**; but they were aroused by a sudden pleasure in the novelty, habitual for most of the vulgar folk.

The guard had their own emperor **in the middle of them** and **raised their shields and spears above their heads to stop any stones being thrown on the procession from the houses . . . none of the commons dared to stand in his way, but neither did they cheer him . . .**[27]

At the end of this chapter, Ammianus remarks (26.6.19) that some may wonder at such disasters arising from such beginnings, 'perhaps ignorant of the examples' (*ignari forsitan exemplorum*), and embarks on a catalogue which, after beginning in late Hellenistic Greece with the pseudo-Philip, runs through the rebellions of Heliogabalus against Macrinus in 218 and Maximin against Alexander in 235, and ends with the suicide of Gordian I in 238 (26.6.19–20). The *exempla* of Chapter 6 of Book 26 as a whole (which generally

[27] A particularly interesting feature is the soldiers fearful of tiles or stones being thrown from the roof, though it could be argued to be a commonplace. Cf. e.g. Thucydides 2.4.2 and Barry (1996).

preserve their chronological order: Cleander, Plautianus, Didius Iulianus, and all the emperors from Macrinus to Gordian I) form as it were a survey of the *History* of Herodian.[28]

Nor is this the only place in the surviving books where Herodian can be seen as a model for a longer passage: during the civil war against Constantius, the city of Aquileia shut itself up against Julian's men. Julian's reaction to the defection was to remember from what he had read and heard that the city had never been sacked or surrendered (21.12.1), and one of the works in which he might have read of an earlier siege of Aquileia was precisely Book 8 of Herodian. It has been argued by Claire Sotinel that Ammianus deliberately plays up the similarities with Herodian's siege narrative throughout the chapter, to create a larger contrast between Julian and Maximin.[29] He doubtless also alluded to his own account in the lost books.

Thus far, a clear case for the importance of the *History* of Herodian as a significant source for *exempla* and very likely also for the lost books. The case has not always been accepted, and the reason for this should be considered. It is, essentially, that even in *exempla* and brief historical references Ammianus has information on the period that contradicts Herodian, as when his explanation of the name Pessinus adduces additional material. For M. F. A. Brok that divergence was significant. He adduced another case with two *exempla* cited at 29.1.17: here the plots against Valens are compared to two assassination attempts against Commodus and Severus. In the first case Ammianus shows a similarity to Herodian 1.6.5, in calling the senator who attacked Commodus by his *cognomen* Quintianus rather than his other names Claudius Pompeianus (which are used by Dio 72.4.4 and *HA Comm.* 4.2).[30] However, Brok points out two divergences from Herodian in this first *exemplum*: Ammianus places this assassination attempt 'after many different internal threats' (*post intestina pericula multa et*

[28] Chronologically Plautianus belongs after Didius Iulianus. Note how much, in 26.6.19–20, the ignorant have to fill in for themselves. It is *not* stated for their benefit that this is a complete sequence of emperors, nor that Macrinus was himself a usurper, nor that Heliogabalus and Maximin were themselves killed in usurpations.

[29] Sotinel (2003) and (2005), 57–9.

[30] In fact *V*'s reading is Quintinianus, but most editors dismiss this spelling as corrupted by dittography and print Quintianus.

uaria), whereas Herodian, like Dio and the *HA*, has this attempt towards the beginning of Commodus' reign; Ammianus says that Commodus was wounded almost to the point of serious injury by a dagger (*ad debilitatem paene pugione uulneraretur*), whereas Herodian like the other sources says that Quintianus was arrested before doing any harm. The second *exemplum* paired with this one concerns the plot against Severus involving the Praetorian Prefect Plautianus and the centurion Saturninus. Though Ammianus' account is closer to Herodian than Dio's, he adds new details, placing the assassination attempt in the emperor's bedroom and suggesting that only the young Caracalla's personal intervention saved the emperor.

Neither of these divergences is a cogent counter-argument against the reading of Herodian. In the first case the *exemplum* appears to have been altered by *inuentio*, so that it fits Valens better, both by placing the assassination attempt after dangers earlier in the reign, and by the increased seriousness implied by injury. There are plenty of instances where *exempla* are adapted by what must be considered either failures of memory or purposeful alteration.[31] In the second case, similarly inventive elaboration of Herodian's narrative could be an explanation, but more likely is conflation of another source, which is equally typical of the author. We have seen that in periods for which he had more information Ammianus was capable of vigorous independence in treating his sources. Moreover, Ammianus knew sources other than Herodian for the late second and early third centuries. Of this I shall give just one example: he refers to the tale he had told of the gentleness of Maximin Thrax's wife, which is found in no other surviving source (14.1.8). The references to the period covered by Herodian suggest that Ammianus felt able to allude back to his own account of it in more than abbreviated detail, and that the account itself was both relatively full and based on a number of sources.[32]

[31] Ch. 6, Section II below. I can therefore not give credit to Brok's suggestion that it is unscientific to claim that Ammianus was narrating Herodian's information from memory. Brok (1976–7), 206.

[32] I hope to cover in detail elsewhere the interlinked question of Ammianus' sources and methods of composition in the lost books, and how *exempla* from that period impact on the surviving books.

To conclude: there are ways – unwise ones – by which the conclusion that Ammianus and Herodian shared a source can be escaped. Ammianus' additional information might lead one to imagine some sort of *Herodianus auctus*. This author will have imitated Herodian to the extent of having a digression on the Magna Mater in the reign of Commodus, but he will have added the facts that Scipio Nasica had been responsible for the translation of her statue to Rome from Pessinus, and that Theopompus had a divergent detail in his etymology of the name Pessinus. Alternatively one could postulate a common source whom both authors had followed very closely. It is preferable by far to assume that the person who supplemented Herodian was Ammianus himself – as ever learned, as ever contaminating his allusions. His use of Herodian for the period 180–238 will only be problematic if the assumption is made that he had either the capacity or the inclination to follow only one source at a time.[33]

IV Eutropius

The focus of this section is Ammianus' use of a source, Eutropius' *Breuiarium*, which he certainly did not need to use. It is commonplace to contrast Ammianus positively to the dominant trend in the secular historiography of his time, abbreviated history (how much this apparent dominance is dependent on what survives is of course debateable). He himself disparaged this trend, or so it appears, in the programmatic preface to Book 15: 'brevity is only to be praised when it breaks through untimely delays but subtracts nothing from the understanding of events'. Ammianus mentioned

[33] Such a depressing image of Ammianus' source use need not be accepted. And though Ammianus' apparent preference in the lost books for Herodian over other sources may not favour his judgement (see Barnes (1998), 213), at least it seems clear that he had consulted other sources. For all that his reference to Marius Maximus is disparaging (28.4.14), it makes it likely that Ammianus had used him (Michael Kulikowski makes a forceful case for Ammianus' allusion to Marius Maximus in a recent article (2007)); it is extremely likely too that he had consulted Cassius Dio. I would now take further my argument in Kelly (2005), and argue that the 'source' of the *exemplum* at 21.16.11 was Dio 72.29, and that divergences can be attributed to Ammianus' *inuentio*. If there is a single fact which suggests that Ammianus had access to a diversity of sources for the lost books, it lies in the fact that four of his twelve back-references to Marcus Aurelius' reign give information found in no other source (see Kelly (2005), n. 10).

three breviarists by name, Aurelius Victor, Eutropius and Festus: all wrote within a decade between about 360 and 370. But he mentions them all as historical actors. The only one whom Ammianus describes as a historian is Victor, who is also praised for his outstanding character (21.10.6); Eutropius is neutrally described (29.1.36) and Festus is a villain (29.2.22–8). Paradoxically it is Victor of whom no intertextual trace has been found in the extant text. Ammianus' dependence on Festus in digressions has been well known since an important article of 1881 by Mommsen.[34] His use of Eutropius is less well documented, though occasionally suggested in the scholarship.[35] Even if it is unsurprising (Eutropius' *Breuiarium* was a great success, being translated twice into Greek and used as a source by many subsequent writers), it is worth illustrating in detail.[36]

The illustration will depend primarily on imitation of the very end of the *Breuiarium*. This is hardly surprising: earlier passages tend to overlap with the abbreviated tradition, and it is impossible to see whether Ammianus has imitated Eutropius or the slightly more detailed accounts of the same events to be found in Eutropius' principal source for imperial history, the lost *Kaisergeschichte*. So when Ammianus speaks of how Diocletian introduced *adoratio purpurae* (15.5.18), and how he humiliated Galerius after defeat by the Persians (14.11.10), the similarity cannot be assessed with any certainty, though in each case the *Kaisergeschichte* seems a likelier source on balance.[37] Moreover, the later sections of a breviary were always likeliest to receive the most scrutiny from readers because they handled information immediately before the present – whether, as for Aurelius Victor in 360, this involved a semi-panegyrical account of the present reign, or, as for Eutropius

[34] Mommsen (1881), 605–9.

[35] E.g. Bonamente (1986), 61–2. For a denial of Ammianus' reading of Eutropius see Rosen (1982), 169–72.

[36] One unexpected way in which passages of Eutropius have infiltrated Ammianus' history is through the chapter headings which Adrien de Valois printed in his edition of 1681 and which have appeared in all editions since. Adrien drew on Eutropius for several headings (e.g. 25.3, 25.7, and perhaps 24.2): see Kelly (forthcoming).

[37] See Rosen (1982), 170–1. Discussion of the *Kaisergeschichte* in these terms of course makes the assumption that the *KG* which we reconstruct really was a single text rather than a succession of similar texts each imitating and developing their predecessors. For an imaginative reassessment of the subject see Burgess (2005).

ten years later, demanded an assessment of the politics of the last few years in the light of a change of dynasties. Victor was a junior civil servant in Illyricum looking for attention, Eutropius already a holder of high office at Valens' court.[38] How would they compliment the emperor or set a trail for his future policies?

The end of Eutropius' book fits well with Ammianus' views. He offers a warm and generous assessment of Julian; he lays the blame for the treaty which signed away Nisibis and half of Mesopotamia squarely on Jovian; he argues that the formal surrender of Roman territory had never previously occurred in the 1,118 years since the foundation of the empire, bringing up *exempla* from Roman history; he asserts that Jovian was deterred from staying in the East by fear of a usurper; he describes his death and offers three possible explanations. Finally he announces that the reign of the current emperors must bring his account to a stop, as the rest must be told in a grander style.

The closing sentiments are of course reflected in those of Ammianus' own sphragis; and though one might think them commonplace, the striking verbal similarity of Eutropius' words and Ammianus' makes allusion inescapable.[39] A further verbal echo indicates that Eutropius had at least a passing influence in the later books: when Gratian was elevated to Augustus, Ammianus, who knew or suspected that he would never record the young emperor's initial successes and tragic fall, described his character as one which would have fully fitted an emperor comparable with the best of old, 'if it had been permitted by the fates and his intimates' (*si per fata proximosque licuisset*, 27.6.15). Consciously or not, the words echo, with a qualification, what Eutropius had written of Julian: 'an outstanding man and one who would have led the state with distinction, if it had been permitted by the fates' (*uir egregius et rem publicam insigniter moderaturus, si per fata licuisset*, Eutropius 10.16.2).[40]

[38] But not, it appears, *magister memoriae*: see Burgess (2001).

[39] Eutropius 10.18.3 *nam* ***reliqua stilo maiore*** *dicenda sunt* ~ 31.16.9 *scribant* ***reliqua*** *potiores aetate, / doctrinis florentes. / quos id (si libuerit) aggressuros / procudere linguas ad* ***maiores*** *moneo* ***stilos***. For further discussion see Paschoud (2004) and Kelly (2007).

[40] The phrase does not appear to be used elsewhere in Latin. This verbal echo significantly strengthens the likelihood that Ammianus' immediately following observation is

For a more material debt one can turn to the description of Jovian's death and its causes.[41]

25.10.12 hinc quoque Iouianum celeri gradu praescriptus uitae finiendae dies exegit. / cum enim uenisset Dadastanam, / qui locus Bithyniam distinguit et Galatas / **exanimatus** inuentus est nocte. / super cuius **obitu** dubietates emersere complures. / (13) **fertur** enim **recenti calce cubiculi** illiti ferre **odorem** noxium nequiuisse, / uel extuberato capite perisse **succensione prunarum immensa**, / aut certe ex colluuione ciborum auida **cruditate** distentus. / **decessit** autem **anno tricensimo aetatis et tertio**. / cumque huic et Aemiliano Scipioni uitae exitus similis euenisset, / super neutrius morte quaestionem comperimus agitatam.

From here too Jovian was driven on hotfoot by the day appointed to end his life. For when he had reached Dadastana, a place on the boundary of Bithynia and the Galatians, he was found dead at night. Concerning his death many doubts cropped up. (13) It is said that he could not bear the poisonous odour of his bedroom recently smeared with plaster, or that he'd died with his head swollen up from a vast burning of coals, or for sure that after massive overindulgence in food he was distended with indigestion. At any rate, he died in the thirty-third year of his life. And although a similar

Eutropius 10.17.3 itaque iter ingressus atque Illyricum petens in Galatiae finibus repentina morte **obiit**, uir alias neque iners neque inprudens. (18.1) multi **exanimatum opinantur** nimia **cruditate** (inter cenandum enim epulis indulserat), alii **odore cubiculi**, quod ex **recenti** tectorio **calcis** graue quiescentibus erat, quidam **nimietate prunarum**, quas graui frigore adoleri multas iusserat. (2) **decessit** imperii mense septimo, tertio decimo Kal. Mart., **aetatis**, ut qui plurimum uel minimum tradunt, **tertio et tricesimo anno**, ac benignitate principum, qui ei successerunt, inter diuos relatus est.

So he had begun to travel and was making for Illyricum when in the borders of Galatia he died a sudden death, a man otherwise neither indolent nor foolish. (18.1) Many think that he died from excessive indigestion (he had indulged in banquets in the midst of his dining), others from the smell of his bedroom, which because of a recent covering of plaster was troublesome for sleepers, some people from a surfeit of coals, of which he'd ordered that many should be burnt in the severe cold. (2) He died in his seventh month of rule, on 17 February, in the thirty-third year of his life according

also derived from Eutropius: that Marcus Aurelius' reign with Verus offered the closest precedent for Valentinian making his brother and son Augusti (Eutropius 8.9.2 ~ 27.6.16).

[41] For a strikingly different interpretation to mine see Ratti (1997), esp. 499–508.

departure from life befell him as Scipio Aemilianus, we have not learnt that any enquiry was made over the death of either.

to those who give the upper and lower limits. By the generosity of the princes who succeeded him he was enrolled among the gods.

It could of course be argued that similarities between such texts are exactly what would be expected: both are covering a death which happened at a known place and time; the causes of death were obviously much talked about; the emperor's age (roughly) was known. These are precisely the formal details that any imperial death might justify, though Ammianus is notably briefer than usual, and especially in comparison to the death of Julian earlier in the book. A sceptic could also argue that these three causes of death (gluttonous overindulgence, fumes of wet plaster, the coals in the bedroom), are found in a number of other authors, and that Ammianus has them in a different order (2, 3, 1; the plaster, the coals, overindulgence), and also has some additional details – the graphic *extuberato capite* ('with swollen head') stands out.[42] And yet the order in which common details are covered is remarkably similar, and the linguistic coincidences are very close (especially the use of the same two words for death: *exanimatus/-um*, *decessit*) and extensive. It seems extremely likely that Ammianus either followed Eutropius or something very close to Eutropius – and it is superfluous to posit an intermediate source, and unnecessary to suppose that Eutropius, writing only six years on, had a written source as such.[43]

Ammianus too did not need a written source for the death of Jovian; he was able to add to Eutropius' account the place where it occurred, and it is even possible that he was at Dadastana with the guard.[44] Why might he have followed Eutropius here? In my view, the answer is that Eutropius is not so much the source of information but an intertext. Let us examine how Ammianus alters his 'source'. He is markedly more melodramatic in the list of causes of death: I have already mentioned the extraordinary detail *extuberato*

[42] These three explanations are also found at Sozomen 6.6.1; other authors tend to have one or two.

[43] It may, however, be argued that what we have in Eutropius represents what might be called the 'official version'.

[44] See den Boeft *et al.* ad 25.10.1.

capite, and changing *nimietate prunarum* to *succensione prunarum immensa* ('from a surfeit of coals', 'from a vast burning of coals') adds to the impression of Jovian's excess. Of the three possible causes of death, overindulgence is moved from first of three to last, is also melodramatised, and is given particular force by *aut certe* ('or for sure'), a usage which, it has been suggested, often introduces the so-called loaded alternative, the author's preferred interpretation in cases of rumour. From this the Dutch commentators have concluded that Ammianus meant to portray Jovian as a victim of his own gluttony.[45]

The structure of the passage may, however, cast doubt on this. After describing the fact of the death, Ammianus adds the fact that very many doubts arose about it. And after detailing the causes of death, he does not give the length of the reign, the date, or express the mild uncertainty about Jovian's age found in Eutropius; his deification is also omitted. Ammianus adds an *exemplum* for the death, Scipio Aemilianus, and comments that neither Jovian's death nor Scipio's was investigated. Ammianus' imitation of Eutropius (or something very like Eutropius) is therefore framed by an expression of doubt. And the nature of the allusion to Scipio Aemilianus is more forceful. If Ammianus had a specific source for the death of Scipio, we cannot identify it: both the *Periochae* of Livy and Cicero's *Pro Milone* mention the absence of an enquiry into Scipio's death in similar terms.[46] But the immediate context within Cicero's speech, which was well known to Ammianus, is surely suggestive: Cicero refers to the grief in Rome *cum P. Africano domi suae quiescenti illa nocturna uis esset inlata* ('when night-time violence was brought against Publius Africanus as he slept at home', *Mil.* 16). Ammianus' intention was clearly to hint, without in any way taking responsibility for the suggestion, that Jovian was poisoned: a theory which other contemporaries also believed.[47] Once that is accepted, the language of the rest of

[45] Den Boeft *et al.*, xiii and ad 25.10.13.

[46] *de morte tamen eius nulla quaestio acta*, 'but about his death no enquiry was made' (Livy *Per.* 59); *num igitur ulla quaestio de Africani morte lata est? certe nulla*, 'So no enquiry was made, was it, about Africanus' [i.e. Aemilianus'] death? Certainly it wasn't' (Cicero *Mil.* 16).

[47] Eunapius fr. 29 mentions a poisoned mushroom, and John Chrysostom *Ep. ad Phil.* 15.5 (*PG* 62.295) also implied poisoning. Wagner ad loc. first suggested that Ammianus

the account appears appropriate to this suggestion: the raising of many doubts (*dubietates . . . complures*), and even the reference to the 'the day appointed to end his life' (*praescriptus uitae finiendae dies*) are appropriate to murder.

Why, then, does Ammianus' account purposely resemble Eutropius'? Two reasons occur: one is that allusion to Eutropius is entirely appropriate to the nature of his narrative of Jovian. Though Jovian in fact stayed for some time in various urban centres, Ammianus presents his whole reign as a rush to the West to establish his power. As Jovian is driven on *celeri gradu*, 'hotfoot', so too is the narrative, and it is in keeping with Ammianus' overall estimation of Jovian's insignificance that his death is treated briefly in a manner reminiscent of the most successful breviary of the period. Indeed, he outdoes Eutropius in brevity, cutting several details, such as the date of Jovian's death and the fact of his consecration. Secondly, if Eutropius is imitated for the three partially contradictory common explanations (*fertur*, 'it is said that . . .'), the effect is to render the *Breuiarium* into the commonly uttered 'official explanations' of Jovian's death, stuck as if in quotation marks, and mocked by Ammianus' dark hints before and after.

Yet another passage at the end of Eutropius' history also finds its reflection in the work of Ammianus. He develops Eutropius' musings on Jovian's peace treaty in 363 which surrendered Nisibis and much of Mesopotamia (which he too attributes to Jovian's fear of usurpation in the West). Both authors reproach Jovian for the allegedly unprecedented act of giving away Roman territory by treaty, Ammianus somewhat more explicitly than Eutropius; Ammianus objects that in the old days triumphs were not decreed for generals who won back territory that the Romans had lost (his *exempla*, not matched in Eutropius, are derived from Valerius Maximus); and finally both observe that the right thing would have

hinted at murder, followed by Brok (1959), 248. Writing in the *Cambridge Ancient History* John Curran has observed in passing the true ambiguity of Ammianus' narrative (1998, 80 and n. 6). For a rather different view see den Boeft *et al.* ad loc. Whether or not *aut certe* introduces a 'loaded' alternative, as den Boeft *et al.* think, I would argue that this is the favoured alternative among those which were reported, and that the possibility which is meant to stick in the reader's mind is the one which Ammianus puts last, in the following sentence. Whether Ammianus wanted to suggest that Jovian was murdered is of course a different question either to whether he believed it or to whether it was actually the case.

been to repudiate the treaty and fight back, using the same three examples from republican history (the Caudine Forks, Albinus in Numidia and Mancinus at Numantia).

25.9.9 **numquam** enim **ab urbis ortu** inueniri potest annalibus replicatis, ut arbitror, / **terrarum pars ulla nostrarum** / ab imperatore uel consule **hosti concessa** . . .

For **never since the city's rising** could one find on looking back through the annals, I think, that **any part of our lands was conceded to the enemy** by emperor or consul . . .[48]

. . . sed **ne ob recepta quidem, quae direpta sunt, / uerum ob amplificata regna triumphales glorias fuisse delatas**. (10) unde **Publio Scipioni ob recuperatas Hispanias**, / Fuluio **Capua** post diuturna certamina superata / et **Opimio** post diuersos exitus proeliorum / **Fregellanis** tunc interneciuis hostibus **ad deditionem compulsis**, / **triumphi sunt denegati**.

. . . rather **the glory of triumphs was not even allowed for taking back what was snatched away, but only for increasing the territories ruled.** (10) Hence **Publius Scipio, for his recovery**

Eutropius 10.17.1 . . . multatus finibus ac **nonnulla imperii Romani parte tradita**. (2) quod ante eum annis mille centum et duobus de uiginti fere, **ex quo Romanum imperium conditum erat, numquam** accidit.

. . . he suffered loss to the borders, **with a significant part of the Roman Empire handed over**. (2) Before him, in the one thousand one hundred and eighteen or so years **since the Roman Empire had been founded**, this had **never** happened.

Valerius Maximus 2.8.4 sapientiores igitur Q. **Fuluius**, qui **Capua** capta, et L. **Opimius**, qui **Fregellanis ad deditionem compulsis** triumphandi potestatem a senatu petierunt, uterque editis operibus magnificus, sed neuter petitae rei compos, non quidem inuidia patrum conscriptorum, cui numquam aditum in curiam esse uoluerunt, sed summa diligentia obseruandi iuris, quo cautum erat ut **pro aucto imperio, non pro reciperatis quae populi Romani fuissent triumphus decerneretur** . . . (5) quin etiam ius, de quo loquor, sic custoditum est, ut **P. Scipioni ob reciperatas Hispanias**, M. Marcello ob captas Syracusas **triumphus non decerneretur** . . .

Wiser therefore were Quintus **Fulvius when Capua was** captured and Lucius **Opimius when the Fregellans were compelled to surrender**, who sought the right to triumph from the Senate. Each was outstanding in the deeds he had

[48] Note the appropriateness of the chronologically reversed order *ab imperatore uel consule* to the action of looking backwards through the annals (*annalibus replicatis*).

of the Spanish provinces, Fulvius, when Capua was defeated after lengthy conflict, and **Opimius**, although after battles with various outcome **the Fregellans**, at that time murderous foes, **were compelled to surrender, were** [all three] **denied triumphs**.

achieved, but neither obtained what they asked: not because the Conscript Fathers were envious (they wanted no place for envy in the curia), but because they were exceptionally careful in preserving the law, which ensured that **a triumph was decreed for increasing the empire, not for recovering what had belonged to the Roman people . . .** (5) Indeed the law of which I speak was so guarded that **Publius Scipio for his recovery of the Spanish provinces**, and Marcus Marcellus for the capture of Syracuse, **were not decreed a triumph**.

(11) id etiam memoriae nos ueteres docent, / in extremis casibus icta cum dedecore foedera, / postquam partes uerbis iurauere conceptis, / **repetitione bellorum ilico dissoluta**, / ut **temporibus priscis apud Furcas Caudinas / sub iugum legionibus missis in Samnio**, / et per Albinum in **Numidia** sceleste pace excogitata, / et auctore turpiter pactionis festinatae Mancino / dedito **Numantinis**.

Eutropius 10.17.2 quin etiam **legiones nostrae** ita et **apud Caudium** per Pontium Telesinum et in Hispania **apud Numantiam** et **in Numidia sub iugum missae sunt**, ut nihil tamen finium traderetur. ea pacis condicio non penitus reprehendenda foret, si foederis necessitatem tum cum integrum fuit mutare uoluisset, sicut a Romanis omnibus his bellis, quae commemoraui, factum est. Nam et **Samnitibus** et **Numantinis** et **Numidis confestim bella inlata** sunt neque pax rata fuit.

(11) This too ancient records teach us, that treaties made shamefully in extreme circumstances, once the parties had sworn with the agreed oaths, were straightaway dissolved by a **rekindling of the war**, as **in olden times at the Caudine Forks, when the legions were sent beneath the yoke in Samnium**, and when peace was wickedly devised by the deed of Albinus in **Numidia**, and when Mancinus, who had agreed a shamefully hasty treaty, was handed over to the **Numantians**.

Indeed, at **Caudium** thanks to Pontius Telesinus, at **Numantia** in Spain, and in **Numidia, our legions were sent under the yoke**, but in such a way that nothing within our borders was handed over. Those terms of peace would not have been wholly reprehensible if he had been willing to change the obligations of the treaty when it was in his power, as was done by the Romans in all these wars which I have mentioned. **For wars were immediately waged** on the **Samnites** and **Numantians** and **Numidians** and the peace was not ratified.

We should note first that the content of Ammianus' argument can be explained by his development of Eutropius' argument: both start by arguing not that the Romans had not lost territory before, but that they had not surrendered it by treaty to a foe; and both then cite the same precedents for immediately restarting wars after embarrassing defeats. Ammianus inserts a non-Eutropian argument in the second half of 25.9.9 and 25.9.10, which can clearly be identified as deriving directly from Valerius Maximus. One effect of inserting this section is to split the two rather different points which Eutropius is making; though not particularly forceful as argument, the passage adds the weight of additional *exempla* to Ammianus' supposed survey of Roman annals. (In explaining why Ammianus chose to insert it here, one conceivable explanation is that he was prompted to look up two of Eutropius' examples in Valerius Maximus – the defeats of Mancinus at Numantia and Albinus in Numidia can be found at 2.7.1–2 – and that in the search he happened on these *exempla* nearby at 2.8.4–5.)[49]

The nature of the alterations which Ammianus makes to his two sources is consistent. He is willing to reorder, to trim, and to expand. The passage derived from Valerius is shorter than the original, but he glosses his *exempla*: Capua was defeated 'after lengthy conflict', the Fregellans were 'at that time murderous foes', defeated 'after battles with various outcome'. He also reorders them: Scipio is placed before Fulvius and Opimius, presumably in an attempt to restore chronological order.[50] In adapting Eutropius' examples, he rewrites so that each is mentioned only once; Ammianus also swaps around his choice of additional information. The name of the foreign general who inflicted the defeat at the Caudine Forks is suppressed, but the other two examples are elaborated, with the names of the Roman generals responsible for the surrenders. Ammianus also changes the order of the *exempla*, moving away from chronological order maintained in Eutropius so that the surrender of Mancinus to the Numantians can be placed at the climax. The changes are meaningful. Eutropius

[49] Ammianus knew his way particularly well around Book 2 of Valerius. He alludes to the vocabulary of 2.8 at 14.10.8, 16.3.3 and 21.16.15, and of 2.7.2 at 28.4.4 and 30.4.6.

[50] See Fontaine ad loc. (n. 693). In fact, the failure of Fulvius to be awarded a triumph shortly preceded Scipio's, both during the Second Punic War.

was writing in about 370, at a time when Valens had completed his Gothic War and was looking to justify aggression against Persia. Ammianus was much more concerned with pinning blame for the territorial losses on Jovian; hence he added from his own general knowledge the names of the Roman military commanders, and ended with the fact that a general who had negotiated a shamefully hasty treaty had been handed over to the enemy. This suggestiveness goes against the text's ostensible attitude to Jovian, 'an unfinished youth', whose lack of previous experience meant that it was not right to blame or to praise him (25.9.7); it accords, however, with the hostile subtext found towards him throughout.[51]

The conclusion that Ammianus is elaborating a passage of Eutropius here was first drawn by Friedrich Lindenbrog in his edition of 1609, but it has sometimes been questioned. A short digression will be necessary. Doubts arose partly, perhaps, because the extent to which the final chapters of Eutropius are redeployed had not been demonstrated as fully as here; the main reason, however, was the presence of somewhat similar passages in other contemporary authors. The *Breuiarium* of Festus, written either very soon after, or at the same the time as, Eutropius', stresses the unprecedented nature of Jovian's territorial concessions, though without deploying *exempla* (29.2); and Zosimus also digresses into examples of the republican period (3.32): the passage is likely but not certain to be derived from his principal source for the period, Eunapius, who wrote shortly before or after Ammianus. The favoured conclusion has been that we have evidence of a common source, written at some point between Jovian's peace and Eutropius six years later, which is followed by all the others.[52]

In support of this, it has been alleged that Eutropius' arguments are unclear and his allegation that surrender of territory is unprecedented is inconsistent with the rest of his *Breuiarium*, and that therefore he must be summarising another source. It is true that, compared to Ammianus, Eutropius' arguments seem sketchy, but

[51] See e.g. Barnes (1998), 138–42, Heather (1999), Lenski (2000).
[52] See e.g. Paschoud (1975), 188–201, and den Boeft *et al.* ad 25.9.9–11.

a careful reading by Bonamente has shown the underlying logic and consistency with the rest of his work.[53] It is also observed that Ammianus does not follow the vocabulary of Eutropius that closely in this passage, which might better be explained by a common source; and it is certainly true that the intertextual relationship to Valerius Maximus in 25.9.9–10 is notably closer than that to Eutropius in the surrounding sentences. I would argue that this is because Valerius is a valued literary model, and Eutropius is a contemporary being subjected to *aemulatio*.

The nature of the common source is also problematic: Paschoud argues that this is the lost history of Nicomachus Flavianus, whom he believes for other reasons to have been a major source for Eunapius and thus indirectly for Zosimus. As the only thing known for certain about Flavianus' *Annales*, beyond their title, is that the work was dedicated to Theodosius, this requires the postulate of a much earlier first edition. And yet, though reassessments of the peace deal of 363 must have been made from the moment it happened, it is worth repeating that Eutropius' and Festus' remarks on its unprecedented nature are remarkably apt to the moment, from the end of 369, when Valens had for the time being finished his business with the Goths and was moving to the eastern frontier: if such a context is assumed, there is not too much space for a common source. Moreover, the nature of the surviving sources is not actually best explained by the theory of a single common source from which all the rest derived their argument and their *exempla*. Festus has no *exempla* at all. Zosimus' *exempla* begin with late republican conquests in Mesopotamia, and continue with previous imperial expeditions against Persia. Were they all to derive from the same source, one would expect some overlap; but rather, Ammianus has the same examples as Eutropius, plus three more, and Zosimus has utterly different ones. Ammianus' differences from Eutropius are also explicable. The passage from Valerius is likely to be his own addition (it would be a remarkable coincidence if the *exempla* derived from the common source, but just happened to come from one of Ammianus' favourite chapters of Valerius Maximus).[54] And if the *exempla* which he shares with Eutropius had come from

[53] Bonamente (1986), 110–27. [54] See n. 49 above.

a common source instead, one would expect the two authors to have more similarities, but in fact Ammianus takes over the three *exempla* and changes them so that they resemble Eutropius only basically. Eutropius elaborates the disaster of the Caudine Forks with the name of the enemy commander, *per Pontium Telesinum*, and leaves the other two without information. Ammianus removes Pontius Telesinus but adds the name of the Roman commander in the other two instances, in the first case adding *per Albinum*. Should we assume that the common source had the names of all the commanders on both sides and that Eutropius and Ammianus coincidentally chose to treat them in exactly the opposite way?

In fact, the likeliest assumption is that there is no common source, but rather that the unexampled nature of Jovian's peace was a commonplace. For Eutropius and Festus, courtiers of Valens, it was natural to suggest that avenging it was the next step. Such an argument was attractive to pro-Julianic historians like Eunapius and Ammianus in the following generation, because it provided a historically respectable way to suggest that the surrender of Nisibis was an unprecedented act, the direct result not of the actions, but of the loss, of Julian. Ammianus chose to use Eutropius' argumentation and to improve on it; Eunapius chose a different set of *exempla*. We cannot say whether he had the idea specifically from reading Eutropius (who in that case would unexpectedly emerge as the 'common source'); nor can we say for certain whether his meditations were available to Ammianus and perhaps helped to persuade him to include a digression of the same type.[55]

To summarise: Ammianus' use of Eutropius functions in several ways. In describing the death of Jovian, where the language is quite close, the purpose is, I argue, to use the language of breviary to make Jovian's death seem a triviality, and also to turn Eutropius' three explanations for the death into an 'official version' on which he subtly casts doubt. (In a not dissimilar fashion, the echo of Eutropius in the sphragis of the *Res Gestae* is largely a marker of difference between Eutropius' polite closing cliché and Ammianus' subversion of the cliché.) His historical contextualisation

[55] On the dating of Eunapius relative to Ammianus see Ch. 2, n. 139 above.

of Jovian's peace, however, follows Eutropius' pattern of thought closely. But here there are few lexical connections and the *exempla* are expanded and transformed. All in all, the style is significantly aggrandised and the argument made much more pointed. Readers who observed connections to Eutropius were predominantly intended to notice the differences.

V Conclusion

What has come so far could in no way be called a comprehensive survey of the question of Ammianus' sources in the *Res Gestae*, nor do I propose to embark on such a survey. And while it is interesting and important in itself to show, as in the examples of Sections I to IV, that Ammianus had 'used' an inscription, an ecclesiastical history, a major Greek history of the third century, and a contemporary breviary, such demonstrations have not been the primary aim of this chapter. More important is to show how such sources are used, and to consider the implications of this form of intertextuality for the interpretation of the *Res Gestae* and its sources more broadly.

If he had had such a thing, Ammianus' bibliography would have been a lengthy one. The influence of the sources which I have observed above for the most part covers only brief passages; however, the extent to which he can be seen engaging with many of his contemporaries, illustrated in considerable but by no means exhaustive detail by Guy Sabbah, is most impressive.[56] It also seems clear to me that the range of written sources for the lost books was considerably broader than has sometimes been argued.[57] For all that, abundance of sources does not mean that in other respects his practice resembled that of modern historians. Precise, if extraordinary, stories about the tsunami are generalised into a metaphor for the travails of the Roman Empire; he thinks nothing of making an exemplary assassination attempt more dangerous and hence a better example. Very frequently sources are alluded to so that Ammianus can assert the precise opposite, or an earlier historical event is used as the basis for telling the story of what happened in a completely different recent one. There are no footnotes to indicate

[56] Sabbah (1978). [57] See n. 33 above.

to less well informed readers what he is doing. And to some readers, what he is doing may seem shocking. To my mind Ammianus' inventiveness is to be appreciated rather than condemned, and is no different to the practice of most classical historians.

I have constantly used the language of allusion for Ammianus' interactions with 'sources'. This is partly because the identification of source relationships and of allusion requires exactly the same sort of demonstration. But it is also because source relationships, like intertextual relationships more broadly, become apparent only to be corrected, played with, or even directly contradicted; at other points Ammianus competitively rewrites the original. He is fond of contamination, introducing several source relationships at once. One might of course attempt to distinguish relationships with sources from allusive relationships on the grounds that allusion is often seen as 'reference' to an external text, which is supposed to be recognised and interpreted, while a source relationship is not. In practice, this distinction is hard to maintain. Without some sort of marker ('in Plato's words', 'as some sycophants allege') the author cannot guarantee that either an allusion or a relationship with a source will be recognised; conversely, he can also not guarantee that a textual relationship will not be observed and interpreted. In any case, very many of Ammianus' source relationships do seem to encourage and reward interpretation, once they are recognised, and, like allusions, function by drawing attention to what lies outside the text itself.

However, one effect of Ammianus' readiness to alter, contradict and contaminate different sources, which has been relevant to all my case studies above, is that it does of course make his source relationships harder to spot. All four of these examples have passed unnoticed by many readers; and some have been denied. It may be that a number of other such relationships remain to be identified.[58] Attempts are sometimes made to define extended relationships with putative lost historians: the nature of Ammianus' intertextuality makes this a risky practice, because he shows little inclination to follow sources consistently. Individual similarities between his text and later writers like Zonaras may be suggestive by themselves,

[58] See Bleckmann (2007).

and valuable for interpretation at the local level; but I remain to be convinced that they represent a single identifiable lost source, or one which Ammianus followed closely.[59] Scholarship should focus in another direction. Engagement with contemporary documents which he has incontrovertibly read, like Libanius and Julian, offers us something we possess for no other ancient historian.[60] Occasional glimpses can be caught in other authors: for example, what Tacitus has done with Claudius' speech on admitting Gauls to the Senate, or with the *Res Gestae Diui Augusti*, or now with the *Senatus Consultum de Cn. Pisone Patre*.[61] With Ammianus, more of these relationships are visible. He puts Julian's panegyrics of Constantius into Constantius' own mouth and into his glorious procession into Rome.[62] When Julian turns on his promoter, his attack on Constantius in the letter to the Athenians finds its way into Constantius' own indignant speech as he leads his soldiers into civil war, and with it Gregory of Nazianzus' invectives against Julian.[63] A fragment of Julian's *Caesares* makes its way into one of the speeches in Persia, but his remarks are altered to describe a different emperor.[64] This intertextuality is too little studied, because it seems too different from the 'original'. But the multiplicity of historical sources, used in fragments, mirrors the multifarious nature of his allusions; the manipulations and ventriloquy of the sources are a perfect analogy for the way Ammianus confidently puns with and reverses and places in unexpected contexts the authors of the past.

[59] See n. 4 above.

[60] The primary proponent of this neglected type of intertextuality in the case of Ammianus is Guy Sabbah, who with plausibility but less proof also argues that the *relationes* of the burgeoning bureaucracy provided the author with information ((1978), 157–77).

[61] See n. 4 above.

[62] Cf. e.g. 15.8.14 to Julian *Or.* 3.123b (Pighi (1936a), 60); 16.10.8 to Julian *Or.* 1.37c (Lindenbrog ad loc.).

[63] See den Boeft *et al.* ad 21.13.10–15.

[64] See Ch. 4, Section IV.7, Ch. 7, Section 1.

CHAPTER 6

THE EXEMPLARY HISTORIAN

> The examples are numberless . . . But if anybody should wish to know all of them, as various and constant as they are, he's fool enough to think he can investigate the number of the sands and the weight of the mountains.[1]
>
> (14.11.29, 34)

Many readers would agree with Ammianus' sentiment when reaching the conclusion of the catalogue of *exempla* that closes the first extant book of the *Res Gestae*. Musing on the fall of Gallus Caesar and the other innumerable cases of Fortune's inconstancy, Ammianus lists the rise of Agathocles from potter to king, the fall of Dionysius from terror of the nations to schoolmaster, the rise of the fuller Andriscus to kingship and the fall of Perseus' legitimate son; next, turning from Hellenistic to Roman history, how four Roman generals were surrendered to the enemy: Mancinus, Veturius, Claudius and Regulus. The slightly different example of Pompeius Magnus, slaughtered in Egypt for the pleasure of eunuchs, leads on to the slave-leaders, Eunus, Viriathus and Spartacus, before whom noble Romans supplicated (14.11.31–3). The list is imposing and perhaps baffling. The sizeable number is partly the point, as it turns out, but how applicable are they? The question raises itself both in simple terms of the chronological distance of the individual *exempla* (the murder of Pompeius, most recent of these *exempla*, happened over 400 years before Gallus' execution), and also of more general relevance. The examples speak more of capricious Fortune than the fate of Gallus (14.11.29): some do not even entail the deaths of their actors. Do they reveal most of all Ammianus' want of aesthetic judgement?

[1] 14.11.29 *cuius rei cum innumera sint exempla . . .* (34) *quae omnia si scire quisquam uelit, / quam uaria sint et assidua, / harenarum numerum idem iam desipiens et montium pondera scrutari putabit.*

Classical *exempla* are blatant and numerous, indeed unpleasantly obtrusive to many readers. Recurring in every book and in many guises, they typify Ammianus' work. They are as much a signature feature of Ammianus as speeches in Thucydides. No previous historian can match the number or the range of his examples. He is the classicising historian par excellence, and the *exempla* embrace the whole of the classical past, ranging from the quest for the Golden Fleece to contemporary emperors, from Greek philosophers to the heroes of the Roman Republic. Examples are employed creatively; indeed they are not merely creative but created. Ammianus evidently thought that the period he described was not utterly barren of virtues, and the emperors, administrators, soldiers and philosophers of his own time are characterised, when deserved, as creating positive or negative examples for future generations.[2]

The *exemplum* is a complicated figure of speech and thought. The aspect on which I shall focus in particular here is one of which we have already seen instances in the last two chapters: that is, the *exemplum* as allusion. When Julian's troops protested against Constantius' stinginess in a manner which echoed the letter of Pompeius in Sallust's *Histories* (Ch. 4, Section IV.7), the allusion summoned up the *exemplum* of Pompeius (though Pompeius was not actually named) and his similarities to, and differences from, Julian. And a number of his *exempla* from the late second and early third century have been shown above to have an intertextual relationship with Herodian's history (Ch. 5, Section III). If it is accepted that the *exemplum* is a form of allusion, however, it has

[2] Emperors: Julian e.g. at 24.5.11 [*Iulianus*] *ut . . . ad fortiter faciendum esset exemplo* ('[Julian acted . . .] so as to be an example for brave deeds'), 16.5.16 *regendi . . . uias bonis principibus aemulandas* ('paths of government to be imitated by good princes'); Valentinian at 30.9.1 *consentaneum est uenire post haec ad eius actus sequendos recte sentientibus et probandos* ('it is agreeable to turn after these [his bad qualities] to those of his achievements which are to be followed and approved by the right-minded'); negatively e.g. Gallus at 14.1.9. City Prefects stand out among the administrators: e.g. *Symmachus . . . inter praecipua nominandus exempla doctrinarum* ('to be named among the most notable examples of learning', 27.3.3). Soldiers: e.g. 24.4.20 *ibi tum uarietate casuum obsidentium labor / obsessorumque industria / uicissim facinoribus speciosis inclaruit* ('there and then, with various outcomes the toil of the besiegers and the tirelessness of the besieged were distinguished in turn with splendid deeds'). Philosophers: Epigonus and Eusebius at 14.9.5–6, Simonides at 29.1.37–9: *adulescens quidem uerum nostra memoria seuerissimus* ('though a young man, he had the strictest principles we can remember').

two distinct features: first, that it often challenges the reader's knowledge of persons and facts rather than texts *per se*, and indeed these persons and facts may often represent a whole indefinable range of texts; secondly, that it is highly visible, in a way that not all allusions are.

I shall look first at the definition of exemplum, both to contextualise my approach and to survey the range of *exempla* and similar items in Ammianus' work (Section I); next at how *exempla* interact with their sources (Section II), and how they can make and undercut political arguments (Section III). I shall then turn to a case study: the exemplary comparisons used for Gallus Caesar towards the end of Book 14 (Section IV). This will illustrate the range of techniques and interaction of *exempla*. It will also touch on the passage which stands at the head of this chapter: despite its appearance of a *locus communis de fortuna*, it is not what Quintilian called *infelix supellex* (2.4.29). It is, rather, an important programmatic passage for comprehending the function of *exempla* in the *Res Gestae*.

I Defining *exemplum*

A definition of *exemplum* can begin from Aristotle's attempts to define the workings of the closest Greek equivalent, παράδειγμα, in the *Ars Rhetorica*. He calls it rhetorical ἐπαγωγή ('induction', *Rh.* 1.1356b2–6), and elaborates (1.1357b27–30):

> It is neither the relation of part to whole, nor of whole to part, nor of one whole to another whole, but of part to part, of like to like; whenever both come under the same genus, but one is better known than the other, it is an example.[3]

He exemplifies this by using the case of Dionysius of Syracuse (1.1357b30–6): it can be argued that Dionysius aspires to tyranny in that he has requested a bodyguard. Pisistratus and Theagenes of Megara both requested bodyguards and both became tyrants.

Exemplum is a form of inductive argument, then, which juxtaposes two ideas. It appeals to experience in one case in order

[3] ἔστι δὲ οὔτε ὡς μέρος πρὸς ὅλον οὔθ' ὡς ὅλον πρὸς μέρος οὔθ' ὡς ὅλον πρὸς ὅλον, ἀλλ' ὡς μέρος πρὸς μέρος, ὅμοιον πρὸς ὅμοιον – ὅταν ἄμφω μὲν ᾖ ὑπὸ τὸ αὐτὸ γένος, γνωριμώτερον δὲ θάτερον ᾖ θατέρου, παράδειγμα ἐστιν.

to draw conclusions in the other. *Exempla* are persuasive but not strictly logical (there are, after all, other motivations for a man to seek a bodyguard than ambitions of tyranny). They are also, as Aristotle says, partial (an aspect illustrated by the etymology of the Latin word *exemplum*: from *eximere*, 'to cut out'). One of the imperfections of argument from exemplarity is that the *exempla* are excerpted from their broader context. Such an excerption, if it is to appeal to the memory of an audience, cannot inevitably be concealed and will not inevitably be successful. *Exempla* can be manipulated, and with difficulty changed, but there is no guarantee the intended reception will prevail.[4] *Exempla* may be normative, but they are also debatable. (To take an example from modern politics, Dan Quayle could point out the equivalence of his experience in Congress when seeking the Vice-Presidency with that of J. F. Kennedy seeking the Presidency, but his opponent could suggest that in other respects the comparison did not hold.)[5] It will be seen how Ammianus can make use, and simultaneously question the aptness, of the semi-official comparisons to earlier emperors which were used to promote the rulers of his own day.

Aristotle is as much prescriptive and idealising as descriptive – and chronologically Ammianus is as close to the high Middle Ages as he is to the Greek philosopher. A description of medieval *exempla* might mention their purpose as ornaments to the text: such a description would not be out of place for some of Ammianus' examples. Calling an *exemplum* an inductive argument is certainly

[4] A passage of Velleius on the dangerous precedent shows awareness of the mutability of *exempla*, and specifically of the dangers of precedents (2.3.4): *non enim ibi consistunt exempla unde coeperunt, sed quamlibet in tenuem recepta tramitem latissime euagandi sibi uiam faciunt, et ubi semel recto deerratum est, in praeceps peruenitur, nec quisquam sibi putat turpe quod alii fuit fructuosum* ('examples, you see, don't stand still where they started, but although accepted into the narrowest of contexts, make a path on which they can wander far and wide, and when things have once wandered off the straight and narrow, they take a fall, nor does anybody think shameful for himself what was profitable for another').

[5] 'Quayle: I have as much experience in the Congress as Jack Kennedy did when he sought the Presidency.
Bentsen: Senator, I served with Jack Kennedy. I knew Jack Kennedy. Jack Kennedy was a friend of mine. Senator, you are no Jack Kennedy. [*huge applause*]
Quayle: That was really uncalled-for, Senator. [*applause, laughter*]
Bentsen: You're the one that was making the comparison, Senator.'
(Debate between candidates for the US Vice-Presidency, 14 September 1988).

idealistic. In practice, overt argument is unusual, even to the extent found in the case of Dionysius. We will find that *exemplum* usually stands somewhere in between argument and ornament.

Aristotle's own use of *exemplum* is helped by the fact that he puts this theoretical case in the present tense, fully aware that Dionysius had become a tyrant, though perhaps unaware that Dionysius would become one of the classic *exempla* of tyranny.[6] This makes him an excellent example of an example: *exempla* are concerned not only with interpretation of the present from the past but also the interpretation of the future from the present. This important and neglected point is well expressed by Jane Chaplin in her study of *exempla* in Livy: 'But *exempla* have one essential element. By their very nature, they involve two time-frames: either the past is recollected and applied to the present, or the present is envisioned as a source of models for the future.'[7] When he compared Julian to Marcus Aurelius (16.1.4, 22.5.4, 25.4.17) the comparison was to an emperor that Ammianus himself had already described – one presumes – as exemplary. The example of Julian himself haunts his successors, Valentinian and Valens.[8] The distinction is limited, but there is one important difference. The *exemplum* that looks from present to past is by definition intertextual. When the present is envisioned as exemplary for the future, it is not guaranteed that other texts will use that *exemplum*.[9] Ammianus' Julian is constantly referred to as an *exemplum* following his death; although Urban Prefects are frequently described as imitable by Ammianus, they do not recur within the text. (The same could be argued of their respective reception in other later texts.) As my interest is in *exemplum* as intertextuality, my focus here will be on the first category, where the past is recollected and applied to the present (some examples of the other type of *exemplum* will be examined in the following chapter).[10] It is here worth noting one subtlety which

[6] Cf. 15.5.37, 16.8.10, 29.2.4. [7] Chaplin (2000), 197. [8] See Ch. 7, Section III.

[9] Livy's Lucretia portrays her death as preventing the creation of a bad example ('nor will any wanton live hereafter because of Lucretia's example', *nec ulla deinde impudica Lucretiae exemplo uiuet*, Livy 1.58.10). Many texts would use the example, whether positive or horrifying, of Lucretia, but the subsequent books of Livy (as extant) notably do not. Chaplin (2000), 1.

[10] This second category – *exempla* generated by Ammianus within his narrative – has recently been the subject of a study by Wittchow (2001); his approach is narratological, treating them as akin to anecdotes.

is missing from Chaplin's description above, though it is certainly not absent from her book. It is not only the past which is applied to the present: we can also sometimes see the past altered to fit with the needs of the present![11]

Exempla live in a broad semantic field: inductive arguments, allusions, anecdotes might all be semi-synonyms. Commonest of all has been to see them as distinctly tasteless and unnecessary ornaments, an eccentricity of Ammianus' style and Ammianus' age which should be first disparaged and then ignored. When Gibbon rendered Ammianus' Roman digressions, he expurgated most of the *exempla uetustatis* from his rendition.[12] H. T. Rowell, having depreciated digressions, put beside them the 'moralising *exempla*, drawn from an apparently inexhaustible supply, with which Ammianus spoils the climax of many a superb piece of narrative'.[13] The effect of the examples is passed over. The natural response for the commentator has been to identify sources, or more often 'parallels'; for the writer of monographs the usual response is silence. The neglect is unfortunate, and my argument will be that it is very often productive to return to the source of the *exempla* and to complete the implied argument, whether that is a particular text or a story covered in a range of texts. As a process, this is of course fundamentally allusive.[14]

Exempla can be understood in many ways; they also come in many guises. Breadth is advisable in defining their character and number within the text. This can be illustrated by a look at the list which R. C. Blockley includes as an appendix to his study of Ammianus.[15] The book has a fine summary chapter on *exempla*, which recognises that *exempla* are both summoned up from the past and created for the future.[16] The subsequent non-inclusion in Blockley's appendix of the examples created by the actors and

[11] As we have already seen with Herodian (Ch. 5, Section III).

[12] See Womersley (1988), 169–81. [13] Rowell (1964), 33 (= 1967, 293).

[14] Compare to my words above Thomas (1986), 172 n. 8, on allusion or 'reference', quoted in Ch. 4 n. 13 above.

[15] Blockley (1975), App. F and G; Neumann (1987), 60, provides addenda. Blockley (1994) has further thoughts on *exempla*.

[16] 'The great example is of course Julian, and Ammianus is careful to point out his merits and the actions which illustrate them, to furnish him with quotable anecdotes and, by comparing him with Alexander, Trajan and Marcus Aurelius, to set him firmly in the line of great rulers who are to be imitated.' Blockley (1975), 167.

action of the *Res Gestae* is plainly deliberate. Other omissions are perhaps not.

Blockley does not include occasions when characters think of the actions of other characters in the extant books. But what is the difference between Julian learning from the example of his brother Gallus (as he does at 17.1.14 and 21.1.2), and from that of Marcus Aurelius (as at 16.1.4 and 22.5.4)? Both Gallus and Marcus were described in the *Res Gestae*, one (in part) in an extant and the other in a lost section of the work. Why is one not to be counted as an *exemplum*? The case is similar when Valentinian worries about Procopius' usurpation, and remembers the speed with which Julian had crossed Europe ('he was terrified by a recent example', *documento . . . recenti . . . terrebatur*, 26.5.11).[17]

For the sake of clarity, Blockley separates *exempla* and *sententiae* (that is to say, memorable sayings). Nobody doubts that words and deeds are different; but in the ancient collections such as that of Valerius Maximus, sayings and deeds were placed alongside each other. Looking at Ammianus in particular it will be found that the lessons of *sententiae* and *exempla* are drawn in the same way; this incidentally offers a neat demonstration of the allusive nature of *exempla*.[18]

Blockley is probably also excessively bound by the vocabulary which introduces examples.[19] It is not necessary to have it explicitly stated that a character was similar to someone or imitated him, or dissimilar to or ignorant of him, for a comparison to be suggested. For example, the famous *aduentus* of Constantius (16.10) shows the buildings of Rome providing a kind of architectural *exemplum* to the arrogant emperor. Constantius stood fixed with astonishment at the Market of Trajan and declared that he could only *imitate* Trajan's horse (16.10.15). An account of the military success of Julian at Strasbourg (16.12) is juxtaposed with the emperor's undeserved triumph, and Julian subsequently restores a building of

[17] See Ch. 7, Section III.2.

[18] Blockley uses the same signs in the tables in App. F and G to denote whether the person compared knew or was ignorant of the *exemplum* or *sententia*.

[19] For example, 14.11.20 is unmentioned (Gallus was taken for his execution to a place near that where Crispus Caesar had been killed on Constantine's orders (discussed below p. 286).

Trajan's (17.1.11), a fort in Alamann territory. No ostensible comparison is made, but the foundation of the fort by Trajan certainly creates an *exemplum*. A comparison of both Constantius and Julian to Trajan, and thereby to each other: the one cannot imitate him, the other does.[20] Neither is mentioned in Blockley's appendix.

Unspecific *exempla* are often found. At the very start of the extant books, Gallus is accused of having failed to try those he had adjudged guilty, 'something which savage princes have sometimes done' (*quod aliquotiens fecere principes saeui*, 14.1.5). Thalassius did not try to calm the Caesar, 'in the way that lofty offices sometimes softened the rages of princes' (*ut aliquotiens celsae potestates iras principum molliuerunt*, 14.1.10). Later in the same book (14.5.5), Constantius is accused of having surpassed even unrelenting princes, *inexorabiles principes*, as a cruel judge. The absence of names leaves this *exemplum* more open than most; it may also reflect the historical ignorance of the characters.

Another type of historical reference which should probably be classified as an *exemplum* is the 'first occurrence' or 'first begetter',[21] a case such as when Ursicinus' return to favour is indicated by *adoratio* of the imperial purple: 'Diocletian was the first of all to introduce this foreign and royal practice of adoration, whereas we have read that previously princes were always greeted in a similar way to civilian officials [*iudices*]' (15.5.18).[22] The past has no prophetic meaning for the present here, but it does have explanatory force.[23] Similarly, in the first Roman digression, readers learn of the origins of gilded statues and shaded amphitheatres (14.6.8, 25): both examples derive from Valerius Maximus' *Facta et Dicta Memorabilia*.[24] A variation on this type, which is well represented by the possible translation of *exemplum* as 'precedent', is also found:[25] the unprecedented or unexampled action. When something is said to have been done 'in previously unprecedented

[20] Julian had been compared at the start of the previous book to Trajan, along with other good emperors: 'very like Trajan in the glorious marches of war' (*bellorum gloriosis cursibus Traiani simillimus*, 16.1.4).

[21] The rhetorical trope of πρῶτος εὑρετής. See Viansino (1977), 95 (*non uidi*).

[22] *Diocletianus enim Augustus omnium primus / externo et regio more / instituit adorari, / cum semper antea ad similitudinem iudicum / salutatos principes legerimus.*

[23] It also invites comparison with Diocletian, and even with foreign kingly practice.

[24] See Section II below.

[25] Chaplin (2000) dedicates an entire chapter (Ch. 5, 137–67) to *exempla* as precedents.

fashion' (*adhuc inusitato more*), or 'with a new precedent' (*nouo exemplo*), this generates an *exemplum* for the future, but also takes the place of an example of the past because it demands scrutiny of the past. The emperor Valentinian, for instance, made his brother and his son not Caesars but Augusti, in which 'he went beyond the custom established of old' (*morem institutum antiquitus supergressus*), though the emperor Marcus offered some parallel, having made his adoptive brother Verus a fellow Augustus without in any way diminishing his imperial majesty (27.6.16). Identifying the example required a notional survey of the imperial *fasti* – though in fact the comparison to Marcus was bandied around at the time, and Ammianus might have got it from Eutropius.[26]

It is understandable that Blockley does not admit into his list *exempla* which belong to the digressions (except the two Roman digressions): these tend to be straightforward historical references. A learned gloss (for example, mentioning alongside a city the name of its founder) or a continuous piece of narrative explaining the origins of, say, the Gauls or the Parthians is unlikely to be exemplary.[27] But the digressions are not altogether without *exempla*. On occasion characters mentioned in digressions arguably prove exemplary for characters in the main narrative. Germanicus Caesar's rejection by the Apis bull (22.14.8) arguably anticipates the various omens predicting the death of Julian.[28] Hercules as the originator of the Gauls is likely to have some exemplary force at the point of the narrative where Julian is first created Caesar and sent to Gaul, albeit on an imprecise level:[29] with other portions of that text, the stories of Hannibal or the aetiology of the Matrona pass, exemplarity is harder to identify. In any case, judgements of this sort are subjective.[30]

Lists of Ammianus' *exempla* tell only a partial story. There are occasions when no *exemplum* is used, and the silence can be

[26] It is worth contrasting the reference to Marcus Aurelius and Lucius Verus in Eutropius, writing under Valentinian and Valens (8.9.2), to those in other authors writing before and after who followed the same basic source (Aurelius Victor *De Caesaribus* 16.3, and the anonymous *Epitome de Caesaribus* 16.5). Ammianus was not malicious enough to mention the case of Valerian, who promoted his son Gallienus to be a full Augustus almost immediately – those rulers offered a very negative example.

[27] City and founder: e.g. 14.8.2 Seleucia and Seleucus, Claudiopolis and Claudius; origins of the Gauls: 15.9.2–7; origins of the Parthians: 23.6.2–6.

[28] See Ch. 4, p. 184. [29] 15.9.3; cf. Rike (1987), 24–5. [30] 15.10.6–11.

striking. Though other emperors have obituaries filled with *exempla*. Valens has none.[31] To be sure, his death is compared to that of the emperor Decius (31.13.13) or the republican general Scipio Calvus (31.13.17), but the assessment of his reign entirely lacks examples (31.14.1–7). This is perhaps to be explained as reflecting Valens' own ignorance.[32] The usurper Procopius is compared in a famous passage to an over-ornate actor (26.6.15). Procopius does not lack for examples, mainly in the constant usurpations of the Severan age, when, in Herodian's words, there were more emperors than the years warranted (1.1.5);[33] but at this point, where an example might be expected, the comparison acts as a substitute for an *exemplum*, as if Procopius does not merit a historical comparison. The faults of the Roman people are described at several points in terms reminiscent of the theatre.[34] Emperors and commanders become the old men of comedy, courtiers their sycophants, loathsome secret agents become the plotting slaves. Similarly, anger can be that of a lion, deceit that of a serpent.[35] Animal comparisons, as when Maximinus is constantly characterised by snake similes (28.1.7, 33, 41), are clearly substituting for *exempla*;[36] the characterisation of Paulus Catena and other administrators through allusions to comedy has the same function.[37] It is notable that there is no external *exemplum* for Christianity, only Julian's comparison to wild beasts (22.5.4), typical in tone of Ammianus more than of Julian, and the suggestion (27.3.15) that the popes should adopt the humble lifestyle and posture of provincial bishops.

One important aspect of exemplarity in Ammianus which may already be evident is the extent to which *exempla* look outwards. A comparison to Livy is instructive. The great majority of examples

[31] The same feature is found for Jovian (25.10.13), with the exception of his imitation of the very recent example of Constantius. Constantius' obituary has nine or ten by my reckoning, Julian's five and Valentinian's eighteen.

[32] He was *subagrestis ingenii, nec bellicis nec liberalibus studiis eruditus* ('of bumpkinish intellect, learned neither in military nor liberal pursuits', 31.14.5).

[33] See Ch. 5, Section III.

[34] 14.6.16 (compare Terence *Eunuchus* 780), 28.4.12, 27, 32, 34 (cf. Plautus *Pseudolus* 840–1, 880, and Ch. 4, Section III).

[35] E.g. 14.9.9, 28.1.7.

[36] Blockley (1975), 183–4, has a list of animal comparisons; see also Barnes (1998), 107–11.

[37] See Ch. 4, n. 33.

cited in Livy are ones which have already been created by the Livian text. His project of recording the entirety of Roman history naturally increases the chances of this greatly. Chaplin emphasises the extent to which *exempla* are debatable and capable of alteration over time. Though ancient *exempla* have more authority, recent ones tend to have more relevance to audiences. Chaplin focuses especially on the way that they are subsequently invoked. It is commonest for them to be part of speeches or 'focalised' through a particular character. Much rarer is the authorial use of *exemplum*.[38]

An inspection of Ammianus shows a rather different pattern. The loss of the first thirteen books makes it impossible to be fully precise, but though there are many *exempla* of the past which refer to matter within the range of the *Res Gestae* the majority come from periods outside Ammianus' work (at my count nearly 75 per cent). And though one can certainly find plenty of instances of examples being invoked in speeches or in the thoughts of characters, the great majority are openly authorial (over 85 per cent). There are of course comparatively far fewer speeches in the text of Ammianus, a reflection of the politics of the period. But it is a distinctive feature of Ammianus' style that he adduces *exempla* which markedly do not come from the thoughts of characters, and indeed the characters' ignorance is frequently stressed. The greater prominence of external allusions, intertexts rather than intra-texts, one might say, pulls the classical past into Ammianus' work. Compared to the *exempla* contained within the *illustre monumentum* of Livy, the *Res Gestae* is closer to the arch of Constantine – a monument adorned with exemplary *spolia*.

II The sources of *exempla*

In this section, my aim is to examine the techniques with which Ammianus interacts with the sources of his *exempla*; I shall also look more closely at whether it matters what source an *exemplum* comes from, and to what extent 'authorship' is significant.

This is not a thorough-going survey of the sources of Ammianus' *exempla*, though the somewhat haphazard results of scholarship

[38] Chaplin (2000), 3–4, 50–72.

hitherto make that desirable. For the record, I am confident that among the authors identifiably alluded to in *exempla* are Cicero (at least half a dozen different works), Cassius Dio, Eutropius, Festus, Florus, Gellius, Herodian, Homer, Isocrates, the *Kaisergeschichte*, Livy, Claudius Mamertinus (the panegyrist of Julian), Plutarch, Polybius, Quintilian, Sallust, Solinus, Valerius Maximus and Vergil. Many of Ammianus' *exempla* from the years 96–353 must in fact be presumed to be intra-textual; in other cases the sources must be presumed to be lost works; and in a great many, 'source' is simply not a meaningful term. For example, yet another comparison of Roman soldiers to the Decii of old, or to Sicinius and Sergius, is a cliché which allows no identification of sources (though it is not therefore meaningless).[39] When the upstarts investigating the treason of the Roman nobility are compared to Busiris, Antaeus and Phalaris (28.1.46), one has seen them all before and not only in Ammianus (Phalaris at 26.10.5, Antaeus at 30.4.19). They occur intermittently as *exempla* in Latin literature, especially Ovid, but all three are present and close together in *HA Maximini Duo* and Claudian's *In Rufinum*.[40] These *exempla* are characteristically but not exclusively a typical fourth-century phenomenon. Indeed, even to the reader of Golden and Silver Latin the exemplarity of the fourth century stands out: it is palpably more ubiquitous and more wide-ranging in its field of cultural reference than, for instance, the powerful effect of the *exempla maiorum* in the literature, nomenclature and culture of the Roman nobility of the late republic.[41]

Many *exempla* seem to be chosen in competition with his contemporaries. Ammianus is sometimes found correcting the faulty use of *exempla* by his characters, when an emperor is compared by

[39] Interesting, for instance, that the Decii are first adduced in the extant text as an *exemplum* for three Roman commanders with untraditional names: Arintheus, Seniauchus and Bappo (15.4.11). The comparison of Natuspardo to Sicinius and Sergius (27.10.16) exhibits a similar indifference to ethnic origins. Such examples sit uneasily with the long-standing concern of German scholarship with Ammianus' *Antigermanismus*.

[40] Busiris, king of Egypt, and Phalaris are associated by Ovid at *Tristia* 3.11.39–40, as are Busiris and Antaeus as cruel victims of Hercules at *Met.* 9.182–4. The three names are in close proximity at *HA Maximini Duo* 6.9, 8.5, and in Claudian, *In Rufinum* 1.253, 254, 288 (Syme (1968), 132).

[41] On this see e.g. Flower (1996). See Rambaud (1953), 25–54, for the wide range of historical examples in Cicero.

himself or by his supporters to a favoured predecessor; so Jovian's similarity to Constantius (25.9.3, 25.10.14–15) and Valentinian's link to Aurelian (30.8.8) are disparaged, and even Julian's emulation of Marcus is qualified (22.5.5).[42] Sometimes he can be seen competing with the examples of other contemporaries: the merchant and soldier Antoninus, who defected to Persia before the invasion of 359, is described by Libanius (*Or.* 12.74) in the light of the example of Demaratus, the Medising King of Sparta in Herodotus. It is presumably in a quest for variation that Ammianus describes Antoninus, crossing the Tigris into Persia, as 'in an opposing sense, like that Zopyrus, the betrayer of Babylon' (*ex contraria specie / Zopyri illius similis / Babylonii proditoris*, 18.5.3). (Zopyrus was a Persian noble who maimed himself and defected to Babylon in order to betray it to the Persians, Herodotus 3.153–60.)[43] And it is possible that, when Ammianus calls the battle of Adrianople the most disastrous battle in Roman history except Cannae (31.13.19), he is correcting the exaggeration with which Themistius defended Theodosius' failure to defeat the Goths by calling them a worse threat than Hannibal (*Or.* 34.22).[44]

Though *exempla* are derived from a wide range of sources, it is fair to say that many are derived from the sort of works which modern readers tend to treat with snobbish disdain. Ammianus clearly makes use of 'handbooks' like Valerius Maximus, Gellius, or Festus. His use of them is far from slavish, however, as the following case studies will show: indeed it is his independence that will cause alarm.

Firstly, Dolabella and the woman of Smyrna. In Book 29 Ammianus describes the reign of terror that befell Antioch and the East when a plot against Valens' life was uncovered. In an extravagant patchwork of learning, he apostrophises the wisdom that might have given Valens the security not to overreact: he echoes Cicero

[42] On Julian's emulation of Marcus see Lacombrade (1965); Kelly (2005); downplayed by Hunt (1995). On Jovian, Valentinian and their models see further below Ch. 7, Section III.1 and III.2.

[43] On this occasion it seems fair to say that Ammianus' *exemplum* comes off worse. See Sabbah (1978), 278–9; Blockley (1998), 251. This strange use of Zopyrus might serve as a supporting argument for anyone who wished to depreciate the extent, directness, or freshness of Ammianus' knowledge of Herodotus (on which see Fornara (1992b), 421–3).

[44] Lenski (1997), 162.

and quotes an otherwise unknown *dictum* of Caesar the dictator. He condemns Valens' hasty use of the death penalty, and continues with an *exemplum* 'well known to antiquity' (*ut exemplum est illud antiquitati admodum notum*, 29.2.18):

29.2.19 apud proconsulem Asiae Dolabellam / Smyrnaea mulier subolem propriam et maritum / uenenis necasse confessa, / quod filium e matrimonio priore susceptum occiderint, / et comperendinata, / cum consilium, ad quod res ex more delata est, / anceps, quid inter ultionem et scelus statui debeat, haesitaret, / ad Areopagitas missa est, / Athenienses iudices tristiores, / quorum aequitas deorum quoque iurgia dicitur distinxisse. / hi causa cognita / centesimo post anno cum accusatore mulierem adesse iusserunt, / ne aut absoluerent ueneficam aut ultrix necessitudinum puniretur. / ita numquam tardum existimatur, / quod est omnium ultimum.

Before the proconsul of Asia, Dolabella, a woman of Smyrna admitted having murdered her own offspring and her husband with poison, because they had killed a son begotten from a previous marriage. And when she'd been bound over to appear two days later, since his council, to whom the matter was delegated according to

Gellius 12.7 Ad Cn. Dolabellam proconsulari imperio prouinciam Asiam obtinentem deducta mulier Smyrnaea est. (2) eadem mulier uirum et filium eodem tempore uenenis clam datis uita interfecerat atque id fecisse se confitebatur dicebatque se habuisse faciendi causam, quoniam idem illi maritus et filius alterum filium mulieris ex uiro priore genitum, adulescentem optimum et innocentissimum, exceptum insidiis occidissent. idque ita factum controuersia non erat. (3) Dolabella retulit ad consilium. (4) nemo quisquam ex consilio sententiam ferre in causa tam ancipiti audebat, quod et confessum ueneficium quo maritus et filius necati forent, non admittendum impunitum uidebatur et digna tamen poena in homines sceleratos uindicatum fuisset. (5) Dolabella eam rem Athenas ad Ariopagitas ut ad iudices grauiores exercitatioresque reiecit. (6) Ariopagitae cognita causa accusatorem mulieris et ipsam, quae accusabatur, centesimo anno adesse iusserunt. (7) sic neque absolutum mulieris ueneficium est, quod per leges non licuit, neque nocens damnata poenitaque, quae digna uenia fuit.

When Gnaeus Dolabella held the province of Asia with proconsular *imperium* a woman of Smyrna was brought before him. (2) This woman had killed her husband and son on the same occasion by secretly giving them poison, and admitted that she'd done it and said that she'd had a reason to do it, since those same men, the husband and son, had treacherously caught and killed another son of the woman, born of a previous husband, an outstanding and blameless youth. And there was no doubt that it had happened

custom, were hesitating, in two minds as to how it ought to be judged between vengeance and crime, she was sent to the Areopagites, those severe judges of Athens by whose fairness even the gods' quarrels are said to have been settled. When they had heard the case, they ordered the woman and her accuser to attend in a hundred years time, so that they should neither acquit a poisoner nor punish the avenger of her family. Thus what is last of all things is never considered late.

so. (3) Dolabella took it to his council. (4) Absolutely nobody from the council dared to give a decision on so two-sided a case, since they thought that acknowledged poisoning, by which her husband and son had been killed, should not be allowed to go unpunished, and yet a fitting punishment had been visited upon wicked men. (5) Dolabella referred the case to Athens, to the Ariopagites, as severer and more experienced judges. (6) Having heard the case, the Ariopagites ordered the accuser of the woman and the accused herself to attend in a hundred years. (7) Thus the woman wasn't acquitted of poisoning, which was forbidden by law, nor was a guilty person who was worthy of pardon convicted and punished.

The same story is found in both Valerius Maximus 8.1.amb.2 and Gellius 12.7. Gellius attributes it to the ninth (*sic*) book of Valerius, with the main alteration being the addition (invention) of the details of legal procedure, the referral to the *consilium*. One glimpse at Gellius' account is enough to demonstrate that, though Ammianus knew both authors well, he drew on Gellius here, in the main trimming the details (the good character of the murdered son, for instance), and joining together the brief sentences.[45] The only details added are a technical procedure (*comperendinata*), and the reference to the mythical judgement of Orestes 'by whose fairness even the gods' quarrels are said to have been settled', *quorum aequitas deorum quoque iurgia dicitur distinxisse*: both alterations illustrate the way that *exempla* of this sort are not set in stone but are creatively developed.[46]

Secondly, some examples from the first Roman digression. Ammianus contrasts the Roman plutocrats of his own day with their virtuous and impoverished forebears (14.6.11):

hac ex causa collaticia stipe / Valerius humatur ille Publicola, / et subsidiis amicorum mariti, / inops cum liberis / uxor alitur Reguli, / et dotatur ex aerario filia

[45] I am not aware of any case where Ammianus has echoed either the language or the *exempla* of Valerius Maximus Book 8, though he clearly echoes all the other books.
[46] See Holford-Strevens (1987), 57.

Scipionis, / cum nobilitas florem adultae uirginis diuturnum / absentia pauperis erubesceret patris.

Hence Valerius, surnamed Publicola, was buried from contributed funds, and the impoverished wife of Regulus was supported with the help of her husband's friends, and the daughter of Scipio was dowered from the treasury, since the nobility blushed that the maidenhood of a grown virgin endured because of her impoverished father's absence.

All of these characters are found in the same chapter of Valerius Maximus (4.4.1, 6, 10).[47] Though Valerius writes that Regulus' family was supported by the Senate, not his friends (4.4.6), this divergence surely must yield to the fact that all three appear in order in the same chapter of the *Facta et Dicta Memorabilia*. Chronological order is preserved, as is usual when Ammianus has a sequence of *exempla*. Besides, there are two other passages with debts to Valerius in the same digression. At 14.6.8 Ammianus mentions that Acilius Glabrio had been the first to overlay statues with gold, after the defeat of King Antiochus, information also found in Livy 40.34.5 and Valerius 2.5.1. And there is the account of the awnings of the theatres (14.6.25):

nonnulli sub uelabris umbraculorum theatralium latent, / quae, Campanam imitatus lasciuiam, / Catulus in aedilitate sua suspendit omnium primus.

A number lurk beneath the awnings of the theatre's parasols, which Catulus in his aedileship was the first person to hang up, in imitation of Campanian luxury.

Possible sources have been suggested as Valerius Maximus 2.4.6 or Pliny *NH* 19.23. However, a short look at the texts puts the matter beyond doubt. Valerius: *Q. Catulus* ***Campanam imitatus luxuriam*** *primus spectantium consessum* ***uelorum umbraculis*** *texit*. Pliny: *in theatris tenta umbram fecere, quod primus omnium inuenit Q. Catulus cum Capitolium dedicaret*.[48] To Valerius there are close

[47] The source was evident to Straub writing about the imperial image (1939), 202, and to Klotz writing on Valerius ((1942), 60: 'XXIV [read XIV] 6.11 ist außer Val.Max. IV 4,10 auch IV 4, 1.5 [read 6] benutzt'), but no commentator until Andrew Wallace-Hadrill, annotating the Penguin Classics translation (1986, 446), observed the full nature of this close textual relationship. Neither Finke, in his dissertation on Ammianus' sources for republican history (1904), nor the commentators, de Jonge and Galletier, improved on their seventeenth-century predecessors. See now Rohrbacher (2005), 21–3, 25.

[48] 'Quintus Catulus, imitating Campanian luxury, first covered the spectators' seating with the shade of sails.' 'In theatres stretched [linen cloths] were used to make shade, which was first invented by Q. Catulus when he dedicated the Capitol.'

similarities, from Pliny a major divergence. Pliny correctly dates the event to Catulus' restoration of the Capitol rather than his – otherwise unattested – aedileship. The absence of this aedileship from Valerius Maximus may cause momentary alarm, but Henri de Valois demonstrates that it is Ammianus' erroneous addition.[49] (It is possible that the error arises from a false recollection of a text such as Pliny.) In this one chapter of Ammianus, then, one sees five different uses of Valerius, three from the same chapter, and the other two (2.4.6, 2.5.1) even closer: from within a page of each other in modern texts of Valerius. In two of these five places, Ammianus appears to have made errors either of transcription or of memory.[50]

A third case: Socrates the lyre-player. The second Roman digression offers another instance of potentially alarming error. Ammianus attacks the Roman nobility because they read no other books than Juvenal and Marius Maximus, and suggests that they ought to read a great variety of literature (28.4.14). A constant function of the examples in Ammianus' history is to show the purpose and utility of historical learning, to defend the validity of historical writing and to prove that historical actors must know their authors: here he proffers an example from the life of Socrates. When under sentence of death, he heard a skilful lyre-player accompanying a poem of Stesichorus and asked the man if he would teach him. When asked why, since he was going to die tomorrow, Socrates replied, 'So I might leave this life knowing something more' (28.4.15). The story is unparalleled. Ammianus seems to have mixed a *dictum* from the lips of Solon with the conventional *exemplum* of Socrates learning to play the lyre in old age. The confusion is understandable: Solon and Socrates are frequently adjacent as *exempla* of a spirited old age, for example in Cicero's *De Senectute* 26, and Valerius Maximus, who follows Cicero (8.7.ext.8,14). A verse of Solon, γηράσκω γ' αἰεὶ πολλὰ διδασκόμενος ('I grow old always learning many things', Plutarch *Sol.* 31), is presumably the ultimate source of the *dictum*. Cicero quotes him as saying that 'learning something daily he was becoming an old man' (*se cotidie aliquid*

[49] Valesius ad loc.: 'id de suo admensus est noster Marcellinus: in quo uereor ne eum ratio fugerit'. See also Finke (1904), 19–20.

[50] On these and other *exempla* derived from Valerius Maximus see now Rohrbacher (2005).

addiscentem . . . senem fieri). The closest version to Ammianus' *exemplum* that we have is in a fragment of Aelian (fr. 190, apud Stobaeum 3.29.58): 'Solon the Athenian, son of Execestides, when his nephew sang a lyric of Sappho at a drinking party, enjoyed the song and asked the young man to teach it to him. When asked why he was so keen to do this he replied: "So that I can learn it and then die (ἵνα μαθὼν αὐτὸ ἀποθάνω)"'.[51] It looks as if, in an *exemplum* designed to show the value of wide reading and a constant quest for knowledge, Ammianus has confused two stories.[52]

A fourth and last example comes from the digression on Thrace in Book 27 (and incidentally demonstrates the potential for passages in digressions to have exemplary status). Ammianus mentions the tribe of the Scordisci, 'by whose savageness, when the Roman state had been plagued by many military disasters, it finally lost a whole army with its commander' (*quorum asperitate post multiplices pugnarum aerumnas / saepe res Romana uexata / postremo omnem amisit exercitum cum rectore*, 27.4.4). The defeat is that of M. Porcius Cato (cos. 114 BC). Ammianus' general source for the Scordisci in this passage was Festus (*Breuiarium* 9). Festus, however, does not report the Roman defeat, though it can be found in Festus' source, Florus (*Epit.* 1.39.4). Ammianus had read Florus, and probably other Roman histories that covered the period on the grand or the condensed scale, Livy or Eutropius.[53] Divergences of this type have led some commentators into paroxysms of guesswork; rather than the simple conclusion that Ammianus followed Festus but supplemented his knowledge from external sources such as Florus, they posit a lost common source for Florus and Festus and Ammianus.[54] No other source, however, reports that Cato died in that battle. The alteration must be assumed to be

[51] Tr. N. G. Wilson.

[52] It is not of course demonstrable that the invention in this case is Ammianus'. A good many of his *exempla* must be assumed to derive from lost works. But the likelihood is that readings of Cicero and Aelian combined to produce a new *exemplum*.

[53] See above p. 178 on Ammianus' knowledge of Livy, though we cannot prove that he had read Livy's lost books. On his knowledge of Eutropius see Ch. 5, Section IV. See also Eutropius 4.24 on this battle.

[54] Finke (1904), 55, denies the direct use of Festus, demonstrated by Mommsen (1881), 605–9 (=1909, 396–400), in this case because Festus omitted this battle, in general because of a wish to minimise Ammianus' learning.

due either to Ammianus' faulty memory or to his wilful error. I suspect the latter, as the alteration also notably serves an exemplary purpose: it is one of the earliest omens of the defeat and death of Valens at Adrianople.[55] It is followed by a passage describing what will later be the theatre of the Gothic War of the 370s.

What to make of these *exempla* and the alterations made to them? It would be wrong to conclude that they show Ammianus utterly dependent on handbooks. Although it is easier to find examples of dignified poverty by turning to the poverty section of a collection of *exempla* than by reading Livy, it does not mean that Ammianus had not read Livy (in any case, there is no greater possibility of historical authenticity in Livy's discussion of Valerius Publicola than in Valerius Maximus', and Ammianus demonstrably *had* read and absorbed Sallust, Livy and Tacitus).[56] A small example: in Book 30 Ammianus tells the story of how King Pyrrhus' doctor had solicited a bribe from the Romans for poisoning his master; they sent the king a warning (30.1.22). The direct source is almost certainly Gellius 3.8,[57] but the cognomen of the Roman consul Fabricius Luscinus, who reported his doctor's treachery to the enemy, is correctly added by Ammianus from external knowledge. Not admittedly an addition that required an intimate knowledge of republican history. What these examples do show, however, is the creativity with which Ammianus alters *exempla*. In the fact of this, he is hardly unusual (whole books of exemplary fictions about Greek philosophers and Roman republican heroes were compiled without scholarly apparatus).

Sometimes details which he adds, such as Catulus' aedileship, are erroneous, sometimes, as with Fabricius' cognomen, they are correct. Sometimes the adaptation seems simply to make the story better: the *dictum* 'so that I might die knowing this' works much better for Socrates than for Solon, whether the reattribution was a

[55] See the introduction to Marié's Budé (1984), 28–9, and ad loc.; Kelly (2004), 163.

[56] For factual rather than linguistic debts to Sallust see Finke (1904), 20–30. On Livy and Tacitus see above pp. 175–8.

[57] Gellius 3.8.5 offers two possible names for the doctor, Timochares and Nicias, whence Ammianus has *Democharen, uel ut quidam scribunt, Nician* ('Democharen, or as others write, Nicias'). The confusion over the aurally similar sounds *Demo-* and *Timo-* might suggest that Ammianus' working methods included being read to and dictating in the manner attested for the elder Pliny by his nephew, *Ep.* 3.5.10–12.

mistake or a joke. But he is also willing to adapt *exempla* to make them fit their rhetorical function at their point in his narrative better. Regulus' wife and children being supported by his friends rather than the Senate (not so large a discrepancy, in any case, 14.6.11) fits perfectly with the focus of the digression as a whole on the Roman abuse of friendship.[58] More forceful is the amendment of history that made the Roman defeat in Thrace in the late second century BC at the hands of the savage Scordisci wipe out an army *and* its leader, in preparation for the fate of Valens. Nor are *exempla* from the period of Ammianus' own history immune from alterations which make them serve their exemplary purpose better: I showed in the previous chapter how in 29.1.17 Ammianus had adapted an *exemplum* very probably taken from Herodian, of an assassination plot against Commodus – he said it happened 'after many different internal threats' (*post intestina pericula multa et uaria*), when all other sources place it at the beginning of the reign, and he increases the seriousness of it by having Commodus wounded, though this seems quite inauthentic. The *exemplum* was altered to fit the seriousness of the current instance.[59]

Ammianus' *inuentio* when faced with *exempla* may look like carelessness, and sometimes perhaps it is. But it is striking that his practice here is similar to that which was observed with other sources in the previous chapter. *Contaminatio* remains a constant: he is willing to adapt his sources by bringing in additional information from outside. It is of course debateable to what extent alterations in *exempla* are intended to be interpretable by readers; but I would hesitate to endorse fully the view of David Rohrbacher, who justifies the separate treatment of *exempla* and allusions:

> A reader who recognizes the provenance and the context of the *exempla* derived from Valerius Maximus that are discussed below will gain no additional insight into Ammianus' meaning, while an allusion may gain in piquancy should the reader return to the text and context of the original author.[60]

I think rather that the interpretability of all types of intertextuality is variable, and that though this is doubtless true of many *exempla*, the fact that a number of them offer marked variants from the original does suggest the possibility of interpreting them allusively.

[58] Rohrbacher (2005). [59] Ch. 5, Section III. [60] Rohrbacher (2005), 20–1.

It is worth emphasising, however, that though particular sources of *exempla* can in many cases be identified, *exempla* are often portrayed as the general property of antiquity, and their authorship is de-emphasised. There are of course cases where an *exemplum* is also a conventional allusion to one particular text. This is particularly the case with those privileged texts whose antiquity permits them to be quoted or referred to directly, Homer, Vergil and Cicero. The *exempla* of the Trojan War during the siege of Amida are also allusions to the *Iliad*. Ammianus compares the investigative prowlings of inquisitive agents of the state to the Cibyratae under Verres (15.3.3): clearly an allusion to Cicero, and significantly to more than one of their appearances (*Verr.* 3.28, 4.47).

This is not the normal pattern. Take the story of Dolabella and the woman of Smyrna, discussed above, which we find in Valerius Maximus, adapted from Valerius in Aulus Gellius, and adapted from Gellius in Ammianus. It is interesting that Ammianus refers to the story as well known to antiquity (*exemplum . . . antiquitati admodum notum*, 29.2.19). One does not know if other versions of this story have been lost. Potentially, though, this description may mean no more than that the story was found in two related versions in a couple of 'secondary' texts. Nonetheless, the tale is seen as the property of a singular and oft-invoked antiquity.

Even a writer such as Herodotus whose age and status sanctioned mention by name can be invoked in such a way. When Ammianus gazed down from a high point far away on to the Persian army and saw the king in shining garments leading them, the incredibility of the scene led him to think of another Persian army, that described by Herodotus for the review at Doriscum. Here the *exemplum* is attributed to *fabulosa Graecia*, 'Storied Greece' (18.6.23). The same *exemplum* is used in Book 31 (31.4.6–7) to describe the barbarian hordes:

31.4.7 resipiscant tandem memoriae ueteres, / Medicas acies ductantes ad Graeciam. / quae dum Hellespontiacos pontes / et discidio quodam fabrili / mare sub imo Athonis pede quaesitum exponunt / et turmatim apud Doriscum exercitus recensetos, / concordante omni posteritate / ut fabulosae sunt lectae. / (8) nam postquam innumerae gentium multitudines / per prouincias circumfusae / pandentesque se in spatia ampla camporum / regiones omnes et cuncta oppleuere montium iuga, / fides quoque uetustatis recenti documento firmata est.

Let those ancient histories at last be revived, those which lead the Median columns to Greece. While they told of bridges across the Hellespont, and sea brought to the very foot of Athos by some sort of artificial channel, and armies counted out by squadrons at Doriscum, they were read by the common agreement of all later ages as fabulous. (8) For after numberless swarms of nations were poured through the provinces, and spreading themselves over the great extent of the plains filled all regions and every mountain ridge, this new proof confirmed the trustworthiness of antiquity.

Here is a historical tradition which we should have no hesitation in identifying with the name of Herodotus. Ammianus does not name Herodotus in either place.[61] He employs locutions (*memoriae ueteres*, *fabulosa Graecia*, *uetustas*) and a vigorous image (the *memoriae ueteres* leading the Median armies into Greece)[62] which could be read either as emphatically wider than one author or as magnifying that author. The allusion is in one sense to the whole uncountable flood of texts ('with all subsequent generations in agreement', *concordante omni posteritate*), at whose head is Herodotus, which repeat or doubt his story and turn it into so powerful an *exemplum*.[63]

But the fact that *exempla* often lack one particular aspect of allusiveness, an identifiable connection to another text, does not mean that they therefore lack meaning. In the following section, I shall examine the argumentative functions of *exempla*.

III Calling up the past

Aristotle's example of Dionysius, which I quoted in Section 1 above, offered an unusually worked out *exemplum* of the argumentation involved in *exempla*. In Ammianus' *exempla*, what is remarkable and perhaps unusual in its extent is the silence: that is to say, examples of the past are introduced without their point being explained or their details elaborated (a probable cause of some of the disdain they have suffered).

[61] Herodotus is named only at 22.15.28 (a reference perhaps derived from Pliny *NH* 36.79, according to den Boeft *et al.* ad loc.).

[62] *Ductantes*, iterative.

[63] On Ammianus' knowledge of Herodotus see Fornara (1992b), 421–3, Teitler (1999), 218–22.

For example, in Book 23, the fleet accompanying Julian on the Persian expedition arrives 'like that of Xerxes, that most powerful king' (*Xerxis illius potentissimi regis instar classis aduenit*, 23.3.9). The obvious point is that, although the comparison is developed as one of size, both fleets were destined to be destroyed. The comparison is developed further. We are told that part of Julian's navy was designed for putting bridges together (*ad compaginandos pontes*, 23.3.9). Later the emperor with his whole army waits at Cercusium to cross the river over a bridge of ships (*per naualem . . . pontem*, 23.5.4), when a discouraging letter arrives from Sallust, Prefect of Gaul, begging him to abandon the expedition. But Julian crosses and breaks the bridge. We have already been reminded by Ammianus of Xerxes' crossing of the Hellespont in a digression in the previous book (22.8.4), and in a digression which swiftly follows another reminder is found: Xerxes attacked Greece 'having reversed the norms of the elements' (*elementorum usu mutato . . .*, 23.6.8) whereupon almost all his forces on land and sea were destroyed. Ammianus does not explicitly make the argument, and indeed the argument that either the size of Julian's fleet or his hubris is comparable to Xerxes', and that therefore a similar fate awaited him, was not made explicitly, as the cases were too divergent. Instead, there is reference to the knowledge of his readers, and to reminders in adjacent passages of his own text.

Ammianus' silence on the significance of an *exemplum* is not found merely in notorious clichés such as Xerxes' defeat by the elements. In Book 29, Count Theodosius is sent against the Moorish rebel Firmus. Ammianus writes that (29.5.4)

> [eius] uirtutes ut impetrabilis / ea tempestate prae ceteris enitebant, / Domitii Corbulonis et Lusii simillimi ueterum, / quorum prior sub Nerone, alter Traiano rem regente Romanam / pluribus inclaruere fortibus factis.
>
> His virtues shone out as of one more effective than the rest at that time; he was most similar to Domitius Corbulo and Lusius in olden times; under Nero the former of these, and when Trajan ruled the Roman state the second became famed for many bold deeds.

The similarity is ostensibly of their outstanding characters in their respective times, but the superlative *simillimi* and the naming of the

emperors under whom these exemplary generals lived underlines the additional similarity, that Domitius Corbulo, Lusius Quietus and Count Theodosius all (supposedly) fell victim to imperial jealousy or court intrigue. Ammianus would not describe the death of Theodosius in early 376 (indeed the sensitive issue of the execution of the father of the ruling emperor has sometimes been thought the reason for his full account stopping at 375 in the West as against 378 in the East). But he had, one presumes, described the fall of Lusius in one of his earliest books, and he had previously used Corbulo as an *exemplum*, mentioning his death ('as once Domitius Corbulo is said to have been killed, amidst the dregs of the Neronian period a faithful and careful defender of the provinces', *ut quondam Domitius Corbulo dicitur caesus, / in colluuione illa Neroniani saeculi prouinciarum fidus defensor et cautus*, 15.2.5). By a (possibly obscure) allusion either to his reader's knowledge or to another part of his own work, Ammianus states what he left otherwise unstated.[64]

I have already discussed in the last chapter another death which is complicated by the subtle use of *exemplum*: that of the emperor Jovian.[65] Modern scholars assert with some confidence that the death was natural.[66] What contemporaries thought is by no means so clear; Eutropius' three versions, which are more or less followed by Ammianus, are none of them particularly divergent and all studiedly uncontroversial. For others, including John Chrysostom, poisoning was clearly suspected.[67] Ammianus adds an *exemplum*: 'and though a departure from life befell Jovian similar to that of Scipio Aemilianus, we learn that no investigation was made into the deaths of either of them' (*cumque huic et Aemiliano Scipioni uitae exitus similis euenisset, super neutrius morte quaestionem comperimus agitatam*, 25.10.13). This could be taken simply as an expression of Ammianus' surprise that nobody enquired into

[64] It is also worth noting that Lusius was a successful general under Trajan whose fall came at the start of the following reign; likewise the elder Theodosius was executed at the start of the next reign.

[65] Ch. 5, Section IV.

[66] It is strange that modern historians inevitably basing themselves on even more limited evidence than ancient ones reach such confident conclusions (see, for instance, Matthews (1989), 188).

[67] Eutropius 10.18.1, John Chrysostom *Ep. ad Phil.* 15.5 (*PG* 62.295).

the death of so important a figure.[68] But a look at the parallel accounts of it (there is a similarity of wording with both Cicero's *Pro Milone* and the *Periochae* of Livy) shows that it is better taken as hinting, without taking any responsibility for it, that Jovian's death was like Scipio's in that it was strongly suspected of being unnatural.[69]

For a fourth and contrasting example of an exemplary argument, I shall recur briefly to a passage of which I have previously published a discussion.[70] In his obituary of Constantius II, Ammianus was running through the emperor's judicial savagery, especially in treason trials and in the aftermath of civil war; he was worse in such situations than classic bad emperors (Caligula, Domitian, Commodus, Gallienus). Ammianus complains that Constantius never showed mercy and conjures up an *exemplum* of the emperor whom he should have imitated (21.16.11–12):

. . . Marci illius dissimilis principis uerecundi, / qui cum ad imperiale culmen in Syria Cassius surrexisset, / epistularum fascem ab eo ad conscios missum, / perlatore capto sibi oblatum / ilico signatum exuri praecepit, / agens adhuc in Illyrico, / ne insidiatoribus cognitis / inuitus quosdam habere posset offensos. / (12) utque recte sentientes quidam arbitrabantur, / uirtutis erat potius indicium magnae, / imperio eundem Constantium sine cruore cessisse / quam uindicasse tam inclementer.

[Constantius] was quite unlike that reverend prince Marcus [Aurelius], who, when [Avidius] Cassius had risen to the imperial rank in Syria, was offered a bundle of letters, which Cassius had sent to conspirators, by a captured messenger, and straightaway ordered them burnt unopened, at a time when he was still based in Illyricum: this he did so that he could not, through the identification of the plotters, unwillingly regard some men as his enemies. (12) And, as some right-thinking people thought, it would have been a sign of great virtue had the same Constantius left power without bloodshed rather than exercising vengeance with such inclemency.

A version of the story is also found in Dio 72.29. The detail which interests me here is the geographical one, where again Ammianus coincides with Dio: that Marcus had been in Illyricum when Cassius arose in Syria.[71] The detail is typical of Ammianus' sensitivity to the importance of distance in civil wars, as shown for

[68] Den Boeft *et al.* ad loc. [69] Cicero *Mil.* 16, Livy *Per.* 59. [70] Kelly (2005).
[71] It is suggested by den Boeft *et al.* ad loc. that mention of Illyricum was prompted by the word *ilico*.

example in the usurpation of Procopius.[72] It must certainly have been an issue in the civil war against Magnentius, which Ammianus described immediately prior to the extant books and which prompted the merciless recriminations that he is here condemning. The precise geography, however, is applicable as an example to nothing so much as the situation in the last few months of 361, when Julian had reached Sirmium and Constantius remained long in Syria before dying in Cilicia. Not only does Constantius fail to live up to the clemency exemplified by the legitimate emperor Marcus, but the passage implicitly imprints Constantius on to the usurper Cassius, and Julian on to Marcus. The detail of this reading can be pressed further. The next sentence of Ammianus' account suggests that many right-thinking people believed that Constantius should have renounced his power without bloodshed. This is both emphatically suggesting at Julian's legitimacy, and bringing to mind the example of Marcus: Dio has him proclaim his readiness to renounce his empire (72.24.4). In this case the characteristic lack of explanation of *exempla* is absolutely vital. Ammianus is able to argue subliminally what he would never have argued openly: that Julian was not a usurper.

Several of the above examples show that if *exempla* are moments in the work that reach across time, they are also linked to and in competition with each other. The *exemplum* of Marcus would be less suggestive of Julian were he not elsewhere compared to Marcus; that of Xerxes relies on the surrounding text. Their arrangement is not a matter of chance. Blockley documents well how particular characters attract particular types of *exemplum*: Julian's *exempla* tend to be for military heroism,[73] Constantius' for suspicion and hatred of good men.[74] The use of ironic *exempla* in the second Roman digression is similarly a feature invoked uniquely here.[75] Alongside this consistency with which particular characters are given consistent *exempla*, Blockley has observed a notable change in the nature of *exempla* through the work: 'In the first part of the History (XIV–XXV) the usages are consistent and broadly epideictic. In the second part (XXVI–XXX) they are more

[72] See e.g. Matthews 1989, 197–8. [73] Blockley (1994), 56.
[74] Blockley (1994), 57. [75] Blockley (1994), 61.

varied, ranging from epideictic to argumentative. In the final book they are consistently analytical.'[76] The development in method is probably less the result of separate times of composition than it is of the differing exigencies of varying portions of the text.[77] The Roman army's journey into Parthia is also a journey into memories of the past, led by an emperor who demands examples and who has an ability to create them.[78] But it is worth noticing that at one stage of his career Julian is remarkably free of *exempla*. Contrast the eighteen *exempla* of Book 24 with those of Book 20, of which there are two at a generous count.[79] Julian's usurpation was hard to represent as historically precedented without drawing attention to its true character.[80] As for the comparative dearth of examples for Valentinian and Valens, two points must be made: first that their minds are full of Julian (invocations of characters from within the work as extant are not counted as *exempla* by Blockley),[81] second that Valens, as an ignoramus, does not merit them.[82] The move towards analytical examples in the last book is, as Blockley suggests, a function of the unusual way in which the Gothic War takes precedence over the characters involved.

There is a danger of over-simplification in Blockley's description, however. It would be wrong, for instance, to think that a moral element is absent in the *exempla* of the last book. A moralising aspect enters what is probably the most analytical of Ammianus' *exempla*. This comes at 31.5.11–17. It has been discussed at length and illuminatingly by Barnes, so I shall here only discuss it briefly.[83] Ammianus decries the contemporaries who had been dazzled by present woes into thinking that nothing like the Gothic crisis had ever been known before. They were ignorant of ancient history. Indeed, not only ancient but relatively recent history showed that such things had happened before. Ammianus gave three examples. The Teutones and Cimbri had flooded into Italy in

[76] Blockley (1994), 61–2.

[77] Blockley (1994), 58, proposes that the method changed over the various periods of composition.

[78] On this see now Lendon (2005), esp. 295–6.

[79] At 20.1.1 Julian considers the precedent of Constans and decides not to cross to Britain; at 20.8.17 Julian invokes unspecified previous emperors.

[80] For more detailed discussion of this point see Kelly (2005).

[81] See above p. 262. [82] See also Ch. 7, Section III.3 below.

[83] Barnes (1998), 175–7; see also pp. 27–8 above.

the late second century BC, but after inflicting grave losses had been overcome by outstanding generals, and been annihilated. Likewise, in the reign of Marcus Aurelius, diverse barbarian tribes had come together, and it was only after immense disasters, including (if the meaning of a corrupt text can be salvaged) the death of a general,[84] that affairs were set back in order, thanks to the outstanding and uncorrupted nature of public morality. The action moves on to the mid-third century, and the invasion of the Getic fleet from the Black Sea, the death of the emperor Decius and his son, in battle, and other sieges, sacks and massacres. It was Claudius, an outstanding general, and the severe Aurelian after him, who turned the tide, and the beaten barbarians were barely heard from for a long age thereafter.

I have here simplified the examples, with the aim of illustrating the basic pattern: barbarian influx, with the imagery of flooding; serious defeats for the Romans, including the deaths of generals and sacks of cities; eventual recovery thanks to outstanding generals; the massacre of the barbarians. Indeed, it is arguable that, in order to produce this pattern, Ammianus reversed the order of third-century events to place the barbarian naval attacks of 268 before the death of Decius and his son in 251 (31.5.15–16).[85] It is also notable that he places his principal moral explanation – that 'sober antiquity had not yet been polluted by the softness of a more dissolute way of life' (31.5.14) – after the second of his three *exempla*. It gives an incomplete feel to the three *exempla*, taken together. And this is carefully engineered: because the present case was unclosed, the barbarians had flooded in, and Valens and his army had been obliterated; but it was not clear that Theodosius had filled the role of the great leader who habitually saved the situation, and the enemy had not been annihilated. The *exemplum* is argumentative, then, but it is also moral. The 'softness of a more dissolute way of life' (*solutioris uitae mollities*), which had not yet afflicted people at the time of Marcus, may well be an oblique reference to Christianity,

[84] Perhaps Marcus' Praetorian Prefect Macrinius Vindex.

[85] It must be admitted that this is not a full explanation of the chronological confusion of the passage, considerable for somebody who had written a history covering the third century AD.

as Barnes argues.[86] The question would be much clearer if we possessed the lost books to which the text doubtless referred.

The next section will further examine the potential intra-textual qualities of exemplary comparisons, by looking closely at how *exempla* function in a narrow passage of the work: the fall of Caesar Gallus at the end of Book 14. This will lead into an attempted interpretation of the ostentatious series of *exempla* with which I began this chapter.

IV Gallus: finding the right examples

When Constantius was encouraging Caesar Gallus to return from the East after political failure there, he wrote continuous letters (14.11.9).[87] He is said to have included an *exemplum* (14.11.10):

quibus subserebat non adeo uetus exemplum, / quod Diocletiano et eius collegae / ut apparitores Caesares non resides, / sed ultro citroque discurrentes obtemperabant / et in Syria Augusti uehiculum irascentis / per spatium mille passuum fere / pedes antegressus est Galerius purpuratus.

He added to this an example from not so far back, that their Caesars obeyed Diocletian and his colleague like attendants, not remaining in one place but running about this way and that, and in Syria before the angry Augustus' carriage the purple-clad Galerius had gone on foot for close on a mile.

Ammianus doubtless covered this episode in a lost book: Galerius appears to be something of a hero of his.[88] This *exemplum* is the only point at which Ammianus calls Galerius by that name instead of Maximianus (Maximian Herculius is referred to only here, as *eius collegae*). The story is told in a similar vein by Eutropius at 9.24, where he names him Galerius Maximianus, though normally he is simply Galerius: 'So he was driven off and set off towards Diocletian, and when he had met him on the road, he is said to have been greeted with such rudeness by Diocletian that he's

[86] Barnes (1998), 176.

[87] The importance of these documents is emphasised by the repetition: in 14.11.1, they are part of the plan ('gentler writings', *mollioribus scriptis*), in 6 Gallus' wife Constantina is encouraged by 'many invented blandishments', *multis fictisque blanditiis*, in 9 we hear of 'the constant letters of the emperor, bidding and begging', *imperatoris scripta . . . assidua monentis orantisque*.

[88] Mentioned also at 22.4.8, 23.5.11, 24.1.10, 25.7.9, 25.10.2.

reported to have run purple-clad alongside the carriage for several miles.'[89] The nomenclature, together with the use of *purpuratus* and *uehiculum*, suggests either Ammianus' reading of Eutropius, or more probably that both versions derive from Eutropius' source, the *Kaisergeschichte*: the minor divergence over distance is typical of the breviaries.[90] The *exemplum* may actually have been used by Constantius; it may of course simply be inventive characterisation. If so, it is apt, and not only because the intellectually limited Constantius is shown closely echoing a simple abbreviated history. A passage which might have suggested this example to Ammianus comes at the end of Aurelius Victor's *De Caesaribus* (42.19). Victor was writing in the no-man's-land of Sirmium during the constitutional crisis of 360–1,[91] and pinned his colours on the fence with a suggestion that Julian should imitate Tiberius and Galerius, both rulers who had been diligent subordinates before inheriting in their own right.

The emperor's use of this example should remind a bemused reader that *exempla* are not merely a curiosity of Ammianus' style, but an established way for régimes to define themselves (perhaps especially in the fourth century, though this may be a trick of the sources). The suggestion of Victor's example to Julian, as of Constantius' to Gallus, was that the Caesar should defer to the Augustus, and might expect to step up in due course. The use of an *exemplum* which is 'not so old', *non adeo uetus*, reflects the common view that while ancient examples have greater authority, recent ones have more persuasive power.[92]

It seems unlikely that the *exemplum* of Diocletian and Galerius is in itself responsible for persuading Gallus to return to the West, where he is stripped of his position and executed. He has been portrayed from the start of the book as wishing to usurp (*ausurus hostilia*, 14.1.1), and Ammianus has just reaffirmed that such was his intention. It is, at the most, part of Constantius' strategy of

[89] *pulsus igitur et ad Diocletianum profectus cum ei in itinere occurrisset, tanta insolentia a Diocletiano fertur exceptus, ut per aliquot passuum milia purpuratus tradatur ad uehiculum cucurrisse.*

[90] On Ammianus' reading of Eutropius in general see Ch. 5, Section IV.

[91] See Nixon (1991) and Bird (1996) on the date of Victor's work.

[92] See e.g. Chaplin (2000), 101, 103, 120–31.

changing Gallus' officials, separating him from his wife, and sending constant letters and messengers with a mixture of conciliatory and cajoling noises. The decisive persuasion is that of an individual. Scudilo, tribune of the Scutarii, arrives after many others, concealing cunning persuasion beneath an apparently unpolished exterior (*uelamento subagrestis ingenii*, 14.11.11). Scudilo flatters him and tells him that he is required to share Constantius' majesty and be a partner of his labours (*futurum socium quoque laborum*). The apparent reminiscence of a famous phrase of Tacitus (*Ann.* 4.2.3) brings in the example of Sejanus, another fallen upstart. Gallus, with blunted senses (14.11.12), completely fails to recognise the concealed example, if it is such,[93] in the mouth of an apparent boor, just as he did not see through the false comparison to Diocletian and Galerius.

Whereas the case of Diocletian and Galerius is heavily marked – an *exemplum* called an *exemplum* and transmitted through a character – it finds a counterbalance and rival when the deceit is finally ended and Gallus is stripped of his robes. He is placed in a private cart and taken to Histria, near the town of Pola, 'where once, we have heard, Constantine's son Crispus was killed' (*ubi quondam peremptum Constantini filium accepimus Crispum*, 14.11.20). The *exemplum* is quite unmarked: in appearance it is merely a historical reference. The word *accepimus*, 'we have heard', imparts an air of distance, which belies the recentness of the event, and the fact that Crispus' death must have been described in the lost books.[94] Crucial historical detail (that Crispus was Caesar at the time he was killed on the orders of his father, the Augustus) is left for the reader to fill in for himself and thus better Gallus. Gallus could have found other warnings besides, and more recent ones, of the harshness of Constantine's dynasty towards their kin, not least the

[93] Contextually the parallel between Gallus and Sejanus is almost perfect, but *socius laborum* is not a rare phrase, and one may be misled by its modern fame in the context of Sejanus. Unfortunately, since the sections describing the fall of Sejanus are missing from Tacitus, we cannot know whether the allusion is supported in some other way: but it is worth recalling that Tiberius too engineered Sejanus' downfall with letters.

[94] Indeed Matthews (1989), 29, suggests that Ammianus writes about the death of Crispus here as if for the first time, seemingly arguing that this was a real possibility. It seems to me inconceivable that an anti-Constantinian author like Ammianus would not have mentioned this major item on the charge-sheet: the case instead illustrates typical coyness about making the argument of *exempla* explicit.

murders of most of his side of the family after Constantine's death. But as with many other villains and failures in the *Res Gestae*, he is incapable of understanding or recognising historical example. When asked why he put individuals in Antioch to death, he blames his wife. Ammianus contrasts his attitude with the exemplary behaviour of Alexander, introducing the *exemplum* with the comment that Gallus certainly didn't know it (*ignorans profecto*, 14.11.22).

In contrast to Gallus, others are able to recognise the validity of recent example. Julian, whose restrained habits differed from those of his brother Gallus as much as Titus' from Domitian's (14.11.28), is the character who is most often found the opposite of ignorant. Julian's historical learning enables him to imitate the behaviour of the ancients; but he also considers the recent past. Repeatedly in his thoughts is the precedent of his brother's fate (17.1.14, 21.1.2). His interpretation is justified. When Constantius describes his own misjudgement (*compellor nunc apud uos, amantissimi uiri, / confiteri meos errores, / quin potius, si dici liceat uerum, humanitatem*, 21.13.10), he reminds the soldiers first of his promotion of Gallus and then laments his failure to learn from it (*et angebat nos una sed secura doloris praeteriti recordatio. / at nunc aliud accidit, / ausim dicere praeteritis maestius*, 12); he then laments his kindness to Julian (13).[95] The odious courtiers had warned him of Julian (15.8.2), using the *exemplum* of Gallus.

There are other implicit comparisons made at the death of Gallus, which function in a similar way to *exemplum*. When accused of the deaths he had caused in Antioch, he blanches, 'covered with the paleness of Adrastus' (*Adrasteo pallore perfusus*, 14.11.22: an intimation of doom and allusion to Vergil *Aen.* 6.480). Next Ammianus describes Gallus' hands being tied 'in the manner of some guilty brigand' (*in modum noxii cuiusdam latronis*, 14.11.23) and then how

ceruice abscisa / ereptaque uultus et capitis dignitate / cadauer est relictum informe, / paulo ante urbibus et prouinciis formidatum.

[95] 'I am now compelled to admit before you, most affectionate men, my mistakes – no rather, if the truth can be told, my kindness . . . A single but safe memory of past pain would grieve me, but now something else has happened, I'd venture to say worse than the earlier events.'

His neck was severed, and the dignity of his features and his head taken from him, and the corpse was left disfigured, shortly before feared by cities and provinces.

There is an allusion to Vergil's account of the death of another robber, Cacus (*Aen.* 8.264–5):[96] . . . *pedibusque informe cadauer / protrahitur* ('the shapeless corpse was dragged by the feet'). Gallus' wife Constantina has also been compared, with lesser and greater degrees of subtlety, to mythical monsters, openly to Megaera (14.1.2) and discreetly to Vergil's Scylla (14.9.3), when she peers round a curtain in a courtroom. Ammianus has her 'thrusting out her jaws' (*exsertantis ora*).[97]

But the portrayal of Gallus is not simply as monster: there is pity, and the death is characterised as a crime destined to be revenged. There is a further Vergilian allusion, comparable in form and sense, rather than vocabulary, to the death of Priam (*Aen.* 2.556–8):

> . . . tot quondam populis terrisque superbum
> regnatorem Asiae. iacet ingens litore truncus,
> auolsumque umeris caput et sine nomine corpus.

. . . once proud in so many peoples and lands, the ruler of Asia. The vast trunk lies on the shore, the head torn from the shoulders and a body without a name.

The double allusion in itself, as well as recalling the fitting 'ruler of Asia', picks up the technique employed in this second Vergilian passage. The presence of Vergil heightens the pity by suggesting the anonymity, and thence the universality, of a headless corpse. The earliest Vergilian scholars recognised the applicability of this account of Priam's death to the death of Pompeius Magnus: the headless body (suddenly, illogically) on the beach and the use of *ingens* both hinting at Magnus.[98] Lucan recognised such an

[96] Fletcher (1937), 382; see also Galletier and Fontaine ad 14.11.23, Blockley (1980b).

[97] *stimulis reginae exsertantis ora subinde per aulaeum* ('whipped on by the queen, who repeatedly thrust her jaws forth through the curtain', 14.9.3). Cf. Vergil *Aen.* 3.424–8 (also Homer *Od.* 12.245): *at Scyllam caecis cohibet spelunca latebris, / **ora exsertantem** et nauis in saxa trahentem. / prima hominis facies et pulchro pectore uirgo / pube tenus, postrema immani corpore pistrix, / delphinum caudas utero commissa luporum* ('But Scylla a cave hides in a unseen lair, **thrusting forth her jaws** and dragging ships on to the rocks. Human in appearance at first, and a fair-breasted maiden as far as the groin, later she's a vast-bodied whale, combining dolphin-tails with wolves' belly'). On Constantina and this passage see Wieber-Scariot (2000).

[98] Servius ad Vergil *Aen.* 2.557: *Pompei tangit historiam, cum 'ingens' dicit, non 'magnus'* ('He touches on the history of Pompeius, saying *ingens* [huge] rather than *Magnus* ["great", Pompeius' surname]').

interpretation, alluding to the passage (1.685–6) in a prophecy of the death of Pompeius.[99] The main force of this double allusion is to emphasise its own ambiguity. Gallus is compared to two contrasting Vergilian characters, Cacus and Priam. It illustrates the difficulty of finding an *exemplum* for Gallus.

Again the fact that Vergil's Priam was recognised as in some way identifiable with Pompeius may be in Ammianus' mind. This possibility links this passage to the catalogue of *exempla* which follows shortly afterwards and closes the book, and which is also an illustration of the difficulty of exemplifying Gallus. One of the allusions is to Pompeius (14.11.32):

istius [*sc.* Fortunae] iniquitate Pompeius / post quaesitum Magni ex rerum gestarum amplitudine cognomentum / ad spadonum libidinem / in Aegypto trucidatur.

By her [i.e. Fortune's] iniquity, after Pompeius has gained the surname Magnus from the greatness of his achievements, he is slaughtered for the pleasure of eunuchs in Egypt.

Gallus himself has been a victim of plotting courtiers, including the eunuch chamberlain Eusebius (14.11.2, 21), and elsewhere in the chapter we hear of the scheming of the court eunuchs (14.11.3).

Of all that long list, Pompeius is the example most easily applicable to Gallus (14.11.32). As I mentioned, the focus of the list is not so much Gallus' character as how Gallus fits into the broader theme of the inconstancy of fortune. There is a satisfying ring composition from the beginning of the book, where again Fortune was invoked.[100] Gallus had been raised to Fortune's highest pinnacle (*in summum Fortunae fastigium*), but experienced her fickle changes (14.11.29),

[99] *hunc ego, fluminea deformis truncus harena / qui iacet, agnosco* ('him I recognise, who lies a misshaped trunk on river sands'). An illuminating discussion and further references in Hinds (1998), 8–10. Ammianus' allusion neatly complements the proposal of Morgan (2000), esp. 52–5, that Vergil is himself alluding to and adopting a historiographical tone in response to the *Histories* of Asinius Pollio.

[100] . . . *Fortunae saeuientis procellae / tempestates alias rebus infudere communibus, / per multa illa et dira facinora Caesaris Galli, / qui ex squalore imo miseriarum / . . . ad principale culmen insperato saltu prouectus* / . . . ('. . . the gusts of raging Fortune poured new storms on the commonwealth through the many and ominous misdeeds of Caesar Gallus, who had been carried from the lowest depths of wretchedness to the imperial rank in an unhoped-for leap', 14.1.1). I read *saltu* with Kellerbauer and Kießling rather than *V*'s *cultu* (influenced by the nearby *culmen*). See Barnes (1998), 205.

. . . qui ludunt mortalitatem, / nunc euehentes quosdam in sidera, / nunc ad Cocyti profunda mergentes. / cuius rei cum innumera sint exempla, / pauca tactu summo transcurram.

. . . which play with humankind, now carrying some up to the stars, now plunging them in the deep waters of Cocytus. Of this fact the examples are unnumbered, but I will run through just a few with cursory mentions.

And Ammianus lists two pairs of Hellenistic Greek examples: upstarts who became monarchs and tyrants who lost their hereditary rank and undertook humble occupations;[101] next four Roman generals who were surrendered to the enemy,[102] and then Pompeius, whose greater relevance to the example of Gallus I have suggested above. By a rather surprising leap backwards in time, Eunus' slave rebellion in Sicily follows,[103] leading on to a series of rhetorical questions (14.11.33):

quam multi splendido loco nati <Romani>, / eadem rerum domina coniuente, / Viriathi genua sunt amplexi et Spartaci? / quot capita quae horruere gentes funesti carnifices absciderunt? / alter in uincula ducitur, / alter insperatae praeficitur potestati, / alius a summo culmine dignitatis excutitur.

How many Romans born in splendid state, with the connivance of the same mistress of events, have embraced the knees of Viriathus and Spartacus? How many heads at which the nations trembled have grim executioners severed? One is led in chains, a second is elevated to unhoped-for power, another is cast down from the highest summit of rank.

The series of *exempla* is easy to disparage. The basic structure might be faulted: two pairs from Greek history, the first not really a pair at all, four surrendered Roman generals, then a fifth whose

[101] The elder Dionysius is employed as an *exemplum* elsewhere (16.8.10, where the source is Cicero *Tusc.* 5.58–9). Whether Ammianus differentiates the two Dionysii (the younger is described here) is uncertain. The rise of Agathocles is considerably later than the fall of the younger Dionysius. The upstart Andriscus reappears as an *exemplum* for usurpation during Procopius' revolt (26.6.20).

[102] The four generals, Mancinus, Veturius, Claudius and Regulus, were delivered up to the enemy in varying circumstances connected with the traditional refusal of the Roman Republic to ransom prisoners. Chronologically, they are disordered (Mancinus belongs to 136 BC, Veturius to 321, Claudius to 236, and Regulus to 255). The cases of Veturius and Regulus are famous; Claudius is very obscure, and was only offered to the enemy rather than handed over, according to Valerius Maximus 6.3.3.

[103] The thought of Eunus may have occurred to Ammianus from the previously mentioned **eunuchs** (εὐνοῦχοι) for whose pleasure Pompeius was killed, though he uses the Latin word *spadones*. Evidence, *pace* Barnes, for Ammianus 'thinking in Greek'? In chronological order, Eunus' revolt should come between those of Viriathus and of Spartacus.

case is slightly different, a slave-rebel prompting the names of two more, before tailing off into indeterminate listing: *alter . . . alter . . . alius*. The chronology within the individual portions is suspect, much more so than in most of Ammianus' sets of *exempla*.[104]

The *exempla*, in all likelihood from a range of different sources, are of course introduced as representing the instability of fortune. But in their position, they will inevitably be read for their relevance to the fate of Gallus: indeed they become increasingly apt. By the last two sentences when the *exempla* cease to be named individuals, all of the characteristics described fit Gallus – beheading, being enchained, unexpected power, being shaken from the highest rank. Gallus was described as 'feared by cities and provinces' (*urbibus et prouinciis formidatum*, 14.11.23), and the final rhetorical question asks how many heads *quae horruere gentes* ('at which the nations trembled', 14.11.33) have been cut off by grim executioners; but even at the start of the catalogue of *exempla* Dionysius is *gentium quondam terrorem* ('formerly the terror of the nations', 14.11.32); the mixture of terror and pity inspired by Gallus is also found in a number of the *exempla*. Among the exemplary parallels are details which do not fit: the Roman generals are closest in that they were handed over to their foes for uncertain fates. Pompeius, who could be seen as the culmination of that list, is obviously himself the aptest *exemplum*, because of the manner of his death. There is an implied comment on Constantius' courtiers, in comparing them to external foes. When Eunus is mentioned he is the subject of the sentence; in contrast, for the other two slave-leaders the focus is on the noble Romans at their feet. In all cases the readers' external knowledge shows that their dominance would not last; what is ambiguous is whether Gallus is being compared to the slave-rebels or their victims. And of course he is impossible to classify, being both monster and victim, and the *exempla* run out into anonymity, which suggests the inadequacy of exemplarity, at any rate in Gallus' case.

[104] The chronological arrangement of *exempla* is a typical reflex both for Ammianus (e.g. 16.1.4, 21.16.8–10) and for many of his sources. Error can either act as a confirmation of the source or suggest that there is a mixture of sources. Thus the Roman commanders who conquered Thrace are introduced in the wrong order (27.4.10–11), in an error shared with Festus 9.2 but not with Florus *Epit.* 1.39.5, 6.

The difficulty of controlling exemplary comparisons is summarised by the allusive closing words (14.11.34):

But if anybody should wish to know all of them, as various and constant as they are, he's fool enough to think he can investigate the number of the sands and the weight of the mountains.[105]

As a closural formula, this picks up from Ammianus' stated intent of covering a few of the innumerable examples with cursory mention, *tactu summo* (14.11.29). It has the authority of a Vergilian allusion (*Georgics* 2.105–6): 'he who would know this would also wish to learn how many sands of the Libyan plain are lifted by the west wind'.[106] Allusion to the same passage occurs at two other points in the work, both of which are notably programmatic. One passage quotes the lines in asserting that it is impossible to know the full number of the Gothic hordes (31.4.6).[107] The other is the methodological preface to Book 26. Ammianus portrays some critics of his work protesting, as though injured, if the emperor's table-talk goes unmentioned, or common soldiers' punishments, or the names of minor forts in geographical excursus, or those attending the Urban Praetor, and many similar things inconsonant with the principles of history. History concerns itself with high matters (26.1.1),

non humilium minutias causarum. / quas si scitari uoluerit quispiam, / indiuidua illa corpuscula / uolitantia per inane, / ἀτόμους, ut nos appellamus, / numerari posse sperabit.

not the individual details of humble cases. Should anybody wish to know these, he'll hope to count those indivisible little bodies constantly flying through the air, 'atoms' as we call them in Greek.[108]

[105] *quae omnia si scire quisquam uelit quam uaria sint et assidua, / harenarum numerum idem iam desipiens et montium pondera scrutari putabit.*

[106] *quem qui scire uelit, Libyci uelit aequoris idem / discere, quam multae Zephyro turbentur harenae.*

[107] With the alteration, presumably due to Ammianus' error, of *turbentur* to *truduntur*.

[108] Cf. also 28.1.15 *et quoniam existimo forsitan aliquos haec lecturos, / exquisite scrutando notare, / strepentes id actum esse prius, non illud, / aut ea, quae uiderint, praetermissa, / hactenus faciendum est satis, / quod non omnia narratu sunt digna, / quae per squalidas transiere personas . . .* ('and since I think that future readers, investigating closely, may mark me down, complaining that A not B happened first, or that these events which they saw themselves have been left out, it must simply be accepted that not everything is worthy of being told which passes among the unpolished orders . . .').

The thought balances that in the preface to Book 15, where Ammianus imagined and dismissed critics of the length of his narrative in the books to come. It is no chance that after the last words of Book 14, *harenarum numerum idem iam desipiens et montium pondera* ***scrutari*** *putabit* ('he's fool enough to think he can **investigate** the number of the sands and the weight of the mountains'), Book 15 begins *utcumque potui ueritatem* ***scrutari*** . . . ('as far as I could **investigate** the truth . . .').[109] This is a very carefully composed intra-textual network.

The conclusion of Book 14, like the drift in the preceding catalogue of *exempla* from the *deliberately* flawed into anonymity, makes a particular point of the difficulty of fitting any coherent example to as extraordinary a mixture of parts as Gallus. If Gallus is in some ways unexampled, he is also an exemplary warning of the dangers of not knowing examples (and does indeed act as an admonitory example for Julian). But the conclusion also points more generally to the fact that there is a need to limit the potentially endless supply of *exempla*. As for the internal allusions to his own prefaces, it must be granted that in each preface Ammianus makes remarks appropriate to individual portions of the work (greater detail for the Julianic books (15–25), and less thereafter); nonetheless it is central that the role of *exempla* is described at the end of Book 14 in exactly the same language as the ideals of history. The impossibility of listing all the *exempla* is the same as the impossibility (and undesirability) of identifying all the details of historical causation. In some sense, *exempla* ('bits cut out') are the building blocks of history, and their selection the selection of details worthy of history, 'which is accustomed to run through lofty business' (*discurrere per negotiorum celsitudines assuetae*).[110]

[109] The impossibility of finding the true scale from which to view human history is underlined in this chapter by the condemnation of Constantius' naming himself *Aeternitas mea* ('my Eternity') or *orbis totius dominus* ('Lord of the whole globe', 15.1.3): he invokes the infinity of worlds of Democritus dreamed of by Alexander, and from Cicero the conclusion of all *mathematici* that in comparison to the vastness of the universe the whole earth is like a small point.

[110] Worthy of quotation is Livy *praef.* 10 *hoc illud est praecipue in cognitione rerum salubre ac frugiferum, omnis te exempli documenta in inlustri posita monumento intueri: inde tibi tuaeque rei publicae quod imitere capias, inde foedum inceptu, foedum exitu, quod uites.* ('This is especially helpful and fruitful in understanding events, for you to look at the lessons of every example set in a shining monument; from there you can take for

V Conclusion

The range of the *exempla* is immensely wide: mythical and modern, Latin and Greek, kings and philosophers. But it is also, in practice, limited. Just as the digressions tend to focus on Hellenic foundations and Roman conquests, so the *exempla* are those of a traditional Graeco-Roman culture. If this immense variety of figures can profitably be adduced for comparison to Ammianus' own times, it argues for their validity and the irrelevance of what is omitted. There are no barbarian *exempla*, unless one includes Persian kings who belong to Greek historiography;[111] conversely barbarians fighting for Rome are compared to true Romans.[112] There are no Christian *exempla*. Barbarism and Christianity are assimilated and marginalised.[113]

Ammianus' history constantly proclaims the value of historical learning. It also proclaims the continuity and unity of its subject, the Roman Empire, across time and space. In the remarkable timelessness of the digressions, and the geographical sweep of the narrative, the idealised combination of Roman virtue and Hellenic civilisation is constantly reaffirmed.[114] In the main the engine that drives these two ideals forward is historical example. Ammianus' characters are constantly compared to those of previous history, and their quality is constantly judged by their own ability to recognise their historical context. Knowledge of history consists of knowledge of *exempla*, and successful characters imitate the good and avoid the

yourself and for your republic what you can imitate, from there what's shameful at the start and in its result, so that you can avoid it'). Ammianus' use of the unique *cognitio gestorum* for the common (and less obviously historiographical) *cognitio rerum* in his own preface at 15.1.1 could be seen as an allusion (see Ch. 2 n. 129 above), another suggestion of the significance of *exempla* in the *Res Gestae*.

[111] E.g. 23.3.9, 30.8.4. [112] See above p. 267 n. 39.

[113] Barnes (1998), 121, suggests that some *exempla* are subconsciously influenced by what he believes to be Ammianus' residual Christian modes of thought.

[114] An aesthetic principle in the arrangement of *exempla* which is more definitively Ammianean is the pairing of examples from Greek and Roman antiquity, visible from the very start of the work, with the pairing of Amphiaraus and Marcius (14.1.7), or Hesiod and Cato (14.6.8), or Seleucia and Claudiopolis (14.8.2), or at the end Artaxerxes and Papirius Cursor (30.8.4–5). Classen's splendid article (1972), which deals with this feature, seems presumptuous in saying that Amphiaraus is the better known of this pair of prophets (41). With Seleucia and Claudiopolis he is on firm ground. The presence of the Persian Artaxerxes suggests that the principle is aesthetic as much as nationalistic.

bad. Wickedness or ineffectiveness is associated with ignorance of the *exempla* adduced by the narrator.

The use of allusion in the passages discussed above works in a manner similar to the *exempla*. To be sure, the names of the comparands, or the idea that there might be comparands, are left to the interpreter of the allusion, but *exempla* are not so different: some can be found that leave names to be filled in or that contain no more than names and demand interpretation. There is therefore semantic overlap between allusion and *exemplum*; and one must acknowledge that while identifying the *exempla* in the work is fundamentally a finite and manageable task, it is also subjective. As wide as possible a definition is necessary, as is the discussion of marginal cases.

Exempla, like allusions, can be competitive (as with Cacus against Priam) and therefore debatable. For example, the *exemplum* of Diocletian and Galerius potentially has a different effect as used by Constantius to persuade Gallus, than when Ammianus uses it to remind his readers (one presumes) of his own previous narrative. This quality, the allusive and evasive way in which examples are often put forward, and the gaps in the details, make them places which test and demand analysis and implicate the reader. There is a constant and fine balance between glossing and leaving unglossed. Julian's centrality to the work is not a little connected to his ability to interpret his historical context in a way which very largely agrees with Ammianus. He respects the continuity of the Roman Empire and Hellenic wisdom. Partly as a result, he has the ability to create *exempla*.

CHAPTER 7

JULIAN'S MONUMENT

After the Persian disaster, the body of Julian was brought back to Tarsus for burial. Gregory of Nazianzus tells us that the procession was accompanied by paid clowns who mocked his apostasy and his demise to the accompaniment of flutes (*Or.* 5.18). His remains were burnt before burial in a tomb outside the town.[1] Just as the pagan Julian had participated in Constantius' Christian burial, the pious Christian Jovian decorated his predecessor's tomb when passing through Tarsus.

In his *Funeral Oration*, the sophist of Antioch, Libanius, had held that Julian should not have been buried at Tarsus, but in Athens, in the garden of the Academy beside Plato, to be celebrated as Plato was by an eternal succession of teachers and youths.[2] Ammianus used Jovian's decoration of the tomb to make a forceful and vigorous intervention, correcting Libanius and bringing Julian powerfully into the imagination of his Roman audience (25.10.5):

exindeque egredi nimium properans, / exornari sepulchrum statuit Iuliani, / in pomerio situm itineris, / quod ad Tauri montis angustias ducit; / cuius suprema et cineres, / si qui tunc iuste consuleret, / non Cydnus uidere deberet, / quamuis gratissimus amnis et liquidus, / sed ad perpetuandam gloriam recte factorum / praeterlambere Tiberis, / intersecans urbem aeternam / diuorumque ueterum monumenta praestringens.

Though in excessive haste to leave [Tarsus], [Jovian] decided to decorate the tomb of Julian, situated at the city boundary on the road which leads to the passes of

[1] The burial outside the town limits is repeatedly mentioned, and is an important variation in pagan and Christian burial practices. Cf. e.g. Cameron and Hall (1999), 347–8. The fact that Ammianus seems to refer to Julian's ashes (*cineres*) also seems a significant variation between pagan and Christian practice; against, see den Boeft *et al.* ad 25.10.5.

[2] τοῦτον ἐδέξατο μὲν τὸ πρὸ Ταρσῶν τῆς Κιλικίας χωρίον, εἶχε δ' ἂν δικαιότερον τὸ τῆς Ἀκαδημίας πλησίον τοῦ Πλάτωνος, ὥστ' αὐτῷ παρὰ τῶν ἀεὶ νέων τε καὶ διδασκάλων ἃ καὶ τῷ Πλάτωνι τελεῖσθαι ('A grave just outside Tarsus in Cilicia received his body. It ought more properly to have been in the Academy next to Plato's tomb, so that he too might receive the honours paid to Plato by endless generations of students and teachers', *Or.* 18.306 (tr. Norman)).

Mt Taurus. But as for his remains and ashes, if anyone then showed sound judgment, the Cydnus ought not look on them, although it is a beautiful and clear stream, but to perpetuate the glory of his noble deeds the Tiber should wash past them, which cuts through the eternal city and flows by the memorials of the deified emperors of old.

The neo-Platonic golden chain of teachers and pupils that Libanius imagined paying homage in the Academy of Athens was replaced in Ammianus' conception by a different exemplary succession, the tombs of ancient deified emperors by the side of the Tiber. Julian's imagined tomb evokes the first burial in the imperial monuments by the Tiber and the end of another timeless succession, Vergil's parade of Roman heroes (*Aen.* 6.873–4):[3]

> uel quae, Tiberine, uidebis
> funera, cum tumulum praeterlabere recentem!

What obsequies will you see, Tiberinus, as you flow past the new-raised tomb!

So Julian is imprinted on to the last hero of Vergil's procession: 'if by any means you could break the harsh fates – you will be Marcellus'.[4] Julian's imaginary monument, like the mound built for Marcellus, faces both future and past. His is the last addition to the tombs of those deified emperors of old with whom Ammianus chose to begin his work and whose example he constantly cited. The eternal city has the power to make eternal the memory of noble deeds, and Julian himself ought to become an example to future generations.

A monument in Rome would have been incongruous in reality. Emperors had not been buried there for many decades. Julian was a Greek-speaker, born in Constantinople, and is known to have

[3] The Mausoleums of Augustus and Hadrian were the most famous of the tombs by the Tiber, and contained the remains of many other emperors and members of imperial families. The Mausoleum of Augustus was begun in 28 BC, and Marcellus was buried there five years later.

[4] *si qua fata aspera rumpas – tu Marcellus eris* (Vergil *Aen.* 6.882–3). Even the description of the Cydnus, in its due and traditional acknowledgement of the limpidity of the stream (cf. Curtius 3.4.8 and Fontaine ad loc.), evokes the qualities of Vergil's personified Tiber. The river god's words are: *ego sum, pleno quem flumine cernis* ***stringentem*** *ripas et pinguia culta* ***secantem***, *caeruleus* ***Thybris***, *caelo* ***gratissimus amnis*** ('I am he whom you see laving my banks with full flood, and cleaving the rich fields, the blue Tiber, river best beloved of heaven', *Aen.* 8.62–4).

had uneasy relations with the Roman Senate (21.10.7). His appropriation to a Roman context is forced, but it mirrors Ammianus' practice throughout the work.[5] Indeed, Julian's exemplary monument stands as a metaphorical symbol for the *Res Gestae* as a whole. Julian himself is the physical centrepiece, straddling the work from Books 15 to 25. In these books the narrative slows down: *opus moueo maius, maiorque mihi rerum nascitur ordo* ('I launch a greater work, a greater succession of events is born for me', 15.9.1, a near quotation of Vergil *Aen.* 7.44–5). A period of a mere nine years is covered by eleven books, over half of the surviving text and over a third of the whole work when it was extant. The final fourteen years will be covered in only six books. Julian is one of the few characters to have any historical learning, and he consciously follows the examples, both Roman and Greek, which the narrator thrusts at other characters. Julian's place as an heir, even in his faults, to exemplary earlier emperors (especially those of the second century) is particularly strongly marked in Ammianus' work. And the last six books show the beginnings of how to understand Julian as *exemplum* by invoking his memory indirectly and directly as detrimental to, and envied by, the reigning emperors.

The last three chapters of this book looked at Ammianus' intertextual relationships with other authors, considered in various ways. In this chapter, I turn to look at intra-textual relationships, both internal allusions and the features of writing which give structural coherence to the work as a whole. The imagined tomb of Julian is such a feature. Many readers have observed that Julian brings unity to the work, and my focus in this chapter will be on him. I shall be looking very briefly at how the accounts of earlier emperors may have been manipulated to create an example for him (Section I), and at how internal allusions show him providing an example of rulership even in his lifetime (Section II). Finally I shall look in detail at how the last books start showing the example of Julian, expressed both through textual echoes

[5] Cf. 16.5.10. Here a proverb attributed by Julian to Plato is taken word for word from Cicero *Att.* 5.15.3. Julian is remodelled as Roman when he thinks himself Athenian.

and specific *exempla*, impacting on and showing up his successors (Section III).[6]

I Examples for Julian

Guessing how Ammianus dealt with individuals in the lost books is an uncertain business. Although he gives a remarkable number of cross-references, and also refers to the period covered by the lost books in numerous *exempla*, we can do no more than guess at how individuals were treated. I have speculated elsewhere that one of the reasons for Ammianus beginning where he did was the opportunity of including the exemplary rulers of the second century, who are so often summoned up as an *exemplum* for Julian in particular.[7] But were the reigns and characters of Trajan and Marcus, say, described in such a way as to provide exemplary preparation for the narrative of Julian? We might want to imagine so, but then much of our evidence comes from places in the extant books where their characters are compared to Julian's.[8]

This methodological circle cannot be squared, but I will cite one case where it seems likely on the face of things that Ammianus adapted his narrative of the third century to prepare for Julian. At the moment of departure on the Persian campaign, Ammianus reintroduces the first-person voice to the narrative: 'setting out from there, we came to Zaitha . . . here we saw the tomb, conspicuous from a distance, of the emperor Gordian, whose deeds from early boyhood and most fortunate commands of armies and treacherous death we described at the appropriate time' (23.5.7).[9] Shortly

[6] Thus this chapter to some extent compensates for the omission in the last of how the text generates *exempla*.

[7] Kelly (2005), 416.

[8] Similarly, a study of back-references to earlier emperors might suggest that Ammianus was deeply concerned with Persian campaigns before Julian: for example, there are fourteen back-references to Trajan, and seven to Galerius, many of the former and almost all of the latter concerned with their Persian Wars. But is this because Ammianus gave a great deal of attention to the Persian Wars in the lost books or because he does so in the extant books?

[9] *profecti exinde Zaitham uenimus locum . . . hic Gordiani imperatoris longe conspicuum uidimus tumulum, / cuius actus a pueritia prima / exercituumque felicissimos ductus / et insidiosum interitum / digessimus tempore competenti.*

afterwards, Julian makes a speech, and in it explains to the soldiers that the Romans had often had successes in Persia. He mentions the successes of Trajan, Verus and Severus, but the longest attention goes once more to Gordian III, whose tomb they had just beheld (again, *uidimus*) and honoured (23.5.17):

> and he would have returned with equal splendour . . . having overcome and put to flight the Persian King at Resaina, had he not fallen by an impious wound here, where he is buried, through the faction of the Praetorian Prefect Philip, with a few wicked accomplices. Nor did his spirit wander long unavenged, because as though Justice was weighing them, all those who conspired for his <destruction> perished with torturous punishments.[10]

Our historical information on Gordian III is pitifully thin. It is not known to us whether he was indeed killed by Philip, by the Persians, or died a natural death, and Ammianus' account is not beyond criticism.[11] A number of observations spring to mind:

- It is striking that the tomb is given so sharp a focus by the historian at the point of his reappearance in the narrative, and by the hero in the first of his speeches in the Persian expedition.
- It is also striking that the tomb of Gordian appears in the midst of a sequence of omens of Julian's death (23.5.4–6, 8–14).
- It is possible that Ammianus may have 'moved' Julian's speech in order for it to be able to appear after the army has seen the tomb. (Zosimus' account places the speech and the sighting of the tomb in the opposite order.)[12]
- Gordian III was a teenager, and it is likely that any glorious military commands (*felicissimos exercituum ductus*) were not his personal achievement. This is, however, exactly the sort of language with which Ammianus describes Julian.[13]

[10] *redissetque pari splendore iunior Gordianus, / cuius monumentum nunc uidimus honorate, / apud Resainam superato fugatoque rege Persarum, / ni factione Philippi / praefecti praetorio / sceleste iuuantibus paucis / in hoc ubi sepultus est loco, / uulnere impio cecidisset. / nec errauere diu manes eius inulti, / quod uelut librante Iustitia / omnes, qui in eius conspirauere <perniciem>, / cruciabilibus interiere suppliciis.*

[11] See den Boeft *et al.* ad loc.

[12] For further details and bibliography see Matthews (1989), 131 and 178. Against this argument see Fornara (1985).

[13] The word *felix* is almost exclusively reserved for Julian in the extant books: 17.1.14; cf. 21.16.13, a quotation from Cicero denying *felicitas* to Constantius; the superlative grade in 16.12.18 *felicissime omnium Caesar* and 20.4.15 *post multas felicissimas uictorias*; cf. 23.1.5 for an ominous use, playing on the imperial titulature.

- Ammianus refers to a treacherous death. Rumours that a Roman, and perhaps a Christian, was responsible for the death of Julian arose very early (25.6.6) and were part of the religious polemic of the time. Ammianus does not disclaim such rumours.[14] The greatest claim to fame of Gordian's alleged killer, Philip, was his supposed Christianity.
- Ammianus puts into Julian's mouth a description of the punishments of Gordian's killers taken from his own *Caesars*, where, however, it describes the death of Alexander Severus. The reattribution turns it into a prophecy of his own death.[15]

I would not insist equally on all of these points (for example, though Ammianus does not rule out the possibility, I doubt he really thought that Julian had been killed by one of his own side); I think that it is clear that he manipulates the *exemplum* of Gordian to make it suggest a possible fit for Julian. And if, as he says, he described Gordian in terms of exemplary praise at the appropriate time, it is very likely that he did so in order to make him an *exemplum* for Julian.

II Julian as model

Julian is repeatedly said to have acted in exemplary fashion during his lifetime. Nineteen times, at my reckoning, his deeds or character explicitly or obviously create an example: so he can provide a 'slight but remarkable proof of tolerance and gentleness' (*patientiae et lenitudinis . . . documentum leue quidem sed mirandum*, 22.9.16), or his war in Germany (comparable to those against Carthage and the Teutones) can itself be called memorable (17.1.14); his deeds continued to inspire after Constantius' death. Many other characters, prefects, officials, soldiers and philosophers, are named or depicted as exemplary in the course of the work, but in very few places is their *exemplum* re-enacted or even remembered. Julian stands out.[16]

His *exemplum* will be followed; and as the following case shows, this does not only happen posthumously, and it does not only

[14] See e.g. Hahn (1960) and den Boeft *et al.* ad 25.3.6.
[15] See Ch. 4, Section IV.7. [16] See Ch. 6 n. 2.

happen when explicit attention is drawn to it. Though Constantius' jealous anxiety can be seen as soon as the battle of Strasbourg is over, his reaction to Julian is rather more complex. Constantius' campaigns of the year after Strasbourg, 358, are placed at the end of the succeeding book. His success and the uncharacteristically favourable tone with which Ammianus lauds him at this point have struck many readers as puzzling and in need of an explanation: some have wondered whether the passage betrays an awkwardly incorporated panegyrical source.[17] One overlooked explanation is that Constantius has learnt from his Caesar's example. He advances early in the year to take the Sarmatians and Quadi by surprise (17.12.4), just as Julian is described as having done to the Salian Franks earlier in the book (17.8.2–3). Constantius' and Julian's early campaigns in 358 were probably more or less simultaneous (if anything, Constantius' will have been earlier), but, by placing Julian first, Ammianus makes him appear to be an example for Constantius. A later scene reinforces this interpretation. Constantius' hapless victims, the Limigantes, flee from his men into the river: it is noteworthy that this scene is in some ways a miniaturised version of a scene from Julian's victory at Strasbourg the previous year, where the barbarian rout is elaborately described (16.12.55–7):

16.12.55 et quia cursu sub armis concito **fugientes** / miles indefessus urgebat, / **quidam nandi peritia** eximi **se posse** discriminibus **arbitrati** / animas fluctibus **commiserunt** . . . (56) unde id obseruatum est / ut marginibus insistentes **confoderent telorum uarietate** Germanos, / **quorum** si quem morti uelocitas subtraxisset, / iacti corporis pondere ad ima fluminis subsidebat. (57) et . . . licebat iam sine metu uidere, / nandi strenuis quosdam nescios adhaerentes, / fluitantes alios, cum expeditioribus linquerentur, ut stipites, / et uelut luctante amnis uiolentia uorari quosdam fluctibus inuolutos / . . . **spumans** denique **cruore** barbarico / decolor alueus / insueta stupebat augmenta.

17.13.15 **fugientes** tamen **aliqui** tela incendiorumque magnitudinem amnis uicini **se commisere** gurgitibus, / **peritia nandi** ripas ulteriores occupare **posse sperantes**, / **quorum** plerique summersi necati sunt, / **alii iaculis periere confixi** / adeo ut abunde **cruore** diffuso meatus fluminis **spumaret** immensi. / ita per elementum utrumque / Sarmatas uincentium ira uirtusque deleuit.

[17] See e.g. Barnes (1998), 138, and Paschoud (1999a), 361–2.

And because the tireless soldiers pressed on those **fleeing** at high pace despite the weight of their arms, **some** of the foe **thought they could** rescue themselves from perils **through their skill at swimming** and **entrusted their souls to the waves** . . . (56) And therefore it was seen that men stood on the banks and **pierced** the Germans **with various weapons**; if any **of them** escaped death through their speed, he sank to the bottom of the river from the weight of a wounded body. (57) And . . . now it was possible to look on without fear: some ignorant of swimming clinging on to strong swimmers, others floating like logs when left behind by the faster ones, and others swept up and devoured by the waves as though the violence of the river was wrestling with them . . . Finally, **foaming** with barbarian **gore**, the discoloured river-bed stood astonished at its unaccustomed increase. But **some**, **fleeing** the spears and the great extent of the fires, **entrusted themselves to the waters, hoping they could** gain the far banks **through their skill at swimming**. Most **of them** were killed by drowning, others perished **pierced through by missiles**, so much that the flow of the vast river **foamed** with widely spread **gore**. Thus the anger and bravery of the conquerors destroyed the Sarmatians in both elements.

Whatever Ammianus' sources for the Sarmatian campaigns of Constantius, at this point the principal allusion is surely an internal one. Such a phenomenon is not rare in Latin historiography. An example from Tacitus has been sharply elucidated by Tony Woodman: the description of Germanicus' army discovering the battlefield of the Teutoburger Wald (*Ann.* 1.61–62.1) contains countless verbal echoes of Vitellius' crowing voyeurism at the gory battlefield of Bedriacum (*Hist.* 2.70). In that case, the function of the internal allusion is not necessarily clear, and Woodman's favoured explanation is more or less that Tacitus was repeating a winning formula from his earlier work.[18] In Ammianus, the allusive purpose of imitating what he himself had written only a book earlier is far clearer: it is to show Constantius' success as an echo, albeit a diminished one, of Julian's achievements (and indeed, I have necessarily abbreviated the narrative of Strasbourg quoted above).

III Julian *post mortem*

Ammianus' picture of the reign of Constantius is particularly notable for characters being played off against each other (thus

[18] Woodman (1979), (1988), 169–79.

Gallus, an otherwise black character, is also portrayed in a pitiable way in order to blacken Constantius).[19] In the portions of Book 25 which follow Julian's death, and in the last six books, a new version of this playing-off of characters against each other is found. It is now Julian's posthumous example against which the deeds of Jovian, Valentinian and Valens are compared. Julian reappears twenty-five times in seven books. And although some of these reappearances are natural or circumstantial, such as reference to his death shortly after its occurrence, or mentioning him in the background to his cousin Procopius' revolt, most are not so simple. (The most complex is the adornment of Julian's tomb by Jovian, which I quoted at the start of this chapter, and which sketches the process by which Ammianus' history will make Julian live on.) But to put Julian's status as a posthumous example into context, a brief examination should be made of the treatment of Constantius after that emperor's death. This is because an account of Constantius' reign exists for comparison, and because Julian is both explicitly and implicitly contrasted to Constantius throughout their joint reign.

1 Constantius

I count twenty-one posthumous references to Constantius in ten books (22–31): nine belong to the book immediately following his death (22). Some of these are simply references to his death being reported in various locations (22.1.2, 22.2.1, 22.8.49) and the rest refer to his partisans, and their varying fates. One of these (22.14.4) is in an anecdote displaying Julian's clemency. The later references are mostly in passing as well, for example to his daughter (26.7.10, 26.9.3, 29.6.7) or brothers-in-law (29.2.9), or as a chronological marker (26.6.1). Only two are obviously exemplary, and both relate to Jovian. Sabinus, a decurion of Nisibis, accused Jovian over the surrender of the city: although Constantius had been defeated by the Persians, and had once had to flee to an unprotected *statio* and live off a crust begged from an old woman, until his last day he had never lost any territory,[20] whereas Jovian had at the very start

[19] See Ch. 6, Section IV; Sabbah (1978), 455.

[20] Sapor did not retain control of cities such as Amida which he had captured by siege.

of his reign abandoned the protecting wall which had long kept the provinces intact (25.9.3). Hardly flattering to Jovian to use as an *exemplum* of military success an emperor famous for infelicity in external wars. But then it is suggested in the obituary that the comparison was one made by Jovian himself (25.10.14–15):[21]

et aemulari malebat Constantium, / agens seria quaedam aliquotiens post meridiem, / iocarique palam cum proximis assuetus. / Christiani legis itidem studiosus / et non numquam honorificus, / mediocriter eruditus, / magisque beniuolus, / et perpensius, ut apparebat ex paucis quos promouerat iudices, electurus; / edax tamen et uino Venerique indulgens, / quae uitia imperiali uerecundia forsitan correxisset.

And he preferred to rival Constantius, sometimes carrying out serious business in the afternoon, and wont to jest openly with his intimates. He was likewise an enthusiast of the Christian sect and at times generous to it; educated to a middling degree, and more kind-natured; and would have been very careful (so it appeared from the few officials he promoted) in appointments; but he was gluttonous and given to wine and venery – though perhaps he would have put right these faults from respect for his imperial position.

The comparison was not unnatural: Constantius was a moderately successful and lately deceased ruler, emphatically dissimilar to Julian; and Jovian's first prominence came when he escorted the body of Constantius to Constantinople (21.16.20–1). But the aptness of the comparison is called into doubt.[22] Spending serious afternoons and Christian devotion were Constantian in style, as was middling education and caution over appointments (21.16.3–4).[23] But the open joking and the gluttony and the lack of chastity contradict all of Constantius' most important virtues.[24] This combined with the accusation of Sabinus makes the comparison seem unedifying; it reflects badly on Jovian, without redeeming Constantius.[25]

[21] It is also evident from portrayal of the emperors on the coinage. See e.g. Potter (2004), 524–5.

[22] Fontaine ad 25.10.15 (p. 287 n. 727).

[23] Though this quality of Constantius' was not universally admitted, cf. Victor 42.24.

[24] *imperatoriae auctoritatis coturnum ubique custodiens* ('he everywhere guarded the buskin of imperial authority', 21.16.1), *edendi potandique moderatione* ('with his moderation of eating and drinking', 5), *impendio castus* ('exceptionally chaste', 6).

[25] Sabbah (1978), 495, observes a similarity in a different way. 'Le couple antagoniste Julien-Jovien vient relayer, après la pause relative que constitue dans l'argumentation le récit du règne de Julien, le couple antagoniste Constance-Julien, créant la même tension

2 *Julian and Valentinian*

Julian is still a formidable presence in the last six books: he is contrasted with Valentinian and Valens in different ways.[26] In Book 26 he is particularly present (eight mentions). This is in part achieved through the persons of his appointees. Apronianus, Prefect of Rome, who had advanced thanks to Julian (26.3.2), is strongly defended.[27] At 26.5.2, Julian's appointees are divided between the two imperial brothers. Both brothers together are accused of being jealous of Julian. They sought evidence against his friends (26.4.4), but found none – after the defeat of Procopius the opportunity was taken to punish more harshly those partisans of Procopius who had also been favoured by Julian (26.10.8):

> . . . et absoluto Euphrasio, / Phronimius Cherronesum deportatur, / inclementius in eodem punitus negotio, / ea re quod diuo Iuliano fuit acceptus, / cuius memorandis uirtutibus / ambo fratres principes obtrectabant, / nec similes eius nec suppares.
>
> And while Euphrasius got off, Phronimius was sent off to the Chersonese, punished with less clemency for the same business – it was because he had been favoured by the deified Julian, whose memorable virtues both the imperial brothers disparaged, though not like him and not close to equalling him.

The language is polemical. Julian himself had criticised the memory of Constantine (*memoriam . . . uexauit*, 21.10.8), but Valentinian and Valens are described as disparaging not Julian's *memoria* but his memorable virtues (among which his justice was notable); to say that they were not his like or his equals implies their jealous aspiration to be so. Another passage in Book 26 offers the implication that Ammianus' constant repeated mentions of Julian are really reflections of an inferiority complex in the two brothers.

et entraînant la même interaction des arguments.' ('The opposing pair Julian–Jovian comes to replace, after the relative pause which the narrative of Julian's reign constitutes in the argumentation, the opposing pair Constantius–Julian, creating the same tension and introducing the same interaction of arguments.') Jovian posthumously is used as little more than a chronological marker and as a way of signalling the disastrous treaty. Identifying this treaty so firmly with Jovian, who might be considered merely to have been clearing up Julian's mess, is perhaps the most important example of the tendentious seesaw-like playing-off of characters against each other.

[26] Sabbah (1978), 495–506.

[27] See Sabbah (1978), 497–8. He observes that an incident which really belonged to Julian's reign is placed in Valentinian's, perhaps partly so that the reign of Julian should not be sullied by magic trials.

When Valentinian heard of the revolt of Procopius, he had to decide whether to give succour to Valens or to remain in the West to fight the Alamanni. Ammianus interprets his thoughts thus (26.5.11):

documento enim recenti impendio terrebatur, / reputans paulo antea Iulianum, / contempto bellorum ciuilium ubique uictore, / nec speratum nec expectatum / ab urbe in urbem / incredibili uelocitate transisse.[28]

For he was greatly alarmed by a recent example: he considered how shortly before Julian, unafraid of a consistent winner in civil wars, passed against hope and expectation from city to city with unimagined speed.

In fact Valentinian did not turn to fight against Procopius, so the doubts that Ammianus places in his mind, implying belief in his own inferiority, comprise an interesting and tendentious counter-factual.

Julian's success at Strasbourg and after was reflected by the peace which endured in Gaul until after his death: 'after he had left the western zone, as long as he remained on earth, all the tribes were motionless and at rest, as though soothed by some worldwide wand' (*et postquam ex occidua plaga digressus est, / quoad fuit in terris, / quieuere nationes omnes immobiles, / ac si quodam caduceo leniente mundano*, 25.4.14).[29] A causal link between Julian being alive and the boundaries being inviolate is suggested. The beginning of Book 27 sees the same two ideas juxtaposed (27.1.1):

dum per eoum orbem / haec quae narrauimus / diuersi rerum expediunt casus, / Alamanni post aerumnosas iacturas et uulnera, / quae congressi saepe Iuliano Caesari pertulerunt, / uiribus tandem resumptis, / licet imparibus pristinis, / ob causam expositam / supra Gallicanos limites formidati iam persultabant.

While through the Orient the changing course of events was developing as we have narrated, the Alamanni, after the disastrous losses and wounds which they had suffered from their frequent battles with Julian Caesar, having at last renewed their strength (which did not yet equal its old vigour), were already, for the reason explained above, overleaping the frontiers of Gaul, inspiring fear.

The passage not only preserves the implicit idea of Julian's great *auctoritas* keeping the peace throughout the empire while he was

[28] See Sabbah (1978), 496 n. 124.

[29] In fact the general motif of the peacefulness of Julian's reign as sole Augustus seems very important to Ammianus (see Section IV below).

alive;[30] it also offers a defence of the efficacy of Julian's victories at Strasbourg and elsewhere by implying the inferiority of the German menace now. A favourable comparison of Julian to Valentinian's generals who are defeated in the following chapter is implied, and beyond that a favourable comparison to Valentinian himself.

A practical illustration of Valentinian's inferiority to Julian is also found. Following the graphic description of instances of Valentinian's cruelty, Ammianus proposes (29.4.1) to discuss his care for the state. He continues (2):

agitabatur autem inter multiplices curas / id omnium primum atque potissimum, / ut Macrianum regem . . . ui superstitem raperet uel insidiis, / ut multo ante Vadomarium Iulianus.

And among manifold cares, this concerned him first and foremost, to seize king Macrianus alive by force or a trick, as long before Julian had taken Vadomarius.

It is not stated whether the comparison to Julian was in Valentinian's own mind, though the previous references to his attitude to Julian and the emphasis that capturing Macrianus was first and foremost among his cares might suggest that it was.[31] At any rate, even if Valentinian is excused blame for the incident, he fails to achieve the glory that Julian had achieved: even at his most impressive he cannot match him. And Valentinian is perhaps also undermined by the anger that is attributed to him, 'like a lion gnashing his empty jaws because of a lost stag or she-goat' (*tamquam leo ob ceruum amissum uel capream / morsus uacuos concrepans*, 29.4.7). This is an aspect of his character in which Valentinian contrasts strongly with Julian.[32]

[30] This combination of ideas can arguably also be seen in 26.4.5, where barbarian invasions are described in terms linguistically similar to 27.1.1: *hoc tempore uelut per uniuersum orbem Romanum / bellicum canentibus bucinis, / excitae gentes saeuissimae / **limites** sibi proximos **persultabant*** ('at this time as though the trumpets were singing the war-cry through the whole Roman world, the most savage nations were aroused and **overleaping the frontiers** nearest them'). But just as Julian was named at 27.1.1, this passage follows immediately from the mention of the name of Julian. It was rumoured that investigations of the cause of the sicknesses suffered by the imperial brothers were to raise hatred against the memory of Julian and his friends: of the plots of the latter no evidence was to be found. The juxtaposition is significant.

[31] Sabbah (1978), 500.

[32] Sabbah (1978), 500–1. Sabbah thinks that the use of the lion for the image is emphasising the contrast with Julian, who represents the more positive aspects of the type of man defined by physiognomy as the lion, while Valentinian is attributed the negative aspects. Ammianus only has one implied comparison of Julian to a lion, in the omen of 23.5.8.

Even in Valentinian's obituary, Julian crops up. Here the connection between the death of Julian and the revival of the warlike spirit of the Alamanni, implied at 26.4.5 and 27.1.1, is finally made openly. Valentinian at the very start of his reign (30.7.5–6)

> Gallias petit, / Alamannicis patentes excursibus, / reuiuiscentibus erectius cognito principis Iuliani interitu, / quem post Constantem solum omnium formidabant. / ideo autem etiam Valentinianus merito timebatur . . .
>
> made for Gaul, open to the Alamann attacks which were revived more intently once the emperor Julian's death was known: after Constans they were afraid only of him. But Valentinian too was deservedly feared . . .

It seems strange to use the obituary of one emperor for the praise of another; even if Valentinian is also being praised, to say nothing of Constans, the use of *etiam* ('Valentinian too . . .') is remarkable. The infiltration of Julian into passages such as these is subtle, as is the way that it is increasingly openly asserted that Julian's government of the empire, or even his existence on earth, was responsible for keeping the peace. Another feature in which this obituary invites comparisons with Julian is through the emperors whom Ammianus chooses to compare to Valentinian. He rejects the comparison chosen by Valentinian's partisans to Aurelian (30.8.8).[33] He compares him to Hadrian in his depreciation of the well-dressed, the learned, the wealthy, the noble, the brave, 'so that he alone should appear to excel in fine abilities' (*ut solus uideretur bonis artibus eminere*, 30.8.10); Julian too had been compared to Hadrian in one of his faults (25.4.17).[34] Most interesting is the comparison of Valentinian to the unequivocally 'good' emperors of the second century – Trajan, Antoninus Pius and Marcus (Hadrian is a more complex case). His tendency towards timorousness is described; Remigius, the *magister officiorum*, would hint at barbarian outbreaks to temper the emperor's savage fury, and because fear broke

[33] See Jerome *Chron.* s.a. 365; Alföldi (1952) 27 n. 1, 47, 60.

[34] See Nixon (1971), 364–5. He observes that both the *Epitome de Caesaribus* (45.6) and Ammianus compare Valentinian with Hadrian and that 'this is no coincidence' (364). The *Epitome* 45.6 remarks on Valentinian's painting, sculpting, good memory and introduction of new weapons as being like Hadrian (cf. 14.2–5), Ammianus remarks on how both denigrated brave men. Whether we see this as owing to a common source or as an indication of Ammianus' independent use of comparisons made by others, it is an intriguing similarity.

him down he would soon become as soft and merciful as Antoninus (30.8.12). Moving over to his virtues: had he regulated the rest of his conduct according to those of his acts which were worthy of praise and imitation, 'he would have lived like Trajan and Marcus' (*uixerat ut Traianus et Marcus*, 30.9.1).

Julian was compared to all of these emperors: in 16.1.4, they figure, preceded by Titus, in chronological order, each representing a separate imperial virtue. After Strasbourg, Julian repairs a fort built by Trajan (17.1.11), and during the Persian campaign he adopts the habit of swearing oaths in the style of Trajan (24.3.9). The *clementia* of Antoninus is in the context of cardinal virtues when applied to Julian; for Valentinian it represents a feebleness brought on by fear. Julian's similarity to these emperors is repeatedly argued, whereas Valentinian's is a might-have-been.

3 Julian and Valens

Valens too is compared to Julian, though in a less open way, and with different emphases.[35] It has already been observed that he punished Phronimius more severely (26.10.8) because of his closeness to Julian. There are other comparisons of Valens to Julian in the administration of justice. One of these is the condemnation of Maximus, another partisan of Julian, 'the philosopher, a man with a huge reputation for learning, because of whose most fertile conversations Julian stood out as an emperor abundant as regards learning' (*ille philosophus, / uir ingenti nomine doctrinarum, / cuius ex uberrimis sermonibus ad scientiam copiosus Iulianus extitit imperator*, 29.1.42). The learning of both philosopher and emperor is noted, a contrast to the bumpkin Valens. Maximus was taken to his native city to be killed, and to make an example of him; the danger taught him that 'bias in an investigator is worse than all accusations' (*quaesitoris iniquitatem omnibus esse criminibus grauiorem*). In the context of the previously described attitude of Valentinian and Valens to the followers of Julian, the punishment is implied to be at least in part because of his relationship with Julian.

[35] Sabbah (1978), 502–6.

The contrast in the execution of justice by Julian and Valens is made again in 30.4.1. Valens' associates tried to deter him from his enthusiasm for judging, fearing

ne ita ut Iuliani temporibus, / defensione innocentiae respirante, / frangeretur potentium tumor, / assumpta licentia latius solitus euagari.

that like in Julian's time, with the defence of innocence breathing again, the haughtiness of the powerful, which as usual took advantage of its licence to wander further abroad, would be shattered.

The revival of justice is a characteristic of the times of Julian. Beside the many examples Ammianus gives of Julian's execution of justice, in themselves contrasting with Valens, this looks back to the repeated statement that Julian's reign might rightly be seen as an age, in accordance with Julian's own oft-repeated words (*ut ipse dicebat assidue*, 22.10.6), when Justice returned to earth (22.10.6–7, 25.4.19–20).[36] Ammianus had himself confirmed Julian's estimation of his own virtues; now he placed it in the mind of his villains. The Praetorian Prefect Modestus, like his emperor of 'backward intellect, with no polish from reading the classics' (30.4.2),[37] was particularly prominent in persuading Valens to refrain from judging, and 'Valens, believing that the examination of swarms of cases had been instituted to humble the loftiness of his power, left off completely, as Modestus had urged'.[38] Valens' ignorance is seen as a motivating factor in his error. There is therefore a general as well as a specific contrast to Julian.

Julian need not be named to be present. Ammianus remarking again on an instance of Valens' injustice exclaims (29.2.18):

o praeclara informatio doctrinarum, / munere caelesti indulta felicibus, / quae uel uitiosas naturas saepe excoluisti! / quanta in illa caligine temporum correxisses, / si Valenti scire per te licuisset, / nihil aliud esse imperium, / ut sapientes definiunt, / nisi curam salutis alienae.

[36] Not only is the language almost identical in both places, but so too is the allusion to Aratus, who raises Justice to heaven away from sinful mankind, and in both places the praise precedes the condemnation of the decree on teaching, the exception that proved the rule.

[37] *subagreste ingenium, / nullis uetustatis lectionibus expolitum.*

[38] *ille ad humilitandam celsitudinem potestatis / negotiorum examina spectanda instituta esse arbitratus (ut monebat) abstinuit penitus.*

Oh noble moulding of learning, bestowed on the fortunate by a heavenly gift, you who have often ennobled even vicious natures! How much could you have put right in the blackness of the times, if Valens could have known through you that empire, as the wise define it, is nothing other than guarding the safety of others.

Again the emperor's injustice is ascribed to lack of knowledge and education. A saying attributed to Julius Caesar follows, and an *exemplum* 'well known to the ancients'.[39] But this section alludes to Julian, firstly in the general contrast of a philosophical emperor who was in his own words 'well acquainted with ancient history' (*antiquitatum peritus*, 23.5.21), further in the use of the word *felix*, which as I have observed above is particularly associated with Julian in the *Res Gestae*,[40] and, most importantly, by the textual rapport between what Valens did not know and what Julian asserted in his deathbed speech. Compare the belief, unknown to Valens, that 'empire, as the wise define it, is nothing other than guarding the safety of others', and Julian's claim that he was always inclined to more peaceful measures, 'considering that the purpose of just empire is the subjects' comfort and safety' (*reputans . . . iusti esse finem imperii, oboedientium commodum et salutem*, 25.3.18).[41] Julian is therefore one of the *sapientes* of whom Valens is ignorant. That Julian's own statement was derivative is in no way to lessen its importance, since we have seen that being open to exemplary words and deeds is itself potentially exemplary. Julian's words also find an echo in the obituary of Valentinian (30.8.14):

nec afflictis (si fors ingruisset inferior) / erat ullum in principis benignitate perfugium, / quod semper, ut agitato mari iactatis, / portus patuit exoptatus. / finis enim iusti imperii / (ut sapientes docent) utilitas oboedientium aestimatur et salus.

Nor did those who were in difficulties, if some ill fortune had assailed them, find that the emperor's generosity offered any escape, though it has always been open like a longed-for haven for those tossed on stormy sea. After all, the purpose of just empire, as the wise teach, is considered to be the benefit and safety of the subjects.

Ignorance is not here levelled against Valentinian, as it was for Valens. For Valens, ignorance is a motif. With Valentinian,

[39] 29.2.19: see Ch. 6, Section II. [40] See n. 13.
[41] For this commonplace, cf. e.g. Cic. *Off.* 1.85; see further Valesius ad 29.2.18.

ignorance is mentioned once in the obituary.[42] Indeed Valentinian has just been quoted using classical *exempla*, justifying harsh judges as Lycurgi or Cassii. This misuse of *exempla* characterises the difference between Valentinian and his brother. In Valentinian's obituary the comparisons can be made, and it can be discussed how the emperor fails to live up to them; in the obituary of Valens, no *exempla* are used. Valentinian's military successes are diminished by Julian's; the horrors of Valens' injustice are aggrandised by comparison to Julian's justice.

4 Strasbourg and Adrianople

But there is also a military comparison between Julian and Valens. Just as Constantius' successes against the Sarmatians are portrayed as a successful but feebler echo of Strasbourg (Section II above), so the battle of Adrianople is also constantly reminiscent of Julian's victory. It seems certain that, however much attention might have been devoted to, say, the Milvian Bridge or Mursa, the two great set-piece battles of Ammianus' work were Strasbourg and Adrianople. The one closed, in the middle of a campaigning season, the book which stood in the centre of the work as a whole; the other closed the work. A great Roman victory against the barbarians under the central hero of the work is opposed to a catastrophic defeat by the barbarians under an immeasurably inferior successor. In the scale of their depiction in the narrative they would invite comparison, even were there not other similarities. As R. C. Blockley has observed:[43]

> In the battle of Adrianople, Ammianus implies, the forces were more evenly matched than at Strasburg. The Goths were raging as savagely as the Alemanni had been twenty-one years before. However, on this occasion the Roman Emperor Valens displayed the rashness and over-confidence that Chonodomar had exhibited at Strasburg.

[42] *atquin potuit exempla multa contueri maiorum . . haec forsitan Valentinianus ignorans* ('and yet he could have observed many examples of our forebears . . . of these Valentinian was perhaps ignorant', 30.8.4, 6).

[43] Blockley (1977), 224–5. He discussed the size of the armies earlier (219–20). This implication of Ammianus' should be compared to his insistence that the Alammanni's strength was unequal to that of old (27.1.1). In both instances Julian is praised and his successor denigrated. On Strasbourg see also Pighi (1936a), 61–127.

At Strasbourg, Ammianus goes to great lengths to emphasise the caution of Julian.[44] One way in which that caution was exercised was in his restraining words addressed to the troops (16.12.9–12). It was hot and approaching noon; the soldiers were tired and hungry and thirsty; the moon was waning and the night would be dark. Julian advocated that the army encamp and wait for the next day.[45] The soldiers did not let him finish his speech in their enthusiasm for battle (16.12.13). Julian's caution, which on that occasion was not necessary, would however have been salutary at Adrianople.[46] There, likewise, the Roman army had arrived in the heat of the noonday sun (31.12.11), the soldiers were hot and thirsty – to which another destructive evil was added, hunger which tortured both men and beasts (31.12.13). At the end of the battle, the slaughter was only ended by the moonless night (31.13.11).

These are impressive parallels. Nor are they all. In the first chapter of this book, I showed how the Roman failure to bury all their dead at the preliminary skirmish of Ad Salices contrasted with Julian's piety after Strasbourg:

31.7.16 **humatis** denique pro locorum et temporis ratione / honoratis quibusdam inter defunctos, / reliqua **peremptorum corpora dirae uolucres consumpserunt**, / assuetae illo tempore cadaueribus pasci, / ut indicant nunc usque albentes ossibus campi.

Finally some of the more highly ranked among the deceased were **buried**, as far as time and place permitted: the rest of **the bodies of the dead were consumed by ominous fowl**, who at that time became used to feeding on corpses, as is shown by the plains which even now are white with bones.

17.1.1 . . . Martius iuuenis, / Rheno post Argentoratensem pugnam otiose fluente, securus / sollicitusque idem **ne dirae uolucres consumerent corpora peremptorum**, / sine discretione cunctos **humari** mandauit.

. . . his mind at ease now that the Rhine flowed peacefully after the battle at Strasbourg, the warlike youth was at the same time anxious **to keep ominous fowl from devouring the bodies of the dead**, and gave orders that all should **be buried** without distinction.[47]

[44] Not of course a virtue which always characterised him. See 16.12.9, 10, 12, 33, and 47 for the caution (*consilium, cautela, quies*) of Julian and the Roman soldiers.

[45] Albeit possibly, in textbook style, to test the mettle of the troops as much as in sincerity.

[46] Blockley (1977), 226, suggests that it was Fritigern who showed the caution that the Romans had shown at Strasbourg (31.12.14–15).

[47] I also compared on p. 28 *cunctis igitur* ***summis infimisque*** *approbantibus tunc opportune* ***congr****ediendum* ('so with everyone, both highest and lowest, agreeing that the time

It is impossible to know, for lack of comparable material, whether the historical facts were manipulated in order to produce the similarity between the accounts of Strasbourg and Adrianople: presumably existing sources imposed some degree of restraint. Nonetheless the speech that Julian makes at Strasbourg would have prevented the problems that the Roman army faced at Adrianople.

The case that the historical narrative is manipulated in order to compare and contrast these two great battles is not impregnable, then, but it is credible. It is clear, after all, that the accounts of previous emperors are manipulated for exemplary purposes in the surviving account, as when the glorious deeds of the teenage Gordian provide a paradigm and an omen for Julian (Section I above). The creation of exemplary parallels might have affected the narrative of either battle: the *exemplum* functions reciprocally. Julian is established at Strasbourg as exemplary hero and military tactician. This *exemplum*, apparent but unnamed at Adrianople, is certainly to the detriment of Valens, ignorant as he was, and motivated mainly by jealousy of Gratian.

But as well as diminishing Valens, the comparison also exalts Julian. The reminder of his (neglected) example has the effect of strengthening it. Not only are *exempla* validated by repetition, but the manner of the recollection of Julian's example is particularly interesting. His speech at Strasbourg, against the flow of the narrative, urges rest and restraint: it could look like weakness and indeed could be used to argue that his military prowess was not so great. Adrianople validates that aspect of his example, and on the larger scale it could be argued that Adrianople is necessary for understanding Julian's achievement.

The structural role of these *exempla* is important. It may be suggested that a link would have been visible in the *Res Gestae*, when fully extant, between Strasbourg, at the centre, and the two opposite ends of the work, Trajan in Book I and Adrianople in

was ripe for battle', 16.12.18) and *sed unanimanti ardore, **summi et infimi** inter se **congruentes*** ('with single-minded determination the highest and lowest came together', 31.5.14). The first of these describes Julian's army begging to be allowed to fight, the second belongs to a description of how the Romans had traditionally escaped from dangers on the same scale as Adrianople; the implication is that on that occasion the leadership was inferior. Julian accepted military advice, Valens did not, and it is reasonable to see in the contrast implicit criticism of Valens. Neumann (1987), 24.

Book 31. Strasbourg is the node of the work, where Julian follows the example of Trajan and offers an example to Valens. Ammianus wrote of Trajan in the knowledge that Julian would come later, and of Julian in the knowledge that Trajan had come before him; the account of Julian has foreknowledge that Valens and Adrianople would follow.

IV Conclusion

If Julian's reign is constructed in an exemplary fashion, it is not only through the narrative, or the addition of allusions to the heroes of the past,[48] or the anecdotes illustrating the justice or the military virtue of Julian, though these will be reprised after his death. It is also in the structure: Julian's personal *auctoritas* preserved the peace in all parts of the empire during his reign, and there was freedom both from civil and external conflict. The siege of Aquileia is placed entirely before and the Roman prefecture of Apronianus after Julian's reign.[49] From the start of Book 22 until his death in Book 25, the account only diverges from the emperor for grand geographical digressions. After his death and funeral procession, the account reverts in Books 26–30 to moving abruptly, and sometimes awkwardly, from East to West, as it had for Julian's war with Constantius in Books 20–1.

Is the *Res Gestae* itself, therefore, created in the image of Julian's imagined monument beside the Tiber in Rome, placing him among the deified emperors and perpetuating the glory of his righteous deeds? Julian's imaginary monument shares with the *Res Gestae* its subject, its location, its purpose: they share a belief enshrined in their structure in the continuity of the Roman Empire.[50] But the *Res Gestae* cannot be identified entirely as Julian's monument. Julian is certainly idealised, not least in the posthumous references, where, as I have shown, he offers the means to judge Valentinian and Valens (and perhaps their successors?). But Julian alive is more

[48] I hope to have shown above all that few of the *exempla* can be treated as mere *additions*.
[49] 21.11–12, 26.3. See Sabbah (1978), 481–2.
[50] For further discussion of *mise en abyme* in the *Res Gestae* see Kelly (2004), Sections IV–V.

problematic, especially in the three and a half books which treat his sole rule: as is well known, the heroising of Julian is balanced by criticism of many major aspects of his policy. Comparing Julian to his successors was obviously less challenging than comparing him to himself. Readers assume that what clashes with the ideal is reality. It is this clash between the exemplary Julian and the Julian of the narrative that makes Ammianus' history so persuasive and successful.

EPILOGUE

haec ut miles quondam et Graecus, / a principatu Caesaris Neruae exorsus / ad usque Valentis interitum / pro uirium explicaui mensura, / opus ueritatem professum / numquam, ut arbitror, / sciens silentio ausus corrumpere uel mendacio. / scribant reliqua potiores aetate, / doctrinis florentes. / quos id, si libuerit, aggressuros, / procudere linguas ad maiores moneo stilos.

These events, beginning from the principate of Nerva Caesar up to the death of Valens, I, a soldier once and a Greek, have unrolled to the best of my strength: it is a work which claims truthfulness and which, so I think, I have never knowingly dared to warp with silence or falsehood. Let the rest be written by men with youth on their side, in the bloom of learning. To those who would embark on this, if it please them, I give the advice to forge their tongues to grander styles.

(31.16.9)

There are four great Latin historians whose works survive from antiquity, and it is sad but also fitting that only in the last does the historian's farewell to his readers survive. The works of the younger classical historians to whom Ammianus passed on his task are lost.[1] He reminded readers of his learning (*Graecus*), and that his work had covered nearly 300 years, and had taken its place in the canon after Tacitus, his last worthy predecessor. He also reminded them of his qualifications to write the history of his own time, in which he had played his part (*miles quondam*), and, by referring to the youth of the succeeding generation, suggested that this had been a life's work.[2]

In this work I have argued that the personal details which the historian obtrudes into the narrative, apparently intimate and frequently moving, are almost invariably inseparable from, perhaps

[1] On Sulpicius Alexander and Renatus Profuturus Frigeridus see Paschoud (1999b).

[2] The bibliography on the sphragis is considerable: see Calboli (1974), Rosen (1982), 41–8, Blockley (1998), Guzmán-Armario (2003a), Paschoud (2004) and Kelly (2007) for the most recent discussions; almost every book devoted to Ammianus includes discussion of it.

subordinate to, his historiographical aims of establishing his honesty, independence, and authority. Past scholarship has often shown an obsession with extracting insights into the historian's life and personality from such passages – or just as often, passages which have been arbitrarily deemed autobiographical. But what is in reality a lack of information combines with the historian's artistry and evasiveness to make biographical interpretations unacceptably conjectural (Chapters 1–3). By contrast, I have argued for the meaningful nature of his intertextuality as a path to understanding. Allusion in Ammianus is immensely diverse, but it tends often to be carefully controlled – whether internal or external, whether to the classics or to his contemporaries (Chapters 4–7).

Ammianus' sphragis illustrates in miniature this diversity of allusion and its potential meaningfulness. As well as echoing other passages within the work, it alludes to a central theoretical work and to a central model of Roman historiography, and also unexpectedly to a contemporary. Cicero's famous *dictum* in *De Oratore* that the first duty of the historian was to tell the truth and the second to abstain from lies is married, in the claim of 'a work which professes truthfulness', to words from the preface of Tacitus' *Histories*.[3] And the practice of allusion is signalled within the text. The words *ad maiores . . . stilos* mean not 'in the manner of great writers' but 'to grander styles of writing',[4] so they are not an open acknowledgement but a strong hint at the presence of deliberate and carefully controlled intertextuality with great models.[5] But the words are also crucially ambiguous, because they allude unmistakeably to a contemporary. Eutropius' conclusion (10.18.3) declares that the reign of the current emperors must be told in a grander style, that is to say, panegyric. The allusion suggests that

[3] Cicero *De Or.* 2.62, cf. also 3.121, 3.183 (see Blockley (1998), 306). Tacitus refers to himself as among those *incorruptam fidem professis* ('those who have professed unwarped truthfulness', 1.1.3): cf. *opus* ***ueritatem professum*** *numquam . . . silentio ausus* ***corrumpere*** *uel mendacio. Fides* is for Ammianus a virtual synonym of *ueritas* (see Sabbah (1978), 19–23). The words which introduce Tacitus' second paragraph, *opus aggredior opimum casibus* ('I embark on a work fertile in disasters', 1.2.1), are echoed by *id . . . aggressuros* (the only other usage of *aggredior* for a literary *opus* which I have found is Frontinus *Strat.* 1.pr.3). See also Blockley (2001) for a development of his arguments on Ammianus as Ciceronian historian.

[4] So Paschoud (2004) and Kelly (2007) in response to Blockley (1998).

[5] Indeed, yet another of Hinds' intertextual signposts.

Ammianus invites his successors to write panegyric, contradicting the apparent invitation of the text that they continue writing in the same allusive and truthful manner as he had done. The contradiction is a productive one: it forces the reader to distinguish between Ammianus' refusal to embark on the history of the current reign, which could not be done without telling lies or omitting truths, and the breviarist's statement that his present style is unworthy of the greatness of the current ruling house. Here is yet another sign of Ammianus' dissatisfaction with the régime of Theodosius, once again carefully hidden behind an allusion.[6]

I am conscious of many possibilities unpursued in this book. A conviction with which I began this work was that the flowering of Latin literary scholarship on classical historiography and on intertextuality could also illuminate Ammianus, and one of my aims has been to stress his intertextual connections and similarity of intertextual technique with the likes of Vergil and Sallust. Not that studies of Ammianus cannot inform those of earlier authors: to pick on just one topic, his technique of allusive adaptations of contemporary sources (Chapter 5 above) could offer a valuable comparandum to scholars working on Tacitus. Though I would rather see Ammianus' aesthetic, in particular his allusive technique, as classical than as late-antique, it would also be productive to view him in the context of the other authors of the later empire, a context where religion, language and genre have left him notably lonely. If his autobiographical passages focus on the formation of a historiographical persona (Chapter 2), is he comparable to those historians writing in Greek, such as Olympiodorus, Priscus and Procopius, who are equally prominent in their own works? I have interacted little here with the most important modern debate on Ammianus, on his relationship to Christianity, but how does his intertextuality compare to that of his Christian contemporaries, like Ambrose and Jerome?[7] One context has been identified in which he alludes to an unmistakeably Christian source: are there more?[8] A study of the distribution of allusions to particular works

[6] Cf. Chapter 1, Section II. [7] See Fontaine (1992).

[8] See Ch. 2, Section V, and the Appendix, and Bleckmann (2007). For excellent observation of Ammianus' use of Christian language and his coverage of pagan–Christian polemic see den Boeft *et al.* ad 22.11.10, 22.12.8.

could provide valuable evidence of Ammianus' working methods. I also regret, though readers may not, that I did not have space for a thorough-going survey of the sources of his knowledge in *exempla* and digressions. The extent to which (I suspect) it would show the dominance of Latin in his learning would raise considerable questions for those who focus on his Greek rather than his bilingual culture.[9] And beyond these possible approaches not here pursued, there must be countless others which I could never have imagined.

[9] See Ch. 4, n. 112.

APPENDIX

SOURCES FOR THE TSUNAMI OF AD 365

The purpose of this appendix is to set out the evidence for a lost source which described the great tsunami of 365. This source can be reconstructed from the ninth-century Byzantine chroniclers Theophanes Confessor and Georgius Monachus (or George the Monk), and also from the twelfth-century Syriac Chronicle of Michael Syrus (or St Michael the Great). I put the case for this source's existence in my article 'Ammianus and the Great Tsunami'.[1] The argument is laid out again here for two reasons: first, that the relevant texts may be absent from even well-stocked classical libraries; secondly, because I wrongly failed to consider Michael Syrus, whose relevance was pointed out by Professor Bruno Bleckmann.[2] None of these texts have received much consideration in studies of the tsunami of 365. This is unsurprising, as all were written many centuries after the events described and each in different ways exaggerates, garbles or misplaces the events of the tsunami. Nonetheless, taken together, they provide an account of some historical value, with a number of apparently authentic details otherwise unknown. My interest, however, is principally in how the source was used and abused by Ammianus.

In the table below, I have compared Theophanes, Georgius Monachus and Michael Syrus. I have included the Greek text of Theophanes and George where verbal similarities are most noteworthy (their texts can be found complete at the end of this appendix).[3] Despite considerable variations, the structure of all three is similar: they describe first events known to have taken place in Alexandria ((a)–(e) below), where the tsunami threw ships on to rooftops (Michael Syrus confuses the location); then each has an incident in the Adriatic where a ship is alleged to have landed on the seabed when the waters vanished and to have been refloated when they returned (h).

[1] Kelly (2004), 148–55.

[2] Bleckmann (2007). I had the opportunity of hearing this paper at the *Ammianus after Julian* colloquium in Wassenaar in 2005.

[3] I have used Mango and Scott's translation of Theophanes (1997). The version of Georgius Monachus is my own. That of Michael Syrus I based on the French translation of Chabot (1899), 292, and the Latin translation of Bidez (1913), 239. My colleague Dr Jennifer Nimmo Smith was kind enough to check my version carefully against the original.

	Theophanes AM 5859	George the Monk 560–1 (462M)	Michael the Syrian 7.7 (Chabot p. 149 column 2, lines 15–41.
Date and context	AM 5859 = AD 366: the account follows the suppression of Procopius (May 366).	The reign of Gratian is being described.	The usurpation of Procopius has just been narrated.
	'In the same year the emperor Valens spent some time at Marcianopolis in Mysia. In the eighth Indiction [= AD 365] . . .	'In these times . . .	'Valens went to Egypt. And while he was at Marcianopolis . . .
(a)	. . . there was a great earthquake in the night throughout all the world, so that in Alexandria . . .	. . . there was a great and fearful earthquake, so that in Alexandria . . .	. . . there was an earthquake to which there had been nothing similar since the beginning of the world.
	[σεισμὸς δὲ γέγονε μέγας καθ' ὅλης τῆς γῆς ἐν τῇ η' ἰνδικτιῶνι ἐν νυκτί, ὡς καὶ ἐν Ἀλεξανδρείᾳ . . .]	[. . . σεισμὸς μέγας καὶ φοβερώτατος γέγονεν, ὡς ἐν Ἀλεξανδρείᾳ . . .]	
(b)	. . . ships moored to the shore were lifted high up over the top of tall buildings and walls and were carried within [the city] into courtyards and houses.	—	The sea was disturbed and it threw the ships over the walls of the city and they fell within courtyards.
(c)	When the water had receded, they [the ships] remained on dry land.	. . . the sea disappeared for a long time and boats were found lying as if on dry land.	The sea abandoned its place and the dry land appeared and the ships were lying unanchored.

	Theophanes AM 5859	George the Monk 560–1 (462M)	Michael the Syrian 7.7 (Chabot p. 149 column 2, lines 15–41.
	[ὑπαναχωρησάσης δὲ τῆς θαλάσσης, ἔμεινεν ἐπὶ ξηρᾶς (*sc.* τὰ πλοῖα).]	[. . . ὑποχωρῆσαι μὲν τὴν θάλασσαν ἐπὶ πολύ, τὰ δὲ πλοῖα ὡς ἐπὶ ξηρᾶς εὑρεθῆναι κείμενα.]	
(d)	The people fled from the city because of the earthquake but when they saw the ships on the dry land they went up to them to loot their cargoes.	And a multitude of people ran to see the unexpected wonder.	And the people ran to plunder.
	[οἱ δὲ λαοὶ ἐκ τῆς πόλεως φεύγοντες διὰ τὸν σεισμόν, θεωρήσαντες τὰ πλοῖα ἐπὶ τῆς ξηρᾶς, εἰς ἁρπαγὴν τῶν ἐν τοῖς πλοίοις φορτίων ἐπῆλθον . . .]	[πλήθους δὲ λαοῦ συνδραμόντος εἰς θέαν τοῦ παραδόξου θαύματος . . .]	
(e)	But the returning water covered them all.	And when the water turned around and came back further than its accustomed place, 50,000 people were drowned; and some of the ships moored there the waters covered . . .	But the sea returned on to them and covered them.

Theophanes AM 5859	George the Monk 560–1 (462M)	Michael the Syrian 7.7 (Chabot p. 149 column 2, lines 15–41.
[. . . καὶ ἐπιστρέψαν τὸ ὕδωρ πάντας ἐκάλυψεν.]	[. . . καὶ τοῦ ὕδατος πάλιν ὑποστρέψαντος καὶ ἐκβεβηκότος μακρότερον τοῦ συνήθους τόπου, κατεποντίσθησαν ἀνθρώπων μυριάδες ε', καὶ τὰς μὲν ἐκεῖσε προσορμιζούσας ναῦς τὸ ὕδωρ κατεκάλυψεν . . .]	

George the Monk only

(f) . . . others found in the river Nile the river hurled on to the dry land with great force, to a distance of 180 stades.

(g) Moreover most parts of Crete and Achaea and Boeotia and Epirus and Sicily then came to be destroyed, when the sea returned, and many ships, with the waters raised on high, were thrown up to a hundred stades onto mountainsides, and <it happened that> the British Isles and parts of Africa underwent the same and worse, and of almost all the world the parts next to the sea were either <. . .> by the earthquakes or drowned by the sea.[4] [Cf. Theophanes (a).]

	Theophanes	George the Monk	Michael the Syrian
(h)	Other sailors related that they were sailing in the Adriatic at that hour when they were caught up and suddenly their ship was sitting on the sea-bed; after a short time the water returned again and	And indeed in the gulfs too and the great seas, the areas around the Adriatic and the Aegean Sea and many others retreated and divided as though a wall were on one side and the waters on another, and dry land appeared. And	Sailors indeed told that these events also happened in the Adriatic Sea and that the sea was shaken. And it went over the dry land for many miles and it hid villages and their inhabitants; and its bed appeared dry. And the ships were thrown on to land, and the men within were filled with

[4] Or 'were submerged by the earthquakes or the sea'?

	Theophanes AM 5859	George the Monk 560–1 (462M)	Michael the Syrian 7.7 (Chabot p. 149 column 2, lines 15–41.
	so they resumed their voyage.'	many ships were then found floating, and those resting on the bottom were raised again by the revival of the waters.'	fright. But suddenly the sea returned and it went up upon the sea and floated, while the men were not harmed at all.'
(i)	—	George closes by telling of 'continuous earthquakes', two of which are identifiable with those at Nicaea in 368 and at Germe, also in Bithynia, in 368 or 369.	—

A discussion of the relationship of these sources should begin with that between Theophanes and Michael Syrus, clearly close to each other. Both have (b), which is lacking in George; both are missing George's (f), (g) and (i). At several points Michael could be translating Theophanes.[5] However, each has independent information: Theophanes gives the Indiction year correctly and says the earthquake occurred in the night, a timing which is reconcilable with Ammianus' narrative;[6] he identifies the city where ships were tossed on to rooftops as Alexandria (a); he has the credible detail of individuals leaving the city because of the earthquake (d). Michael's narrative may lack a date and the name of Alexandria (thus giving the impression that the tsunami afflicted Marcianople, a landlocked city, and that that city was in or on the way to Egypt), but at several points contains text which has no equivalent in Theophanes (notably at (h), but also (a) and (b)), to an extent which rules out the possibility that Michael is copying Theophanes. The narratives bring clarity to each other. For example, the events of (b) logically belong after (c)–(e): the ships were thrown among the houses only after the sea had withdrawn and returned violently. It is clearer from Michael's account that (b) is originally a 'headline', a description of the most dramatic result of the tsunami,

[5] This assumption is made by Jacques and Bousquet (1984), 449, and wrongly accepted in Kelly (2004).

[6] See Kelly (2004), 144 and n. 21.

and that Theophanes has confused the ships left on dry land by the tsunami (b) with those left on the dry seabed by the initial withdrawal of the waters (c).[7]

The relationship of Georgius Monachus to these sources is more distant. He dates the events to Gratian's reign, he lacks the 'headline' (b) about the ships on the rooftops; when people run to the ships grounded in the harbour (d), it is not, as in Theophanes and Michael, because they wish to plunder them but because they are drawn by the unexpected marvel. He has a figure for those killed (five myriads, 50,000) (e); he does not describe boats on rooftops but has them cast inland by implausible distances (f)–(g). In (g) he magnifies the disaster to cover vast areas, naming not only Crete, Achaea, Epirus and Sicily (either attested as experiencing the earthquake or the tsunami, or likely to have done so),[8] but also, incredibly, the British Isles and parts of Africa. The material which follows (h) evidently alludes to the story of the sailors who landed on the bottom of the Adriatic, though it deviates from it considerably. Finally George assimilates this earthquake to those which afflicted Nicaea on 11 October 368 and Germe shortly afterwards, which we know of from Socrates 4.11. George at this point is plainly not modelled on Theophanes, though it seems likely that he ultimately shares a source with him. But the variations are significant. He has original information which has not survived in Theophanes and Michael (the apparent reference to a bore in the Nile (f), and the list of areas affected (g)); at other points he offers his own or an intermediate source's hyperbolic elaborations (the effects in Africa and the British Isles, (g)), as well as what may be a variant in the original source (he portrays people gazing in wonder at the ships grounded in the waterless harbour when Theophanes and Michael have them looting). The extent of these differences and the chronological displacement mean that we must posit at least one intermediate source.

As Bleckmann has pointed out in reacting to my initial article, the similarity of Theophanes and Michael Syrus here has been noticed before. It is one of a number of points where their similarity has been used to argue for the existence of a lost Church history. The fragments, reconstructed from the evidence of (*inter alia*) *Chronicon Paschale*, Theophanes, the *Chronicle of 724*, Michael Syrus, and Jerome's *Chronicle*, are published in Bidez's edition of Philostorgius.[9] The author's alleged religious persuasion has led to the epithet of the Arian or Homoean historiographer: he is thought to have written in Antioch in about 380. As often with anonymous reconstructed sources, there is plenty of disagreement about the date, extent and purpose of the work, or whether a single work is

[7] Kelly (2004), 149–50.

[8] Recent studies agree that Crete was the epicentre of the earthquake (Jacques and Bousquet (1984), Henry (1985), Guidoboni *et al.* (1989) and (1994). Destruction there is attested by three lives of Athanasius (Anonymous, *PG* 25.210, Photius, *Vita Athanasii* 14 (*PG* 25.222) and Simeon Metaphrastes, *Vita Athanasii* 17 (*PG* 25.245)). For Achaea see Ammianus 26.10.19 and *IG* 4.674; for Epirus and Sicily see Jerome, *Life of Hilarion* 40 and *Chron.* s.a. 366.

[9] Bidez (1913), Anhang 7 (202–41). This historian's existence was first posited by Gwatkin (1882); see also Battifol (1895) and most recently Brennecke (1998a), 93–5.

actually at issue.[10] I do not propose to examine the nature of the work closely, or consider whether Theophanes and Michael Syrus used it directly; I simply note that the conventional dating would have meant that it was available to Ammianus, and furthermore that the use of this source by Ammianus at a quite different juncture was recently posited, plausibly if not compellingly, by Brennecke.[11] I have suggested that George's use of this source must be indirect, and Bleckmann has proposed that we may be dealing with a fragment of Philostorgius. The later attribution of the dire event to the reign of an orthodox emperor like Gratian suggests an 'Arian' author, and the references to Africa (called by the Latin name rather than the Greek Libya) and the British Isles suggest an early rather than a middle Byzantine date for this material being added. Philostorgius appears to have used the Arian historiographer elsewhere and is known to have penetrated middle Byzantine collections from the Church historians; Georgius Monachus could in turn have derived his narrative from such a compilation, as is suggested by the following passage describing the Nicaea and Germe earthquakes (i), which ultimately comes from Socrates' *Church History*.[12]

Bleckmann's reconstruction of the source relationships, then, is highly plausible, though it may not be perfectly demonstrable. For my purposes, more important than showing that the ultimate source of these works was a lost Church historian, Arian or not, is to show that it was known to and used by Ammianus. His transformation of this source is violent (I shall only discuss it briefly, though I have said more in Chapter 2, Section v, and in my article of 2004). The events described are rearranged to make a single chronologically coherent narrative, at the expense of geographical coherence. Ammianus generalises from particular stories, blending together what happened at Alexandria and the tale of the sailors in the middle of the Adriatic in 26.10.16–18. First we have the sea's disappearance, so that the seabed is laid bare (16). This reference to the story of the Adriatic sailors is then blended with the crowds looting the ships at Alexandria, who are, however, portrayed as wandering about collecting fish in their hands (17). After the sea's return (18), the death and destruction involve both many thousands on the shore (the Alexandrian victims of the chronicles) and the victims of shipwrecks (the Adriatic sailors?). Despite the fact that much that has been described is based on Alexandrian events, the name of Alexandria only occurs in the final sentence, for the famous image of ships on rooftops (19).

Textual parallels supporting Ammianus' deployment of the source of the three later chronicles are listed below. My argument does not depend on any one of these – after all, there are certain types of vocabulary which would recur in any description of an earthquake or a tsunami. However, I would emphasise the separate presence of parallels with all three of the other authors. To take an example

[10] For example Richard Burgess (1999), 113–305, uses the same evidence to reconstruct a continuation of Eusebius' *Chronicle* as far as AD 350. He does not altogether rule out the existence of the Arian historian, however (126 n. 37).

[11] Brennecke (1997).

[12] Bleckmann (2007).

not adduced in my article of 2004, Michael's reference (a) to an earthquake unparalleled since the beginning of the world twice is similar to Ammianus' references (26.10.15) to the lack of parallels in legend or *ueridicae antiquitates*, and to the seabed being uncovered for the first time since the creation (16).[13] Also particularly significant is the apparent linguistic calque of the Greek found in George, and almost found in Theophanes, *uelut arida humo*/ὡς ἐπὶ ξηρᾶς.

Ammianus 26.10.15–19	Theophanes, George the Monk, Michael the Syrian
'While this usurper [Procopius] yet lived, whose various deeds and whose death I have described, on 21 July in the year in which Valentinian was consul for the first time with his brother [AD 365], fearsome terrors suddenly strode through the whole circle of the world, the like of which neither legends nor truthful ancient histories tell us.	The positioning of the event after the usurpation of Procopius is also found in Theophanes and Michael. *Horrendi terrores per omnis orbis ambitum*, cf. (a) Theophanes 'a great earthquake **throughout all the world**'; George 'a great and **fearful** (φοβερώτατος) earthquake'; Michael 'an earthquake **to which there had been nothing similar since the beginning of the world**'. Similar rhetoric already in Jerome *Chron.* s.a. 366.
(16) Slightly after daybreak, and heralded by a thick succession of fiercely shaken thunderbolts, the solidity of the whole earth was made to shake and shudder, and the sea was driven away, its waves were rolled back, and it disappeared, so that the abyss of the depths was uncovered and many-shaped varieties of sea-creatures were seen stuck in the slime; the great wastes of those valleys and mountains, which the very creation had dismissed beneath the vast whirlpools, at that moment, as it was given to be believed, looked up at the sun's rays.	Disappearance of the sea cf. (c). Seabed left bare cf. (h). Seabed revealed for the first time since the creation cf. Michael (a).

[13] Bleckmann (2007) lists some other aspects in which Michael is closer to Ammianus than Theophanes.

Ammianus 26.10.15–19	Theophanes, George the Monk, Michael the Syrian
(17) Many ships, then, were stranded as if on dry land, and people wandered at will about the paltry remains of the waters to collect fish and the like in their hands; then the roaring sea as if insulted by its repulse rises back in turn, and through the teeming shoals dashed itself violently on islands and extensive tracts of the mainland, and flattened innumerable buildings in towns or wherever they were found. Thus in the raging conflict of the elements, the face of the earth was changed to reveal wondrous sights.	Ships stranded and individuals walk on the seabed: cf. both the Adriatic narrative (h) and the Alexandrian (c); cf. ***uelut arida humo*** *connexis* to George, Theophanes (c) [(ὡς) ἐπὶ ξηρᾶς]. Individuals walking on the seabed collecting fish cf. looters in (d). Widespread destruction cf. George (g).
(18) For the mass of waters returning when least expected killed many thousands by drowning, and with the tides whipped up to a height as they rushed back, some ships, after the anger of the watery element had grown old, were seen to have sunk, and the bodies of people killed in shipwrecks lay there, faces up or down.	Deaths by drowning cf. (e). Many thousands cf. George's 50,000 (e) (is Ammianus rejecting the suspect precision of his source?). Remains of sunken ships cf. George (h); the portrayal of the dead bodies contrasts with Theophanes and Michael's (h), where sailors who landed on the seabed are said to have survived.
(19) Other huge ships, thrust out by the mad blasts, perched on the roofs of houses, as happened at Alexandria, and others were hurled nearly two miles from the shore, like the Laconian vessel near the town of Methone which I saw when I passed by, yawning apart from long decay.'	Ships on rooftops at Alexandria cf. (b), and also e.g. Sozomen. Other ships hurled long distances inland cf. George (f)–(g).

Theophanes AM 5859

Τῷ δ' αὐτῷ χρόνῳ διῆγεν Οὐάλης ὁ βασιλεὺς ἐν Μαρκιανουπόλει τῆς Μυσίας. σεισμὸς δὲ γέγονε μέγας καθ' ὅλης τῆς γῆς ἐν τῇ ἡ ἰνδικτιῶνι ἐν νυκτί, ὡς καὶ ἐν Ἀλεξανδρείᾳ πλοῖα προσορμισάμενα τῷ αἰγιαλῷ ἐπαρθῆναι εἰς ὕψος καὶ ὑπερβῆναι τὰς ὑψηλὰς οἰκοδομὰς καὶ τὰ τείχη καὶ μετατεθῆναι ἔνδον εἰς τὰς αὐλὰς καὶ τὰ δώματα τὰ πλοῖα. ὑπαναχωρησάσης δὲ τῆς θαλάσσης, ἔμεινεν ἐπὶ ξηρᾶς· οἱ δὲ λαοὶ ἐκ τῆς πόλεως φεύγοντες διὰ τὸν σεισμόν, θεωρήσαντες τὰ πλοῖα ἐπὶ τῆς ξηρᾶς, εἰς ἁρπαγὴν τῶν ἐν τοῖς πλοίοις φορτίων ἐπῆλθον, καὶ ἐπιστρέψαν τὸ ὕδωρ πάντας ἐκάλυψεν· ἄλλους δὲ ναυτικοὺς διηγήσασθαι, ὡς κατ' ἐκείνην τὴν ὥραν ἐν μέσῳ τοῦ Ἀδρία πελάγους πλέοντας καταληφθῆναι, ἐξαίφνης δὲ ἐν τῷ πελάγει εἰς τὸ ἔδαφος καθίσαι τὸ πλοῖον· καὶ μετὰ βραχὺ πάλιν ἐπανελθεῖν τὸ ὕδωρ, καὶ οὕτω πλεῦσαι.

Georgius Monachus, 560–561 (462M)

Κατ' ἐκείνους δὲ τοὺς καιροὺς σεισμὸς μέγας καὶ φοβερώτατος γέγονεν, ὡς ἐν Ἀλεξανδρείᾳ ὑποχωρῆσαι μὲν τὴν θάλασσαν ἐπὶ πολύ, τὰ δὲ πλοῖα ὡς ἐπὶ ξηρᾶς εὑρεθῆναι κείμενα. πλήθους δὲ λαοῦ συνδραμόντος εἰς θέαν τοῦ παραδόξου θαύματος, καὶ τοῦ ὕδατος πάλιν ὑποστρέψαντος καὶ ἐκβεβηκότος μακρότερον τοῦ συνήθους τόπου, κατεποντίσθησαν ἀνθρώπων μυριάδες ε', καὶ τὰς μὲν ἐκεῖσε προσορμιζούσας ναῦς τὸ ὕδωρ κατεκάλυψεν, τὰς δὲ ἐν τῷ ποταμῷ Νείλῳ εὑρεθείσας ἀπέρριψεν ὁ ποταμὸς εἰς τὴν ξηρὰν μετὰ πολλῆς τῆς ῥύμης μέχρι σταδίων ρπ'. ἀλλὰ μὴν καὶ τῆς Κρήτης καὶ τῆς Ἀχαΐας καὶ Βοιωτίας καὶ τῆς Ἠπείρου καὶ Σικελίας τὰ πλεῖστα μέρη συνέβη τότε ἀπολέσθαι, τῆς θαλάσσης ἀνελθούσης, καὶ πολλὰ πλοῖα ὑψωθέντος τοῦ ὕδατος ἐπὶ τῶν ὀρέων ἐρρίφησαν ἄχρι σταδίων ρ', τάς τε Βρεττανικὰς νήσους καὶ <τὰ> τῆς Ἀφρικῆς τὰ αὐτὰ καὶ χείρονα ὑποστῆναι, καὶ σχεδὸν πασῆς τῆς οἰκουμένης τὰ πρὸς τῇ θαλάσσῃ τὰ μὲν ὑπὸ τῶν σεισμῶν . . ., τὰ δὲ ὑπὸ τῆς θαλάσσης κατεποντίσθησαν. καὶ μέντοι καὶ ἐν τοῖς βυθοῖς καὶ τοῖς μεγάλοις πελάγεσι τὰ ἀμφὶ τὸν Ἀδρίαν καὶ τὸ Αἰγαῖον πέλαγος καὶ ἄλλα πλεῖστα ὑπεχώρησεν καὶ διέστησαν ὡσεὶ τεῖχος ἔνθεν καὶ ἔνθεν τὰ ὕδατα, καὶ ἐφάνη ἡ ξηρά· καὶ πολλὰ τότε πλοῖα εὑρέθησαν πλέοντα καὶ εἰς τὸν πυθμένα καθίσαντα πάλιν ἀνήχθησαν τῇ τοῦ ὕδατος ἀποκαταστάσει. συνεχῶν δὲ καὶ ἐπαλλήλων τῶν σεισμῶν γενομένων, ἡ μὲν μία[14] τῆς Βιθυνίας πόλις πᾶσα συνέπεσε καὶ τὰ κύκλῳ τῶν προαστείων, ἀγροὶ καὶ ἔργα πλεῖστα. ἡ δὲ Γερμὴ καλουμένη πόλις τοῦ Ἑλλεσπόντου πᾶσα ἐκ θεμελίων κατεπτώθη. καὶ πρὸς τούτοις χάσματα πολλὰ κατὰ διαφόρους τόπους ἐγένοντο, ὡς ἐκ τῶν φόβων ἐν τοῖς ὄρεσι μένειν τοὺς ἀνθρώπους, ἐκ δὲ τῆς ἀβροχίας πολλὰ ζῶά τε καὶ ἄνθρωποι διεφθάρησεν.

[14] De Boor: 'fuerit fort. in fonte Georgii ἃ i. e. πρώτη?'

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SUBJECT INDEX

This index aims to give reasonably comprehensive coverage of ancient persons named in the text, and highly selective coverage of nations, place names and themes. Names of polyonymous persons are only given in full to avoid ambiguity or when all names are customarily used; such persons are listed by the most familiar name (Pompeius, not Magnus; Cicero, not Tullius) or that used by Ammianus; in doubtful cases I use the final name, in accordance with late Roman norms (so Sex. Claudius Petronius Probus comes under Probus). The chief offices held by Ammianus' contemporaries are included when relevant. The entry on Ammianus deals with his life, his thought and the literary features of the *Res Gestae*: other subjects can be found under individual headings. For further information on individuals or works marked with *, see the Index locorum.

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